what nobody else has ever done

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by lavendersun

Summary

It all came back to a singular day in his childhood, one that had haunted him on the regular. Some days, he looked in Izuku's eyes and didn't have the courage to hold his gaze; after enduring years of bullying from Katsuki, words that Katsuki could never take back, Izuku still looked at him the same as he had that day in the river. And that scared Katsuki more than any villain, more than any fight, more than the thought of dying.

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or, the canon compliant Katsuki-centric fic about falling in love with your rival.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

growing sideways

Chapter Summary

‘Cause everyone’s growing and everyone’s healthy
I’m terrified that I might never have met me

Looking back on elementary and middle school memories was not a past-time that Katsuki often chose to partake in. For many reasons, reasons that made his skin crawl with a number of emotions that he didn’t want to put a name to, that he didn’t want to admit - even to himself - that he was feeling, reasons that made him want to run far, far away from the things that he had done, the person that he had been, and start all over again.

Because he’d learned a lot, whether or not people recognized it or acknowledged just how much he had changed.

When Katsuki’s quirk had first arrived, sudden and intense and *explosive* , he’d had to learn a lot of lessons right then and there.

His parents had sat him down and explained to him the dangers of his quirk, and his stupid bratty five-year-old self hadn’t bothered to listen because it was *his* quirk, his power, his future as a hero, and if people weren’t smart enough to know that his quirk has dangerous then it wasn’t *his* fault. He’d sat at the dining room table, letting his feet dangle, drumming his fingers against his legs, waiting and waiting for the chance to run off to his room and try to use his quirk again. He didn’t *care* if nitroglycerin could harm the people around him; they should know that he was the best and to stay *out of his way* . He wasn’t stupid either - he knew explosions were *dangerous* and could damage property - and people - and that his quirk wasn’t something to be abused. If he wanted to be a hero, he would need to use it in the right way.

He didn’t care about his parents’ lecture on his quirk; he’d learn how to use it in no time and show them, and all the other idiots in his stupid Kindergarten class, that he was going to be the best.

The memories of his own bratty egoism hadn’t started to bother him until his time at UA when his entire life changed. And when things did start to change, and Katsuki himself started to change, he tried to remember particular snippets of that time - snippets that didn’t paint him as the image of villainy that so many people expected of him.

When his quirk developed and he spent the first few days nurturing it, Katsuki had been most excited to show Izuku.

He'd known the boy his entire life, which really wasn't a big feat at only five years old, but he was about as permanent in his life as his parents, and that was good enough for Katsuki. Their mothers had been friends for years since before they were born, obviously in a way that was deeper than what Katsuki could understand at five, so he didn't question Inko and Izuku spending so much time at his house.

He could remember pivotal points of Inko's presence in his life, though, like her sitting on his couch when he was only four, tissues clutched in her shaking fists, tears streaming down her face. His mother sat beside Inko, a hand resting on her shoulder, the other brushing tears away from her face with a gentleness that Katsuki wasn't accustomed to seeing from her.

Izuku sat beside him on the bottom stair. They were slightly out of view from their parents, just a little down the hallway. Inko had shown up with Izuku, who had entered the Bakugo household timidly, so unlike his usual bubbly self. Mitsuki had taken one look at Inko and had ushered the two boys towards the stairs, telling them to go upstairs and play while the adults talked.

At four, Katsuki had already developed a hatred for being treated as *less than* , even in situations where he definitely wasn't included, and he'd planted himself on the bottom step as soon as his parents were distracted. He wasn't going to let his *stupid mother* tell him what to do. He had tugged Izuku down onto the stairs beside him and whispered, "Do you know what they're talking about?"

Izuku had shrugged, his eyes just as watery as Inko's had been when she'd entered the house. "Something about Dad."

Katsuki strained to listen to his mother and Inko's conversation, but his hearing failed him. He grumbled. "Well, are you gonna tell me or what?"

"Him and Mom have been fighting a lot."

"And? I fight with my mom all the time."

"Like grown-up fighting."

"What does that mean?"

Izuku picked at a thread on the bottom of his All Might shirt. "Mom said that he's going away for a bit. And that I might not see him for a while."

"Oh."

"Yeah."

Katsuki hadn't known what to say to Izuku, and when he looked back on that moment, years later, when he was finally ready to start unpacking all of the times he had fucked up in his life, he still couldn't form a proper response.

He hadn't asked Izuku questions about his dad after that, and, as far as he knew, Izuku didn't talk to him. Not that it was Katsuki's business.

Katsuki tried to convince himself that, when the first signs of his quirk started showing, he'd been excited about the prospect of showing Izuku. After all, Izuku had been his closest friend; he had mattered a smidge more than the idiot extras that they ran around with on the playground. They had done everything together for just about their entire lives, so it was only right that Izuku reserved the title of Katsuki's best friend.

But as much as he tried to tell himself that he had been looking forward to showing his quirk to Izuku, he'd come to the conclusion that he'd been a real asshole at only five years old, and that he'd been more worried about shoving it in Izuku's face that his quirk was just *that cool* .

When he found out that Izuku didn't have a quirk and that his chances of developing one were slim to none, he'd felt a whole mix of emotions that hadn't made sense to his little five year old brain.

He did his best to name them, a decade later, because he wanted to be better. Because to be a hero, to be the number one hero, he had to be better.

The first had been disappointment.

He'd always thought of himself above Izuku, which wasn't anything new; he'd thought himself above all the rest of the neighborhood kids as well. He was closer to Izuku, sure, but still better. He knew he was special, he knew he had potential more than any of the other kids, knew that he could be number one. His parents told him over and over, his teachers mooned over him and his impressive quirk, the neighborhood kids followed his lead on the playground. Every moment in his life had been pushing him towards something more, something big and important and special.

The other kids in their neighborhood talked about heroes, sure, every kid did. But he and Izuku were different from the rest of them. They'd been collecting All Might figurines and clothes and trading cards for as long as Katsuki could remember, and they'd spent more hours than he was comfortable admitting sitting in front of his mom's old laptop, watching All Might movies or rescue footage or interview clips. They'd talked about hero names, stupid plays on All Might. They'd talked about having an agency together, and Katsuki had insisted that Izuku would be his sidekick.

Those plans had gone out the window, and Katsuki had been disappointed. He'd let himself lean on his friend, let himself think that their dreams would come true together, that the games they played at the park would one day become a reality, and he couldn't have been more wrong. Not only could Izuku not become a hero, he was completely quirkless.

He was still working on naming the second emotion, the twist in his stomach that had tightened and tightened and tightened until he felt nauseous. He'd felt the need to push Izuku away from him, as if his quirk-deprived state was somehow *contagious* , like he could somehow infect Katsuki and ruin his dreams of becoming a hero, too. And he wasn't going to let that happen, because he'd been dreaming about it from the moment he could walk, and he wasn't going to let some stupid kid that lived down the street take that away from him.

The third had been sympathy.

That's what Katsuki told himself. Many years later. Many fights later. Many stupid panic attacks later, suffered alone in his dorm room, gasping for breath in the middle of the night.

It had taken a lot of those for him to finally realize, and maybe just *slightly* , that he had done things wrong.

He tried to tell himself that it didn't really fucking matter how he had felt when he had found out that his childhood best friend would never stand at the same level as him, but it sure didn't feel like it didn't matter when Izuku showed up at UA and bested him in every possible way.

Maybe he felt sympathy for what he had done after all the stupid fights he and Izuku had had throughout their first year. Maybe it had taken getting attacked by a villain in the street and being helpless to fight back, or getting kidnapped and watching his idol lose his power in front of thousands of people. Maybe it was watching as his and Izuku's roles were switched, and Izuku pulled further and further ahead of him, and he was left watching, trying and failing to catch up.

Before Katsuki had convinced himself that Izuku was useless just because he was different from Katsuki, he had felt a small shred of sympathy. He'd known that he would have been devastated to learn that he wouldn't get a quirk, and he'd known that he would have thought his life was over at only five years old. It wasn't perfect empathy, he knew, but it was something. It was enough to convince him all those years later that he wasn't all bad. That maybe there was some way he could be better even though he'd spent his entire life showing everyone that he was, simply, a dickhead.

It's not like he wanted to atone. He didn't.

Atoning wasn't what he wanted because, in Katsuki's eyes, prancing around and apologizing, doing things out of *guilt* didn't really matter at the end of everything. If he was to make things better with Izuku, he didn't plan on doing it because he felt fucking guilty; he would do it because he fucking *wanted to* .

It had started with that damn nickname, the one that Katsuki had thought he was so clever for deeming his childhood friend. He'd called him Deku one day on the playground, and the other kids in his group (with names and faces that he didn't even remember) had laughed and teased Izuku right along with him. And since Katsuki was learning the art of reflecting after a shitty first semester of high school, getting kidnapped, learning about "the power of friendship" from Kaminari and Kirishima, and coming to realize that he knew Izuku better than anyone else, he could admit to himself that their "teasing" had been a lot closer to tormenting.

It all came back to a singular day in his childhood, one that had haunted him on the regular. Some days, he looked in Izuku's eyes and didn't have the courage to hold his gaze; after enduring years of bullying from Katsuki, words that Katsuki could never take back, Izuku still looked at him the same as he had that day in the river. And that scared Katsuki more than any villain, more than any fight, more than the thought of dying.

He wasn't like Izuku and he didn't want to be. Izuku could be All Might's shining star and the literal favorite of Class A, and Katsuki would still rather put his hand in his own mouth and light off an explosion than be like that damn nerd.

But he knew that the look in Izuku's eyes, the look that had scared him so long ago, was what made Izuku a hero. Not One for All. Not All Might's extra attention.

It was the look in wide, shining green eyes, an extended hand, a worried voice. Even after harsh nicknames, after pushes and shoves, it was Izuku's unwavering desire to *help* and *save* that scared Katsuki half to death, especially when Katsuki was the furthest thing from deserving.

It had pissed him off, too, that Izuku had dared to think that Katsuki had needed his help. Because Katsuki hadn't needed help from anyone, certainly not a quirkless crybaby. He would *never* be weak enough to need Izuku's help.

Katsuki could have pretended like that day in the river didn't matter, but it did. It reminded him after he got into UA that, while he had the quirk to become a hero, he sure didn't have the fucking personality of one. Sure, saving people would probably make him feel good and all, but that's not what fueled him. What mattered to him was being the best. He wanted to surpass All Might and prove to everyone that he was the greatest. Saving people just came with that.

And achieving that came crumbling right down on his fucking head time and time again as he realized that working ten times harder than everyone else didn't mean shit when it came to Izuku. Waking up early and running miles, spending afternoons lifting and training with his stupid group of friends, studying longer and harder than everyone in their class put him at the top in theory, but that wasn't good enough for him. Not when he could see how far Izuku had come, how much he had faced without becoming a miserable asshole like Katsuki.

It felt like a sin to hate him.

Responsibility for my fucking actions, I guess , he thought, irritated. He wanted to punch something. Repetitively.

Kirishima, who was sitting at Katsuki's desk, peered at him inquisitively, ever the observative friend that Katsuki didn't fucking ask for. "Something bothering you, man?"

"Fuck off," he muttered, trying to refocus on the assignment in front of him.

"You're moodier than usual, though," Kaminari piped up. He was laying on the floor, propped on his elbows and doodling on the edges of his paper. "I mean, there's definitely been some big improvements since the beginning of the year, so gold star there. But you're, like, murdering that paper with your eyes."

Katsuki pointedly ignored Kaminari.

"Is this about Midoriya?" Kirishima asked.

Seriously, what the fuck? Why was Katsuki friends with them again? And how did Kirishima just *know* these things?

“Didn’t I tell you to fuck off?”

“Don’t be like that, man.” Kirishima was giving him *the look* , the one that apparently could read a person in seconds. “We’re just worried about you, that’s all.”

It took Katsuki a moment to recover from that. He reminded himself, a couple times over, that it wasn’t an insult, that his friends didn’t think he was weak. They worried because they cared.

“What does you being worried about me have to do with Deku?”

“Don’t play dumb,” Kaminari said tauntingly. His eyebrows shot up and down quickly, and Kirishima kicked him.

“You guys are just getting closer. It kind of… surprised everyone.”

“Everyone can mind their own fucking business.”

It wasn’t exactly easy to explain the sudden increase in the amount of time Katsuki was spending with Izuku. He couldn’t just say *training* because that would lead to conversations about why Katsuki wanted to train with Izuku and vice versa, especially when they both had a number of other friends that would be willing. And, sure, he could say something about helping Izuku learn to control his new quirk, but the same counter argument could be made to that. He’d meant what he’d promised to Izuku, that he wouldn’t let the secret of One for All out. Katsuki had already done enough fucking damage to All Might; he didn’t need to let it slip to two of Class A’s resident loudmouths that Izuku had gotten his quirk from the number one hero.

“You’ve got to understand where we’re coming from, *Kacchan* . You tried to murder him, like, a week into school. Then you two beat the shit out of each other after you failed the licensing exam and got house arrest. I thought you two had that whole ‘fated rivals’ thing going on. Or is it more of an ‘enemies to lovers’?”

Before Katsuki could jump off the bed and strangle that stupid fuckface *idiot* , Kirishima held him back with a hardened arm.

Kirishima flicked Kaminari’s forehead. “Don’t rile him up, he’ll stop hanging out with us.”

“This isn’t hanging out, assholes. You two picked my fucking lock and then begged me to help you with your homework.”

“Because you’re *so* smart and fun to be around. And irresistible. Did I mention handsome?” Kaminari’s grin grew. “We can call *Deku* up here and ask if he agrees.”

“I’ll fucking *kill* you.”

Kirishima pushed Katsuki back, doing his best to restrain him, but, of course, Kirishima failed to resist joining in on taunting Katsuki. “So I take it you’re not going to tell us about your sudden change of heart, then? Because you *have* been spending way more time with Midoriya lately. I think I saw you smile at him the other day.”

“You wanna die too, fuckface?”

When Katsuki had gotten accepted to UA, after his parents had retired to their bedroom after a celebration that he had scoffed at, he’d been happy. It had been one of the few times in his life that that had been true, and he’d held that moment close to his heart.

He’d fucking *deserved* it, without a doubt. He’d known he was better than all of the other idiots at the entrance exam; that hadn’t taken a genius to see. He’d scoffed at some of the people that had shown up, people who barely had a handle on their quirk, people who were literally in the worst shape he’d ever seen.

Of course, he voiced that to anybody who would listen, because he wanted them to know he would be the best. They could pretend like they would become something more than a D-list hero one day, but he was different. He’d always been different, better.

Katsuki had earned the most points during the entrance exam, and though he wasn’t in the slightest surprised, it only reinforced his idea of himself: he was the best.

And everything, ironically, blew up in his face in his first few weeks.

Katsuki had looked up to All Might his entire life, probably just as much as Izuku (he just wasn’t a complete fucking nerd about it.) It had been obvious to anyone with eyes from their very first day that there was *something* going on there, something that wasn’t just the number one hero talking to a first year student at UA. It pissed him off to no end, and Katsuki tried to hate All Might, tried to see him as a washed-up hero that he would one day beat, all because he saw worth in someone who had been so *useless* his entire life. Fucking Izuku, never giving Katsuki a fucking break from anything, getting into UA and somehow, *somehow* garnering the attention of the person that Katsuki had admired most.

And as for Katsuki? All Might had treated him like everyone else. He hadn’t looked at him with that sense of admiration that he reserved for Izuku; instead, All Might looked at him like he was on the same level as all the other kids in his class, with names that he couldn’t be bothered to remember.

He still admired All Might, as much as he hated to admit that he and Izuku had something in common, but that day had stuck with him. He’d learned a lot in his first fight with Izuku, had figured out pretty fucking quickly that he really wasn’t as amazing as everyone had told him throughout his entire life. He’d lost to fucking Izuku.

Finding out about the true origin of Izuku’s quirk had been a tougher pill to swallow.

After all, he'd been there the day of the Sludge Villain attack. He'd seen Izuku rush in to save him, tears in his eyes, reaching out to him, still willing to help even after Katsuki had told him to-

Thinking about *that* was enough to make Katsuki's hands warm considerably, tiny crackles and pops igniting in his palms. He swore, rubbing his hands on his pants. He tried to refocus on his homework, but his brain had already gotten the best of him, and the equations in front of him blurred together nonsensically.

If their roles would have been reversed that day, would Katsuki have tried to save Izuku?

The thought kept him up at night more often than he wanted to admit. When the incident had happened, he'd been pissed that he'd been so defenseless, and he'd been so goddamn embarrassed that he hadn't wanted to show his face until the world found something more interesting to talk about. He avoided thinking of it as much as he possibly could, ignored the considerable dent it had left in his ego.

When things changed between him and Izuku, when he pieced together what Izuku's whole "borrowed quirk" speech actually meant, his first thought had been *why him? Why not me?*

It didn't take a genius to deduce why All Might never would have chosen him, not even with his quirk that put shame to a majority of the people Katsuki knew.

It never would have been him.

He shouldn't have let it bother him, because he was fucking better than that, but it did.

Before Katsuki become the world's #1 asshole, when he was just a bratty kid, before he cared what the rest of the neighborhood kids thought of him, Katsuki had loved All Might just as much as Izuku had. Finding out that the person he had practically worshipped his entire childhood had chosen the person that Katsuki had *tormented* their entire lives… well.

He'd wondered where he went wrong. Maybe he could've pinpointed the moment and somehow figured out how to fix himself.

Was it his mother and her constant praise? Telling him he was the strongest and smartest in his class, shouting at him when he cried and telling him that heroes weren't vulnerable, telling him that nobody gave a shit about anybody who wasn't number one?

Was it his father and his quiet apprehension, his unwillingness to turn down Katsuki? His father had given him everything he wanted when his mother didn't. When she told Katsuki he was the best, his father nodded along and agreed. When she took Katsuki's toys off of him and shouted at him for being a brat, his father would sit with him, comfort him, let Katsuki mouth off at him without scolding him in return. He hadn't been an enforcer of anything for Katsuki's entire childhood; he'd apprehend Katsuki for swearing here and there, and he'd give pointed looks when Katsuki said something particularly foul, but he hadn't been like Katsuki's mother, snatching toys away when he was a child, then eventually, his phone, grounding him from leaving his room.

Was it that day in the river, when he'd widened the rift between him and Izuku? He'd cemented himself as a real asshole that day, someone that couldn't bear to accept help from someone that he had deemed *weak* . And Izuku had never been weak, he realized. He'd just been strong in the ways that Katsuki wasn't, and that had made Katsuki feel so *low* . He'd seen the look in Izuku's eyes, had convinced himself that Izuku's hand reaching out to him had been out of pity.

Was it middle school, ordering around a group of kids that thought he was the best thing in the entire world? Telling them over and over how much he hated *stupid Deku and his stupid fucking face* , laughing along as they snatched away his precious notebooks, kicking him around in the school courtyard.

It was probably just about everything, he came to realize.

And he knew that he wouldn't have saved Izuku if their roles had been reversed, even if he tried to convince himself that he would have.

He'd basically told him he was better off dead only hours before; he wouldn't have given a shit about him being attacked by some villain in the street. If he would have done anything, it would have been for his own personal gain, a chance to show off his quirk to the useless ass pros that were on the scene.

It was probably only right that Izuku got some crazy good karma and ended up with a quirk that spat in Katsuki's face and the former number one hero as his mentor while Katsuki, essentially, had nothing besides his own issues to work through and a class full of people that could barely stand to be around him.

Because that was the other thing.

Katsuki had grown up around Izuku. They'd been *friends* at one point, friends that had playdates and sleepovers. And then Izuku had turned into a person that Katsuki couldn't stand to look at, all because he didn't have a quirk. Izuku had had nobody from that point on. He no longer pestered Katsuki about All Might merch. He didn't talk to the other kids in their class, mostly due to them all being wrapped around Katsuki's finger.

At UA, everything flipped right on its fucking head.

On day one, it was made fairly clear that a good majority of the class was hopping on the dick-riding train, mooning over Izuku after how *heroic* he had been, saving that stupid girl with the gravity quirk during the entrance exam. They'd been intrigued by his quirk, which left his bones broken anytime he used it.

They hadn't given a shit about Katsuki. They didn't care that he had scored the highest at the entrance exam, or that his quirk was clearly better than the rest of the class. The only things said to him in those first few days were remarks on his obvious attitude problem.

It was the first time Izuku had had friends and Katsuki had not.

Yeah, the kids he hung around with in middle school weren't exactly friends. He realized that, as his first year at UA came to an end. Even if he was annoyed by his friends' persistence, he didn't hate having them around, and they taught him that the "friends" he had had in middle school hadn't been shit.

He could barely remember their faces, let alone their names or quirks. He had never met their parents. He didn't know where they lived, or their favorite colors, or what they wanted to do with their lives. Katsuki had only known that they thought he was the best, and that's why he kept them around.

But Izuku had waltzed right into UA and had practically made friends with everyone in the class. The stupid ass class rep that had scolded him at the entrance exam was suddenly glued to his side. The girl that he'd rescued during the entrance exam, with her fucking rosy cheeks and round face, couldn't seem to do anything without looking at Izuku to search for his opinion. Even goddamn Icy Hot was stuck to him after the Sports Festival.

None of them had befriended Izuku because his quirk was the greatest, or because he was the strongest. They'd chosen to be friends with Izuku because he was Izuku. Sure, they didn't know he'd been quirkless before, but they'd been up his ass even *before* he'd revealed his quirk, so they obviously wouldn't have cared. Izuku's stupid ass friend group was just a reminder of who Katsuki could have been, if he hadn't been so absorbed in himself.

The few people that could tolerate Katsuki beyond their normal class time at UA were decent enough for Katsuki to not mind having around. He liked Kirishima. He didn't mind his overwhelming positivity when it came to most things, because Kirishima was supportive as fuck about literally everything without putting Katsuki on the same pedestal that he was doing his best to step off of. He didn't make Katsuki's every move out to be some great feat of strength, but he noticed the smallest things, the things that Katsuki himself didn't always realize, and he would give him a knowing look and offer to spar with him. Kaminari wasn't half bad either, and his jokes *occasionally* made Katsuki want to laugh, but he rarely gave the electric idiot the satisfaction of knowing that he was funny. Sero *also* wasn't half bad, and Katsuki noted that he wasn't as much of a dunce as Kaminari, which earned him some points. Mina had also forced her way into their little circle, and Katsuki liked her a lot more than he planned to let on. He liked keeping tabs on the people around him, whether to use as leverage or to keep track of who was ahead of him and how hard he needed to work to surpass them, and Mina was a literal expert on *knowing things* .

Mina loved to refer to him as a gossip (he probably was) everytime he demanded that she tell him what she knew about each of her classmates. She would always tell him without arguing, and even if it wasn't always necessary information, (like her thinking that Todoroki was the hottest guy in their class, or that So-and-So from Class B had a crush on What's-His-Face) Katsuki didn't *hate* listening to it. There were times he used it to his advantage, too, asking questions as spaced out as he could possibly get them so as not to raise any alarms or give Mina any ideas that she could taunt him about later on.

Like why Round Face always looked so fucking smitten whenever she was around Izuku. Or why Icy-Hot always seemed to be glued to the damn nerd's side. Because, fucking seriously, they were about as obsessed as it got.

Katsuki didn't care. Keep your enemies closer. Or whatever.

He *tolerated* his friends. They were useful. Sometimes, their stupid jokes made him laugh. On rare occasions, Katsuki found himself smiling in their presence, because he didn't feel like a complete and utter asshole around them. Not when they picked on him like he was anyone else, or when they laughed at his comments about being better than the rest of them. They didn't worship him or kiss the ground he walked on, all because of the potential he had to become number one. When Katsuki had been a kid, he probably would have thrown a fit over someone thinking he wouldn't be the best, but he felt, for once, seen. His friends knew he had the power to go far as a pro, though they kept him in check, the same way they would anyone else. Being with them made Katsuki feel… normal.

In middle school, being an asshole had earned him the attention of all the rag-tag nobodies in his class. They'd followed him around, laughing at his jokes, poking fun at the kids that he terrorized. Nobody had ever stood up to him or called him out on his personality.

His friends did, though. Not in a way that made him feel like an utter piece of shit. Usually, he snapped right back at them with a smart remark, but he remembered every time they called him out, remembered that *maybe* it wouldn't be all that bad to be a little less aggressive. Sometimes, he thought of Kirishima's stupid face and him telling Katsuki, "You know, it wouldn't hurt you to say thank you every once in a while." or something along the lines of Katsuki's lack of manners.

And, in a way that Katsuki still struggled to wrap his mind around, his stupid friends stuck around.

Fucking Izuku stuck around. That's for goddamn sure. Like a bee to a flower. Or maybe, like a leech.

Except Izuku was practically the opposite of a leech, which Katsuki came to realize the longer he spent around Izuku. Izuku was all give and no take, and that fact alone made Katsuki fucking sick, because it was definitely going to catch up to him at some point, and Izuku was well within his capabilities to actually *think* before throwing himself into things.

After the development of Blackwhip - and Katsuki's initial moments of feeling inferior, which had then led to a feeling of resigned acceptance - he'd decided to train with Izuku, and for once, he wasn't doing it only for his own benefit.

He knew the secrets of One for All, and All Might was clearly in no shape to spar with Izuku, so Katsuki spent a number of his evenings kicking Izuku's ass and dodging those weird ass tendrils of power.

All Might supervised a majority of the time, scolding Katsuki here and there about his violence, to which Katsuki typically turned on Izuku and said, "If you can't fucking handle that, you better get ready to have your ass handed to you by the League." Because Katsuki never half-assed anything, certainly not when it came to showing Izuku just how far he had come, and he wasn't going to treat their training like a joke. If Izuku couldn't use his full power against Katsuki without holding back, Katsuki sure as hell wouldn't hold back on

giving him an earful about it. Especially not when Izuku had a tendency to throw his own safety to the wind the moment shit went down.

The least Katsuki could do, after fucking everything, was knock a bit of sense into Izuku's head. If Katsuki pushed himself harder than he really needed to when they sparred, and tried harder than anything else to beat Izuku, maybe, just fucking maybe, something would click beneath all those green curls, and Izuku would start to consider his own safety. If there was one thing he could do to pick up the pieces of what he had broken years before, it was this: training with Izuku, out of his own free will, with his own private hope that Izuku would learn how to think about himself for once.

Which was a part of this whole thing, wasn't it? Training together would help Katsuki become stronger, sure, but it was mostly to help Izuku get a handle on his power. So why did Katsuki stick around, even after Izuku enlisted Round Face and Tape-for-Elbows?

Was it the look in Izuku's eyes as he watched Katsuki? The adoration had always been there, that was nothing new, but there *was* something different glimmering in those wide, wide eyes. Katsuki couldn't name it, but he noted the moments when it flickered there, like when he protected his teammates during training exercises, or when he accepted someones' help without making a big deal of it.

He'd begun learning those skills, in a similar fashion to Izuku learning to master Blackwhip, and something about Izuku's attention to Katsuki's progress made him feel…

Well, he hadn't quite figured that out yet. But he wanted Izuku to keep watching. He wanted to keep getting better, if only so that Izuku's eyes remained wholly on him.

Some days, when a handful or so of the extras imposed on their training, Katsuki would sit with All Might and watch. He didn't have to stay and watch, and the first time All Might had told him that, Katsuki had refused to show up for training for the next week. He was *not* putting up with that skeletal fuck staring into his soul and trying to make him get all emotional. Training was one thing, and Katsuki was willing to put up with it. What he wasn't willing to put up with was All Might looking at him with those fuck ass eyes that said *I know how you feel* .

But All Might certainly knew how to push people to their limits and make them uncomfortable as fuck, and Katsuki learned how to put up with it.

At first, All Might talked about Izuku's progress, about how *proud* he was of the damn nerd for taking everything in stride. During those initial conversations, All Might's tone was light, as if he was testing the waters to see how Katsuki would react.

"You've both come so far," All Might was saying one day, with that faraway look in his eyes, all reminiscent and sentimental and fucking *ew* . "I don't think either of you really expected this, but it's been beneficial. For both of you."

"Yeah, whatever," Katsuki grumbled, slouching further down onto the bench. He'd given up on holding out responses against All Might soon after he'd started training with Izuku; the old man must have picked up some people skills in his years as the number one, and he had

no problem marinating in uncomfortable silence until Katsuki finally broke. “I’m only doing this shit because I know about your little secret.”

All Might didn’t look away from Izuku, who was listening intently to Sero, who was demonstrating some type of capture strategy with his tape. “I think we both know that’s not true anymore, Young Bakugou. If it was, I don’t think you’d still be helping him, not when he has a number of classmates that are willing to step in.”

“You think the rest of those extras are really any comparison to All for One? You’re old, not stupid.”

All Might looked at him pointedly. “You’re right.”

“Yeah, I know I’m-”

“I think you care more than you let on.”

“You really like telling people what you fucking think, don’t you? Sticking your nose where it doesn’t belong, huh?”

“You told me before that you pushed Young Midoriya away because he doesn’t think about himself. And that made you feel weak. It doesn’t anymore.”

The last part could have been framed as a question, but All Might’s tone remained even, his eyes still locked on Izuku. Katsuki watched too, his eyes tracing Izuku’s every move, analyzing the way his body shifted, anticipating attacks.

It was as if Katsuki couldn’t look away from Izuku when he trained, caught in some form of ridiculous hypnosis. Izuku twisted out of the way of a strand of Sero’s tape, the muscles of his back pressing into the lines of his shirt.

“You want me to say I care about him, is that it?”

“I want you to realize that caring about him - and your other classmates - doesn’t make you weak. And I want you to realize that you’re allowed to care about him. Even after your past.”

“He doesn’t need me to care about him.”

“But you do.”

Katsuki could fucking explode.

“I came here to train, not to have some shitty therapy session with some washed-up pro.”

“Young Midoriya cares about you. I’d even go as far to say that he cares about you more than he does the rest of his classmates.”

“Because he’s an idiot.”

“And I think the same can be said for you,” All Might continued as if Katsuki hadn’t said anything. “I’m just trying to figure out if you feel the need to atone, or if you’re starting to see him for who he is.”

If Katsuki hadn’t wanted to leave before, he sure as shit did now.

“I’ve seen you grow over the past year. I know you regret bullying him when you were children. And I know that Young Midoriya isn’t the type to hold grudges, especially not when he thinks so highly of you.”

“Yeah, I already fucking told you he’s an idiot.”

“Don’t do this just because of the guilt,” All Might said, finally turning his head to pin Katsuki with a stare that was way too piercing. “If you’re going to care about him, don’t do it because of who you were in the past or the things that you said. He doesn’t hold it against you.”

Katsuki watched as Izuku leaned down to pick up his water bottle, laughing at something Uraraka said. His cheeks were flushed, and curls stuck to his forehead. His eyes met Katsuki’s, his smile widening, eyes almost pressing shut.

Had he atoned enough for that? For a smile, one that made Katsuki’s insides feel like they were on fire?

All Might was still staring at him, and had most definitely noticed the tiny curve at the corner of Katsuki’s lips. Perceptive bastard.

“If I tell you that I care will you leave me alone about all this bullshit?”

Izuku was heading towards them, his smile lighting up the entire room; Katsuki was blinded. All Might placed a hand on Katsuki’s shoulder and squeezed. “I just want to make sure you care about him for the right reasons.”

And then Izuku was there, standing a little bit too far into Katsuki’s personal space bubble, talking a mile a minute about his training and *oh, Kacchan, what do* you *think? You’re really good with ranged attacks, so I really wanted to hear your input…*

As they walked back to the dorms, Katsuki stomping in the front of their little group, with Izuku trailing behind, laughing about something with Sero and Uraraka, Katsuki couldn’t ignore the way his conversation with All Might had made him feel. Like getting a “talking-to” from a very protective dad before taking his daughter out on a date.

Fucking ridiculous.

living legend

Chapter Summary

> But baby, you, all them things you do
> And those ways you moved send me straight to heaven
> And baby, you, I never said to you
> You really are my living legend

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku had admired heroes since before he could walk. It had been more than just admiration, though. With everything in him, Izuku had *wanted* . He'd wanted to be a hero, wanted to be able to comfort and protect people that couldn't protect themselves.

When Izuku was five years old, he found out he would never develop a quirk. At the first flashes of life, Izuku had already learned how it felt to have your dreams stomped on.

He hadn't wanted to give up, though, because how *heroic* would that be?

Izuku had had to learn a lot about being quirkless. Mainly, that he was different from everyone else. Until he met Melissa, All Might's "niece", he'd never met anyone else without a quirk, let alone someone quirkless who still wanted to be a hero.

He'd grappled with that idea his entire life, more than a little put-off by the way society handled people like him. He knew he was an anomaly; he knew he was different from all of his other classmates, and he knew none of them had a shred of empathy for his situation.

Izuku hadn't asked to be different. He hadn't asked to be so plain in a world filled with people with capabilities that amazed him.

But Izuku had been unlucky, and he had had nobody to blame that on, so he had resonated with that fact for his entire childhood. He couldn't deflect his feelings, the alienation he felt just by existing. There would never be a place for him in the world, not with the inherent value of a person being decided based on the usefulness of their quirk.

In Kindergarten, when his lack of quirk became common knowledge to the rest of his class, Izuku immediately became an outcast. He'd had a handful of friends before, kids that ate lunch with him and chased him around on the playground. After finding out that he was *different* from them, well…

Izuku was no stranger to being alone. Eating lunch alone, in the far corners of the cafeteria, or sometimes on the hallway floor. Spending recess sitting cross-legged, watching his

classmates from afar, so deeply entranced by the different ways in which his peers employed their quirks. He'd been so *fascinated* , so enamored by everything they did. He'd scribbled it down into a notebook, sometimes in crayon if he was so desperate to put a thought onto paper. Izuku had had to adjust to solitude so quickly, so confused as to why the people that had once played heroes with him now turned their noses up and refused to talk to him. He'd ached for the friendships he had once had, and as much as he loved his mother, she couldn't completely fill the void that he felt as he ached for true friendship that he had probably never known.

Somedays, Izuku wanted to reach for those kids, the ones that had turned their backs on him. He wanted to talk with them about movies, or about All Might figurines, or about their homework problems. Izuku wanted them to look at him and stop seeing *different* .

Please , he thought sometimes, *please stop looking at me like I'm so different. I like all the same things as you. We watch the same movies and we all like All Might. Why does it have to matter so much that I don't have a quirk? Can't we still be friends?*

Izuku had thought he'd had true friendship in Bakugou Katsuki, the boy who lived down the street, who's mother was best friend's with Izuku's. They'd been having playdates their entire lives, they collected hero merch together, they begged for sleepovers until their mothers gave in. They hung out with other kids, but it had always seemed to be *Izuku and Katsuki and everyone else* .

Sure, Katsuki had always been a little rougher than all the other kids, with an attitude that was way worse than the entire group combined, but Izuku hadn't *really* minded. Izuku could talk on and on about All Might for as long as he liked with Katsuki, and Katsuki would entertain him, arguing back about what All Might's best era was, or which battle was the most impressive. They shared that love for heroes, or maybe it had been closer to obsession. It hadn't mattered, though, because they both just *got it* in a way the other kids didn't.

That all went away when Katsuki found out Izuku was quirkless. Their mothers still hung out, though Inko's face was typically twisted with distaste whenever Katsuki was snotty towards Izuku. She never said anything about it, though, at least not when Izuku and Katsuki were around.

Izuku never stopped admiring Katsuki, even though Katsuki had clearly lost interest in him. Katsuki was the subject of a number of Izuku's scribbled notes, and Izuku had written out thousands of ideas for strategies and support gear and costumes that would benefit Katsuki when he became a hero. Izuku had *always* looked at Katsuki as a hero; he'd been so far ahead of everyone else when they were younger. Everyone they met had seemed to see the glowing potential of Katsuki, telling him just how incredible he was.

Katsuki had been harsher when they reached middle school, and Izuku had puzzled over it for longer than he liked to admit. He couldn't understand Katsuki's hatred for him. Katsuki had allowed Izuku to follow him around for a good while, until he just stopped tolerating Izuku's presence. He would look at Izuku like it pained him to be near him.

Izuku had understood Katsuki's anger after they both got into UA. After all, Katsuki had been the shining star for their entire lives, with everyone looking at him as amazing, Izuku

included. Those same people had pushed and shoved Izuku, with their hands and their words, deeming him *useless* solely based on his lack of a quirk. It had probably been a pretty big blow to the ego that Katsuki carried so heavily on his shoulders, and Izuku had felt not guilt, but a strong sense of sympathy. After everything Katsuki had put him through, Izuku still understood him, why he had such a deep hatred for feeling weak, why his life was centered around becoming the best. As toxic as it surely was, Izuku would never fault Katsuki for following his dreams, even if his approach probably wasn't the most… orthodox.

In their first few weeks at UA, Izuku caught himself watching Katsuki in everything he did. The way he used his quirk, the way he *always* had a strategy, even in the smallest exercises. Katsuki's mind worked just as quickly as Izuku's, if not quicker, anticipating the world before it happened to him.

Izuku's feelings towards Katsuki had been a point of confusion for him for so long. He'd admired him, first and foremost, for all of the things that make Katsuki, Katsuki. He'd hated him, if only for brief flashes in middle school, during which he wished Katsuki could see that they weren't all that different, at the core of things. They both wanted the same thing, they both came from the same place, they both looked up to the same person. It was Izuku's shortcoming that set them apart, that forced miles between them, miles that he wasn't sure he would ever be able to overcome. As fast as Izuku tried to move, Katsuki was always just a little bit faster, increasing the distance between them, existing just out of his view. So he'd stopped hating Katsuki, and Izuku had hated himself instead.

It made things easier, back then, to look at himself through Katsuki's lens. To see nothing but a quirkless kid who had dreams far bigger than he could ever hope to accomplish.

Easier, yes, but never less painful.

Izuku had been accepted to UA, though, same as Katsuki. A feat in itself, but Izuku felt so pitifully far behind. Working with All Might had led to an increase in his physical capabilities, but having control over his quirk in the way that his classmates had from living with their quirks for the last decade didn't exist for Izuku. He tried and failed, consistently, to master the power that All Might had given him, and while he eventually got a handle on his power, he still felt like he would never reach the level of his classmates. They used their quirks as if they were simply an extension of their bodies, while Izuku had to consciously call upon his for their entire first semester.

And while Izuku hadn't improved as much as he had wanted in terms of his quirk at the beginning of the school year, everything else had been so overwhelmingly *bright* compared to his life before.

For the first time in his life, people had chosen Izuku. From the first day, Uraraka had stood at Izuku's side, unaware of the fact that he had been quirkless his entire life. When she discovered Izuku's quirk, at the same time as him, she hadn't pushed closer solely based on the potential of his power. Her value of him had never been through the lens of the power that he possessed, and she'd been his first friend at UA. Maybe the first person Izuku could even refer to as a friend.

Iida had been soon after, which had been somewhat of a surprise after their… initial start. But after Iida had admitted his respect for Izuku for his actions during the entrance exam, Izuku had decidedly moved up in the world. His first day had earned him two friends, both of whom looked at him for the person he was and nothing more. They'd chosen him.

Todoroki had joined their ranks soon after, with the events of the Sports Festival. Izuku had always had the desire to save sitting dormant just beneath the surface of his skin, and it manifested in ways that weren't always straight-forward. *Saving* had always been an ideal that Izuku placed highest on his list, and his fight with Todoroki had redefined his idea of what it meant. Saving didn't always have to mean protecting someone from a villain or immediate danger; he'd learned that, after seeing the way Todoroki had been so inhibited by the relationship with his father that Izuku hadn't understood at the time. Izuku wondered if his reasons for trying to pull Todoroki's power from him had been selfish, born of his own jealousy at never having a quirk that was his own. Regardless, Izuku had wanted to show Todoroki that he could make his inherited quirk completely his own, without the stain of Endeavor hanging over him.

That translated into how Izuku had felt about his own quirk. His debt to All Might would never fade, not when All Might had handed Izuku his dream in the form of a singular golden hair, and their relationship wasn't comparable to Todoroki and Endeavor's in the slightest, but Izuku had understood him in a way that Todoroki hadn't seemed to be used to. Izuku, more than anything, wanted to turn One for All into his own power, something that he took and molded. So he'd known what Todoroki had been feeling, and Izuku's devotion to saving those around him had outweighed his desire to win the Sports Festival.

After that, Todoroki had shown up for him, more than once, without question. Everything about it had felt so alarming and uncharted, but Izuku had adjusted, because that's what he had always done.

Izuku had been *happy* in a way that he hadn't been throughout his entire life, with people that saw him as something more. It didn't erase the words that had followed him, from the time he had been five years old and deemed worthless. None of that would go away, but Izuku hadn't gotten where he stood, at the most prestigious hero school, from letting things hold him back. The words had been just that: words. And as someone who had way too much time on his hands, in the absence of friends and a quirk to train, Izuku had become an expert on understanding the people around him.

Was that why he had never slipped into truly hating Katsuki, after everything? Because Izuku could look at him and see what they had once been? Kids together, ripping open twin All Might cards, pretending to be heroes on the playground, huddling under blankets after one of their mothers told them to go to bed and watching the latest All Might video. Izuku had come to realize that things didn't just *happen* . Katsuki hadn't become sharp and cruel and full of arrogance of his own accord. He'd been a product of an environment that had placed him on a pedestal, that had taught him that weakness was a bad thing. Izuku had never been able to hate him, not after seeing the pressures of Katsuki's mother firsthand. Her comments on Katsuki's weaknesses, which had led to Katsuki hiding them from the rest of the world and hating himself for even having weaknesses to begin with.

Often, Izuku found himself wondering who Katsuki would have been if he would have had a mother like his own, who had always shown Izuku the value in accepting help from others and understanding the areas in which he could improve. When Izuku had shed tears, time and time and time again, Inko had comforted him, no matter the situation. She'd reminded him of his own strengths, of how important it was to remember that he could only control himself and his actions. When Katsuki had turned on Izuku and pushed him away, Inko had told Izuku that some people weren't raised to understand others, that Katsuki hadn't yet learned to look past surface level.

If Katsuki had had a mother who would wipe his tears instead of cursing him for being weak, if he had had a mother who had taught him that accepting the help of others wasn't a bad thing, where would he have been?

Surely, a lot further ahead than he already was.

Having a deeper understanding for Katsuki and the reasons behind the person that he was, gave Izuku a lot of respect for him, even when he probably should've done everything to push himself away. But Izuku had always been so drawn to Katsuki and his power, how amazing he had been since birth. Izuku had tricked himself into thinking that, maybe now that he held a power comparable to Katsuki's, Katsuki's opinion of him would change, and he would stop seeing Izuku as a pitiful excuse of a person.

That hadn't been the case, and, instead, Izuku had watched as Katsuki grew closer to their classmates in the way that Izuku had craved since he had lost that notion of friendship they had once shared.

Izuku hated himself for the way that it had bothered him, hated the jealousy that overwhelmed him at seeing Katsuki willingly work with others and open himself up to them in ways that he'd never been able to have.

Look at me , Izuku would think, watching as Katsuki sat with Kirishima and Kaminari. *I have power now. I'm not worthless.*

All of Izuku's yearning for a shred of approval from Katsuki, and yet he never seemed to get it. Not when he beat Katsuki in their very first exercise, or when he excelled at the Sports Festival, or even when Izuku had come to Katsuki's aid after he'd been kidnapped.

Izuku couldn't be mad about the fact that Katsuki had only seemed to respect Kirishima for rescuing him, not when Izuku had done exactly what Katsuki had hated about him their entire lives. It still hurt though, that he and Kirishima were so similar, and yet Izuku could never seem close to earning Katsuki's respect.

What was worse than Katsuki accepting Kirishima's help and pushing Izuku's away, was the smaller things. Katsuki's rare laughter at one of Kirishima, Kaminari, Sero, or Mina's jokes, his acceptance of their help every so often, the way Katsuki did things for them that went unnoticed by most. The things that Izuku *always* noticed. When they moved into the dorms and Katsuki staked claim to the kitchen, he seemed to take note of his friends' favorite foods, their distastes, their allergies. His attitude never changed, and he didn't coddle them, but there was something about the way he treated them that Izuku craved. Care and attention, but not

overbearing or constricting. Smaller notions that said *I care* . Moments that weren't in the slightest bit big and flashy, but were affectionate in their own way.

It was moments like those that Izuku sought. He wanted to be on the receiving end of those moments; he wanted to know how it felt to be cared about by Katsuki.

More than Izuku's curiosities about what it felt like to be cared about by Katsuki, he admired the person he had grown up with. Izuku could live with being cast aside, so long as he could watch Katsuki become the hero that he had always been in Izuku's eyes.

The year stretched on, and as UA made its mark on Izuku in way of his strength and power, it began to shape Katsuki in a different way, one that Izuku couldn't overlook. Changes were arduous and didn't always offer evidence immediately, but Izuku always took notice. He saw it in the way Katsuki paid Kirishima back after the incident at Kamino, and how he knocked Jirou out of the way during the training exercise against Class B. It was impossible for Izuku to *not* notice, really. He'd always been observative, taking in every little detail around him and committing it to memory, but when it came to Katsuki, there was such an intense urge inside Izuku, to know everything there was to know about him.

Because that's what it was, right? Izuku was drawn to his power, because he had never had it for himself. Izuku was drawn to his strength and his ambition and his perseverance, because that's who Izuku wanted to be.

Right?

Blackwhip had come into Izuku's life aggressively, so it was only fitting that training the quirk went as such. After its manifestation, in the weeks leading up to winter break, Izuku trained tirelessly, reminiscent of when All Might had first given him One for All. When Aizawa had his back turned during lecture, Izuku would practice controlling the power in smaller, more focused methods. He'd use it to move a pen from one side of his desk to the other, or to flip to the next page in his textbook. All the while, he tried to keep his focus on the class material, determined to be able to summon the quirk as second nature.

Some days, Izuku ate lunch as quickly as he possibly could, then spent the remainder of their break doing various exercises in the shade of the UA tower dedicated to the Hero course. He kept himself wrapped in layers, ignoring the chattering of his bones and the lack of feeling in his fingers and toes.

After he finished the school day, Izuku would run through his typical training regimen, which he had kept up since the beginning of the school year. His routine varied day-by-day, with the focal point being strength training four days of the week. The other three days were split between cardio and combat training. When he finished up with his workout for the day and scribbled his way through his homework, Izuku would make his way over to the campus training facility to meet with All Might and, surprisingly, Katsuki.

Katsuki had joined their meetings ever since Blackwhip had manifested, and even though his expression was bored and agitated throughout the meetings, he seemed to take in a lot of what All Might told them. He began showing up to training soon after, with his arms crossed

and a scowl on his face, but he continued to come to the evening training sessions, even when Izuku assured him that he could train on his own.

Izuku didn't try to trick himself into thinking that Katsuki was doing it out of the goodness of his heart; All Might had asked Katsuki to train with Izuku because he was the only one who knew the secret behind One for All. Izuku had known Katsuki long enough to know that he didn't do things that offered him nothing in return.

That had been the vision Izuku had held of Katsuki for all their lives. For as much as he admired Katsuki, he still recognized his flaws. Which was why he'd been so surprised by Katsuki's sudden willingness to help Izuku.

During the training exercise between 1A and 1B, Izuku had felt so drawn to Katsuki, which wasn't abnormal. What was abnormal, however, was the way Katsuki had seemed to *want* his attention. Like he was trying to prove something to Izuku.

Maybe he had wanted to show Izuku that he'd learned how to work as a team, or that he was starting to consider the safety of others around him, like when he'd kicked Jirou out of the way. Whatever it was, Izuku hadn't been able to look away from him; he'd been entranced by his skills, by his constant improvement. When Izuku had been up to fight, he'd found himself hoping that Katsuki was watching Izuku the same way Izuku had watched him.

Training didn't start off perfect, by any means, because it was still Izuku and Katsuki at the end of the day. Izuku left the facility with scorched eyebrows on more occasions than he cared to keep track of. For the first few weeks, they didn't speak much more than was necessary; they'd toss back and forth ideas for the best ways to train Blackwhip, and Izuku would listen to Katsuki's grumbled theories about how to prepare for the quirks of the other vestiges. They'd walk back to the dorms together, mostly in silence, with Izuku trailing a few steps behind. He didn't mind the quiet between them, though. It was comfortable, and something Izuku had been chasing after since he had been a child. Every once in a while, he'd talk about an assignment or a training exercise from that week or an article he read, and every once in a while, Katsuki would slow his pace and listen. Izuku tried to pretend it didn't mean anything to him, that Katsuki didn't immediately tell him to shut up and get out of his way, that he didn't seem to mind Izuku's rambling. He listened, and occasionally offered his own input. Izuku tried even harder to pretend like his heart didn't stutter in his chest when Katsuki's gaze turned thoughtful and gave a true response, one that didn't make Izuku feel as if he'd strung together the dumbest stream of words imaginable.

Some days, Izuku would check his phone to find a text from Katsuki, which was something he was still trying to adjust to. Katsuki would tell him to meet him in the gym or at the track, or he would text him, simply saying *spar?* Every time, Izuku's heart sped up at the prospect of spending time with Katsuki, something he had been craving ever since he had lost it as a child. He'd spent too long watching Katsuki from afar, fighting off feelings of jealousy as he trained with Kirishima, or played video games with Kaminari, or let Mina rant to him while he cooked dinner. Maybe a little desperately - or recklessly - Izuku hoped that Katsuki was accepting that Izuku had never looked down on him, that he didn't have some insane ulterior motive to exploit Katsuki's weaknesses.

One afternoon, as spring settled over UA and Izuku finished studying for their upcoming exam on the theories of quirk evolution, his phone buzzed on the corner of his desk.

Kacchan

campus pool tn

Deku

Swimming? Do you think that could help with the other quirks somehow?

I don't really know how effective Blackwhip would be in water but it's definitely an interesting thought

If you think it's worth a shot I want to try :)

What were you thinking?

Kacchan

jesus you mumble over text too

just wanted to fucking swim

Deku

Oh!!!

Okay!!! What time?

Kacchan

9

That's how Izuku found himself at the pool later that evening, when darkness had fallen over UA, and the lamp posts had come to life. Clouds shielded the stars that night, and the moon occasionally peeked through the cover, a slim crescent. The air was still chilly, but the pool was comfortably heated.

They swam for what felt like hours without talking much, besides the typical jab at the other, all in the notion of competitiveness.

The sun wasn't shining, and had slipped below the horizon until the next morning, but as Izuku floated beside Katsuki on his back after their umpteenth race, he felt as if he had been bathed in the light of the sun on its most intense day, drawn into its orbit. One day, he would inevitably get too close and go up in flames.

Izuku had no intention of fighting it, though.

The people around him had been telling him he had no sense of self-preservation for nearly the last year, and he hadn't done a single thing to disprove them. This, whatever *this* was,

between him and Katsuki was no exception. Their relationship had followed so many different paths over their mere 16 years of life, had taken on so many shapes and labels that Izuku almost struggled to keep up. If he blinked, everything could change, and all of the carefully placed bandages might fall away and they would return to snarled *stupid Deku* s and tearfully murmured *Kacchan* s.

Izuku was happy to fall into Katsuki's orbit, though. He'd probably always been there anyway.

Because Izuku was observative, and had been for his entire life, he didn't miss the way things had changed, or the way Katsuki had changed. Some days, it felt as if Katsuki was screaming at him to notice, to take stock of every single thing about him, and Izuku had no problem complying. He noticed the way Katsuki worked a little harder to be a teammate, or the way he put more effort into the group of friends that constantly surrounded him. Every so often, on those occasions, Izuku would catch Katsuki looking at him, waiting for Izuku to notice. And Izuku did notice, every time, without fail. He didn't need Katsuki to search for acknowledgement from him, not when that had been a given in their relationship since they were children.

Izuku couldn't place *why* Katsuki wanted him to pay attention to the changes, though. Was he trying to ensure a positive image for himself after he graduated UA and went pro? Did he think Izuku would bring up their childhood to smear his public image?

Out of all of Izuku's theories, those were the ones he found least likely. He even laughed at himself for thinking them to begin with; Katsuki didn't *care* about what the public thought of him, a fact that he made abundantly clear.

Katsuki was less rough around Izuku now, his typicality toned down. If Izuku could guess when that had happened, he would trace it back to Ground Beta, when Izuku told him he'd never looked down on him, had never seen him as weak. It was as if Katsuki had needed only that admission to start seeing Izuku in a different light, as more of a rival than as an enemy. And soon after that, they'd formed a common ground, where they could both rely on each other.

Izuku held that fact close to his heart. He'd always looked to Katsuki throughout his life. He'd been the high point of so many things - of intelligence, of physical capability, of battle strategy. It finally seemed that Katsuki was looking to Izuku as more than just a quirkless kid.

Three hours after they'd met at the pool, they pulled themselves onto the edge, a comfortable amount of space between them. Izuku gazed down at their feet splashing in the water, distorted as the surface of the pool rippled. The evening reminded him of Ground Beta, when it had just been the two of them and their myriad of problems beneath an undisturbed sky. The overwhelming urge to say *something* , to show Katsuki that he could be vulnerable too, overpowered his anxiety of scaring Katsuki off.

Softly, Izuku said, "I watched Nighteye die."

Katsuki stayed quiet for a moment, letting the words settle into the atmosphere. Izuku was afraid he wasn't going to respond when he finally asked, "What, when he got impaled?"

“In the hospital.”

“Oh.”

“Yeah.”

Izuku would probably never forget the way Nighteye had looked at him, the way Nighteye had *looked* , hooked up to so many machines, a mask obscuring his face. His words rang in Izuku’s head more often than he wanted to admit, his cryptic speech about Izuku changing the future. He’d died soon after, with a smile on his face, and though he’d been positive as he lay there dying, Izuku had walked away from the encounter feeling like he could never go back to the person he had been before. His life had suddenly felt so *fragile* . A professional hero, with his own agency and years of experience, had died so… *easily* . Like a flame snuffed out.

Izuku laughed sarcastically. If Nighteye could die that easily, he didn’t want to think about his own chances.

“Laughing about your dead ex-boss? That’s fucking shitty of you.”

“No, no!” Izuku waved his hands in front of his face hurriedly. “I was… just thinking.”

Katsuki kept looking at him out of the corner of his eye, his expression growing more annoyed the longer Izuku stayed silent. “Gonna share with the class?”

“I don’t know. Just… seeing someone that I had thought was so powerful… die. I don’t know,” he repeated. “I guess it’s the same as when we saw All Might… you know.” Izuku hurriedly shifted the conversation away from *that* topic. “I mean, if *pros* that have so much experience and so much training can die just like that, it just makes me feel… so far behind, I guess. Like it could happen to anyone.”

“Yeah, well.” Katsuki kicked one leg, disturbing the surface of the pool. Ripples ebbed away from them, distorting their reflections. He spoke again after the water returned to its undisturbed state. “Death is kind of part of our job, you know. Should’ve thought about that before pigging out on All Might’s hair.”

Izuku looked across the pool, up towards the four-towered UA campus. On his very first day, he hadn’t been thinking about the concept of death; it had seemed so far away, something that wouldn’t come into play until he actually became a pro. He wasn’t thinking about watching the people around him get seriously injured or die, and he certainly hadn’t been thinking about the possibility of his own death.

Things had started to become real at the summer camp, after a number of their classmates had been injured and Katsuki had been kidnapped. Izuku had started to realize, after being helpless to save the person that he had known the longest, that the heroes were keeping the rest of the world in the dark regarding the dangers they were up against. If Izuku hadn’t been so absorbed by his own tunnel vision back then, maybe he would have been angry at the pros and the Hero Public Safety Commission for glossing over things that were a serious concern and being unable to help teenagers who barely had any training. Nobody knew what they

were up against, and the Commission kept everything tied up nice and pretty from the comfort of their offices and conference rooms. Even as heroes-in-training, they hadn't been briefed on what to expect from *any* of the villains they were up against. What Izuku had come to learn regarding the League of Villains had been from his own experiences with them, experiences that he probably shouldn't have had as a first year hero student.

Still, even after his exposure to a number of traumatic events and villains that scared seasoned pros, Izuku wasn't deterred.

"I'm not scared of dying," he told Katsuki.

He scoffed. "Fucking obviously. You wake up in the morning and decide to throw yourself into harm's way at your first chance."

Izuku cracked a small smile. He looked at Katsuki, a quick glance that he hoped Katsuki wouldn't catch.

The world was going to shit left and right.

Japan had begun looking at the pro Heroes with less and less faith as conspiracies drifted from the Paranormal Liberation Front. The Nomu attack on Hawks and Endeavor had left the influence of Heroes diminished, with more and more civilians turning their noses up at pros. Izuku wasn't blind to the criticism UA had been consistently facing since the beginning of the school year, and the accusations that the school was ill-equipped to protect its own students. There had been a number of injuries, a kidnapping, a lost quirk. The image Izuku had held of Hero society and UA was flickering.

But, here he was, sitting at the edge of the campus pool, *smiling* with Katsuki. Katsuki was sitting with him, unbothered by his presence, not jumping up to leave, even though they'd finished training almost an hour earlier. His face was calm, his responses were still snappy, but lacking any actual harbored anger towards Izuku.

The world could go to shit for a little bit longer, Izuku decided. Selfishly, he wanted to sit on the edge of that pool forever, smiling at the jokes that Katsuki made, talking about the things he needed to talk about to someone who understood. Because even if they didn't always see eye-to-eye, (actually, they rarely did) Katsuki was typically the only one to understand. He'd known Izuku at every single stage of his life, even if he had hated him, and Katsuki, out of anyone, probably knew exactly why this mattered so much to him.

It had been a bumpy path to get to this moment. Actually, scratch that. Izuku would compare it to hiking over a volcano in sandals up until now.

They'd gotten past it, though, if only to be able to sit beside each other, comfortable in the other's presence. Katsuki was still harsh, rough around the edges in a way that had become somewhat endearing to Izuku, and Izuku had clearly proven himself in some regard, enough so that Katsuki willingly spent time with him.

He thought back to their childhood, to hours spent on the playground pretending to be heroes, making up quirks and hero names and scuffling in the dirt, much to their mothers' disdain.

Then he thought of middle school, of Katsuki's aggression towards him, of the overwhelming amount of *space* between them, as if they'd never known each other to begin with. They were here now, though.

"You *should* be scared to die," Katsuki said, his voice rough. "It'd probably do you pretty good to be at least somewhat fucking rational whenever you're fighting someone."

"Yeah, well," Izuku said sheepishly, tugging at the still-wet curls at the base of his neck. "I guess I just don't think about my own safety in those types of situations."

"You *guess* ? I could've told you that after the, what, tenth time you broke every single bone in your body. I mean, shit, Deku, who the fuck else willingly breaks their bones over and over and *keeps fighting* ? I can't decide if you're really a badass or just one stupid motherfucker."

Izuku ignored the way the compliment (because that was definitely a compliment, *right* ?) made his cheeks feel hot. "If I was worried about dying, I wouldn't be thinking about saving people."

Katsuki scoffed, his expression twisting from jokingly annoyed to agitated. "Can't save people from the afterlife. What are you going to do when you can't come back from it and you really kick the bucket, huh?"

Izuku looked away, unable to answer.

"It would be a real fucking waste for you to die in the middle of a battle because you won't think about yourself every once in a while instead of rushing in like an idiot."

"I made it as far as you, didn't I?" Izuku responded, surprised at the sharpness of his own voice. "You can't just call me an idiot all the time."

"You have an attitude problem." Katsuki glared at him pointedly. "Maybe you should stop hanging around me. And I can call you an idiot when you're being one, which is all the time."

"I don't need you to tell me how to fight," Izuku muttered, defensive, his fists clenching in his lap. "I know what I'm doing."

"If you really knew what you were doing, you wouldn't be training yourself to death and you'd think about your safety, too. Instead of fucking throwing yourself head first into everything without even *thinking* ."

"Why do you care?"

There was silence for a moment, during which Katsuki glared at him incredulously before standing and stomping off to the chair where he'd chucked his belongings. The pool was heated, but unfortunately, the air was not; Katsuki yanked a hoodie over his head. "See. All those notebooks and you're still dumb as shit. I mean, seriously."

"Kacchan-"

“Save it. I’m not in the fucking mood.” Katsuki turned away from him, and Izuku hurried to follow, but one glare had him stopping in his tracks.

He and Katsuki were more comfortable around each other now, sure, but Izuku was still afraid of that changing at the drop of a hat.

As he watched Katsuki stuff his feet into his shoes and stalk off towards the dorms, Izuku retraced their conversation, trying to pinpoint the moment he had messed up. It had been asking Katsuki why he cared, right? Was that what it was? Was Katsuki mad that Izuku thought he cared about him? Had Izuku read too far into things? Had he assumed that Katsuki cared about him just because they trained together, and knew each other’s secrets? Had he built a world on delusion, blinded by the time they’d spent together in the past few months that likely meant nothing?

Izuku cared about Katsuki, had always cared about Katsuki. Even when things had been bad between them, Izuku had never thought of Katsuki as someone he didn’t care for. It might have been the *pull* that Izuku had felt towards Katsuki his entire life, the tug that he felt for Katsuki’s raw power, his capabilities, his desire to be the best. All of it had drawn Izuku in when they were younger, as if Izuku could live out his dreams of becoming a hero through Katsuki. Because Katsuki would become a hero, Izuku was sure. He had never once doubted his childhood friend’s potential. But it had become something *more* when he finally got the chance to see Katsuki for who he was, outside of the image of heroism that Izuku had placed on him when they were children.

Izuku was still learning to navigate the many facets of Katsuki, the slippery footholds and the jutting peaks. He knew Katsuki was God-awful with words, and he was slowly learning how to translate his actions, how to piece them together into sentences and paragraphs and pages. He didn’t always get it right, and he didn’t always understand Katsuki’s anger and frustration and his everything-else-going-on that he didn’t talk about.

When he pulled away that lens he had placed years ago, he saw the many faces of Katsuki over the years. Chubby cheeks and grimy fingers on a playground. Ambitious eyes and raised fists against older kids. Toothy grins and cheerful laughter as they took turns chasing each other around Katsuki’s couch. Sparking hands and angry words. Twisted snarls and tears borne of insecurity. An expression, softened by common ground and acceptance. Hands that Izuku so often reached for in battle, that he so often wanted to hold when he wasn’t fighting for his life.

When he took away the image he had plastered onto Katsuki’s existence, he saw him as a child and as a middle schooler and as a teenager. He saw every bad moment, every time he’d snapped at others or fell too heavily onto his ego.

He saw a boy who hadn’t quite figured it out yet, who hadn’t had someone to nurture him and hear his insecurities or help him build on his weaknesses. He saw a boy who was stronger than anybody else he had ever met, who had more potential than a number of pro heroes and a spirit to match. Izuku saw someone he couldn’t turn away from, because he *understood* . Because he wanted to watch Katsuki grow. He wanted to grow with him.

Sleep, which was already frequently interrupted by his own anxieties and nightmares, evaded him that night.

What confused Izuku the most, though, was why the memory of Katsuki stepping away from him, the defined muscles in his back flexing as beads of water slid towards his waistband, seemed to hang at the forefront of his mind every time his eyes slid shut.

Chapter End Notes

hi thank you for reading!! I really struggle with doing izuku's pov just because I feel like I can put more emotion into katsuki's so I hope this is good! I promise there will be more plot stuff in the next chapter (this is another exposition one to kind of lay everything out)
if you're planning on sticking around, I'm hoping to update pretty frequently and I'll be updating the tags as I go. I have a good majority of this written but im just trying to fill in the gaps and add more plot thingies
I wrote a lot of this fic either after doing shots over winter break or on oxy when I got my wisdom teeth out SO
love yall, kudos and comments appreciated <333

let down

Chapter Summary

> you know, you know where you are with
> you know where you are with
> floor collapsing
> floating, bouncing back

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

If Katsuki were to create a diagram tracking the level of care he had towards Izuku throughout his life, it would have been high up until elementary school, slightly above zero through middle school and the beginning of first year, and then it had peaked at some point unknown to him after their fight at Ground Beta.

Seeing Izuku improve, though it had enraged him at first, the thought of someone who had been so *incapable* catching up to him easily, had wormed its way into his brain. He couldn't ignore the potential that Izuku had, even without All Might's stupid ass quirk. He'd been like that since middle school, so observational that it pissed Katsuki off to no end, because *nothing* got past Izuku. He was at least five steps ahead, always; he knew the ins and outs of literally every quirk to ever exist, was way too good at coming up with plans and gear to fit said quirks.

Then he had showed up to UA, looking like he'd turned into some bodybuilder wannabe overnight, and Katsuki had been so *confused* as to how that had completely failed to catch his attention in middle school.

So, yeah, he felt quite a bit fucking inferior when Izuku showed up with his powerful quirk, completely ripped, with his nerdy-ass notebook clenched in his shaking fists. He'd only felt *worse* when he caught on to Izuku and All Might's private training sessions, their lunches behind closed doors, their absurdly frequent text messages.

Figuring out Izuku's secret, especially after watching All Might fall *because of him,* had really been the cherry right on top of it all. He'd been so *powerless* , so *useless* , when the League had taken him, when that stupid patchwork-faced fuck had wrapped his clammy fingers around Katsuki's neck, just tight enough to be a warning. If he hadn't been claustrophobic after the Sludge villain and Dabi's hand around his neck, he sure as hell was after being chained up in the corner of that dark bar, listening to the League tell him exactly how he came across: a scummy villain like them.

It's not like Katsuki wasn't *aware* he had an attitude problem. Okay, maybe a personality problem, he could admit that. He just hadn't expected so many people to be so convinced that he could be the same as the bottom-of-the-barrel trash that had kidnapped him. At a school summer camp, no less.

Being clued into the fact that the League and a good majority of civilians thought there was even a *chance* he could become a villain, and then watching All Might lose the last of his power all because that generalization had been made in the first place…

Yeah, Katsuki had decided it was probably time for a little bit of reform, or whatever.

That weekend home, before Aizawa and All Might had marched in and proposed their dorm idea, Katsuki had been quiet. He knew his parents noticed, knew that they were being gentle with him in a way that made him so fucking angry. When he walked into the living room, they would pause whatever hushed conversation they were having and give him tight-lipped smiles. When he went to wash dishes, as had been his chore for most of his life, his mom would brush him off and do it herself.

He didn't want their fucking pity. He didn't want them tip-toeing around him, shielding him from what he couldn't be more aware of.

His personality had led to the demise of the hero had admired his entire life.

He'd put the pieces together over the course of that weekend, All Might's point and his prophetic words, Izuku's tearful reaction. If he hadn't known Izuku their entire lives, he would have thought he was blubbering like an idiot just like the rest of the people watching the live stream. Izuku's tears were different that day, though, and his eyes had been wider than normal, a certain type of understanding reflecting All Might's withered figure.

The day after he returned home, his parents had been quiet, as if they'd missed the lesson on how to talk to their teenage son who had just experienced the most traumatic event of his life so far.

His father had made the spicy ramen he liked for dinner, and both of his parents had sat there, chewing their food, saying nothing.

It took about two minutes for Katsuki to lose his mind.

"Can you two just fucking say something? I'm not going to, like, fall apart, holy *shit* ."

"Katsuki," his father reprimanded, but it lacked the stern tone he typically took when Katsuki swore at them.

And then all hell broke loose, and Katsuki *almost* wished he was back in Kamino instead of dealing with this shit.

Tears bubbled up in his mother's eyes and then burst, slipping down her face and dripping onto the table. Katsuki wrinkled his nose as he watched her rub at her eyes. His father looked like he was close behind her, sniffling a few times and avoiding eye contact.

“We’re *worried* about you, you ungrateful brat,” his mother said, her voice distorted by her sobs. “You’ve been different since you came home and you won’t talk to us about it.”

“You can watch the whole thing on TV.”

“Your mother isn’t talking about what happened. She’s worried about how you’re handling it.”

“I’m fucking fine.”

His mother finally got ahold of herself, wiping away the last of her tears. Her face was red and her cheeks were puffy, and he realized this was the first time he had ever seen her cry. “We just want to know if you’re okay. We can get you a therapist-”

“Hell no, you think I want to go talk to some stranger about my problems in some stuffy ass office? You gonna pay someone to tell me to take deep breaths and count to ten?”

Masaru gave him a disappointed look, his eyebrows pulling together. “It might help you.”

“Going to therapy will piss me off a lot more than dealing with my own shit.”

“We just want you to talk to us.” Mitsuki reached for his hand, but Katsuki ripped his back, glaring at her. “Were you scared? Are you worried they’re going to come after you again?”

“If I was a fucking crybaby, I wouldn’t have signed up to be a hero in the first place,” he said dryly.

“We were scared you were going to die, Katsuki.”

His father’s tone was deadly serious, in the way it only had been a few times throughout his life when he was in “serious trouble.”

Katsuki hadn’t been a delusional preteen like *someone* he knew; he knew that pros died daily, knew that the job was dangerous and that he couldn’t expect other people to have his back.

The one thing that had slipped his mind, though, was the fact that there were people that cared if he died.

His parents had supported his dream his entire life; his mother had bought him mounds of hero merch, and his father had taken him to every single hero movie on the day they released. Conversations like this one, about his safety, hadn’t come up. His mother had doted on him his entire life, telling him how powerful he was, how he would be able to beat any villain in the future. His parents had never shown signs of doubt, like they were right then, that he couldn’t handle anything thrown at him.

His fingers twisted in his shirt under the table, sweat building on his palms.

They doubted him.

For the first time in his life, his parents were treating him like he wasn’t capable.

“If you think I’m not going to be a hero because some fuck ass villains kidnapped me, I swear to-”

“We don’t doubt you,” his father said gently. “You’ve gone through a lot and you’re not even halfway through your first year at UA. We just want you to know that we’re here, Katsuki.”

He’d promised himself after the incident, after feeling the weight of destroying All Might settle on his shoulders and only his, that he wouldn’t be so much of a piece of shit.

Was it really possible that his parents weren’t looking down on him? That they weren’t doubting his potential? That the tears, the looks in their eyes, were all out of genuine concern for him?

Was that what Izuku had felt all those times? In the river when they were five, when the sludge villain attacked him, when Dabi’s bony fingers locked around his neck?

“Yeah,” he said finally, his feet bouncing restlessly under the table. He couldn’t handle their eyes on him any longer; he felt like he was going to explode. Whether it was out of anger or his inability to navigate his own emotions, he didn’t know. “Yeah. I know.”

Katsuki hadn’t opposed the dorm idea. Actually, he was grateful to get the hell away from his parents’ searching eyes. He’d packed his shit (not his own collection of All Might merch - miniscule compared to Izuku’s) and left as soon as possible, shrugging off his mother when she tried to hug him goodbye.

What he didn’t care for, after he had moved into the dorms, was the way his classmates had hopped around like everything was *fine* , like everything hadn’t changed, like they could just ignore what had just happened.

But things hadn’t changed for them in the way they had for Katsuki.

Of course his classmates could prance around, touring rooms and shouting incessantly without a care. They hadn’t been kidnapped. They hadn’t had the entire world look at them as a villain. They hadn’t ruined the one person they had admired all their lives and been powerless to help.

When he finally pieced together what Izuku had meant after that very first training exercise at UA when he’d said *borrowed power* , he hadn’t known what reaction to expect from Izuku. Katsuki had been too focused on fighting him, on proving that he didn’t need handouts from All Might to be the best. If he could still kick Izuku’s ass, then what the fuck had All Might passing on his power really done?

Izuku had dodged him a few times, narrowly missing Katsuki’s attacks. Katsuki had done his best to push down everything he was feeling at that moment; if there was anything he had over Izuku, it was the fact that he didn’t let his own emotions cloud his mind during a fight. He let his anger fuel him, let it add power to his attacks, but he wasn’t Izuku. He didn’t rush into things headfirst, thinking about his mushy feelings.

Izuku wasn't the child he'd once been, snot-nosed and whimpering. He'd looked at Katsuki, listened as he finally broke.

He hadn't been able to tell his parents what was going on; they wouldn't have understood. But Izuku had shared Katsuki's admiration for All Might their entire lives, and they'd shared a similar sense of emptiness when they'd watched All Might's power snuff out.

Even if he hadn't planned on having some fucking emotional breakdown in front of Izuku, well, there the fuck he was.

And yet, even as the words flowed past his lips in an uncontrollable stream, he couldn't find it in himself to regret it, or to feel ashamed. Ever since he'd seen the look in his parents' eyes, ever since he'd mistaken their concern for doubt, he'd been tracing back the events of his entire life, wondering if that's all it had ever been.

Izuku hadn't done anything wrong to him. All he had done was care about Katsuki.

And that evening, as Izuku dodged his blows and countered with kicks, which was entirely new and *really* pissed Katsuki off, he'd seen an opening.

He hadn't wanted to talk to Izuku or tell him how he was feeling, but that door had been open; it always had been. Whether or not Katsuki wanted to accept it, Izuku had always had his hand extended towards Katsuki, no matter the situation.

And here he was, with nobody else to understand the emotions running through his head, the insecurities that plagued him. The only person who would ever get it was Izuku.

Assignments for the raid on the Jaku City hospital were given out, delegated based on quirk abilities and strengths. The whole operation was kept quiet, hence the students only finding out a few days in advance and being threatened into silence by Aizawa. They weren't to tell their families or anybody else they spoke to that wasn't directly involved in the attack. The work study students were summoned for a few impromptu media training classes, held in one of UA's lecture halls. Midnight and Present Mic led the lessons, and ran through scenarios for what felt like hours.

Katsuki couldn't give less of a shit about media training bullshit. The reveal of the plot to invade both the Jaku City hospital and the Gunga Mountain Villa where the Paranormal Liberation Front was hiding had Katsuki itching to explode any and all villains in his way. Fuck that weird ass guy and his long ass nose, he was going to fuck shit up.

Until assignments were delegated, and he found himself in the same classroom as Izuku, Todoroki, and a handful of their extra classmates, getting told by Aizawa that they would be assisting in evacuating civilians.

"This is fucking bullshit," he snapped as they were dismissed. Izuku trailed just behind him, a pensive look on his face.

"Well, we only have our provisional licenses, so I guess it makes sense for us to be kept off the front lines. Although that doesn't really add up, since we were allowed to help with the

raid on the Hassaikai. I mean, there's a ton of pros so do they *really* need our help? I'm sure Endeavor will be able to handle himself, don't you think?"

Katsuki turned and leveled him with a stare. "You done?"

He could've told Izuku to cut out the muttering, but it was the only thing grounding him, keeping him from marching right up to Aizawa and telling him what a fat load of horseshit it was that he would be helping with *evacuating* .

Izuku looked down at his shoes as they walked down the hall. Katsuki ignored their classmates, who were unreasonably excited at being able to help with the raid. It wasn't like they were doing jack shit, anyways.

"Well… I trust the pros and the Commission, and if they think we're the best bet for evacuation, then I'm sure they're right."

Katsuki waited a whole three seconds before he got annoyed.

"But what? You've got that stupid ass look on your face like you can't figure something out."

"...I agree with you"

Katsuki could have fallen on the floor and died. *Izuku* was questioning the decisions of the pros, the Heroes that he put so much blind faith in and practically worshiped? Nevermind the tingling in Katsuki's gut at Izuku's agreement, that wasn't the focus.

"Your quirk isn't suited for evacuation."

"Oh, fuck you. I'll be fucking better than you at it."

"Kacchan," Izuku admonished, but his voice was tinged with amusement. "I'm serious, though. The pros know that your quirk is more suited for combat. It doesn't make sense why you wouldn't be placed at the villa, not when they could utilize your quirk and your strength."

Izuku loved to pull this shit, had loved doing it since they were children. And it was a very typical Izuku thing to do, tripping over himself to point out everyone's positive traits with a glowing smile on his face. Katsuki had been both a victim and a witness to Izuku's signature attack, and while it used to make him feel anger beyond rationale, this time, it left him feeling a strong sense of pride in himself and his abilities.

Before he could reply, the neighboring classroom's door flew open to reveal another gaggle of UA students. Some of their other classmates were part of the mix, namely Kirishima, Kaminari, Sero, and Mina, all of whom were grinning as they were moved along by the bustle of students surrounding them.

"Look who it is! What's up, Kacchan?" Kaminari made a beeline towards Katsuki and Izuku upon seeing them, a shiteating grin plastered on his face.

"Fuck you," was the only response he offered.

“Hi, Kaminari!” Izuku said cheerfully at the same time. “Where did you guys get assigned? Kacchan and I are helping out with evacuations in Jaku City. Some of our other classmates are too.”

“Oh, us?” Kaminari’s smirk grew even more cocky. “We’re helping out at the villa.”

“The fuck you are.”

Kirishima put a hand on Kaminari’s shoulder. “Hate to do this to you, man, but yeah. And Kaminari’s the bigshot.”

This day couldn’t get any fucking worse.

“You mean you guys are helping out with the raid on the villa? So cool!”

“Try not to be a big nerd about this, Deku. They’re probably sitting back while the pros handle it, just like we are.”

“Well, yeah,” Sero said, laughing awkwardly. “Except Kaminari.”

“Yeah, what did you mean ‘bigshot,’ Kirishima?”

“You’re looking at the most important guy behind the whole operation,” Kaminari said smugly.

Mina kicked his shin. “Stop acting like that. You looked like you accidentally ate Bakugou’s leftovers without permission after Midnight told you.”

Kaminari glared at her. “Why do you torment me, Mina?”

Katsuki couldn’t handle another second of this shit, because if Kaminari was being placed on the front lines instead of him, then clearly Hero society had taken a turn for the fucking worse. “Let me guess, they’re throwing your dumbass in as a distraction?”

“Are you jealous, *Kacchan* ?” Kaminari cooed, and Katsuki caught Izuku’s eyebrow’s wrinkling at the nickname. “I’m sure all that evacuating will be super exciting. Tons of villains for you to blow up and take all that anger out on.”

“I’ll kill you before you even fucking *see* a villain.”

“Relax, relax! No need to get all butthurt.”

Kirishima stepped between them just as a few small explosions popped in Katsuki’s palms. “There’s a guy with the Paranormal Liberation Front who has some sort of electrification quirk. They want to use Kaminari as a lightning rod.”

Jirou exited the classroom at that moment, using one of her earphone jacks to jab Kaminari in the back of the neck. “So long as he doesn’t chicken out,” she said before turning to walk with Yaoyorozu.

Kaminari watched her go. Mina and Sero let out twin *oooooo* 's.

"You all fucking suck," Katsuki said.

Izuku laughed.

Katsuki really should have known that everything would go to shit.

In between his own insolence at being sent to deal with squabbling grannies and his irritation with his classmates, he hadn't really thought about the attack going wrong.

At the end of the day, he and Izuku were so similar and so different. They both trusted the pro heroes with their lives, and with inside information from Hawks and about every hero in the country participating at either Jaku or Gunga, Katsuki had no reason to doubt. They clearly didn't fucking need him.

And yet, he'd seen that look on Izuku's face, his eyes shadowed, his face blank. There'd been something *wrong* and Katsuki would be damned if he didn't fucking fix it.

Everything went to shit after that, as it always seemed to, and Katsuki didn't have time to be a little smug that he'd been right to doubt the heroes for keeping him on evacuation protocol. Clearly they hadn't been able to handle their shit.

When Izuku turned away from the rest of their class, there wasn't even a moment to doubt Katsuki's own decision; there wasn't a world in which he wouldn't have followed.

He wasn't fucking worried about Izuku.

Realistically, he had known that, if he'd put anyone on par with himself, he'd grudgingly admit that it was Izuku (only to himself when he was completely alone). The nerd could handle himself in a fight a lot better than when they'd first come to UA, especially with his increased usage of One for All and the addition of Blackwhip. At one point, Katsuki had completely outmatched Izuku in physical strength and quirk. Now, Izuku was catching up to him.

It should have pissed him off. Instead, he was just excited.

So, it made no sense that he was worried about Izuku, and it was a tiny hindrance in the back of his brain. The voice in his head mumbled a slew of words, merging together incoherently. *What if he goes off on his own and Shigaraki finds him and he's not strong enough to beat him and he loses and he* dies-

Katsuki cut that voice off as quick as it started, because fussing over Izuku was futile. Izuku wouldn't face Shigaraki on his own, not if Katsuki had anything to do with it.

He took off immediately after Izuku, ignoring Todoroki's shouts. Following Izuku wasn't a question, not when he could see that look on Izuku's face that meant he was probably doing something at the expense of his own safety.

It was chaos from that moment forward, but Katsuki had lived his entire life in chaos, and he was a pro at navigating it. They're beyond the help of the pros, wherever the hell they are. Shigaraki's blast to the city had done a number on the organization of their forces, and the entire country's Hero population was split between Gunga and Jaku. Even if Katsuki had every single pro and their quirks memorized, it wouldn't have mattered; there was nobody who could save Izuku from his fate.

Propelling himself using his blasts was second nature to Katsuki, and he watched out of the corner of his eye as Izuku used both measured leaps boosted by One for All and Blackwhip to move through the city. Even with a new quirk, Izuku still moved in a way that was captivating. His movements were precise, succinct. He didn't flail, as he once had a year earlier. Even with the threat of Shigaraki looming, his shoulders were set with confidence and self-assurance. He spoke into his comm, his voice strong, even as Endeavor shouted back about being left in the dark.

"I'll get him away from anybody. Just get the civilians evacuated."

Katsuki liked that easy confidence on Izuku; it was something he could get used to.

And hearing him give an *order* to the number one hero?

Katsuki didn't really know what he was feeling after that one, but he wasn't about to start thinking about that on the middle of a battlefield.

"Bitching out the number one? What'd you do with the real Deku?"

"I'm not- don't be like that! He doesn't know about One for All and this is just the safest option. I don't want any civilians getting caught in the crossfire if it comes down to it and-

"Chill out, nerd. Didn't say it was a bad thing,"

"I wasn't trying to, uhm, bitch him out. I was just-"

"Deku. It was badass." Badass? Was that the word he was thinking of? Jesus. "And don't swear. Makes you sound like me."

Izuku glanced over at him, and through the dust, he could have sworn Izuku's cheeks were pink. Then his face went slack as he used Blackwhip to swing from a streetlight. "Wait, Kacchan, why are you following me?"

Katsuki boosted himself forward, catching up in a split second. "Gonna give that asshole what he deserves after chaining me up and trying to get me to drink the kool-aid."

"But-"

"You want all the glory for yourself, huh?"

Izuku's face was exasperated, like he had known Katsuki would say something like that. "*Kacchan* ."

He'd been both motivated by the thought of Izuku being left to fight Shigaraki alone and finally getting the chance to kick Shigaraki's crusty ass into the ground. Fuck that guy and his weird ass group of friends that got off on kidnapping teenagers and tried to coerce them into becoming a villain. And were they fucking *challenged* ? Kidnapping a teenager from the country's most prestigious hero school, really?

The comms went out as they neared a section of the city that had been practically leveled. Debris was piled everywhere Katsuki could see, which wasn't saying much; most of his vision was obscured by dust, which had already done a number on his lungs. He'd probably be hacking for the next week. Izuku glanced back at him just as the comms went down, his eyes wide. Through the clouds still rising from the debris and past the lightning dancing around Izuku, he could see a layer of dust coating him, settling in his hair and covering his freckles.

A *feeling* settled over Katsuki, a cold dripping sensation that doused his senses and made his entire body want to curl in on itself. It wasn't fear, no. He wasn't afraid of Shigaraki or whatever the hell else it could be; really, he was itching to fight the damn bastard.

But he couldn't shake off the dread that consumed him, so heavy it almost made him falter.

"Deku-"

And then Shigaraki was there, amidst the dust he had created and-

Since when is that guy ripped? And a fucking cape? Really?

Katsuki lifted his arm, ready to pull the pin on his gauntlet and call it a fucking day. He'd focused his blasts across the city, relying more on his right arm for propulsion and storing as much sweat as he could on his left. Shigaraki wouldn't survive him, and he sure as shit would *never* see Katsuki chained up again in his entire miserable life.

Beside him, he could feel Izuku preparing an attack. With the amount of training they had done together over the past few months, their bodies were in sync. Katsuki knew the ins and outs of Izuku's power, knew which attacks he favored. He knew which leg packed a more powerful kick, knew when Izuku tended to fall back on Air Force. Fighting beside Izuku was as easy as breathing.

Shigaraki's hand shot up, palm outstretched. His voice crawled over the ridges of Katsuki's spine. "Midoriya Izuku." There was a greed in his eyes, a sick and twisted want that made Katsuki want to explode him even more.

He didn't spare Katsuki a glance, which pissed him off even *more* . Shigaraki had gone through the trouble of planning an attack on a high school summer camp for the sole purpose of kidnapping Katsuki, but he couldn't even *acknowledge* him? What a fucking joke.

His ego could wait, though, because Izuku was already shooting towards Shigaraki, that determined look in his eyes, and Shigaraki's hand was *too close* to Izuku's head, and Katsuki could see it before it even happened. He could see Izuku crumbling, turning to dust right in front of him, and for the first time, he really was scared.

Izuku had been right, that evening in the pool, when he'd said all that bullshit about Nighteye dying easily. All it would take was five fingers and Izuku would be gone, nothing more than dust that would be whipped away. Katsuki wouldn't be able to piece him back together, and Izuku would be truly gone.

He didn't know why it scared him so much, but it did.

He reached for the pin on his grenade, because he sure as shit wasn't going to sit back and watch it happen, but there was a flash of yellow in his peripheral, and he was moving suddenly, so fast that the crumbled buildings blurred beneath him, a hand clasped around his wrist. He jolted in panic until Izuku's shrill voice shouted, "Gran Torino!"

Katsuki hadn't met the man before, but he knew Izuku had done his internship with him at the beginning of the school year. The man was tiny and old as shit, and he released his hold on Katsuki's wrist after only a few seconds, depositing him and Izuku on the ground. Shigaraki was still in their sightline, and a few other Heroes had arrived. Katsuki tracked Shigaraki as he shot through the air, twisting and dodging attacks from all sides.

"You got him away from the civilians and into an open area where he'll be easier to handle, and you got him into Eraser's field of vision. Those are quite the accomplishments," Gran Torino was saying.

Katsuki was all at once pissed off and relieved. He'd been so close to pulling the pin on his gauntlet and blasting Shigaraki to hell. There was only so much his regeneration could do in the face of a close-ranged blast, especially with the amount of sweat Katsuki had stored.

His relief, though, wasn't at the fact that he was no longer about to face off with Shigaraki. He'd seen that hand, tarnished and bruised, so close to Izuku's face. So close to reducing him to nothing.

Fucking Izuku. It was always something when it came to him, and Katsuki really had to have an epiphany over it in the middle of a war?

"All For One's quirks have been transferred to Shigaraki. I can't imagine a worse scenario than him stealing One for All," Gran Torino explained

There it was, the big cherry on top of the whole ordeal. Not only could Shigaraki reduce them to dust with one touch of his hand, he could also take their quirks. Which explained why he'd come after Izuku. So much for Katsuki's relief.

In the distance, Shigaraki was twisting and dodging attacks from Endeavor and Ryukyu. Gran Torino shot off towards the fight.

"We should-"

"You thought I was going to fucking wait around? You know better, Deku."

They moved at the same time, their movements syncing up instantaneously. Katsuki could see Shigaraki twisting towards Aizawa, his movements still so *fast* -

Izuku was faster, though. Katsuki smirked. *Checkmate, bitch.*

He redirected Shigaraki's course with a swift punch to the face, pushing him away from where Aizawa was supported by Rock Lock. Katsuki had seen the look in Izuku's eyes right before they'd reentered the fight; he knew how to read Izuku and his movements, had seen the gears turning in that disgustingly genius brain. Izuku flipped over Shigaraki and restrained him with Blackwhip just as Katsuki sent a cluster of aimed explosions for him. Their timing was impeccable, really. It should have pissed him off, that Izuku had known Katsuki would follow through with his plan, but it didn't. Izuku knew him well enough to know that he had thought the same thing. They'd had only seconds to devise a plan, and they had done so without even speaking or looking at each other. At that moment, Katsuki didn't feel behind.

They weren't Katsuki and Izuku, powerful and cocky, powerless and heroic. There wasn't a gap between them, with the leader changing each and every second. Izuku wasn't pulling away and Katsuki wasn't falling back.

Equals .

Endeavor sent Shigaraki flying with a blast that had Katsuki sweating from every pore on his body. He glanced at Izuku, who gave one sharp nod, and Katsuki was off, projecting himself around the fight, meticulously staying out of view of Shigaraki, who hadn't paid him any fucking mind to begin with.

Shigaraki dodged a blast of Endeavor's flames, his body angling towards Izuku, who had stayed in place on the ground.

Idiot . See how far it gets you to ignore me .

Katsuki set off the blast that he'd been saving, his body already preparing itself for the recoil from his gauntlets. The explosion was both ear piercing and earth shattering, and through the flames, Katsuki could see Shigaraki's body withering, his mouth open in a silent scream as the force of the blast and the heat slammed against him.

Izuku was there in an instant, aiming a kick at Shigaraki and sending him into Endeavor's path. Flames erupted, engulfing both the number one hero and Shigaraki. Katsuki landed beside Izuku, giving him a once-over before turning back to the fight. Shigaraki had dodged another blast from Endeavor and shot towards Aizawa, arm outstretched, slipping just past Katsuki and Izuku.

Katsuki knew fighting just as well as he knew himself. His body moved through practiced motions, and he pushed his growing fatigue down with every move he made. He could tell Izuku was in a similar state. At some point, Izuku had coughed up blood, and it dribbled down his chin. When Endeavor shot in and attacked Shigaraki, giving them momentary reprieve, Katsuki acted against his better judgement, lifting a gloved finger and wiping away the streak. As he did, Izuku's eyes never left his, his mouth slightly parted as he sucked in air.

"Don't fucking die on me, nerd."

Izuku's face was pink, which Katsuki assumed was from the exhaustion of attacking over and over and over again. He said, or rather, breathed, "Won't." It sounded ragged and spent and wondrous.

Izuku was tired. His body was sore, energy spent. His bones were broken, and he ignored his own mental warning about damaging them beyond repair. All he knew was *dodge, counter, attack* . His head was swimming, his body *hurt* . Every moment that he could take to breathe was simply excruciating. Being still sent all of his pain slamming right back into him.

He'd been doing his best to keep track of Katsuki as they fought side by side. When Katsuki had followed him, Izuku had done his best not to read into it. It didn't matter, it didn't matter, it didn't matter. Katsuki was doing it out of his own accord, not because he cared about Izuku.

When he'd lifted a hand to wipe the blood from Izuku's chin, well, that had done things to Izuku's heart. He'd seen Katsuki's gaze lingering on his mouth when he'd been almost unable to give a response.

Not the time, Izuku. Focus.

Focusing was hard after fighting for so long. He'd seen too much. The city had fallen. Aizawa had lost his leg. He wasn't sure what was happening at the villa, but things were growing dire in Jaku.

Izuku kept fighting, kept utilizing Float and Blackwhip to the best of his abilities. He used Blackwhip to reinforce his arms, creating a temporary splint even though it hurt so bad he had hissed and said, " *Fuck* ."

Katsuki had been at his side, eyes on his bruised and useless arms, but he'd *laughed* , and Izuku had about fallen out of the air. Katsuki didn't laugh often, and maybe he was delirious, but he had wanted, in that moment, to spend the rest of his life hearing that laugh.

"Don't fucking swear, Deku," Katsuki shouted at him, letting off explosion after explosion. "I told you you're starting to sound like me."

Before Izuku could respond, jagged streaks shot out from Shigaraki, right for him.

Izuku was so, so tired.

A force slammed into his side, pushing him away and, too late, Izuku realized.

Katsuki was there and Shigaraki's stolen quirk was there and it was too fucking late.

Ohfuckohfuckohfuckohfuck -

The image would be ingrained in his mind for the rest of his life. Katsuki, impaled in four places, his blood already soaking through his costume and bubbling past his lips, his face twisted in a grimace, as if he'd been preparing himself for the pain.

He'd shoved Izuku out of the way.

Shigaraki's attack had been meant for Izuku.

Katsuki had done that *for Izuku* .

It meant nothing. He hadn't done it because of anything more than wanting to be a hero. Right?

It could mean nothing. It could mean something.

It didn't matter. Katsuki could *die* from those wounds. He could die right then and there for Izuku and nothing would even matter after that. There wasn't a world that Izuku wanted to live in without Katsuki by his side.

Izuku was so far gone for him, so deeply infatuated with the person he had known since they were children. But things had been changing over the last few months, *Katsuki* had been changing. Izuku would be damned if Katsuki up and died for him before he even got the chance to see the changes between them all the way through.

It didn't matter if Katsuki survived and woke up hating Izuku for being the reason he almost died. Izuku could live with that. He could live with anything that wasn't losing Katsuki forever.

"Don't try… to win this… on your own," Katsuki said, his eyes just barely cracked open.

And then he fell.

Being confined to his hospital room after being barred from seeing Izuku was inching its way up the list of things that pissed Katsuki off to no end. He had been treated by some of the best doctors in the country, and he'd been following the directions of his nurses to a T. If there was one thing he didn't fuck around with, it was his chances at becoming a pro in the future (except for the time he, you know, almost died for his… for Izuku).

What *was* Izuku to him, really?

It was hard to pretend that they were just rivals. Only a few days earlier, Katsuki had shoved Izuku out of the way of Shigaraki's attack and had gotten four stab wounds as his reward. The rivets had pierced the entire way through his body, and his doctor had told him that he would have permanent scars. The internal damage had been healed by Recovery Girl and he'd been lucky that it hadn't been bad. One rivet had gone through his upper thigh, two had pierced his stomach, and the last through his shoulder. To preserve his energy, Recovery Girl and his doctors had decided to let his external damage heal on its own, even if it hurt like hell. It wasn't like the pain was a major concern, though, because after he woke up and immediately stormed Izuku's room, they'd increased his meds, tossing in something that made him feel serenely *calm* for the first time in his life.

After all of that, Katsuki couldn't keep considering Izuku as just a rival. They were past that. The entire time they'd been on the battlefield, they had fought as one, in perfect synchrony.

Izuku had never changed in the way he had treated Katsuki from when they were children. He'd never turned away from Katsuki, or regarded him with apathy. All their lives, he'd respected Katsuki, had viewed him as a *hero* . He'd offered Katsuki his hand time and time again, even when Katsuki had done nothing but push him away.

That wasn't what mattered though.

What mattered were the new aspects of their relationship. Izuku had begun to recognize when Katsuki was joking, and after so many months of training together, he laughed that wonderfully infectious laugh every time Katsuki made a comment. He knew Katsuki's schedule and routine, and on days when Katsuki had been particularly put-off, Izuku had shown up to their training sessions with boxes of takeout and the very specific brand of energy drink Katsuki liked. Izuku had been there for Katsuki's childhood and knew about his very complicated relationship with his mother. When they had long weekends home from UA, Izuku would offer to meet him for a run or to work out or to review for upcoming exams. Katsuki was too proud to admit that he hated going home, even to his dumbass group of friends, but he didn't have to explain himself to Izuku.

Speaking of dumbass friends.

They'd barged their way into his hotel room after Kaminari and Jirou had been cleared, and since he was placed on very strict orders from his doctors for the first few days after he woke up, he was subjected to their blabbering with no escape.

"Tell us about the battle," Mina was begging. "I mean, obviously you weren't scared because you're *you* but it had to have been pretty intense."

She was sitting at the foot of his bed beside Kirishima, which had resulted in Kaminari pouting and claiming that Katsuki was "picking favorites" when he hadn't kicked them off.

"Didn't you fucking read the report?"

"Of course we did," she said, waving him off. "But it left everything about us out. Which is, by the way, kind of weird, don't you think?"

That was another thing Katsuki was dying to talk to Izuku about, which was an odd realization to come to terms with. The nerd would surely spout off a million theories at a mile a minute, and Katsuki would complain about his mumbling but listen to each and every word.

"It's fucked up is what it is," he muttered.

"The Commission is facing a lot of criticism right now," Jirou pointed out. She sat on the arm of the chair closest to Katsuki's bed, which was occupied by Kaminari. "Losing All Might and then finding out everything that we just heard about Endeavor definitely threw everyone for a loop on what they thought about heroes. Imagine how it looks having a bunch of teenagers fight a war for them."

“I wanted to kill that crusty ass bastard. Would’ve served him right for kidnapping me.”

“I still can’t believe you and Midoriya faced him,” Sero said. “Kaminari would’ve pissed his pants.”

“Be nice,” Kaminari whined.

“We know you weren’t scared but what about Midoriya?” Kirishima asked.

“Yeah,” Jirou said. “He’s usually pretty good in a fight but I remember when he was, like, a walking anxiety attack.”

Katsuki thought back to the battlefield and remembered Izuku at his side, shoulders back, eyes determined. He’d been a perfect mask of confidence and Katsuki had *liked* that, which had been weird to think about because why the hell did he care if Izuku was confident in a fight or not? And why did it make his stomach feel… weird? Warm?

“Earth to Bakugou?” Mina was saying, waving a hand in front of his face. She pulled her legs up onto his bed, crossing them and leaning on her elbows. “Whatcha thinking so hard about?”

“He was fine,” he said, shrugging. “Looked pretty confident.”

Eyebrows went up all around the room.

Kaminari broke the silence. “You were paying attention?”

“Of course I was paying attention you thick-skulled fuck.”

Mina’s face lit up in a way that Katsuki recognized. She was about to torment him. “So you’re telling me that when you were running from, like, the scariest, creepiest-”

“-Crustiest,” Kaminari interjected.

“-villain, you were thinking about how *confident* Midoriya looked?”

Here they went. Reading into something that was *normal* . What kind of hero was he if he couldn’t take stock of Izuku while they fought together? Nevermind the lingering mystery feeling around Izuku looking like he was ready to kick ass that Katsuki pointedly didn’t want to think about while his friends were in the room. It wasn’t the feeling of inferiority that he’d been fighting off for months when it came to Izuku, because if either of them were lacking in the confidence department, it wasn’t Katsuki. “He bitched Endeavor. Told him to go deal with civilians while he dealt with Shigaraki.”

“That’s manly as shit,” Kirishima said.

Mina waggled her eyebrows. “That’s kind of hot.”

Hot .

Huh.

For most of Katsuki's life, he'd been too focused on his goals to think about shit like that. He didn't feed into the pros that pushed their own sex appeal for higher rankings and more money, and he didn't particularly care for them either. His middle school cronies had been shitty preteen assholes that loved to talk his ear off about which girls in their class had the biggest tits. Katsuki had never been interested.

He'd chalked his own disinterest in girls up to his laser-focus on becoming the best. The fuck did he need a girlfriend for when he was going to become the number one hero?

And deep down, he'd probably always known that there was something different about him, something that he hadn't wanted to think about lest it became true. He'd been in middle school when the pieces of shit that he hung around made fun of a boy in their class for being *gay* , tormenting him similarly to the way they did Izuku. Katsuki hadn't understood what it meant and had asked his parents that evening which had been a huge mistake.

Mitsuki had looked at him, spoon halfway to her mouth, shocked.

Masaru had always been a little better with sensitive topics, and had recovered much quicker than Katsuki's mother. "Why are you asking?"

"Someone said it at school."

"To you?" his mother demanded. "Someone called you that?"

"No. There's a kid in my class. They make fun of him for it."

Mitsuki glared at him. "Well, you better not make fun of anyone for it, you hear me? You're already enough of a brat as is."

"Can you just tell me what the hell it means?"

"It's when boys like boys," Masaru explained. "Or when girls like other girls."

Katsuki had always had a way with words, even as a middle school brat. "Who gives a fuck?"

His mother had laughed about that one for almost a minute straight, tears bubbling up in her eyes. Masaru hadn't even grounded him for swearing at the dinner table.

The bullying of their gay classmate had persisted, though, and Katsuki didn't take part, but he didn't step in either. He simply watched a boy suffer a fate that was no fault of his own, over something he couldn't control.

He'd tortured Izuku over something similar, he came to realize, years later.

Katsuki couldn't bring himself to give the kid shit for it. Not when he didn't give a damn about girls either. It didn't make a difference to him if that kid wanted to kiss up on another boy. At least he didn't run his mouth about which actress he wanted to fuck, or how bad he

wanted to get his dick sucked. Katsuki fucking hated the way his friends talked anyway, so disgusting and descriptive that he had wanted to poke his eyes out. The very few times he'd watched porn with girls in it had been uncomfortable to say the least. He didn't have the time or patience in his life for girls that worried over their appearances or wanted to treat him like he had a soft side. He wanted to be a pro hero, and that didn't include coming home to someone who had baby-soft skin and a full face of makeup and high-pitched girly moans.

He hadn't been able to admit it to himself in middle school. It hadn't been until UA, when that twinkly bastard told everyone he was planning a trip to visit his boyfriend in France that Katsuki had even dared to think about it.

Nobody had batted an eye. His classmates had been ecstatic, actually, that someone in their class had a boyfriend or girlfriend. Aoyama hadn't been bullied or tormented or picked on. People hadn't called him names or shoved him into lockers.

It hadn't fucking mattered.

So did that explain the way he had felt when he'd been watching Izuku on the battlefield? Did that explain why he hadn't wanted to look away from him? Why he wanted to watch every move Izuku made, the set of those muscular shoulders, the divot between fluffy eyebrows? Was that why he wanted to see *more* of that side of Izuku?

Did he think his childhood best friend, the middle schooler he had bullied, his current rival and almost friend, was *hot* ?

"You know, he didn't disagree," Jirou pointed out, bringing him out of his thoughts. His face felt like it was burning.

"Do you want to die?"

"It's only hot when Midoriya acts like that," Sero taunted.

"I will seriously fucking kill you."

"See? You have, like, no sex appeal," Kaminari said.

"And Deku does?"

"You tell us. You were there when he bitched Endeavor," Kaminari replied.

"Yeah, did it make you all, you know, hot and bothered?" Mina asked, leaning closer to him by the second.

"Shut the fuck up. No." Maybe? He definitely hadn't been bothered, not in a negative sense.

"So you were?" She was looming over him, eyes alight. She was a fucking sponge for drama.

"I was fucking not. We were on a battlefield."

“You know,” Jirou started, “it’s kind of suspicious that you’re denying being turned on by it just because you were on a battlefield. Not because of the whole it-being-Midoriya-thing.”

“Yeah, if you weren’t on a battlefield and he bitched out Endeavor *would* you have thought it was hot?” Kirishima asked, and actually fuck him for playing into their shit. That was definitely against his whole “bro code” bullshit.

“Or did it add a little extra thrill to it? Like ‘damn, my lifelong enemy that I’ve despised for years is suddenly fuckable, I should sacrifice my life for him.’”

He glared at Sero. “Stop. I’m fucking warning all of you.”

“You haven’t denied it.” Jirou.

“It’s okay to think someone’s attractive, dude. Even if it’s in a bro way.” Kirishima.

“Except it definitely isn’t in a ‘bro way.’” Kaminari.

“Will you all please fuck off about it?”

“He said please!” Mina retreated a hair. “Guys, it’s a Christmas miracle!”

“Let’s give him some air, guys,” Kirishima said, but he was still laughing.

Their tirade paused for a whole thirty seconds in which Katsuki sat there and *thought* .

“Well?” Kaminari pestered, breaking the silence.

Katsuki had never been the type to worry about the opinions of extras. He was going to be the best in any and all regards.

Maybe, just maybe, he had woken up wanting to be a better friend. One that participated in their stupid group excursions, or got drunk on the weekends with Kaminari, Sero, and Kirishima, or watched shitty reality TV in Mina’s dorm. Or talked about the people they thought were hot.

“Yeah. It was kind of fucking hot. Fuck all of you.”

Then, “When I’m out of this stupid ass hospital we’re all hanging out. Don’t argue over it.”

Chapter End Notes

thank you for reading!! this chapter was UGH a lot to write because I want to keep it as close to canon as possible so I had to rewatch all the jaku fight scenes to make sure my

writing was pretty accurate. I cut out a bit of it because I feel like it might have been boring to read me reiterating literally everything that happened in the episodes buuuuut I hope this was pretty good

im really trying to nail their dynamic and I hope im doing a good job? Im a sucker for pining/devoted katsuki (he is, he just doesn't know it yet)

hope y'all enjoyed this one :) kudos and comments appreciated
<3

evermore

Chapter Summary

though he's already flown
so far beyond my reach
he's never out of sight

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

After three miserable days in the hospital (not including the one he spent unconscious), Katsuki was discharged. His nurses had made sure his bandages were secure over his arm and around his abdomen, and he'd been given a handful of pill bottles with stern instructions from his doctor and parents alike.

All Might had offered to drive him back to UA, which he wasn't particularly happy about. Ever since waking up in the hospital and demanding to see Izuku, nobody had relented, even when All Might let it slip that Izuku had woken up and talked to Inko. Katsuki had been pissed, *obviously* , because he'd done the equivalent of taking a bullet for Izuku and it seemed that nobody cared. He'd heard Inko's voice outside his room at one point, but she hadn't come in, which Katsuki both understood and expected. What angered him, though, were the pro heroes that he'd *trusted* . All Might had visited Katsuki a handful of times, for no longer than a few minutes, to check on his progress and see how he was doing. Jeanist had visited him a few times as well, and had revealed nothing when Katsuki had shouted at him that he knew something was going on with Izuku and *why won't you just let me fucking see him* ?

He knew he had behaved like a child, and that he had a considerable amount of notes about his attitude written on his chart, but he didn't *care* . From the time he'd been impaled and passed out to Shigaraki and the rest of the League escaping, his memories were fuzzy. He'd known that Izuku had broken his arms at some point, and that his legs weren't faring much better. He'd seen blood on his face and dotting his uniform, and in flashes of memories, he could see Izuku's face, a little battered but so *determined* .

He'd thrown fits in the hospital. The first day, he had blatantly refused to eat until they let him see Izuku. He didn't care that Izuku was unconscious; he just wanted to see for himself that Izuku was okay, that he would wake up and everything would be fine. Katsuki wanted Izuku to wake up and know that *he* was okay; he didn't care about Izuku crying and thanking him, which was guaranteed to happen at some point. He just wanted Izuku to know that he was going to be fine. They were both going to be fine.

But the nurses hadn't relented, and they'd threatened to give him a feeding tube if he kept acting out.

After that, he'd changed courses, doing every single damn thing the hospital staff told him to do. He hadn't been given a good reason as to why he couldn't see Izuku, with the damn nerd being unconscious, so he figured the staff might have been pissed that he wasn't listening to them. Katsuki ate his apple sauce and took his pills promptly like the best fucking patient they'd ever had.

It got him nowhere.

He'd figured it out, on day three, a few hours before he'd been allowed to leave. It wasn't hard to deduce, not after one of his nurse's let it slip that some of the pro heroes had been visiting Izuku quite frequently since his arrival at the hospital.

Katsuki sat in the passenger seat of All Might's car, leg cramped against the door, arms crossed, eyes glaring out the window. He'd arrived at the hospital on a stretcher, soaked in a disgusting concoction of his own blood and dust.

Katsuki had liked one of them a lot more than the others, mostly because she didn't bullshit or treat him like a child. She didn't scold him when he swore, and she hadn't sugarcoated the extent of his wounds. She also didn't kiss the ground he walked on, praising him for jumping in and trying to save his friend. She simply changed his bandages with practiced efficiency and gave him orders with a no-arguing tone.

She'd told him that when he'd arrived at the hospital, they'd had to cut away his hero costume, which had been plastered to his skin and unsalvageable.

"How are you holding up, Young Bakugou? The injuries you sustained were pretty serious."

Katsuki continued staring out the window. "Fuck you."

"I know you're angry that you weren't allowed to see Young Midoriya but-"

"Angry? Don't give me that shit, All Might."

"The things that have happened were not in the scope of what the Commission expected. You have to understand why we can't just move on like things will be the same. I'm sure you've heard about the state of the country. Crime is at an all time high, heroes are quitting their jobs left and right. There's nobody for the citizens to look to and rely on. With so much unknown-"

"Yeah, I got all that. Just wanted to fucking see him."

He admitted it quietly, if only to spare himself the embarrassment.

"Young Midoriya didn't want-"

"I don't want to hear shit about what he wants. I know him." Katsuki finally tore his gaze away from the bleak streets flying past. All Might's expression was a reflection of the state of

the city: empty. “I already know his stupid ass plan.”

All Might’s eyes flicked over to him, a telltale sign that Katsuki had been right.

“And no, I didn’t sneak into his room and beat it out of him. I just fucking know him. I know that all he cares about is saving people and now that he’s a target, he won’t want to bring anyone else into this. He’s going to try and do it all on his own.”

All Might didn’t confirm or deny, which was confirmation enough for Katsuki. If the situation were different, he would have given himself a pat on the back for reading Izuku so aptly.

But the situation was spread before him. Tartarus had fallen, along with a number of other highly secure prisons across the country. Criminals of all backgrounds had been released into Japan, and the system that society had relied so heavily on had fallen apart. Pros had practically become the villains of the public, who’d deemed them unreliable government tools. All For One was out there with Shigaraki and his Nomu, with an armoire of quirks that he’d had decades to master.

And amidst all of that was a 16 year old kid who’d had a quirk for barely a year, carrying the weight of it on his shoulders alone.

Funny how things worked out. Funny how Katsuki’s body had thrown itself in front of Izuku, how he’d *finally* come to terms with the idea of letting himself be supported by others, only for Izuku to take his place and spear-head the issue completely on his own.

Katsuki would be lying if there wasn’t a part of him that was consumed by anxiety. Izuku was out there, god knows where, with no concern for his own well-being. He wouldn’t be taken down by villains, but rather, by his own stupid, *stupid* desire to save.

Green eyes. The sound of water flowing over rocks. A hand outstretched.

“If he dies because of this,” Katsuki said, his voice low and as serious as ever, “I will never forgive you.”

“Young Bakugou-”

“You gave your quirk to the one fucking person that will never stop trying to save people. He will keep saving until he’s dead.”

“I can assure you-”

“You can’t assure shit, you washed up-” he stopped himself, took a breath. “I’ve known him forever. I *know* him. You’re letting him go out there on his own *knowing* how he is.”

“Do you think I want him out there, Young Bakugou? Do you think I want to see him try and do this on his own?”

All Might’s voice was shaky, but Katsuki didn’t give half a shit. Fuck the Hero Commission. Fuck their teachers for letting them fight. Fuck the adults for not realizing it was a little

fucked up to have kids fight in a war.

“No. But I know you didn’t try to stop him.”

“You haven’t been in his shoes. You haven’t felt the weight that he feels. I know that you’re trying to understand, and that you probably do more than the rest of your peers. But I’ve held that power. I’ve faced All For One.”

“Fuck you, All Might,” he said again, and he hated the way his own voice sounded so childlike. He was looking at the man that had once been his hero, and he couldn’t feel anything other than resentment and betrayal. “It’s even worse that you know how he’s feeling and still let him go.”

All Might was silent for a long, long time. They were getting closer to UA, but it didn’t matter. Izuku wouldn’t be there.

“I love that boy,” he said finally. “You can hate me, Katsuki. You can blame me for everything. I’ll find a way to live with how I’ve failed you. But don’t doubt for a second that I care about him very, very much. He’s not fighting alone out there, as much as you seem to think he is. I’ll die before I let something happen to him.”

I’ve already tried that. See where it got us.

Katsuki had been willing to lay down his life to save Izuku. Sure, he hadn’t planned to jump in front of him, but he hadn’t woken up regretting it. If he’d had more time to think in that moment, he still would have fucking done it. Over and over again.

I didn’t get to tell you everything yet. I didn’t get to make it up to you or apologize.

Then, *I haven’t gotten to fix things with you. I haven’t gotten to appreciate you in the ways that I didn’t know I wanted to.*

He couldn’t hate All Might for this, as much as he wanted to. He’d known Izuku their entire lives, and more than anyone, he knew that he couldn’t be stopped when his whole hero complex took over. Even if Katsuki had been allowed to visit him, nothing would have changed. He couldn’t trick himself into thinking that he could have gotten on his hands and knees and begged Izuku to stay, that Izuku would have listened after everything Katsuki had done.

Because Katsuki didn’t deserve that courtesy from Izuku, even if there was a chance that he could have stopped him from leaving. Green eyes, so bright and forgiving and full of emotion, looking at him like he was everything, always, their entire lives. Katsuki wished so badly he’d been able to go to his room, insult him, tell him to get his fucking head on straight because he’d never been stupid.

You don’t know him like I do , is what he wanted to say. He didn’t. He was trying to be better.

Yeah, see that, Deku? Can’t fucking die on me yet. I’ve still gotta prove that I’m ahead of you .

Katsuki walked back to the dorms alone. UA had opened its gates to civilians as a refuge. He knew his parents were there, with Inko. He didn't bother visiting.

All Might had handed him a letter before he had gotten out of the car and told him to read it when the rest of the class got theirs, whatever the fuck that meant.

When he was alone in his dorm, after dealing with the squabbling of his overbearing classmates, he opened it.

It was written on lined paper, out of one of Izuku's precious notebooks. The handwriting was sloppy, probably a side effect of him wrecking his arms for the umpteenth time. The thought of Izuku alone in a hospital room, writing a letter to Katsuki with shaking hands, made him want to explode the damn thing.

Kacchan

You've probably already figured out my plan. You've always been able to read me so I guess this is no different.

Please don't be upset that I didn't want to see you at the hospital. The Heroes told me that you fought everyone that told you you couldn't, which is definitely you. I'm really glad you're okay. So please don't take it personally. Sometimes it's easier to not say goodbye.

The letters to the rest of the class reveal the secret of One For All and how I got it. I've explained to them that I won't be coming back to UA. I'm not going to let anybody else get hurt because of me. I know you'll want to chase me down and threaten to beat me up for being reckless, but please just stay at UA. I'm doing what I have to do. I don't want you to get hurt again because of me.

I don't know when I'll see you again so this is goodbye for now. Please look out for my mom for me.

Thank you for saving me.

Deku

Izuku

There were a couple tear splatters on the paper. Some were from Izuku. Some were from Katsuki.

There was so much he'd wanted to say to Izuku on that battlefield. There was so much he wanted to say to Izuku now. He wouldn't let himself feel weak for the few tears that he shed. He wanted to apologize, wanted to grab Izuku by the shoulders and shake him and scream at him for being stupid, wanted to fight beside him because it was so fucking stupid for Izuku to have to do it all on his own. The fight didn't have to be just him and All For One. It didn't have to be Izuku against the fucking world.

Katsuki was angry. He was so fucking angry.

Izuku was out there *alone* . He was planning to face All For One alone. He'd said he didn't know when he would see Katsuki again.

He wiped the tears off his face. He kicked his desk chair over.

Fuck you fuck you fuck you fuck you fuck you .

Izuku couldn't die on his own. Not until Katsuki apologized for everything he'd ever done.

Izuku had probably already forgiven him. Even All Might had said that. But Katsuki didn't care about forgiveness. He just needed Izuku to know that he regretted it, that he'd learned from it, that was, truly, sorry.

He didn't have excuses for his actions. He wouldn't try to bullshit his way out of taking blame for who he'd been. He wouldn't fool himself into thinking that he would ever deserve Izuku, in whatever way that might be. But he would be damned if he let Izuku die before he got the chance to take accountability for what he had done.

And if there were other things he wanted to do before Izuku could kick the fucking bucket, well, that was his business and his business only. He still wasn't ready to dwell on it.

A week passed. A week that crawled by. Classes were postponed and the students had instead been instructed to assist with maintaining the makeshift shelters that had overtaken the campus. Uraraka had taken charge of the whole thing, putting out assignments and shifts for everyone. Duties were divided among the class, like preparing food, serving food, dispensing supplies, first aid on incoming refugees, and keeping the shelters maintained and organized. She kept Katsuki off the list on the first day, and he had chewed her out over it because he wasn't going to fucking fall apart over being told to cook for the civilians.

"I'm not going to stop being a fucking hero just because Deku isn't here," he snapped. Deep breath. "Just tell me where you want me to go, Pink Cheeks. Anything is fucking better than sitting here doing nothing."

He respected her, a whole lot fucking more than he did the rest of their classmates. Her intentions had been good, so he hadn't been all that pissed off about it. What *had* pissed him off was how easily she had seen through him. She'd watched him carefully when the entire class had read their letters, had narrowed her eyes when he ripped his up and determined that Izuku was working with the pros. When she directed him to help with checking refugees in at the front gates and helping with first aid, her eyes had been knowing. Almost as if she got it.

Maybe that's why she had taken charge. So she didn't have to wallow in her thoughts of Izuku being out there *alone* . Katsuki almost knew for certain that Izuku had stopped paying attention to eating and sleeping, and that he was functioning on drive and adrenaline alone.

The dorms were empty without Izuku. Katsuki should have appreciated him before.

He found himself looking for a flash of green hair that no longer belonged to the UA dorms. When he returned to the building in the afternoons, he fought the urge to check if Izuku was sitting at one of the tables, mumbling his way through homework, or sitting on the couch and playing video games with Kaminari.

After that first week, he caved and called Izuku. It rang once before he was met with Izuku's voicemail. So he *had* taken his phone. He called again. And again and again and again. Voicemail every time.

If he wouldn't answer Katsuki's calls, maybe he would read a fucking text.

Kacchan

listen here nerd

i know what you're doing and that you think we'll all get fucked up if you're around

guess what dickhead we're not weak

so get that out of your fucking head

fuck you a whole lot actually

we're all training to be heroes not just you mr main fucking character

if you think we can't handle shit then you're dead fucking wrong

fuck you deku i know ur reading these

fuck you

if you don't come back i'm breaking into your room and stealing all your special edition all might merch and burning it

fine i'm not burning it but i'm keeping that shit for myself and ur never getting it back

okay actually FUCK you for not answering

i wanted to listen to ur nerd ass ramble about the dumbass commission and all the shit they're pulling because ik damn well you have some opinions on it

i won't even tell u to shut up. or be annoyed about the rambling

it doesn't really annoy me actually

no fuck this shit i'm not gonna sit here texting you like i give two shits what happens. come back to ua and see how many damns i give about it

i don't give a shit if you come back i didn't even notice you were gone

come on fucking answer me

fuck you midoriya izuku fuck you VERY much

The texts had been spread out over an hour. An hour in which he hadn't been assigned anywhere on campus and he had about lost his damn mind. All Might hadn't shown up to campus since he'd dropped Katsuki off, and everytime Katsuki had tried to call him, it had gone straight to voicemail. How the hell was he supposed to trust that All Might was going to keep Izuku from getting himself killed when he couldn't even pick up the damn phone?

Katsuki's phone dinged. He tripped over himself to retrieve it from where he had thrown it against his wall.

Deku

I promise everything is okay Kacchan really. You know why I have to do this. I don't want you to be worried about me (which you probably aren't) but I promise. I'm fine. I can't come back to UA and I know that you know that. It's the same reason why we got Shigaraki away from everyone during the battle. Please stop texting me. I'm not coming back until it's completely safe.

Kacchan

alright you fucking self sacrificing piece of shit get it through your THICK FUCKING SKULL that i'm worried.

is that what you want to hear? that i fucking care what happens to you? what is it going to take for you to realize that we don't give two fucks about the risks

just come back and let us fucking help you

these stupid extras love you

it doesn't have to be your own stupid burden

Deku

You don't have to worry about me. I'm working with All Might and Endeavor and Hawks.

And Jeanist.

They're looking out for me. If you don't trust me then trust them.

Kacchan

i don't trust fucking jack shit when it comes to you

don't act like you won't abandon them the minute you think they're in danger too

Deku

I'm going to destroy my phone. I've captured a few of All For One's assassins already, and Danger Sense has been helping. But it's risky to keep it on me. I don't want All For One to know who to use against me.

Kacchan

don't you fucking dare deku

you think all for one won't come here and kill your mom just to lure you back? or pink cheeks and class rep?

he doesn't need your fucking phone to know who to use against you

we're all fucked no matter what so you might as well just fucking come back

Deku

I appreciate you being concerned. But I'm fine.

Gray dots appeared in the corner of his screen. They disappeared. They came back.

Deku

If the rest of the class loves me why are you the one fighting so hard for me to come back?

Kacchan

fuck you we're not talking about this over text

i'm not having that conversation right now

the whole stupid class wants your dumbass to come back

Deku

You?

Kacchan

wouldn't be fucking texting you if i didn't

Deku

Please try to understand why I have to do this. When I've dealt with All For One I'll come back. We can have this conversation then?

Kacchan

fuck you

there's no fucking conversation

don't want to fucking talk to you about shit

His texts stopped going through after that. He threw his phone at the wall again.

Two more weeks passed. Katsuki about killed himself doing shit for the refugees. His back fucking *hurt* . His wounds had scabbed and then scarred. He looked at them in the mirror every evening and got pissed off. They were a constant reminder of Izuku, or rather, Izuku's absence.

Green curly hair. Green, bright eyes, shining with undeserved admiration. Freckles, too many to count, covering skin that looked soft to the touch. The smell of ozone and the flash of lightning. Hands holding Katsuki's, every so often, when they trained together and worked on a move. Izuku's hands were bigger, stronger. A voice, so sweet and soft and occasionally *sassy* in a way that made Katsuki want to stop dead in his tracks and stare.

He visited his parents. He snuck them extra food. He avoided Inko like the fucking plague. He couldn't bear seeing her, not after everything. At one point, she'd been like a second mother to him. But he hadn't seen her at all during middle school, when he'd made her son's life a living hell, and he was pretty positive she wasn't the type to take that lightly. Izuku had forgiven him, sure, but Katsuki knew from his own experiences that a mother's love was like no other. Part of him also felt responsible for Izuku being gone, and though she'd visited him in the hospital and probably knew what her son had planned, Katsuki couldn't help but feel like he could've stopped Izuku, could have found a way to keep him at UA.

Days blurred together, and his routine that he'd worked so hard to maintain began to slip. He turned down Kirishima's requests to train or lift together, and he ignored Kaminari's whiny texts about playing video games or hanging out.

Katsuki was given an evening shift one day, opposite of most of his classmates. The dorms were empty, aside from the people on his shift, who were holed up in their rooms. He had a plan that was definitely a breach of privacy but he didn't fucking care.

He'd been searching for some piece of evidence of Izuku ever since he'd returned from the hospital. And if he couldn't see Izuku's smile or hear his breathy giggles, he would find what he needed somewhere else.

He broke into Izuku's dorm.

It was an All Might shrine, which was expected. What Katsuki didn't expect was the intense rush of feelings that slammed into his body. Nostalgia, first, for the decorations that he recognized from Izuku's childhood bedroom. Second, his own *sadness* that he had been repressing ever since he'd figured Izuku out.

He'd been stupidly delirious after being impaled. He had thought that there was a chance that he would wake up and apologize to Izuku for everything he'd done and Izuku would *smile* at him, the smile that kept Katsuki up at night as he tried to figure out what the actual fuck he was feeling.

But that hadn't happened, and there was an Izuku sized hole in his heart that wasn't getting filled. Katsuki missed Izuku, in the way you would miss your arm if it suddenly got cut off. He craved his presence, as weird as that fucking sounded, but it was true. Two weeks without mumbling and he was losing his goddamn mind from the silence.

Katsuki laid in Izuku's bed like a creepy loser. He kicked off his shoes and laid on his side, his face pressed against an All Might pillowcase. It smelled like lavender shampoo. He laid uncomfortably at first, all too aware of the fact that this was where Izuku slept every single night and that he was most definitely overstepping a boundary that had never actually been verbalized. But he didn't fucking care. He'd been searching for evidence of Izuku and it was *here* .

He fell asleep, better than he had in the last two weeks, with an All Might blanket pulled up over his face, and the shameful thought of Izuku laying beside him, just out of reach.

It had been disorienting to wake up in the fucking All Might shrine. But the blanket smelled like Izuku.

God, he was fucking gone, wasn't he?

His friends hadn't brought it up since the hospital, not after Izuku had up and left. But it had been on his mind constantly.

He was fucking attracted to the nerd, was that it? He thought his face was kind of nice to look at. He liked freckles. And the color green.

He knew it wasn't just that. He knew he didn't deserve to feel that way, that Izuku would *never* feel that way.

Still, Katsuki wallowed in it.

It wasn't admiration any more. Actually, he didn't admire Izuku for shit after the stunt he pulled. He didn't want to be like that, didn't want to face his problems on his own, not after learning how to rely on the people around him. He didn't care to catch up to somebody who so carelessly threw themself into harm's way.

But it made his heart pull - in a disgusting *mushy* way - to think of Izuku and how he had only ever wanted to *save* . His dedication, his drive, his *everything* .

Everything Izuku did had him wanting more. Katsuki wanted to watch him get better and better, and he wanted to work twice as hard to keep up. He wanted to earn Izuku's brightest smiles, his laughter. He wanted to memorize the feeling of Izuku's hand in his own, when they weren't in the middle of a battle, fighting for their lives.

It had become something more, what Katsuki felt for Izuku. It wasn't just rivalry anymore. It probably hadn't been for a while.

He stole the stupid ass All Might blanket off Izuku's bed.

A week later, the class had had enough. None of them had heard from Izuku since he'd answered Katsuki's texts three weeks earlier. Katsuki had spent too many nights pouring over articles on a "dark, ragged figure appearing to have multiple quirks" that had taken down a number of dangerous villains over the last month. Even though his actions were heroic, the people seemed to take Izuku as some kind of danger to society.

Uraraka suggested confronting Endeavor. At that point, Katsuki would do just about anything.

Izuku had been gone for a month.

For the first time in his life, he tied his tie and wore his blazer. He wondered if Izuku would have said something, if he would have gone red and smiled at Katsuki over it.

Uraraka sure had shit had noticed and it was really starting to piss Katsuki off that she was as observative as she was.

Did she *know* ? There's no way she knew, right? Katsuki hadn't even put a label on what he was feeling for Izuku in his own head, so how could she have possibly figured it out?

Katsuki only let his mind approach that topic when he was alone in his dorm, wrapped in an All Might blanket that's scent was slowly fading, when he didn't have to worry about how strong he was. When he didn't have to worry about what he felt making him weak.

Izuku being away was miserable. Katsuki had been *miserable* for a month. But he understood why he'd done it.

The evening before their meeting with Endeavor and Nezu, Katsuki couldn't get the image of Izuku, alone in the dark, hungry and cold, functioning on no sleep and still not breaking, all to protect the people he cared about. Katsuki imagined their roles reversed, imagined someone targeting Izuku to get to him, and he understood.

If, for some reason, Katsuki became a target, he knew he would do just about fucking anything to keep Izuku from being harmed because of it.

That wasn't to say that he would run away, or that he wouldn't trust Izuku to handle himself. Because Katsuki would. He knew what Izuku was capable of, knew that he could probably kick Katsuki's ass if he actually gave it his all while they sparred. He wasn't fucking weak or whiny or any of the things that Katsuki hated; Izuku had proven, over and over again, that he was tough as shit, that he could hold his own. He was strong in different ways than Katsuki, in ways that made him *want* . And his desire wasn't born out of jealousy or a desire to catch up, *no* , his desires were selfish and undeserved. He wanted Izuku's strength, his kindness, his compassion, his heroism, all for himself. To hold close to his chest. To find solace in, when nobody else would ever understand him.

He wanted all of those things about Izuku, and he wanted to keep them locked away and protected from the fucked up world they lived in. He wanted to fight beside Izuku, to make sure that the war didn't change him or tarnish his spirit. He wanted to learn his scars, to know how they felt beneath his fingertips, to know how they felt beneath his lips-

Katsuki's hands popped a few times in the dark of his room, small explosions that lit up the dark. His face was so fucking hot and most definitely bright red. He'd just narrowly avoided blowing up Izuku's All Might blanket.

There were tears in his eyes.

He was angry and frustrated and he felt fucking useless and he missed Izuku and he didn't understand *anything* , because why in hell had he turned lovesick over someone he could never have, over someone he would never *deserve* , but he still wanted so desperately, even if he was only able to have it for half of a second. He couldn't go the rest of his life not *knowing* how it felt to be truly by Izuku's side, as his equal, as the person Izuku could lean on but that could also lean on him.

He wanted, he wanted so badly that it was all consuming and impossible to think past and he fucking hated himself for it because he had never been the person to become distracted by their emotions. Izuku had done enough of that for the both of them, and Katsuki had picked up the slack.

Everything that had frustrated him to no end about Izuku had suddenly become traits that Katsuki enjoyed. The mumbling, the way he simultaneously treated Katsuki like he was just anyone else but also the person he admired the most, the way he so easily protected people, bringing smiles to their faces in the process, his overexcitement about the small things, his determination and spirit that had never been broken. Then there was his face, his stupidly bright smile and freckled cheeks, green curls that Katsuki wanted to tangle his fingers in, eyes that he got lost in just about every time he looked into them.

Katsuki pulled at his own hair, his hands fisted in it hard enough to hurt. *Fucking STOP* , he screamed at his own mind, willing away images that he didn't want to see. It was bad enough that Izuku was temporarily out of his life; he didn't need the added stress of *longing* .

But Katsuki knew better, and he knew this feeling had been growing in him for longer than he wanted to think about. It wouldn't go away when Izuku came back. It probably wouldn't go away ever.

Katsuki hadn't been wrong. Seeing Izuku hadn't banished his thoughts of running his fingers over freckled cheeks or kissing the scars on his hands.

If anything, it hit him so much stronger than it had the evening he'd lost control of both his quirk and his tear ducts.

He and the rest of Class A had followed Izuku's tracker a day after getting it off Endeavor and getting the go-ahead from Nezu to bring Izuku back to UA. They'd decided, as a class, to try their best to keep Izuku from being injured, but to be aware of the fact that he was most definitely going to bolt the minute he knew they were there. Katsuki had made it very clear that they could share their sob stories and tell him how much they loved him, and that Izuku still wouldn't give a shit.

He could have said something, before Izuku had destroyed his phone.

What he would have said, he still had no idea. " *Hey, I'm really sorry I bullied you all our lives. Anyways, let's make out.* " Fuck that.

He'd taken charge of the whole "Bring Back Deku" operation, because he would be damned if he let the rest of those extras try and form a plan when *he* knew Izuku better than any of them. Uraraka and Iida had been alarmed when he'd told them he would fight Izuku at full strength if that's what it took, and he'd felt suddenly possessive. They didn't *know* Izuku like he did; he wanted to call the shots and make the decisions, because the whole situation felt like his responsibility. *Izuku* felt like his responsibility.

The thought didn't scare him nearly as much as it should have. If anything, it was a comfort that he slipped into. After all, hadn't Izuku treated his kidnapping the same? He'd been pissed back then, that Izuku had shoved his nose where it didn't belong to "save" Katsuki. He hadn't fucking needed the help.

Which is what he had told himself in the months after, whenever memories surfaced of that fucking hand wrapping around his neck and the shackles tight on his wrists and the *fear* that came with the feeling of not being able to use his quirk. He told himself, over and over, that Izuku had thought he was weak, that Izuku had seen him as someone to save.

A year later, he wasn't all that fucking mad about it. It had taken so much work, so many mantras to himself whenever he became overwhelmed by his own insecurities and his hatred of his own weaknesses, that it was *okay* . It wasn't a bad thing to need help or to accept it. It didn't make him any less of a person.

Staring into Izuku's eyes, so clearly desperate for sleep and so un-Izuku-like, Katsuki hoped Izuku understood that.

It would be ironic, really, for Izuku to reject him after so many years of being the one reaching out. In every situation, in every moment of Katsuki's life, Izuku had been a constant force, a hand extended and ready to help, ready to *save* .

They'd been fighting Izuku for nearly an hour at this point. It had started raining at some point, and it had only picked up the longer they fought. It lashed at Katsuki's face, tiny drops soaking his hair and costume. He itched to be inside, to be somewhere that didn't affect his quirk. Before he could even create a tiny explosion, the rain washed his sweat away.

Still, he stayed and fought and shouted and ached. All for Izuku. Everything for Izuku to come back.

All of it, for this moment, drenched to the bone and shivering, watching Izuku pant, his shoulders curved inward. He was so unlike the Izuku that Katsuki had come to know in the last few months, to the Izuku he had known since they were five. He looked so impossibly young, only 16. He'd grown at UA, that much was glaringly obvious to Katsuki. Defined muscles and a more pronounced jawline, but some of his boyish features had persisted. His cheeks still held some of their baby fat, and his eyes were so *big* . It made Katsuki shudder; those characteristics reminded him of what Izuku had looked like back when they were children. He'd grown, but Izuku was still a kid. A kid with the weight of the world resting on his shoulders and forcing him away from his friends.

His head hung low, his posture was god-awful. He'd clearly suffered a handful of scrapes and minor wounds over the course of the month he'd been away from UA, and dried blood stuck to his skin and costume in multiple places. His freckles were hidden behind a layer of grime, and his hair was matted down to his head.

Still, Katsuki thought he was beautiful.

He'd unlocked two new quirks since leaving UA, and, even if he looked (and smelled) like shit, Katsuki was *proud* . And impressed. And annoyed as fuck. And everything else.

Izuku was in front of him, and everything he'd figured out over the last month felt stronger.

And before he knew it, he was apologizing, the words that he had tried to string together a million times over again throughout the last month finally coming together. He hadn't planned to apologize here, soaked to the bone and in front of their entire class, but he didn't *care* . This all would have been for nothing if Izuku didn't willingly come back to UA.

Katsuki wasn't just apologizing for that, though. He wasn't telling Izuku how he felt only in hopes that he would stop fighting them. He'd wanted to say these things for a while, at least since the battle in Jaku, but most certainly before that. Had he felt it, when they'd trained together so many nights in a row? Had he felt it when Izuku had opened up to him about Nighteye and Katsuki had been so fucking *mad* that Izuku didn't care about himself?

He didn't know or care; he would have apologized at some point regardless. But he wanted Izuku to understand, at that moment, that he was done pushing Izuku away or seeing him as weak. He was done fighting alone when Izuku had been willing to fight by his side since the very beginning. He wanted Izuku to meet him in the middle, to put back out the hand he had retracted when he'd fled the hospital. Katsuki's hand was already there waiting, if Izuku would only take it.

"Izuku," he said, after too many years, "I'm sorry for everything."

There were tears in those green, green eyes. On impulse, one that was foreign but not unwelcome, Katsuki stepped forward, almost as if his body intended to walk right up to Izuku and brush those tears away.

If that was how it was to be from now on, with Katsuki moving without thinking, he really needed to figure his shit out.

He took another few steps, slowly, as if Izuku were a frightened animal.

More tears bubbled up, surely of exhaustion and hunger and a month spent fighting alone.

Izuku started to collapse.

Katsuki was already there, catching him and holding him up. Izuku's arms clutched at Katsuki's, his grip weak. His arm, which had been recovering well since the impalement, gave a slight shout in protest as he supported all of Izuku's weight.

Training together over the last six months meant that they'd been close on many occasions. When they sparred without quirks, it wasn't uncommon for one of them to end up pinning the other to the ground. Even in battle, they'd come to rely on each other, guarding each other's backs or locking hands.

This was different, and the proximity had every single one of Katsuki's nerve endings lighting on fire. Izuku was *in his arms* ; he wasn't running away or denying Katsuki's apology. He was letting Katsuki support him.

"I'm sorry for saying you couldn't keep up," Izuku croaked, his voice hoarse.

"I know," Katsuki murmured, shifting him closer. Izuku's hero costume was soaked through, and he was shivering against Katsuki's chest. He'd folded himself up, as if he was finally letting someone else watch his back after a month of being on his own. His face was pressed against Katsuki's upper arm, and he could feel Izuku's breathing steadily slowing down. They were soaked, and Katsuki fucking hated the rain, but for this moment, he'd stand in a storm for days on end if that's what it took.

Izuku was safe, and he was there in Katsuki's arms, and while it wasn't all the way to what he wanted, it was a little bit closer to something like salvation. For both of them.

Chapter End Notes

thank you so much for reading!! kudos and comments veryyyy appreciated!
ALSO I started a tiktok @lvndrsunny if u wanna give that a follow
I hope y'all enjoyed this chapter, I LOVE vigilante deku so so much but I really wanted to explore katsuki's side of it
love y'all
<3

teenage dream

Chapter Summary

> when am I gonna stop being great for my age
> and just start being good?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It took a lot of convincing for Katsuki to allow Shoji to use his arms to support Izuku on their way back to UA.

First of all, he'd talked to the guy, like, maybe three fucking times in the last year. Definitely not enough to earn Katsuki's trust, especially where Izuku was involved. Considering the fact that Izuku had just fought the class tooth and nail, even though he was teetering on unconsciousness, Katsuki wasn't all that convinced that Izuku wouldn't try to run away again at the first chance.

He'd apologized. It had changed Izuku's mind in the moment, but would his mind stay that way? Would he make a pit stop at UA and flee the minute the class stopped watching him like a hawk?

In those first few moments after Izuku passed out, Katsuki held him, a little awkwardly. The whole class was staring at him in blatant shock after his apology. Besides Kirishima, Kaminari, Sero, Mina, Uraraka, Jirou, and Todoroki, the rest of the extras of Class A were looking at him like he'd grown a second head.

Which, honestly, Katsuki couldn't be mad about. His apology had contradicted everything he'd said and done since the beginning of the year.

He'd let his hand run over Izuku's shoulders in a pitiful attempt at comfort. When he'd been a child, physical contact had been sparse. Katsuki had been well-versed in knee scrapes and bee stings and splinters; he'd been a rowdy, uncontrollable kid with a thirst for anything remotely dangerous. His mother hadn't pitied him; he'd learned very early on not to seek comfort from her. The first few times he'd gotten hurt at the park, she'd shouted at him not to be stupid, that it was his own stupid fault.

He'd watched from afar when Izuku got hurt, though. Katsuki had watched as Inko had wiped tears from his cheeks and put little All Might band-aids on his scrapes and hugged him until his smile returned in full force. Katsuki had mistaken those moments for weakness, but years later, he found himself wondering how he would have turned out if his mother had been the one putting band-aids on his scratches and telling him everything would be okay.

Katsuki didn't know how to comfort people. He'd never learned the art of either comforting or being comforted, and in any situation where he'd even *tried* to make someone feel better, he'd failed.

Izuku, delirious against him, was clearly not needing some half-assed comment from Katsuki. He needed *something* , and Katsuki was all too aware of his own shortcomings in situations like this.

He shifted Izuku in his arms, bearing all of his weight, which was no small feat. He'd really fucking packed muscle on in the last year. His head lolled against Katsuki's shoulder, his arms hanging loosely at his sides. He smelled like shit- courtesy of the last month spent probably without showering. Katsuki could feel how fast Izuku's heart was beating against him, undoubtedly overworked after the 1 vs. 19.

He hadn't wanted to let go. He'd actually wanted to carry Izuku all the way back to UA on his own.

But the class had regained their composure, and Glasses had been determined to make their return *as efficient as possible* .

"Shoji's quirk is probably best suited to transport him," Yaoyaorozu was saying.

Katsuki's arms tightened, a twinge of annoyance shooting through him. *He'd* been the one to determine that Izuku was working with the pros, *he'd* been the one to stand up to Endeavor and Nezu, *he'd* been the one to find Izuku during the villain attack, and *his* apology had been the breaking point to bringing Izuku back to UA.

"I can use my quirk to-"

"I've got him," Katsuki cut Uraraka off with a glare. Her face scrunched in a mixture of surprise and indignation. "You guys really think I can't handle carrying him? I fucking got it."

He saw Mina's eyebrows go up from behind Uraraka and he very pointedly ignored her.

"You've done a lot already," Yaoyaorozu argued, her tone somewhat motherly. "You're still recovering from your injuries. Let someone else help out."

Izuku shifted against him, his head moving ever so slightly. Katsuki squeezed him gently around the waist, hoping Izuku understood what it meant: *you can rest now, you're not alone anymore* .

He wanted to spit in her face and tell her to fuck off, but that was behavior that he had corrected over the course of the year and Izuku would definitely not take lightly to Katsuki insulting their friends.

After all, he'd fought in the rain for hours to convince Izuku that it was alright to accept help from others.

"Fine," he snapped.

He could get over not being the one to carry Izuku into UA.

When he'd seen the faces of his classmates as Izuku had fallen into his arms, he'd been a little smug after the fact. All their fucking talk for Izuku to come back because of him.

Getting past the refugees was a whole other fuckfest in itself. Katsuki almost couldn't be bothered to listen to Uraraka's speech; he couldn't fucking figure her out and that pissed him off. Did she want Izuku or did she want to be Izuku? Ever since the beginning of the year, the two had been all flustered and tongue-tied around each other, but Katsuki had chalked Izuku's end of it up to the fact that he probably had never talked to another girl in his life. At least not one that had been nice to him.

Uraraka however… well. Katsuki respected her, and had from the moment she'd held up against him during the Sports Festival. He wasn't some asshole that beat the shit out of girls for fun. He beat the shit out of any and everyone, and he certainly didn't hold back. There had never been a situation in which he'd wanted to give anything less than 100%, and he definitely hadn't been planning on doing that during the biggest UA showcase of the year.

But she still threw him for a loop. Her eyes always seemed to follow Izuku, no matter what he was doing. During training exercises, she gravitated towards him, more than she did their other classmates. She sat beside him at lunch and they hung out in the common room and it had really started to annoy him. She made Izuku smile and laugh so *effortlessly* , and he hated it. He hated that things were so easy between them, especially after the thoughts he had had only a few nights earlier.

So Katsuki stood by while she gave her speech about the importance of supporting heroes and blah blah blah. He'd heard enough sob stories from their classmates to last him for a considerable amount of time. He was more worried about the fact that Izuku looked like death standing up, shivering and swaying.

Izuku teetered beside him, his eyes all teary. Katsuki shifted closer, just enough so that he could catch him again if he needed to. Izuku was watching Uraraka, so clearly captivated by her speech. Katsuki couldn't help the disgusting swirl of feelings in his gut, something like jealousy towards Uraraka, dark and angry and misplaced. He knew that Izuku had had a similar look in his eyes when Katsuki had apologized, but it would never be the same between the two of them. No matter what they were - enemies, rivals, friends, something else - there would never be a clean slate. Nothing would ever wash away the insults, the shoves, the degrading, the things Katsuki had said that kept him awake. Nothing would ever turn him into a girl that could make Izuku smile so easily, that had never been anything but kind to him. She'd seen him as a hero from the start, not nearly 17 years too late.

He took a small step away from Izuku. He probably didn't even deserve to catch Izuku when he fell.

After the boys had wrangled Izuku into the bath and discarded his hero costume, Katsuki had designated himself to keeping Izuku from trying to run away.

He hadn't seemed to be flighty in the bath; his eyes had been heavily lidded and he'd dozed off in the water a handful of times. Katsuki wasn't particularly worried about him trying

anything for the rest of the evening. After the entire class went to sleep, though, *that* was another story.

While Izuku sat on the couch, dodging questions from the class, Katsuki gathered up the gear that hadn't been tossed and set off to clean it. Todoroki stepped in, shutting down the pestering, which Katsuki should have done, but he hadn't.

He sat in the kitchen, scrubbing at Izuku's grungy gloves and belt with a soapy rag. The tattered cape that he'd thrown a fit about keeping had been tossed immediately into the washing machine.

"You don't have to do that."

Katsuki didn't even look up. They hadn't talked since he had apologized.

"Yeah, I know."

Izuku didn't say anything for a long while. Katsuki continued scrubbing, so hard that his hands began to hurt. His fingers shook and his annoyance was building as Izuku continued to stand there, not saying *anything* -

"Thank you."

"Someone had to fucking do it. These gloves are rancid."

"Kacchan."

"Do you want to smell 'em?"

"I'm not talking about you cleaning my stuff."

Katsuki set the gloves and rag down on the table and finally looked up.

The sight before him was disorienting. Izuku's hair was no longer drenched and matted; it was still damp from the bath, but it had begun to regain its curl and volume. His freckles were no longer hidden between grime and blood. His clothes were clean and he wasn't slouching.

But his eyes were different. They lacked their typical shine. Izuku no longer looked in tune with his childish side; he looked like he'd seen too much, like he'd been beaten down to a point of dejected acceptance. Bright green shimmering with admiration had been replaced by dull, burnt-out eyes, devoid of life and joy and hope for the future.

It drove Katsuki crazy to think of the world changing Izuku. He hadn't cared when he was a middle schooler, but he cared now.

Izuku deserved everything, even more so than the rest of their class. Katsuki had repressed it for years, had pushed Izuku away because he'd been so intimidated by how *heroic* he'd been on instinct. He'd been born with something that Katsuki hadn't, something that gave him more potential to become a hero than anyone else. And through it all, through scuffles on the

playground and years of bullying and a seclusion from society that Katsuki would never be able to relate to, Izuku had stayed so *bright* . He hadn't faltered, or turned cruel to the people who had tormented him. He'd seen so much good, in everyone and everything, their entire lives.

He wanted to show the League of Villains that they weren't shit, sure, but Katsuki had started to realize, as he watched Izuku struggle, that they were *too young* . They'd only been at UA for a year; he and Izuku and Todoroki were probably the only ones among their class that were at a similar level to some pro heroes, but they were still kids.

Katsuki hated when his parents told him that, when they fussed over him and said that he was too young to be fighting. But seeing Izuku, his spirit so clearly diminished, he couldn't help but agree.

The Commission and UA alike had taken *kids* , inexperienced children, and turned them into weapons. Because that's what the Commission did, right? That's what had happened to Hawks; acute manipulation over the course of years, molding him into their perfect little weapon. And that's what they were doing at UA. Katsuki couldn't blame them, not when he'd chosen that life for himself and didn't regret it, not for one second. But he was tired of the dumbass lectures and lessons that didn't matter. Learning how to handle interviewers, classes on marketing their merch, lectures on the importance of appealing to society in order to be successful.

All of that shit was so fucking pointless. They'd taken children with quirks that stood out and turned them into valuable assets.

They'd taken children and turned them into weapons. They might as well have actually prepared them for the war they were about to fight in. Where were their classes on strategy? On battle plans? On fighting as a part of a whole, not just as an individual? Sure, they'd had exercises that had encouraged those things, but not nearly enough to actually show them what a war was like. They hadn't worked on formations, hadn't arranged plans for how all the pros would come together as an army in case something like this happened. They were a profession, by nature, that operated mostly independently. There were Hero duos here and there, but the vast majority of pros worked by themselves, with sidekicks and interns working beneath them, supported by their agency.

Katsuki had been there when Shigaraki had destroyed Jaku. He'd seen buildings crumble, taking innocent civilians with them. He'd heard children crying out for their parents that had disappeared into the crowd. The injuries he'd seen, crushed limbs, puncture wounds, so much blood… UA hadn't prepared him for that. The school hadn't prepared any of them for that.

He didn't have a weak stomach, and he'd known what to expect, but the same couldn't be said for his classmates. He'd seen Izuku's face as debris had rained down on the city, capturing the lives of innocents. Katsuki had seen how shaken up it had made him.

"You shouldn't be fucking thanking me for apologizing to you. That's backwards."

"I'm not thanking you for the apology, really." Izuku sat down on one of the stools at the kitchen island. He'd left an empty one between him and Katsuki. The notion made Katsuki

want to throw up; did he not feel safe enough to sit next to Katsuki? “I’m thanking you for… I don’t know, for being vulnerable in front of the whole class just to bring me back. I just… I don’t get why you did it, you know? I mean, why would you care about me coming back?”

“You’re an asshole,” Katsuki said. He picked the rag back up and wiped over the same spot on one of Izuku’s gloves over and over again. “A stupid one, too.”

“Biologically, they’re not stupid. They have a very specific function and-”

“You’re giving me a lecture on assholes? Really, Izuku?”

That was still new. He was still getting used to it.

But he liked seeing the face Izuku made when he said his name, a sort of soft bewilderment. It was a step closer to the way he had looked before everything had gone downhill.

“Seriously Kacchan. I… really appreciated that.”

He was severely fucking uncomfortable.

“Yeah, nerd. Don’t get used to it.”

Izuku smiled, laying his head on his arms on top of the island. He watched Katsuki through half-lidded, bleary eyes. “I guess I shouldn’t be too surprised.”

“The fuck is that supposed to mean?”

“Well, everyone else was saying really sweet stuff and you never want to lose. I bet you were thinking about how you were gonna one-up all of them.”

“First off, I wasn’t being *sweet* . See, that’s your fucking problem. You thank me for apologizing to you for bullying you and then you call me *sweet* ?”

“I guess not sweet, but… genuine.”

“Fuck yeah it was genuine.” Katsuki glared at him. “I don’t bullshit.”

“Never.”

“Don’t get smart.”

Izuku yawned, shifting his shoulders. “‘M not. You tell me all the time how stupid I am.”

So I’m still an asshole .

“You’re stupid about your safety. And you’re stupid with this whole… I don’t fucking know, you have this fucking dick sucking hero complex thing going on and *that’s* stupid.”

“I have a *what* complex?” Izuku shot up straight, his face going bright red. “I- you- what-”

“Don’t deny it. You literally dick ride just about anyone on this planet if you think they need saving. All Might told me about how you almost got your ass blasted by Lady Whoever-the-fuck and you were *still* trying to make her see the light.”

“I do not-” Izuku’s voice quieted, “- *dick ride* anybody.”

Katsuki peered at him. “Did you just say dick?”

“ *Kacchan* .”

“You did.”

“You said it first. You said it *twice* .”

“Yeah and I’m me.”

“What, am I not allowed to say dick?”

“Now *you* said it twice.”

Izuku threw his hands up. “You’re impossible. I don’t even know why I came back.”

“That’s not a very funny joke, asshole.” Katsuki had been scrubbing at the glove for entirely too long. He switched to the belt. He couldn’t look at Izuku; he’d done too much mushy eye contact for a lifetime. “You looked like you were about to drop dead. You’re useless to everyone if you don’t take care of yourself.”

“So you only wanted me to come back so I’d be useful again?” Izuku’s voice was subdued. It brought all of Katsuki’s fears of him trying to run away again rushing to the surface.

“I couldn’t give less of a shit about those stupid ass villains,” he snapped, spinning on the stool to face Izuku. “I’m done watching you destroy yourself for everyone else. I’m just waiting for you to fucking get a grip and start thinking about yourself for once. It’s not about you being fucking useful, it’s about you ending up dead in a ditch somewhere because you went way past your limits when you have people who *want to fucking help you* .”

Izuku’s lips curved up in a small smile. It was nowhere near the same as what it had been before the raid on Jaku and Gunga, but it would have to do until Katsuki could fix it. And he was fucking going to. “I’m glad I have you watching my back, Kacchan.”

Katsuki scoffed.

Izuku reached out and rested his hand over top of Katsuki's. He faltered in his obsessive scrubbing. “Your apology meant a lot to me. And I know you didn’t just say all of that to get me to come back. You don’t say things you don’t mean.”

Izuku’s hand was still on his. Katsuki could feel the raised edges of his scars, the tougher skin that had a faded color. He’d imagined how they would feel against him, he’d imagined kissing those scars, each and every single-

Izuku pulled his hand back, his face flushing. He stood from his stool, shifting awkwardly from foot to foot before heading towards the doorway to the common room.

“Oh, and Kacchan?”

He swallowed the lump in his throat. “What, nerd?”

“I know you texted me about stealing stuff from my All Might collection. I didn’t really think you meant my blanket. It’s not a collector’s item or anything.”

Fuck everything .

“You can fucking have it back. It’s not even comfortable.”

There was no point in hiding.

Izuku smiled at him, eyes glinting. This was the side of Izuku that got him, that made him feel like he needed to stay alert at all times. “I’ll get it off of you some other time.” Then, “Sleep well Kacchan.”

Izuku slept on the couch that night. And if Katsuki sat in the arm chair across from him until early the next morning, nobody needed to fucking know.

Dodge, counter, alter trajectory, aim, focus his blast, *shoot* -

Izuku flopped to the ground in front of Katsuki, a gloved arm resting over his forehead. His hero costume hadn’t been salvageable, and a new one was in the works courtesy of Hatsume, so he was dressed in their gym tracksuit with his gloves and a former version of his iron-soled shoes.

Katsuki would be lying if he said those shoes didn’t hurt like a bitch. Enhanced with One for All at 45%, a kick from Izuku was enough to leave his ribs bruised for the next few days.

After Izuku had returned to UA, and spent 18 hours sleeping, he’d thrown himself right back into training. Their classmates had argued against it, had told Izuku he needed more rest and that he should start slow and ease himself back into training. Izuku hadn’t listened.

Katsuki hadn’t given his input on the situation while the whole class berated Izuku for training just as hard as the rest of them. His stance on it was complicated; he didn’t want Izuku to overwork himself to the point that he had been at just a few days prior, but the fact still remained that All for One and Shigaraki were out there somewhere, surely plotting every way to steal Izuku’s quirk.

He trained with Izuku instead of coddling him. Telling Izuku to stop training would get him nowhere, but training with him would allow Katsuki to make sure he was taking care of his body and not pushing his limits.

It seemed that Izuku was comfortable enough around Katsuki to admit when he was tired, or when his body felt weak and achy. He told Katsuki when he needed a break, or when he was struggling to adapt to the new quirks he’d unlocked during his month away. He didn’t

complain when Katsuki shoved a plate into his hand at dinner time each day, piled higher than the rest of their classmates'. He let Katsuki herd him to his room without arguing, an amused smile playing on his lips as Katsuki told him that he couldn't beat villains if he was falling asleep standing up.

Katsuki took note of everything, and that day, as he tried out his cluster move for the umpteenth time, he noticed Izuku's hands and arms quivering. They'd been sparring for hours at that point, with short breaks that were few and far between.

Katsuki had known that Izuku had been warned about repetitively breaking his bones and that it would eventually cause permanent damage if he overdid it.

"Your arms are shaking," Katsuki said matter-of-factly, watching Izuku struggle to catch his breath.

Izuku laughed. "Well, I've broken my arms more than anything else, so they've suffered the worst."

Katsuki flopped down onto the ground beside him. "See, you say shit like that so casually. Like, that's not fucking normal, Izuku."

Izuku gulped down half of his water bottle before handing it to Katsuki. He tried not to think of the fact that Izuku had just sipped from it as he lifted it to his own lips.

"Everybody has side effects from their quirks," Izuku argued, stretching his arms out in front of them. They shook, just enough for Katsuki to notice it. Izuku clenched and unclenched his fists a few times.

"Yeah, not everybody suffers permanent damage from theirs."

"It's not that bad."

"Do they hurt? Your arms."

Izuku rolled onto his side, eyes boring into Katsuki. "I mean, yeah. Sometimes they ache, either when I put too much stress on them or when I don't use them for too long. They get all cramp-y. And it gets hard to use my hands. Kind of like when your hands are so cold that it's hard to move your fingers around."

"Should've listened when they told you not to keep breaking them. On purpose."

Izuku's lips flicked up into a small smile. Katsuki had started to notice that this smile was one Izuku only used for *him* . That fact made him more than a little smug. "That's why I don't complain or ask Recovery Girl if there's anything I can do about it. It was my own fault."

"I'm sure there's exercises and shit you can do."

"Yeah." Izuku closed his eyes, letting out a deep exhale. "After the whole thing with Shigaraki and the League, y'know, at Jaku." Izuku blinked his eyes open at that, his

expression so full of emotion that Katsuki thought he was about to burst into tears. “When you…”

“What, when I got stabbed?” Izuku flinched. “Crusty asshole can’t get rid of me that easily. I’m still here, right?”

Izuku smiled again. “All Might told me that Recovery Girl treated me right after I got to the hospital. She healed the worst of my injuries then, which probably drained my stamina and triggered the coma. All Might said she didn’t want to heal me anymore after that because she was worried that…”

“That healing you while you were in a coma would kill you.”

“Right. And All Might told me that she’d checked over all my injuries and evaluated me and everything. She said that having my bones broken so many times over again can lead to them healing crooked or with deformities. When your bones break and heal, in normal cases, over time they get back to full strength. But with my quirk, well, there’s a lot more force behind me breaking my bones, which concerns my doctors. It takes longer for them to heal properly, even with Recovery Girl using her quirk on me. On top of that, there’s so many different types of breaks that they explained to me, and there’s actually a lot of complications when it comes to healing bones.”

Katsuki rolled onto his side to face Izuku, who’s eyes were squinted in thought.

“They said a lot can go wrong with my healing if I keep breaking bones. Like them not growing together at the right angle, or not growing completely back together at all. And the doctors are worried about how it’s damaging everything else in my body, too. Like my tendons and ligaments. They’re worried it could lead to some sort of blood flow blockage if my healing goes wrong.”

He was ranting, his words starting to jumble together. Katsuki was able to follow, though, because he’d been subjected to Izuku’s mumbling since they were children.

It was a pretty dreadful topic, actually, to hear about all the ways Izuku had fucked up his body and how he couldn’t make it better. But Izuku’s eyes had gotten back some of their shine as he talked.

“It’s all really interesting, actually,” Izuku said, flexing one hand again. “Maybe if this whole hero thing doesn’t work out, I can go treat broken bones, or… something like that.”

Katsuki laughed at that. “Right. You’ve been dreaming about being a hero since you could fucking breathe. No way you’re gonna go work in orthopedics.”

“Back up plans, Kacchan. They’re very important.”

“This is it for me. Fuck a back up plan.”

“What if it doesn’t work out? What if the media doesn’t like you because you have a bad attitude and you don’t make enough money to pay rent?”

“Good thing I’ll know a bone doctor that can afford a two bedroom apartment.”

He was getting way too fucking bold. Joking about them being roommates one day? Izuku was definitely going to think he was fucking out there. He’d bullied him all their lives and now he was joking about *living* together-

“Only if you cook every day. And keep the explosions to a minimum inside.”

Katsuki could envision it a little too clearly. A life with Izuku, a space shared by them. Izuku would return home from a patrol and Katsuki would be cooking, making the food a little less spicy than he would if it were just for him. They’d sit on the couch together and watch the news, keeping a lookout for any word of their old classmates and the other heroes they had come to know. Izuku would undoubtedly have their entire place decorated with sentimental pictures from their time at UA or articles about each of their successes as heroes.

Maybe, just maybe, they wouldn’t need an apartment with two bedrooms.

It felt like something really worth working towards.

Something he wanted almost just as bad as being number one.

“Whatever, nerd. So long as you keep the bone-talk to a minimum.”

“ *Bone-talk* ?”

“Yeah. Bones. Boners. Boning.”

“Kacchan.” Izuku’s face was red. “Stop *that* .”

Katsuki found himself smiling a little too widely, his face and body relaxed. Here they were, lying in the dirt, laughing about stupid shit and smiling with each other. If there was anything good that had come out of the last two months, it would be moments like these. Moments where it seemed as if their past really didn’t matter, like they were no longer Katsuki the bully and Izuku the bullied, but Katsuki and Izuku, classmates, rivals, friends.

They’d both caught their breath long ago, and Katsuki could hear the sounds of their other classmates still sparring off in the distance. He didn’t care; he and Izuku had always been set apart from Class A and this was no different.

“Everything about my bones makes me think about you, though.”

…What.

“ *Huh* ?”

“That came out wrong. Not in a weird way. I did *not* mean that in a weird way.”

“What would be a weird way?”

“Oh my god.”

Katsuki leaned up on one elbow, looking down at Izuku. “You were thinking about your bones. And that made you think about me? Something you wanna say, nerd?”

“Kacchan, I meant your *quirk* .”

“You’re digging yourself deeper and deeper. You should probably stop talking.”

“Yeah I probably should.”

Katsuki watched, amused, as Izuku’s face began to return to normal, ever so slightly rosy and sprinkled with freckles.

“I just meant… the side effects of your quirk. I was thinking about them.”

“Don’t you have it all figured out by now? How many notebook pages do you have about me?”

“You make it sound creepy.”

“It is creepy. You’re creepy.”

“I just meant… I had a lot of time to think when I was… you know.”

Izuku had thought of him. While he’d been away.

It shouldn’t have been a big surprise, really, considering the fact that Katsuki had blown up his phone and been the only one to be able to contact him while he’d been away. And Izuku had always been drawn to him.

Still, the thought of Izuku out there alone, doing his nerdy analysis on Katsuki to either keep himself awake or not feel so lonely, kind of made his heart ache.

“Like… Do you get bad recoil from explosions? When you do your Howitzer, does it hurt? I would kind of expect it to, actually. Do you think if you overuse that move, which would already be challenging since it requires you to store so much sweat, that you could do permanent damage to your arms? And would it be damage to your bones, like me, or would it affect your joints?”

How had Katsuki ever been annoyed by Izuku’s muttering before? And how had he existed for an entire month without it?

“Yeah, I get recoil depending on the size of my explosions. Howitzer hurts like a fucking bitch. It’s the one move I have where I put all of my power into a single blast. My AP Shot is powerful, but it’s spread out over multiple explosions instead of just one. And bigger explosions throw my shoulders out every once in a while. Sometimes it hurts my wrists.”

This was one of the first times Katsuki had ever indulged Izuku, providing answers to his mutterings and theories. Izuku’s eyes were shining with excitement, and he sat up beside Katsuki.

“Do you get side effects from the nitroglycerin? Like, if you don’t use your quirk for too long and your sweat builds up, do you think you’d suffer side effects? It can be used as a heart medication, so would it relax your heart too much and make you sick if you didn’t use it? Say, for example, if you got hit with one of those bullets that takes away your quirk, would it take away your ability to ignite your sweat? I don’t think it would be able to affect your genetic makeup and change the fact that you sweat nitroglycerin, right? So if you lost your quirk, would your sweat poison you over time?”

“I don’t know, I’ve never gone long enough to figure that shit out. And now that you say that, I don’t fucking *want* to find out.”

“I wonder if your body has built up a tolerance, since you’ve been exposed to it constantly for your entire life. That’s probably why it doesn’t relax your heart right now.”

“What am I, your lab rat? Or a fucking science experiment? When do you have time to think about all of this?”

Izuku laughed. “Actually, I’ve been wondering about some of this since we were kids, but…”

“But I was too much of an asshole to answer your questions, right?” Katsuki guessed.

Izuku looked away, his expression sheepish.

Katsuki wanted to fix things, didn’t he?

“Ask away, nerd.”

Izuku’s smile stretched across his entire face. It was like Katsuki was staring into the sun, unable to squint or shield his eyes.

“What about your hands? They’re pretty resistant to heat, right? Because of your explosions. And you were training using boiling water, weren’t you? To make you sweat more so you could make your explosions bigger. Do they get calloused? Do your sweat glands get clogged?”

Before Katsuki could stop him, Izuku was yanking off his own gloves before grabbing Katsuki’s wrist and yanking off his. Izuku lifted Katsuki’s hand, running his fingers across Katsuki’s palm.

Katsuki about short-circuited.

Izuku was tracing the lines of his palm, eyes completely focused on Katsuki’s hand, as if he were captivated by it. He ran a finger up Katsuki’s thumb and Katsuki shuddered involuntarily. Izuku’s fingers were ever so gentle, his skin a rough mixture of smooth and scar-hardened.

“They’re soft,” Izuku said simply. As if Katsuki’s entire world hadn’t gone silent, his mind locked onto the gentle touches traveling across his hand. “I thought you might’ve had callouses.”

“I take care of my skin, dumbass,” he said, his voice tight. He wanted to yank his hand back. He never wanted Izuku to stop doing whatever the hell he was doing. He wanted his heart to stop beating so fucking hard in his chest. “If I damage my sweat glands, I won’t have a quirk anymore.”

Izuku hummed. “You know, quirk marriages are pretty messed up and all, but if you had a kid that inherited your explosion power with someone who had primary hyperhidrosis, don’t you think that would be pretty overpowered?”

“Quit the nerd talk. Primary hyper-what?”

“Primary hyperhidrosis. It’s when you sweat excessively from your palms. I mean, that would be a pretty crazy case of a genetic condition enhancing a quirk.”

“You’re such a freak, Izuku. Who the hell has the time to think of these things? Why do you even *know* these things?”

“I told you, I’ve researched your quirk a lot.”

“You’ve researched my quirk enough to know what genetic condition I should look for in someone if I ever want to have kids?”

“You make it sound weird. It was just a hypothetical. It wouldn’t really be a quirk marriage, per se, it would just be… a lucky coincidence if your wife had it.”

“This whole conversation is weird. You’re weird.”

“I’m just *saying* . It would give your kid a pretty good advantage if they wanted to become a hero.”

“Yeah, and what if I don’t want kids? Or a fucking wife?”

Izuku gave him a surprised look.

Shit .

Izuku wouldn’t be the type to care, right, if someone was gay? He wouldn’t run away from Katsuki, right?

But there was the very high probability of him figuring out exactly what Katsuki had been feeling over the last few months, the tangle of emotions in his gut that made him feel both sick to his stomach and higher than the clouds whenever Izuku even so much as smiled at him.

Fuck.

“I mean, I guess I’m not surprised. You probably wouldn’t even consider something like that until you’re number one, right?”

At least he’s too fucking logical to figure out why I don’t actually want a wife.

“Something like that.”

And then, because Katsuki was his own worst enemy, he asked, “What about you? You want to get married and have kids?”

Izuku thought about it for a moment, finally letting Katsuki’s hand go. His palm was sweaty, and he grabbed Izuku’s hand, wiping it off on his sleeve. All the nerd’s talk about the effects of nitroglycerin had made him self-conscious about his sweat. “Don’t want your heart slowing down because of me,” he muttered when Izuku gave him a weird look.

“I don’t think I’d be against having kids. But… I don’t know. It’s not really something I’ve ever thought about. It would be pretty difficult to find someone who understands what it’s like to be a hero. All the demands, the paperwork, even dealing with the public. And the schedule is really intense. I wouldn’t want to be the dad that’s never around, considering…”

Izuku made a face. “Anyways. I guess I would have kids. But only after I felt really happy in achieving my goals as a hero. I’d still work, I guess, but nothing too dangerous. I just… couldn’t imagine dying and leaving kids behind.”

“You gonna get married?”

“I hope I do, at some point.” Izuku laughed, getting to his feet. Katsuki leaned back on his hands and looked up at him. “I don’t want to be alone forever.”

Again, Katsuki couldn’t help himself. “Pink Cheeks?”

“Huh?”

“You gonna marry Pink Cheeks?”

“Kacchan, *what* are you talking about?” But Izuku’s face had gone red and he avoided Katsuki’s gaze.

“You two are always fucking… I don’t know, looking at each other. And smiling at each other.”

“Friends do that.”

“Do friends give speeches in the rain to bring you back to UA?”

Izuku’s eyes flashed. “You did. And we’re friends, right Kacchan?”

Izuku was way too fucking smart for his own good.

Motherfucker . Katsuki was two for two on saying things that he definitely fucking shouldn’t. Had his whole near death experience really fucked up his brain-to-mouth filter that much?

“Uraraka and I are just friends. Really. I mean, I guess I kind of liked her at the beginning of the year. But she was the first girl I ever really talked to. Or that paid attention to me. If it

would have been, I don't know, Ashido or Hagakure, instead of Uraraka, it probably would have been the same thing."

"Whatever. She definitely has the hots for you."

"She does *not* ."

"Please. That whole speech? And jumping in to save you during your class battle, when you lost control of Blackwhip?"

" *You* gave a speech. And you jumped in front of me and almost *died* to save me from Shigaraki. And *we're* friends. Same thing goes with Uraraka."

Except Katsuki had done those things with feelings towards Izuku that weren't friendship feelings. Even if he hadn't known it for sure at the time, it had been lingering around in his subconscious like a disease.

What point was Izuku even trying to make in bringing those things up? Was he onto Katsuki and his stupid… whatever it was he had for Izuku?

"Whatever, nerd. Sitting here chit-chatting isn't gonna do shit when All for One shows up."

"Right."

Izuku offered him a hand.

It was a small thing. It was a stupid thing, too, because Katsuki should have been over all of this.

Izuku wasn't offering his hand because he thought Katsuki was weak. He wasn't looking down on Katsuki.

They could lean on each other.

It had been a long road, but they'd learned to lean on each other. It had taken Katsuki quite a bit longer to figure it out, but he'd gotten there.

He let Izuku help him to his feet, pulling on his glove and ignoring the phantom feeling of Izuku's fingers caressing his palm.

There wasn't long left before they'd have to fight again. They only had a week to prepare for the war that was going to happen, and they needed to use their time wisely to master their quirks and strategize.

But Katsuki would trade some of his preparation time for moments like these.

"Y'know," he said, taking up a stance across from Izuku, "I was pretty pissed at you when you went away. I wanted to hear all your stupid opinions on Icy Hot's family drama."

"Be nice," Izuku chided.

“What? They’re the ones that were giving us live action reality TV when they invited us over for dinner. Then their long lost sibling ends up being one of the villains we’ve been fighting against this whole fucking time. And he clearly got the drama gene too. I say there’s a time and a fucking place for that shit.”

“It gave us a break from fighting,” Izuku said. Green lightning flared around his body, and he began squatting repetitively in rapid succession. *Stupid ass new quirk* . “And… I don’t know everything about Todoroki’s childhood but… Endeavor’s face was…”

“Funny as fuck? Right? Old bastard got his karma. That’ll show him not to smack his kids around.”

“Your mom smacked you around,” Izuku pointed out dryly.

“Come on, Izuku. You gonna say I didn’t deserve it?”

Izuku activated Float just as Katsuki aimed a controlled blast at him. “Well, Kacchan,” he said cheerfully, dodging another explosion and flicking his fingers, throwing Katsuki off course with a blast of wind as he launched into the air after him, “it obviously didn’t make you any nicer.”

“Oh, you *asshole* .”

Chapter End Notes

wooo another chapter
hoping updates will stay pretty consistent but don't hate me if they get a little spread out. I go back to college next week and I'm going to be working this semester soooo I probably won't have as much free time on my hands to update for you guys
I've really been enjoying writing this. their dynamic is absolutely one of my favorites ever. I really enjoyed doing this chapter even tho I hate doing dialogue (I struggle sm with it) but this just felt fun. I feel like this whole fic has been pretty like angsty in katsuki's head so this felt like a good chapter for development between them
I love hearing your thoughts so leave a comment if you feel like it!! and kudos are always much appreciated
<3

work song

Chapter Summary

when my time comes around
lay me gently in the cold, dark earth
no grave can hold my body down
I'll crawl home to him

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Their week of preparation flew by in a blink. Class A had been directed to assist in rescuing and evacuating civilians, all while keeping up with training their quirks.

Katsuki continued pushing himself, training until he collapsed at the end of each day, his winter costume thoroughly drenched in his own sweat and plastered to his body. His wrists had begun to ache from repetitively firing off high-power blasts, and his shoulders weren't faring much better. He'd taken to wrapping his wrists before bed, giving him a slight reprieve before he would destroy them again the next day.

Finding out that Aoyama had been selling them out to All for One had thrown everyone for a loop, and Katsuki had quietly seethed as he and his parents were interrogated. Because of Aoyama, he'd been kidnapped by the League. Because of Aoyama sharing the location of the training camp, All Might had lost the embers of One for All. Katsuki had already come to terms with his own involvement with the destruction of the hero he had always looked up to. But knowing he wasn't the only one at fault, he was all at once relieved that it hadn't just been him to destroy All Might, and pissed off that Aoyama had fucked them all over and given the League a leg-up.

Aoyama's betrayal had caught the class by surprise, and though Katsuki hadn't pegged him as the type to be involved in something nefarious, he didn't allow himself to be shocked by the reveal. This was war; he'd been fighting off the mentality of innocence, of being a child. Katsuki most definitely wasn't innocent, but he was young. He felt it in his body, in his own unending energy and bratty, childlike responses. Those factors didn't change their situation. He could act like a child and still be placed on the front lines. Izuku could have the innocent, gleaming eyes that he had had since childhood and that wouldn't change the fact that he was the primary target of their opponents.

Nothing would change their situation. Nothing would undo the events of the last year, or the events tracing back through the vestiges of One for All, all the way back to two brothers with more drama than Katsuki cared to understand.

Izuku had insisted that Aoyama could still be a hero, with a hand extended, so similar to a memory Katsuki held close, from years and years ago. He'd had the idea of using Aoyama to draw All for One out of hiding, and Katsuki had smirked from behind the cover of his costume.

They would never be children again after this war. They would only ever be weapons.

Izuku was using that clever brain of his - the one that had sucked up any and every detail about quirks and battles and villains and strategy ever since they were children - as a weapon.

It was yet another reminder of Izuku's very heroic nature. The nature that Katsuki had denied for 17 years.

Quirks were the pillars of their society. Stronger quirks translated to more potential for greatness, higher hero rankings, a bright future. That was what Katsuki had learned very early on, after hearing everyone in his life tell him over and over again that he would one day become the number one hero because his quirk was so *amazing* .

What those people, and Katsuki himself, hadn't realized, was that quirks weren't the only things that made heroes. Quirks weren't the only things that could be used as weapons when it came down to it.

Over the course of his first year at UA, after being bested and beaten over and over again, after seeing the one person he had admired most destroyed because of his own shitty attitude, Katsuki had come to realize that quirks weren't the only things necessary to becoming a hero.

Izuku had always been a hero. He had been saving people ever since they were children in a park, giggling and laughing and playing heroes, none the wiser to the fact that they would one day be fighting in a war so much bigger than themselves.

It had taken Katsuki years to realize that.

They got their assignments a day in advance, after All Might explained their strategy and their usage of Aoyama. Katsuki itched to fight; he owed Shigaraki double after Jaku and he wouldn't mind putting All for One on his ass either. They'd fucked with him and Izuku and the rest of their class one too many times for Katsuki's liking, had murdered countless innocent people, had sent Japan into a state of crisis.

"Aren't you nervous? I'm nervous," Mina said. She was sitting at the end of his bed in his dorm at Troy. The room was nicer than the one he had at Heights Alliance, equipped with his own bathroom and walls that were impenetrable. Still, the place put Katsuki on-edge. It was a weird feeling, knowing that he was going to bed that night and would wake up to fight the most dangerous villains the world had ever seen the next morning.

"The fuck would I be nervous for?" he muttered around the screwdriver in his mouth. He was running a routine check on all of his gear. In the process, he wore his gloves to store as much sweat as he possibly could in preparation for the next day.

“Um, dying?” Kaminari said, incredulous. He was sitting on Katsuki’s floor, his fingers drumming against the hardwood in anticipation.

“Nobody’s dying tomorrow,” Kirishima said. He smiled, even if it looked strained. “We’ve got this. Don’t be negative.”

Katsuki’s friends muttered their responses but none of them sounded all that convinced. He set down his gauntlet and took the screwdriver out of his mouth. “No point worrying about it. We either fight and survive or give up and die. If you’re so scared of dying, why’d you decide to become a hero in the first place?”

Mina kicked him. She was probably the only one in the whole room he would let get away with it. “Don’t let our last memories with you be so *negative* .”

“Well, they’re not gonna be your last memories of me, fuckhead.”

“He’s right,” Kirishima said. He rested a hand on Mina’s thigh. Katsuki’s eyebrows went up. “Nobody’s dying tomorrow.”

Had he really been such a closed-off asshole that he’d missed… whatever the fuck *this* was? God, was he that bad of a friend?

He didn’t have time to think about things like that, not when they would be fighting in a war the next day. He would fix it, though. He would be a better friend. He would let people in.

“Well, before we all kick the bucket, I just want to say, I always thought that mushroom bitch from Class B was into that one guy. Y’know, the one that can hide in darkness, or whatever,” Sero said. He leaned back on his hands from where he was sitting next to Kaminari.

“Seriously, Sero? *That’s* what you’re worried about?” Jirou shot him a look from the other side of Kaminari.

“No, he’s onto something,” Mina said. “I see them walking in the halls together all the time. And, the other day, I watched him hold the door for her back at the dorms. It was so cute!”

“I hope you have better fucking standards than that,” Katsuki muttered.

“It was gentlemanly,” she retorted, crossing her arms. “What’s *your* idea of romance, huh Blasty?”

“Don’t have one.”

“Come on,” Kaminari said, “You totally do.”

“Yeah, you told us you thought Midoriya was hot back when you were in the hospital. What about that?” Sero asked.

“Fuck all of you. I’m never telling any of you anything ever again.”

“Don’t be like that,” Kirishima said from the other side of Mina. “We’re *friends* . Friends talk about stupid things like that.”

“Shitty Hair. Watch it.”

Jirou jabbed Katsuki’s arm with one of her ear jacks. “You don’t scare us anymore. We’re desensitized.”

“I’ll kill all of you.”

“Do you like him?” Mina’s voice went up about two octaves. She tugged on his shirt sleeve. “Do you? That would be *so* cute.”

“Fuck off.”

“It would be!”

“I don’t like him. Can’t fucking stand him, actually.”

In a mocking voice, Sero said, “‘Izuku, come train with me. Izuku, I made you dinner. Izuku, have you been sleeping enough since coming back? Izuku, it was *soooo* sexy when you told Endeavor off, Izu-’ Ow!”

Katsuki aimed a kick at Sero’s shoulder.

He’d rather be fighting that crusty ass bastard right now than deal with their shit.

“Don’t torment him,” Kirishima said, but his voice was amused.

Katsuki looked around at his friends, at the way their expressions weren’t nearly as strained and worried as when they’d all clambered into his room. Mina was giggling, Sero was rubbing his shoulder with a pouty expression on his face, Kaminari’s deep frown had been replaced with his typical smile, and Jirou had a small grin on her face.

If it eased their minds to pick at Katsuki, so be it. It didn’t do any of them good to be stressed the night before a war.

“I bet he likes you,” Kaminari said. “I mean, there’s no way he doesn’t. He’s been following you around like a puppy since you were kids. And everytime you do something, he’s always saying how *amazing* Kacchan is.”

“Don’t forget how he only came back because you apologized,” Jirou added.

“ *And* he’s always picking you over everyone else,” Mina said. “Ei asked him to train the one day and he was all flustered and was like ‘I would but Kacchan already asked me.’”

“First of all,” Katsuki said, side-eyeing her, “ *Ei* ? When the fuck did this-” he pointed between the two of them, “happen?”

“You were too busy checking out Midoriya’s abs to notice. I mean, he’s got a great bod so I get it,” Kirishima said.

“He’s not into me, I can tell you assholes that much,” Katsuki muttered. He picked up one of his grenades, tossing it experimentally in his hand a few times. “He told me he was into Uraraka at the beginning of the year.”

“Yeah, at the beginning of the year,” Sero said. “What does that have to do with now?”

“He likes girls.”

“He *liked* a girl. That doesn’t mean he just likes girls,” Jirou said.

“Yeah, well, she’s about over the moon with him, so.”

“So you *do* like him?” Mina asked, her eyes bright. “I knew it!”

“Never fucking said that.”

“Yeah, but you’re jealous about Uraraka liking him,” Kaminari said. “Totally not normal bro behavior.”

“Bet you’re fucking jealous Shitty Hair has a girlfriend and you don’t.”

The room went silent. Sero coughed to cover a laugh.

“Fucking *what* ?”

Mina pointed between Jirou and Kaminari.

What the fuck *?* Was Katsuki that unaware of his friends’ lives? Did he really not pay enough attention to them to notice the fact that his two closest friends had girlfriends?

“Oh. Shit.”

“Beat you to it, *Kacchan* .”

“Fuck off.”

“If you would just admit that you like Midoriya, *maybe* you wouldn’t be single,” Mina said, leaning her head on Kirishima’s shoulder. “What happened to Mr. Overconfident?”

“More like Mr. Big Ego,” Sero muttered.

“Oh fuck you, Tape-for-Brains. I don’t see you having any options.”

“So you admit you have options?” Sero shot back.

“You know what, if I die tomorrow, at least I won’t have to hear you fuckers *pester* me about stupid shit.”

“Your little crush on Midoriya is *not* stupid,” Kirishima said. “I mean, seriously, I think it would be cute. Super manly.”

“It’s not gonna happen.”

“Your ego,” Kaminari said with an exaggerated gasp. “It’s gone.”

“Your fucking face is gonna be gone here in a second, asshole.”

“Are you gonna talk to him? Before tomorrow?” Jirou asked.

“I’m not fucking-”

He broke off. He didn’t want to say too much, he didn’t want them to know that he was *weak* , that Izuku made him *weak* in such a way that he wasn’t used to. He didn’t want them to know that he didn’t even care anymore, that he would be weak if that’s what it took to stay by Izuku’s side for the rest of their lives, in whatever way that might be. He didn’t want them to laugh, like the “friends” he’d had in middle school would have if they’d found out he liked boys. He didn’t want them to see all these things and think of him as *less* .

They’d all regarded him as their strong point throughout the year. They had all relied on him, at one point or another. They’d all recognized him as one of their classmates with the most potential. He didn’t want that to change. He didn’t want people to see the parts of him that he hid behind walls of steel, much like this very fortress they were in, and think of him as weak.

They aren’t like that .

If he could face off against villains without a sliver of fear, he could talk to his friends about stupid things. He could laugh with them, open up to them, let them in, little by little.

“Even if I did like him,” he said, glaring at each of them in turn, “I’m not that much of an asshole that I’d say something about it the night before a war.”

“Such a gentleman,” Kirishima said, patting Katsuki’s shoulder.

“Are you more of the randomly showing up with flowers type of boyfriend? Or the guy that plans out an entire date down to the tiniest detail?” Kaminari was grinning.

“I think he’s more of the ‘I’m gonna be super mean to you and hope that you catch on that I actually want to fu-’”

“That’s enough,” he groaned, cutting off Sero and covering his face with a gloved hand.

“Who would’ve known that Blasty is such a prude,” Mina squealed.

“I *am not* .”

“You 100% are,” Kaminari taunted.

“You know, we placed bets,” Jirou said.

“You assholes placed bets on me?”

“Oh, yeah, some of them have been going for months,” Sero said.

“I bet that Midoriya would make the first move,” Jirou said.

Katsuki glared at her. “That’s fucked, ears. Don’t even think about saying we’re friends ever again.”

“I don’t think I ever claimed to be your friend in the first place,” she responded dryly.

“I didn’t agree at first,” Kaminari said, laying one arm easily over Jirou’s shoulders. For some reason, that motion made Katsuki *jealous* . Not of either of them, but of their mere existence as two parts of a whole. It was something he wanted, something he’d been trying to convince himself he wasn’t allowed to want. “But I don’t think you’ll *ever* make a move. You’re like, way too repressed.”

“I’m not *repressed* .”

“You can’t even admit you like him!”

“All of you are assholes. Get out of my room.”

“I bet that you would make the first move, if that helps,” Kirishima said.

“You’re such a good friend, Shitty Hair. Betting on my love life.”

“So you admit it? That you have a love life? And that it involves Midoriya?” Mina said, grabbing Katsuki by the shoulder and shaking him.

“Fuck off, Pinky.”

“That wasn’t a no.”

“Eat a dick.”

“Still not a no.” She held out her hand.

Sero groaned and handed her a few wadded-up bills. Kirishima followed suit.

Katsuki glared at them. “Both of you can suck it. I hope you go broke.”

“Well, Bakugou, if you kiss Midoriya first, I’ll make back double what I bet against Mina that you were into him. So do me a solid, would you?” Sero smirked at him, the challenge evident on his face.

“I hate you. All of you.”

Katsuki knocked on Izuku's door. He knew Izuku wouldn't be asleep yet, knew he would spend the next few hours obsessing over the details of their plan for the next day.

The door swung open and Katsuki stepped in without being invited. At one point, Izuku probably would have flinched at the notion. At one point, Katsuki probably would have blown the door open without knocking.

"Hey Kacchan," Izuku said. His eyes looked tired. "Why aren't you sleeping?"

He shoved his arm out, his fist bumping Izuku's chest. "Brought you this."

It was the stupid ass All Might blanket he'd stolen right after Izuku had left. It had smelled like Izuku back then, and Katsuki had spent too long trying to deny the fact that he knew what Izuku smelled like back then.

Izuku looked down at it and smiled. "You packed this? Why? Didn't you have other stuff to bring?"

"Like what? I didn't bring shit."

"Oh."

Izuku's room was also blank, save a few notebooks that were spread across his desk, the pages covered in sloppy handwriting. There were a few sketches of some of the members of the League of Villains that they were familiar with.

"Don't you have this shit committed to memory by now? You should be sleeping."

"I appreciate you worrying about me, really, but I'm okay. I'm not tired."

"What did I tell you about not being useful when you're falling asleep standing up? If you're tired tomorrow and you slip up, that could give Shigaraki a shot at you. Is that what you want?"

"Kacchan."

"I'm serious, Izuku." His hands felt hot. He clenched them into fists, digging his fingernails into his palms. He hadn't come here to yell at Izuku or fight with him. When it came to Izuku's safety, though, it always seemed to end that way. "You need to rest."

"What about you? Are you the exception to all your rules?" Izuku said, his voice snarky. He turned away from Katsuki, sliding open the balcony door and stepping out. He left it open, and Katsuki followed. "You don't have to worry about me so much. It's weird."

"I'm not worrying about you. I'm making sure you're not gonna get yourself killed tomorrow because you were too much of a dumbass to go to sleep."

Izuku glanced over at him, his eyes knowing. *Fuck you, you stupid fucking genius* .
"Whatever you say, Kacchan."

Katsuki turned back around, his palms crackling. He yanked the balcony door open.

He didn't want to yell at Izuku, not tonight, not with the pressures of a war on them. It wasn't fair to Izuku, not when he was All for One's target. If anyone deserved to be stressed, it was Izuku.

"Do you want me to fucking say I'm worried about you?" he hissed, trying to keep his voice down. "Is that it? Because I'll fucking say it Izuku. If that's what it takes, then-"

"I don't want you to say anything. I just-"

"You just what? You just argue with me every time I try to look out for your safety? I didn't realize I was such a shitty person for trying to keep you from getting yourself killed." He shut the balcony door again, feeling suddenly awkward. His palms were sweaty and he rubbed them off on his pants furiously.

"I don't think you're a shitty person, really. I just… I want to make sure that everything goes right tomorrow. I don't want anyone to get hurt because of me."

Katsuki stepped up beside him, leaning against the balcony railing and looking out across the evacuated city. "Everybody chose to be here. They want to fight."

"The only reason any of this is happening is because I have One for All."

"Aren't you the one always saying how heroes *help those in need* ?"

"Yeah, but-"

"You know, over the last year I've learned a whole fucking lot. And I know you noticed because you notice everything." *I know you noticed because you never stop paying attention to me and I never want you to stop* . "Even if I don't want to admit it, especially not to you, you were the one that taught me how to accept help. That accepting help doesn't make you weak."

Izuku didn't respond. His eyebrows were drawn together, his lips pursed in thought. He picked at his fingernails, avoiding Katsuki's gaze.

"Stop trying to do this by yourself. Let us help you."

"I'm scared," Izuku admitted finally, his voice quiet.

"Of fucking Shigaraki? Or nutsack face? Since when?" Katsuki scoffed.

"No. Of seeing the people I care about get hurt because of me."

"I told you, we all fucking chose to be here. If people get hurt tomorrow, it won't be because of you. You can't blame yourself for everything."

Out of the corner of his eye, Katsuki watched a single tear slip down Izuku's cheek. "What if someone *dies* , Kacchan?"

“Fair chance,” he said, shrugging. “But there’s a chance pros will die everytime they go out for a mission. If we don’t fight tomorrow, or if we let you do it all by yourself, more people will die that way.”

Katsuki internally cursed himself again for being the world’s worst comforter. Izuku’s expression still looked torn and distraught. Katsuki had probably failed at convincing him to get any sleep at this point.

But Izuku turned and gave him a small smile. “No matter what happens,” he started, his voice full of confidence, “I’m really happy. About this.” He pointed between himself and Katsuki. “Maybe I was a stupid little kid for holding on to hope that, one day, we would be friends again, or that we would get to be heroes together.” Izuku’s voice sped up, slipping into that typical flustered rambling that Katsuki had grown so used to. “I’m just glad that, I don’t know, that I got the chance to… to be your friend. Or your rival. Or whatever you want to call this.”

Do you feel it too ?

Katsuki was tempted to reach out, to place his hand over Izuku’s on the banister, or to put an arm around his shoulders and pull him close.

“Don’t get sentimental on me, nerd.”

“I’m just worried.”

“Good thing we’re fighting together then, huh?” Katsuki bumped his shoulder into Izuku’s. He’d been privately relieved when they’d been given their assignments and he’d been placed with Izuku. He’d told Izuku once before that he didn’t trust anyone when it came to Izuku’s safety. But Katsuki trusted himself. He wouldn’t let Izuku pull some stupid shit the next day and get himself killed.

“I’m really glad you’ll be there with me. I mean, the rest of our class, they’re great and I trust them, and the pros too and all, and-”

“Don’t gotta explain yourself,” Katsuki mumbled, his face feeling uncharacteristically warm. “I get it.”

If there was anybody Katsuki wanted to fight beside, it was Izuku. A year ago, he probably would have been too distracted by the thought of outdoing Izuku to even be near him on a battlefield. But so much had happened over the course of his first year at UA. So much had changed. Katsuki had changed. His feelings for Izuku had changed.

He’d spent so long hating Izuku for the parts of him that were so heroic. His desire to save, his determination, his courage in the face of any situation, his willingness to help any and everybody, his spirit. He’d pushed Izuku away, afraid of the way he’d made Katsuki feel simply by existing. Izuku went against everything Katsuki had been taught; how could someone without a quirk, which Katsuki had believed to be the essence of being a hero, be so much more heroic than Katsuki, who’s quirk rivaled that of some pros?

He'd realized, after getting beaten down time and time again at UA, that he didn't have to see Izuku as something that made him weak. Izuku could make him stronger. They could be strong. Together.

"Remember when you texted me? When I was… you know?"

"What, when you went rogue for a month and didn't take care of yourself for shit?"

"Yeah."

"What about it?"

"You told me you wouldn't have 'that conversation' with me back then. I wanted to… I don't know. I don't want to leave anything unsaid. Before tomorrow."

This was straying a little too close to a complicated feelings talk that Katsuki was not in the slightest prepared for. He felt the sudden urge to *run* , his fight-or-flight instincts kicking in full-force.

For some reason, Katsuki was itching to fight. He'd spent his entire life working up to something like this, something *big* . He was strong, he knew he was strong. Tomorrow wasn't a situation in which he needed to be a savior. Tomorrow, being powerful would be enough. He wasn't scared of Shigaraki, he wasn't scared to fight, not when this had been the future he had expected for himself since he was four years old.

Talking about his feelings, however, was something that scared him. It set him on edge, more than any villain or any training exercise. There were too many *unknowns* when it came to addressing his feelings. He had known Izuku for long enough to know that Izuku would be kind to him, would listen to him with a smile on his face and adoration in his eyes. And Izuku, self-sacrificial savior Izuku, would do anything to make others happy. Katsuki couldn't bear the thought of a future in which Izuku told him he returned Katsuki's feelings, just to make Katsuki happy.

"Don't do that. Don't say 'unsaid' like we're not going to get the chance to talk after tomorrow."

Izuku opened his mouth to say something presumably stupid about *you never know* , *Kacchan* .

"Neither of us are fucking dying tomorrow. Okay? So as soon as we've got these loser ass villains dealt with, we can talk about all the mushy shit you want."

"Are you scared, Kacchan?"

"Fuck no."

"Not of Shigaraki and the League. I meant… are you scared to admit that you care about me? Are you scared that it makes you weak, after all the years you spent hating me?"

Not for the first time, and certainly not for the last time, Katsuki cursed Izuku's perceptiveness.

"I'm not scared of shit."

"You've never said it, though."

"I'm more of a punch-you-in-the-face guy. Conversations aren't my thing."

Izuku glanced at him, his face drawn in the shadows of the balcony above them. His eyes glowed with amusement, so many shades of green mixing together. How Katsuki hadn't been captivated by those eyes earlier than a few months ago, he had no idea. Izuku still wasn't back to who had been before the fight with Shigaraki, before he'd become convinced that his cursed quirk would cause harm to everyone around him. Katsuki had already promised himself that he would see to it that Izuku returned to himself, full of life and *happy* .

Katsuki scoffed and looked away, down at his hands. They were gripping the banister so tightly, his knuckles turning white.

He had never been good at talking. His parents hadn't taught him how to communicate, how to talk about his feelings. He'd learned, early on, to keep it to himself. Being sad or emotional or showing his care for others made him *weak* . It wasn't a mindset he could fix overnight; it had been ingrained in him for years, to push his own emotions away and keep them under lock and key. Admitting that he cared about Izuku left him vulnerable.

All at once, Katsuki was pissed.

He was pissed at his parents. At his mother, for constantly knocking him down and reminding him of all his shortcomings. When he'd been kidnapped, she'd told him that All Might had lost his power because Katsuki had been *weak* . When he'd come second to Izuku in training exercises, she'd scoffed at him and told him that number one heroes didn't get beat in anything. When he'd been young and hadn't known any better, she hadn't enforced any punishments when he'd been a shitty brat to Izuku. She hadn't sat him down and told him that Izuku being different wasn't a bad thing. She'd never coddled him, or hugged him, or treated him like what he had been: a child. He was mad at his father, for not standing up to her. He was pissed at him for letting Mitsuki instill so many insecurities in him before he had even reached the age of ten. He was frustrated that Masaru had only shown Katsuki gentleness when Mitsuki wasn't around to see it, like it was something to hide.

He was pissed that he loved them both so much, that they'd given him everything in life to succeed. He'd been put into lessons for everything under the sun when he was a child. His parents had paid for a private tutor to ensure that he was smart enough to get into UA. They'd paid for every single piece of hero merch that he had begged for without questioning. When he'd gotten to UA, they'd started giving him a considerable allowance to use however he pleased. They'd never once shut down or doubted him when he said he wanted to become a hero.

How was it right of him to be angry with them when they had always supported him? How was it *fair* that they'd done everything right, except for teaching him that the world didn't

have to exist as the *weak* and the *strong* ?

At some point, his hands had started shaking and smoking, still clenched around the railing.

A pinky, scarred and a bit calloused, rested over Katsuki's own. It was a small touch, as if Izuku *knew* .

Of course Izuku knew. Izuku had been an expert on him since they were in diapers. He must've caught on, at some point, that comforting touches were foreign to Katsuki, a language he had never learned.

He was pushing Katsuki's boundaries, just a little bit.

Even with Katsuki's hands smoking, even with the potential of getting burned, Izuku was still reaching out. Izuku was still trying to save him.

"You're going to get burned," he rasped.

"That's okay," Izuku murmured, soft and warm and everything Katsuki had ever needed.

"I don't want to. Burn you, I mean."

Katsuki's first realization was that his voice sounded torn and broken, so far from the front he had been holding for so long.

Katsuki's second realization was that it didn't matter. Not with Izuku. There was no judgement in those green eyes. There was no chance of Izuku treating him differently or looking down on him or using Katsuki's moment of weakness against him.

There were so many years between them, full of complicated feelings and awful words and actions that Katsuki had come to regret. There was *so much* between them.

Katsuki's third realization was that he *liked* who he was with Izuku. He liked letting his walls down and existing around Izuku without being afraid. If that made him weak, maybe, just maybe, he was okay with that.

Izuku moved a little bit closer, their shoulders brushing. Katsuki focused on his hands, willing them to stop smoking and cool down. He rarely lost control of his quirk, and he didn't want to then, not when Izuku's pinky was looped with his own, so casually, yet so indescribably intimate. He didn't want to add to the scars on Izuku's hands, didn't want to hurt Izuku with his quirk after spending a year growing from the bully he had been in middle school.

But Izuku wasn't moving away. He wasn't yanking his hand back, afraid of Katsuki hurting him. After everything, Katsuki didn't think he deserved it.

"I'll see you tomorrow, Kacchan. You need sleep just as much as I do."

Katsuki turned to the door, a lump forming in his throat as Izuku's pinky slipped from his. "Night, Izuku."

Everything was going the way they'd planned. All for One hadn't been able to see through Shinsou's mind-control on Aoyama. He'd shown up to take Izuku's quirk, as the pros had predicted, with an army of D-list villain scum.

All that was left to do was kick ass, which Katsuki was all too happy to partake in. From the moment he was warped to the deserted parking lot, he was *ready* .

After his conversation with Izuku the night before, his heart felt lighter. Izuku had confirmed nothing, hadn't even hinted at feeling the same as Katsuki, but for some reason, he felt at peace. It was a comfort in itself to know that someone understood him as deeply as Izuku.

He thought of their pinkies intertwined, of the sparkle that was starting to make its way back into Izuku's eyes.

He thought about what he was fighting for, why he wanted to beat Shigaraki.

As the villains were grouped and caged, Katsuki's eyes followed the bastard that had started it all. He held a personal grudge, sure, a fire in him that burned with the urge to show Shigaraki exactly why he never should have fucked with Katsuki to begin with.

But beneath all of that, there was another reason why he was fighting.

Izuku. His smile, bright and kind and genuine. His eyes, observative and adoring and beautiful. His laughter. His joy. His spirit.

Shigaraki had damaged the things that Katsuki had just started to appreciate.

He kept track of which cage Shigaraki was locked in, joining Mirko and pushing it with all of his strength towards the warp gate. His muscles ached, his left shoulder clicking, a trait that had arisen after one of Shigaraki's rivets had pierced through it.

As soon as we've got these loser ass villains dealt with, we can talk about all the mushy shit you want .

Katsuki had meant it. If anything, he was looking forward to it.

If he could take down Shigaraki by Izuku's side, he could talk to him about stupid shit like feelings. It's not like a conversation could turn him into dust in seconds.

His mind replayed moments from the last week, moments that were overshadowed by the war that he had just stepped into. They were moments he wanted to keep close for the rest of his life. They were moments he had been trying so hard to *earn* .

Izuku, rolled on his side and facing Katsuki in the dirt, going on and on about quirks and nerd shit, an easy smile on his face. Katsuki had felt so at ease in that moment, had let himself smile and laugh, guard down. Izuku, standing next to him on the balcony, linking his finger with Katsuki's even when there was a chance of him getting burned. Izuku, falling into Katsuki's arms after Katsuki finally, *finally* apologized for the person he had been.

The warps were closing as the Troy cages were pushed through. Heroes fell into their respective gates as they began to slip closed, one by one.

Katsuki sent one last glance around the parking lot, taking stock of the state of things and-

A cord was wrapped around Izuku's wrist, pulling him back towards another gate. Izuku yanked against it, his eyes wide as they met Katsuki's.

No .

Katsuki shouted his name, a useless attempt at helping him, at keeping him close, as he fell into his own gate and Izuku was pulled through another.

No.

He couldn't panic, couldn't lose his head. He still had a responsibility, a villain to defeat. He couldn't lose track of that.

But Izuku had just been ripped away from him, his eyes wide with a hint of shock. Izuku was *god knows where* , and Monoma wouldn't be able to warp him to the UA battleground. He was supposed to be at Katsuki's side. They were supposed to face Shigaraki together.

For a moment, Katsuki was reminded of Izuku, hair matted and plastered to his face, hero costume drenched, his shoulders hunched and shivering. Izuku had been *alone* , Katsuki hadn't been able to *help him* , Katsuki wouldn't be able to help him *now* .

He's fucking fine, stop worrying about him .

Realistically, Shigaraki was their most dangerous opponent, besides All for One. Izuku hadn't been pulled in after Endeavor and Hawks, so he had most likely been warped to one of the locations fit for the other League members. None of them were particularly notable, maybe besides Endeavor's wayward son, so Katsuki knew there was no reason to be concerned with Izuku's safety. Well, unless a situation arose in which Izuku felt the need to throw himself headfirst into harm's way to protect someone. Which was very possible.

Shit .

Shit shit shit shit shit.

He couldn't think about it. He couldn't be distracted. Shigaraki was in front of them, his gaze darting over Katsuki and the other heroes in turn.

All Katsuki could think, as he lit off explosion after explosion, propelling himself up into the air and plotting his attack, was *Come back and fight by my side* .

Chapter End Notes

woooo another slightly filler-y chapter, brace yourselves for what's next ;)
I hope u all are enjoying reading this as much as I'm enjoying writing it. as always, kudos and comments appreciated :)
ao3 curse struck hard this week I ended up with the stomach flu yesterday and had to miss my first day of class but don't worry I pulled through and wrote another chapter for y'all
love u guys <3

TikTok: @lvndrsunny

all my blood for the sweetness of his laughter

Chapter Summary

(it's never over)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki had told himself, after watching Izuku get pulled through the wrong warp, that he would stay calm. He wouldn't lose his cool, he wouldn't let it affect his fighting, he wouldn't panic. That promise had been to both himself and to Izuku.

He'd promised himself, because Katsuki was better than that. If he was to become a pro, he couldn't get worked up everytime things didn't go to plan. He couldn't freak out anytime Izuku got separated from him during missions, if they ended up working side by side at some point. He couldn't let emotions take over and pull him down, making him *less than* . He was a damn good fighter, and he knew how to plan shit out before diving in headfirst. Feelings and emotions and anxieties had no place in war.

He couldn't let himself become Izuku, someone who jumped into fights with his emotions on the forefront of his mind. How many times had he seen Izuku almost *die* because he'd let things get too personal?

His promise had been to Izuku, too. Katsuki wouldn't fail him, not when Izuku had been warped god-knows-where. Izuku thought of him as a hero, right? Katsuki had told him not to try to do this on his own, to share the burden. If Katsuki *failed* , if he and the other pros couldn't knock Shigaraki down a few pegs, or at least keep him occupied until Izuku showed up, what purpose did they really serve?

But Katsuki, and the other pros, had been wholly unprepared for Shigaraki's body to shift, his fingers multiplying grotesquely, overwhelming the area inside the UA battleground. Even with Monoma cancelling Shigaraki's quirks, he was still proving to be a major pain in Katsuki's ass.

The battleground fell apart faster than was comforting. Sure, they were still able to keep Shigaraki contained, with the employment of the electric barrier and the reinforced ground, courtesy of the support course, but it wasn't *enough.* In the swarm of Shigaraki's fingers, Katsuki lost track of the other pros. Every so often, he'd catch glimpses of them, evidence that they were still up and moving.

Katsuki didn't let himself stop, even for a second. The more he moved, the more sweat he could store for his attacks. If he stopped, if he faltered, Shigaraki's distorted appendages would be on him in a second.

He could see his chance, all at once. He was able to get close enough, after lighting off a Howitzer and careening towards Shigaraki. Everything else faded away; Katsuki couldn't be bothered to think about Shigaraki's incessant, grating voice, his pitiful whining. For that moment, and that moment alone, Katsuki forgot about the original battle plan. He forgot that Izuku was supposed to be there, decorated in lightning, matching his attacks and fighting by his side.

It was just Katsuki and Shigaraki. It was Katsuki and his quirk, the sweat he had stored, the moves that he had been perfecting over the course of the last year, the strategies that had been forming as he dodged Shigaraki's attacks. It was every tiny moment in his life, the horrible words he had said, the shoves, the ego he had held, the remarks of citizens that saw him as a villain, the attack he had taken to save Izuku, his admiration of All Might from the time he'd been a toddler, his desire to *win* , holding Izuku in his arms after a month apart-

Katsuki had overcome himself. He had become something better.

Getting close to Shigaraki had given him the chance to light off a Cluster attack. He used everything he had, all the sweat he had stored, all the power in his veins. He didn't have much time to think as he set off the explosions, laser-focused on ending the fight before it could get any fucking worse.

His ears started ringing from the sheer volume of the attack. His palms ached, his eyes squinting against the brightness of the blast. His wrists had been holding up well, but he could feel them protesting, along with his left shoulder. His body screamed as he focused the attack, forcing every drop of sweat into the explosion as he could. Everything *ached* , pain arcing over his body, reminding him of his limits even as he pushed against them. He wouldn't fail. He wouldn't give up. He would be strong enough.

Bright green eyes, wide and intrigued and captivating. Scarred fingers tracing the lines of Katsuki's palm. Laughter, sweet and genuine and exhilarating. Izuku, his brain working ten times faster than everyone else, had already figured out all of Katsuki's shortcomings in the way of his quirk. Oddly, that fact didn't make Katsuki feel weak. It made him feel *known* in a way he had never been by anybody else.

Katsuki would end this, would end all of this bullshit. Shigaraki had fucked with him too many times, had given Katsuki a reason to want to kick his ass. He'd kidnapped and embarrassed him, making the world look at him like there was some chance he might join their shitty League. He'd impaled Katsuki, and even if that hadn't been directed at him, it still pissed him off.

And he'd taken Izuku, placed unfathomable amounts of stress on his shoulders, alienated him from the people who cared about him, distorted his smile and laugh and joy.

A hand wrapped around Katsuki's wrist.

No .

Katsuki had used every last drop of sweat for that attack, between the Howitzer and his Cluster move. His muscles and joints were in a state of shock from the blowback of his

attack. Blood dripped down his forehead and cheek, landing in his eye and partially distorting his vision. He'd never lit off an explosion of that scale, but any that had come close had taken him a moment to recover from. The throbbing of his entire body left him useless, and Katsuki felt horridly exposed.

He could see Shigaraki, the annoyed grimace on his face as he stared at Katsuki. The grip around his wrist tightened and he bit down, his teeth grinding, as he both felt and heard a series of cracks. If the pain from his own explosion had been debilitating, this was somehow worse. From his elbow down, Katsuki felt nothing but *pain* . Hot, blinding pain. His fingers twitched and Katsuki fought down a gasp.

He was whipped to the side, his body colliding hard with the ground as he tumbled over himself. His head smacked against the ground once, twice, a wave of nausea slamming into him as nails split his forehead. He coughed as he rolled, his ribs revolting; at least a few of them had been broken from the initial slam to the ground. Katsuki should have used the moment to his advantage, should have tucked his head and rolled to his feet to counter, should have twisted his arm so it didn't suffer further damage as he rolled to a stop.

Katsuki did none of those things.

He didn't have another plan. He didn't have a counterattack. He didn't have a way to make the pain *stop* .

He'd given his all. It hadn't been enough. Had it ever been enough?

"If there's a single thing I'm interested in when it comes to you," Shigaraki said, his voice grating against every single one of Katsuki's nerves, "it's *him* ."

He forced himself up onto his uninjured elbow, body shaking with the effort of such a small movement. His vision swam dangerously. He could see Shigaraki and his mass of fingers, but the battleground beyond him was fuzzy.

"You're the person closest to Midoriya Izuku," he said, and Katsuki swore he sounded *delighted* . Like this was just another day to him. Like Katsuki's blast had been a slight inconvenience. "Which means he'll definitely be here."

He would, Katsuki knew he would. For a moment, Katsuki wondered if Shigaraki had been the one to have his head smashed off the ground, because Izuku wasn't coming there for Katsuki, he was coming there to defeat Shigaraki. He almost giggled at the thought, delirious and spent. If Izuku had been stationed somewhere else, he wouldn't have been worried about Katsuki. Right?

The other side of Katsuki's brain, which was fighting off a pounding headache, was saying *he would be worried about you, he worries about everyone, he wants to save* everyone . *You're not special, you're not-*

A kick to his side sent Katsuki back to the ground, a cloud of dust choking him. A foot, scaly and dry and *horrible* , stepped onto his cheek, pushing his face further into the ground. His vision flickered again and he sucked in a breath. His pain was *too much* ; his body hadn't

been able to handle his own attacks let alone Shigaraki breaking his bones and flinging him away like a ragdoll.

Katsuki felt so *weak* . The years he'd spent dodging insecurities and hiding them under insults and his own ego were nothing compared to how he felt in that moment. He'd given his all, had done *everything* in his power to stop Shigaraki, and had still ended up beneath him. He'd attacked with all of his power, given his everything, and it *hadn't been enough* .

He felt Shigaraki's foot kicking him up just as Katsuki was about to set off a few rounds of explosions from the Panzer that Hatsume had equipped him with before the battle. Katsuki's vision filled with dark splotches and he fought off the urge to vomit as his world tipped over, reorienting itself so he was suspended in the air, one of Shigaraki's hands locked around his neck.

The sudden movement of his body sent a new wave of torment over him and Katsuki wanted to shake himself by the shoulders and tell him to stop being so fucking *useless* .

You tried. You did everything you could.

You weren't good enough .

He'd wanted to be the best. He'd wanted to be number one in everything he did. Those had been his motivators throughout his life, as he watched Izuku pull ahead of him in so many different ways and scenarios. His plans had come crashing down on his head once he reached UA, and he'd realized he had been so far behind Izuku from the start, but he hadn't thought he was *this* far behind. Shigaraki had only suffered burns to half of his face from an explosion that had left Katsuki's body shaking and stunned from the recoil.

"I'm glad my quirk's not working," Shigaraki drawled, his hand tightening around Katsuki's throat. He let out a choked noise against his own will, the sensation of air yanked away from him. "He's sensitive about you, you know. Seems like he always has been. He got pretty upset when I almost killed you the last time."

Izuku .

Through the cloud of pain and desperation, Katsuki latched onto the thought of Izuku. He hadn't been strong enough to defeat Shigaraki on his own, had barely even left a dent. He needed Izuku, needed to fight with him. They fought well together, right? Hadn't Izuku said he was happy they would be fighting together? They went well together, didn't they? Had they always? His vision was slipping. He wanted *air* .

"Your corpse will make the perfect present for him when he arrives," Shigaraki purred.

No .

Even with the suffocating hand around his throat and the pain and pure exhaustion wracking Katsuki's body, he was still coherent enough to understand Shigaraki's words, his sickeningly sweet taunts. Izuku wasn't there yet, wouldn't get there for at least a good while, and Katsuki was already spent and incapacitated, dangling from Shigaraki's hand like a lifeless doll.

Dying didn't scare Katsuki. Not in the same way that Izuku didn't feel fear, though. Izuku fought without thinking about dying, throwing every punch like it would be his last. In the smallest instances, he put his life on the line, ready to accept his own end if it meant saving others. Katsuki wasn't like that. He wasn't selfish, didn't put his life above others, but he knew his own strengths. He knew he couldn't save anybody from the afterlife.

He hadn't been scared of death before, but it stood in front of him, one eye twinkling with a sick delight at seeing him in pain, a lifeless grin gracing its face. And Katsuki felt like a kid. He felt like he had the day a group of kids a few years older than him had cornered him in front of the school and beaten him. He felt like *nothing* . Like a life that was so easy to dispose of.

Had he really done so little in his life? Had he even accomplished *anything* ? He'd talked so big to end up bested just as he was about to start his second year of high school.

But those weren't the only thoughts that scared him. Those, actually, paled in comparison to what scared him most.

Katsuki had accepted his feelings for Izuku already. He'd spent enough time trying to fight them off before he'd realized that what he felt for Izuku couldn't fall under the umbrella of rivalry or friendship. He didn't pretend to know how Izuku felt, he didn't torture himself thinking about it. Katsuki knew what he deserved, knew that it wasn't to have Izuku in the ways he wanted.

That didn't change the fact that Izuku cared so deeply about the people around him. It was one of the traits that had always put Izuku in the lead of their two-person race without a finish line. Izuku had spent years trailing along with Katsuki, complimenting him, watching him, admiring him.

Katsuki knew Izuku would lose it if he showed up to Katsuki's corpse. He knew Izuku wouldn't be able to handle it, wouldn't be able to control his quirks enough to fight Shigaraki. He would be taken down just as easily as Katsuki had, all because he cared about other people. All because Katsuki's corpse would be used as a weapon against Izuku. Even in death, Katsuki would be failing Izuku.

Katsuki wanted to strain against Shigaraki's grasp and snarl at him that Izuku would be bothered by *anyone's* corpse. At the same time, a sick and twisted sense of satisfaction curled in his stomach; Shigaraki had recognized that he was close to Izuku, that Izuku *cared* about him.

"Would've been fun to see it the other way around, too," Shigaraki continued. "How would you have reacted if you weren't where you were supposed to be? If it caused *your Izuku* to die, hm?"

The tiny gasps of air that he was able to get weren't cutting it. Katsuki kicked his feet uselessly.

" *Fuck you* ," he rasped, the words dragging needles across the inside of his throat, ripping it to shreds.

Izuku had said something about that the night before, right? How he didn't want anyone to die because of him. He would blame himself, he would never stop blaming himself. Katsuki couldn't die, couldn't let Izuku spend the rest of his life taking responsibility for it. He would hate himself in the afterlife if he had to watch Izuku be miserable over him. How long would it take Izuku to recover? To stop seeing Katsuki's dead body? To stop missing him?

Nejire and Tamaki launched attacks on Shigaraki simultaneously. Katsuki's body was wrenched again, right into the path of Nejire's beam of power. With the state of his body, he couldn't even brace himself for the impact. She redirected it, and he felt the blast skim past him.

He was going to die on that battlefield. He knew that now. He accepted it.

Izuku.

The thought of him was a reason to keep fighting, an incentive to win. Being the best didn't matter, didn't even come *close* to mattering, when Katsuki had something so much more important to fight for.

If he didn't make it off the battlefield alive, he needed to survive long enough to know that Izuku wouldn't blame himself, that he'd win this for them and keep *living* . That he'd get to live out his dreams and become a hero like he'd gone on and on about when they had been brats.

God, they had been *children* at one point. They'd been so tiny, small enough to cower behind their mothers' legs in the face of danger, which had been nothing scarier than older kids on the playground or crowds at the mall. Their voices had been high-pitched and squeaky, and they'd carried toys with them wherever they went, and they'd thought scrapes and cuts were life-ending.

Katsuki felt so *old* , so aged and used. They were no longer children. If he was able to walk off this battlefield, he didn't know if he could ever feel the silly sentiments that he once had. In his bones, he felt like he'd been fighting for a hundred years without rest. Had it really only been less than a day ago that Izuku had linked his pinky with Katsuki's and *smiled* at him like he was everything?

Katsuki's vision went dark again, a blissful second where his pain turned into nothing and his body stopped belonging to him. He didn't feel his body being tossed again, but he was aware of the motion. He didn't *feel* . This pain, this all consuming onslaught on every single part of his body, had become his normal. There would never be another moment of his life in which he wouldn't be subjected to it. His arm and ribs throbbed, his shoulders and back and legs were aching, his brain slammed against his skull.

He could hear Jeanist's voice, could feel the ground beneath him again. His throat felt bruised but he could breathe again, and Katsuki felt stupidly desperate to suck in as much air as his lungs would allow, his chest heaving with the effort.

He'd been tossed aside *again* . Distantly, he could make out Mirio shouting at Shigaraki.

Katsuki had been so *useless* . He'd done everything he could and had accomplished nothing. He'd been thrown aside by both Shigaraki and his own peers, a hindrance more than anything. Shigaraki had said it himself that he saw Katsuki as nothing more than a way to hurt Izuku.

Izuku. How did Katsuki keep *forgetting* about him? His head hurt.

Izuku. Katsuki couldn't stop fighting, he couldn't let everyone discount and discard him. Izuku would never see him as less, would never look at Katsuki and think of him as a burden rather than an asset. He had to get up, he had to do something, he had to help *Izuku* .

Tears bubbled in his eyes and Katsuki was too damaged to care. He didn't feel weak because of his tears. He refused to feel less than because he was crying.

I won't die scared or weak or useless. I won't. I don't want anybody to tell you that I died weak. I don't want you to think that of me .

Katsuki fought to heave himself onto his good elbow, his other arm shouting from the strain. His shoulders shook and spasms wracked his back, nearly sending him right back to the ground. He could feel a hand on his back and Jeanist's eyes on him. He murmured comfortingly, his voice devoid of criticisms or accusations.

"You did more than enough, Dynamight," he said, rubbing Katsuki's shoulder. "You need to recover."

But his words didn't translate into Katsuki's brain. He'd lifted his head, his vision just clear enough to make out Shigaraki and the disgusting masses of fingers that were shooting throughout the battlefield.

When he'd been in Katsuki's grasp the first time, when he'd crushed Katsuki's arm like it was nothing, Katsuki had held onto his coherence enough to pay attention to Shigaraki's moves. When he'd been both down on the ground and held by the throat, he'd fought to keep consciousness, if only to watch his every move.

Katsuki wouldn't let his corpse be some sick gift for Izuku. He wouldn't let Izuku keep doing *this* , or anything, alone. They would be heroes together. They'd said so, back when they were five years old.

Maybe, when Katsuki recovered and got over himself, they could be something more together.

He'd recognized Shigaraki's pattern. He knew exactly which way he needed to feint to avoid his blows, how to dodge his attack and get behind him.

Katsuki refused to walk away from this fight before doing something, *anything* , to help Izuku. His life wouldn't have been a waste, 17 years spent being too much of a coward to face his own insecurities. He'd pushed away the best person he had ever had all because he had been *scared* .

Katsuki wouldn't be scared now.

He forced himself to his feet, trudging forward, one foot after the other. Pain was something he had to learn to ignore; if it wasn't enough to kill him, he could keep going. How many times had he watched Izuku break himself and keep fighting? Katsuki could catch up, he *would* catch up.

As Katsuki dodged Shigaraki, landing in a crouch before launching himself back into the air, images of Izuku flashed through his mind. Katsuki wasn't delusional enough to think that he would make it out of this, that he would somehow survive. But this was his contribution, his final way of saying *I'm sorry* , one last attempt at earning Izuku's kindness and forgiveness.

He remembered Izuku in their first week at UA, his horrified and determined eyes. If Katsuki weren't so focused on avoiding Shigaraki's limbs, he might have laughed fondly at the thought. Back then, Izuku's expressions had made him so *angry* , so completely infuriated that Izuku had somehow made it to the same level as him. Now, he saw that expression so clearly and wanted to *smile* . Izuku had been mortified and out of place, thrust into a school full of people who, like Katsuki, were used to being regarded as powerful. He'd been nothing, hadn't even *tasted* power back then. And yet, he'd still smiled in the face of everything.

In that first training exercise, where they'd been pitted against each other, Izuku had fought him even with broken bones. He'd challenged Katsuki, blow for blow, and had been able to read his moves and dodge them. Even back then, he'd been stepping on the back of Katsuki's shoes, threatening to overtake him at every second. Why had that scared him so much before?

Katsuki had thought about what he would do differently if he could go back. But for the first time, he considered what he would have wanted Izuku to do differently. Katsuki imagined himself, who he was now, doing everything in his power to protect that Izuku from the things they had experienced over the past month. That Izuku, who had put on a good bit of muscle but was unsure in his own body, who laughed about any and everything, who's biggest concern was how he could possibly learn about all their classmates' quirks without getting overwhelmed, had no idea what the future held. That Izuku had been pure and hopeful and full of dreams.

Had that really been the trade off? That Izuku could have a quirk, the quirk of his personal hero, in exchange for the mental turmoil and the trauma of the battles they had fought in? Had he sold his soul that day, when he'd taken All Might's hair? Would Izuku even make it through this to make his dream a reality?

Yes , he fucking would, which was exactly why Katsuki was pushing against every single limit his body had. Past the nails driving their way into his brain and past the throbbing in his arm and past the spasms shooting up his body, borne of exhaustion and overuse of his quirk. He would fight until he dropped, he would *keep fucking going* until he beat Shigaraki, until he was sure that Izuku would survive.

If anyone deserved it, it was Izuku. After everything.

At one point, Izuku had told him that Katsuki had been the hero that was actually in his life. Like, maybe, sticking around Katsuki even though he had been nothing but an asshole, had been enough for Izuku. It had been the closest he had been able to get to the life of a hero.

They'd switched places, hadn't they? Katsuki wasn't going to make it; he could tell his body was destroying itself with each and every explosion, the pain almost enough to bring tears to his eyes. *Not yet* . But so long as he did this, so long as he was able to hold off Shigaraki and help stop him, Izuku could live out his dream. For both of them.

He was upside down, his good arm extended in front of him. He'd been able to slip behind Shigaraki undetected, just quick enough to avoid Shigaraki's distended limbs. He could do this, he could make this explosion count.

Everything *hurt* .

More memories of Izuku flashed in his mind. They'd been kids together. Somewhere, maybe in a shoebox under Izuku's bed, there were crayon drawings of what they wanted their hero costumes to look like. There were pictures of them, too, before Katsuki had turned into a shitty child with nobody to put him in check. Pictures, with their chubby faces pressed together, smiling and sunburnt after hours in the park, or sitting together in front of the TV to watch another episode of an All Might cartoon.

Katsuki could pretend he wasn't on a battlefield, if only for a millisecond. He could pretend that he was chasing Izuku around the living room, both of their fingers sticky from melted popsicles, laughter and squealing filling the air, the scent of katsudon wafting out of the kitchen. That scenario had probably happened more times than Katsuki remembered, but the specific day he was thinking back on had been so *bright* . They'd gotten matching All Might cards, holographic limited edition ones that none of their other friends had. Just them. Always just them. Katsuki and Izuku, Izuku and Katsuki.

His palm grew hot as he focused his next blast, his body covered in sweat. His hair was plastered to his forehead, stuck in a mixture of his own sweat and blood. The explosion tore out of him, with so much *force* behind it, as if it had been borne of his entire body and not just the palm of his hand. He could feel his heart beating so fast in his chest, could hear his pulse in his ears above the rush of the battle. His vision went splotchy again.

Maybe this time I was strong enough to help you, Izuku.

An impact slammed into his chest, so strong Katsuki knew it would be the last thing he ever felt. Aside from the pain of the blow, the last remnants of his awareness were telling him his heart couldn't survive it after how heavily he had been abusing his quirk. It wasn't logical. It wasn't possible.

I'm going to die. I'm going to die. I'm going to die .

Katsuki only had a few breaths left in him before his heart would stop. Around him, he could make out the heroes he'd been fighting beside reaching out to him as he tumbled to the

ground. The dirt rose to meet him, solid and cold beneath his body.

Time was a really funny thing.

His body was failing him, his *heart* was failing him, and he felt like his seconds were slipping away from him fast. He imagined himself reaching out for them, trying to snag an extra handful, but they escaped between his fingers, darting away and *laughing* , just out of reach. He couldn't grasp onto them, couldn't keep them. His seconds were limited, ticking down to zero with every wheezing breath that slipped past his lips.

Beneath him, the ground was cold, still slightly damp as spring settled. With the ringing of his ears, he couldn't hear the fighting and chaos but he knew it was happening. His consciousness was slipping, his vision going both splotchy and blurry, turning his friends into nothing more than dark blots against a too-bright backdrop. Smoke tainted his nostrils, mixing with the scent of his own blood. His mouth was full of it, coppery and bitter.

Katsuki could feel raindrops.

One after the other.

He knew he was going to die.

Oh.

Katsuki had had a straightforward plan since he had been a child: become the number one hero, surpass All Might, be the best.

He hadn't accounted for revisions and amendments. He'd been so laser-focused on his goals, so put off by anything that didn't benefit him in the long run.

So much had changed, though. *He* had changed, probably more than anything.

There were so many things he had never gotten to do, so many things he had turned down or pushed away.

Time. Katsuki had so little of it left, and he had to spend it trapped in his own mind. Thinking in circles.

Raindrops. One after another.

His hearing was making its way back into his ears, but sounds jumbled together, and he didn't have the strength to try and make sense of anything he was hearing.

Where was he? Why was he laying on the ground?

He needed to get up, needed to *keep fighting* , they hadn't won yet, he couldn't just lay here useless while everyone else was fighting-

He was dying.

His heart. He'd used the last of his strength to try to explode Shigaraki, and he'd been punched in the heart.

Izuku .

Katsuki wondered if Izuku had noticed that he'd changed. That, over the past few months, his ambitions had turned away from just being the best, and had turned towards bettering himself so he *deserved* to be the best. Izuku had taught him that being the best wasn't a given based on quirks and strength alone.

The world was getting quieter. The cool ground beneath him felt as if it was getting further away. He could no longer smell smoke or taste his own blood.

Izuku had extended his hand to him so many times over the course of their lives, and Katsuki had only just learned how to accept it. He'd only just learned that accepting help didn't equate to weakness. Katsuki wondered if it made him weak for wishing that Izuku was there with him right now, gloved hand extended, green eyes so, so bright, with a million different emotions, there to pick Katsuki up even when he refused to admit that he needed help.

He'd been worried about falling behind Izuku. At UA, it had seemed that Izuku was pushing ahead of him at every turn. Higher scores on exams, beating him in training exercises, developing new quirks. Katsuki wondered if it was all worth it for Izuku, though. Izuku, who had been turned into a child soldier, with the weight of saving everyone resting on his shoulders. Izuku, who had once been a snot-nosed brat with no quirk, who had extended his hand to rude, self-absorbed, arrogant Katsuki. Izuku, who was still just a *kid* . They were both so young, weren't they? Just barely 17 and 16, fighting a war that was so much bigger than them, with Izuku at the middle of it. They should be sitting in a fucking classroom right now, with Izuku muttering in his ear and Katsuki telling him to be quiet.

Where was Izuku? Why wasn't he there, with Katsuki? They were always together, weren't they? Since forever ago?

They'd been separated. Right. Izuku was on his way.

Katsuki knew he was dying, knew that his chances of catching up to Izuku were fading quick. But maybe this had been enough. Maybe there was a chance that doing this, that giving his life, was enough. Maybe he was finally just as much of a hero as Izuku. Maybe he was finally the hero that Izuku had seen in him for their entire lives.

Let me catch up to you.

He'd thought he had been living in Izuku's shadow for so long, and, as his body tried to keep him alive, he realized that couldn't possibly be true.

He didn't exist in Izuku's shadow, because Izuku simply didn't cast one. He was the brightest point of everything; just being near him made Katsuki feel illuminated.

Katsuki barely registered the raindrops at this point.

God, there were so many things he had wanted to do. So many plans that had come about after he had stopped being such a closed-off asshole.

He wanted to ask All Might for his autograph.

He wanted to finally accept Kirishima's invitation to have a couple drinks with him, Kaminari, Sero, and Mina on a Friday night.

He wanted to hug his parents and see their faces when he finally opened up to them, when he finally gave them a shred of vulnerability.

He wanted…

Something flickered in the edge of his vision, something bright enough to cut through the darkness that had absorbed almost everything else. It might have been green; he couldn't really place it.

It flickered again. Like electricity.

Like Izuku.

So many of his new plans were centered around Izuku.

At some point, *he'd* become centered around Izuku, too. Pulled in by him. Orbiting him.

Fuck this whole war thing. There were so many things he wanted out of his life, now that he'd started picking up the scraps and putting himself back together, better than he had ever been.

He didn't have time to go through everything, laying on that battlefield, trying to catch another glimpse of that green electricity. He could barely move his eyes, and his body was screaming at him, every single part of him *hurting* in a way that he had never felt before. But his desperation to catch one last glimpse of those green sparks outweighed everything else, and he *finally* got it right. He was able to make out the silhouette of wayward curls surrounded by dancing sparks, shrouded entirely in green.

Katsuki wanted.

He'd pushed it down, stomped it into the lowest parts of his being, telling himself over and over that he would never deserve it, that he would never change enough to atone for the person that he had once been. He would never be able to show Izuku how he felt, not in a way that was big enough. Nothing could erase the words he had said to Izuku once, years ago, a *lifetime* ago. Nothing could take back the way Katsuki had pushed him away and treated him like he was useless, all because of his own stupid insecurities.

If Katsuki had the ability to laugh, he would have; he thought, with dark amusement, that this was his karma. He'd realized, way too late, that he wanted what he had pushed away his entire life. It was only fitting that he had made his own grave and was lying in it, in the most literal sense. Izuku would keep living and Katsuki would remain on the battlefield until his skin and his muscles and his bones and his soul became one with the soil.

That green light danced and grew brighter at the very edge of his vision. God, Katsuki was holding onto his life harder than he'd ever held on to anything else, if only to be able to keep catching glimpses of his Izuku.

Fear wormed its way into his heart, though, as that green light flared and tendrils shot out sporadically. Katsuki was more than familiar with Blackwhip, had been there helping Izuku learn how to use it from the start.

The start.

What had Monoma said that day, about Katsuki? The words weren't important; Katsuki hadn't given a fuck what that second class extra had had to say about him, but, even back then, he'd found it… curious how strong of an effect his words had had on Izuku.

Don't , Katsuki thought desperately, as his mind made a last-ditch effort to drench him in awareness. Now that the thought had crossed his mind, he couldn't pretend that it wasn't true.

Izuku had shown him, time and time again, that he cared. In so many cases, he'd been sensitive to the things said about Katsuki, to the things done to Katsuki. Everyone had seen him lose control time and time again: when Katsuki was kidnapped, when Monoma made his snide comments, when Katsuki had sacrificed himself the fucking first time.

Don't , Katsuki wanted to beg. *Don't lose control. Don't be a fucking idiot. Don't you dare throw it all away because of me* .

He knew Izuku too fucking well, though. His pleads would go unanswered.

Katsuki wondered if there was a chance at another life. He wondered if, in another universe, the war hadn't taken him at only 17. Was there another existence out there, one where he and Izuku woke up beside each other?

Katsuki wanted to fold laundry with him. And bitch at him for leaving dirty dishes in their sink. And brush their teeth side by side. And fight over the blanket in the middle of the night. Katsuki could envision it so clearly - a life that was created and upheld by both of them. Together. Because, *we've always worked well together, right, Izuku?*

Everything was slipping. He didn't have much longer left.

He was finding a way to make peace with it. He could spend a couple more seconds reminiscing on the *good* , on the times in which he had patched up the pieces of him and Izuku's relationship. Izuku's fingers tracing the lines of Katsuki's palm, his laughter as he theorized on the side effects of Katsuki's quirk. He could spend a couple more seconds trying to memorize Izuku's face, desperate to take those giant green eyes, constantly shining adoringly, with him to the afterlife, wherever he might end up.

Hey, Izuku , he thought, and he was so far fucking gone, because he had come up with the idea that Izuku knew what he was thinking as he lay there dying. That, somehow, the world would do him one last mercy, would let him say goodbye. *Remember when we were kids*

together? When we played heroes on the playground? I'm glad we got to be heroes together. For a little bit.

Everything hurt.

Katsuki wanted to keep fighting.

Izuku, Izuku, Izuku .

Raindrops. The ground was cold. Why couldn't he feel anything?

Quiet.

Can I still catch up to you?

Chapter End Notes

oh gosh long time coming for this one. I tweaked the actual logistics of his death just a bit (don't hate me) but I liked the idea of him getting to see izuku one more time before he died. im thinking after this is going to be a time skip with a summary of the end of the war as opposed to me writing out literally. every. single. thing. just so we can get to the good stuff
hope you guys enjoyed and comments and kudos are very appreciated!! see u next time <3

TikTok: @lvndrsunny

free now

Chapter Summary

if you find yourself out
if there is a right time
chances are I'll be here
we could share a lifeline
if you feel like falling
catch me on the way down

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

For the better part of a year, Izuku had been learning how to protect people.

What he had yearned for the most, as a child dressed in an All Might onesie, pretending to rescue his mom, was to save people who needed saving. People who couldn't save themselves.

To a five year old, it had seemed so straight-forward; he wanted to save, and save he would.

The weight of the world, and the value placed onto people based on the quirk they were designated at birth, had not crushed those dreams, but had made Izuku's path to reaching them that much more strenuous.

He'd been around classmates at UA, who had mastered their quirks, who had skills and talents beyond Izuku's imagination, who excelled where he failed. He watched his classmates hop over anthills while he scaled mountains, sheer cliff faces that seemed to grow and grow and grow.

In every scenario, Izuku was faced with another challenge, another stepping stone. As if the world wanted to push him down and remind him that he had started as *nothing* . That he had to work ten times harder than everyone, just to catch up to them.

UA had changed him, had taught him that quirks weren't everything; so many of his classmates had quirks that weren't necessarily heroic, but the ways in which they used them *made* them heroic. Izuku had been painted as a *nothing* because he hadn't had a quirk, and when he finally got one, he had wanted so badly to make it *his* . To take One for All and use it in his own way.

For a long time, he'd struggled to watch, from Katsuki's shadow, as he got the attention that Izuku wished he could have shared. Their elementary teachers had praised Katsuki and placed him on a pedestal, and their classmates had followed suit. And Izuku had been so

selfishly jealous, for a small period of time, that he had simply lost the gamble of life and ended up with nothing while Katsuki had everything.

Katsuki had never been to blame, and Izuku had realized that, even from a young age. Genetics played a major role in quirks, and Katsuki's parents' quirks just so happened to compliment each others'. Izuku's parents' quirks were weaker powers, hardly worth mentioning. Neither Izuku or Katsuki had picked their parents or their genes. Neither of them had chosen to be singled out by society.

Izuku could spend the rest of his life hating Katsuki, holding a grudge for words and actions that were years old. He could refuse to acknowledge Katsuki's growth and improvement, his efforts to be *better* . He could hold on to the things Katsuki had done when they had been younger and hadn't known better.

But Izuku *didn't* hold onto those things, because society had failed Katsuki as much as it had failed Izuku. Before Katsuki had been old enough to know better, the world around him had plastered an image onto him, an idea of who he would one day become, based completely off of his power. He hadn't been nurtured, hadn't been taught how to deal with his emotions, because he had been regarded as *strong* from the moment his quirk had manifested in its sparkling, explosive nature.

They were opposite sides of the same coin. Or was that wishful thinking?

Either way, they'd both been failed by the environment they'd been born into. Both of them had had to learn to pick up the pieces over the years, pieces that society and its stipulations had created.

Izuku had forgiven Katsuki before Katsuki had even sought forgiveness. His friends had frowned at him in confusion and worry, as if Izuku was laying down in front of a train by forgiving Katsuki. But Izuku had seen Katsuki's actions, the bigger ones, like throwing himself in front of Izuku or apologizing to him in front of everyone, and the smaller ones, like when he let his guard slip and he was truly himself in front of Izuku.

Was Izuku an idiot for falling for him? For the person who had tormented him when they'd been younger? Probably. Did he regret it? Or detest his own feelings? No.

It shouldn't have surprised him, when he realized that he wanted Katsuki in a way that was no longer born of childish adoration. At one point, he'd stopped looking up to Katsuki as his "hero" that he could live through and he looked at Katsuki for *Katsuki* .

Because, as jealous as Izuku had once been of the easy friendship that Katsuki had found with some of their classmates, they would never know him in the way Izuku did. They would never know Katsuki like Izuku did.

Over the course of their entire lives, nobody had inspired or pushed Izuku like Katsuki did. Sure, his methods weren't exactly conventional until around a few months earlier, but they had still encouraged Izuku. And over the course of the last few months, after their fight at Ground Beta, Izuku had started to peel back the walls that Katsuki had meticulously put up to protect himself. Izuku knew Katsuki's insecurities, his fear of being weak, and how that

translated to how he treated others. And maybe Izuku was messed up in the head, but he *liked* that. He liked that Katsuki was rough around the edges, that he never went easy on Izuku or coddled him. He didn't believe in coddling the people around him, and Izuku had been coddled way too much throughout his life.

At first, the crush had been stupid and childish. A side effect of Izuku's long-term infatuation with Katsuki's talent and potential.

But it had grown. Izuku hadn't had the chance to get over it. Not when Katsuki had started training with him, had started giving him private smiles or cracking jokes with him or allowing Izuku to stand a little closer to him than anybody else. They were small things, small moments in the grand scheme of their intertwined lives, but Izuku held them close all the same.

Going into this war, Izuku had been happy knowing he would be fighting beside Katsuki. If there was one person who could match him, it would be Katsuki, blow for blow. When Izuku faltered, Katsuki would be there. Izuku wouldn't have to search the battlefield for any ally because Katsuki would already *be there* .

The UA battleground hung above the ocean; it was a wonderful creation, borne of science and technology, brought to life by the intelligence of the support course. If they weren't in a war, Izuku would have loved to study it; quirks helped power it, sure, but pure human intellect had brought it to life.

He tried to keep his focus on Shigaraki and defeating him; that was Izuku's mission for the day. What had Katsuki been telling him, over the course of the last few months? To use his head while fighting, to not let his emotions take over?

He'd already been pulled away from his station, had wasted precious time flying to the UA battlefield. He wouldn't disappoint Katsuki now by letting his feelings get involved in this fight.

Izuku felt his foot collide with Shigaraki's face, his focus too narrowed to be concerned about the state of Shigaraki's body, somehow surrounded in armor that appeared to be made of his own enlarged fingers. The power behind his attack felt *strong* , arcing up his legs and making his entire body feel like a livewire. Izuku's kick, powered by both FaJin and One for All, sent Shigaraki careening to the side and into the barrier, some of those gnarly, distended fingers crumbling from the force of the impact. His body shuddered as it collided with the electric forefield, his limbs twitching sickeningly as sparks danced across his skin. Shigaraki's weight had clearly been increased, as Izuku felt a slight tingle in his leg from delivering the blow.

Around Izuku, the UA battleground seemed to be in a state of disarray. Izuku had been a big part of their plan to defeat Shigaraki, but he had expected the others to be able to hold their own against him. Instead, he was met with the sight of the four towers of UA, the windows shattered, the frame of the building dented in some places. The tops of three of the towers were crumbled and destroyed; debris littered the ground around the front of the campus. The reinforced platforms the support course had created were no longer suspended in the air. They were crumbled on the ground, cracked and broken. Even the grass had been destroyed. In some places, the ground was charred and smoking, a clear side effect of-

Kacchan .

Izuku had been so focused on knocking Shigaraki away from Mirio that he hadn't taken the time to search the battlefield for anyone else. But Shigaraki was momentarily incapacitated, which gave Izuku the chance to locate the others, to possibly create a strategy of attack, since they knew what to expect.

He glanced around, past the smoking craters in the ground, toward the outskirts of the battlefield. It gave him no comfort, the amount of blood soaking the earth. He could see Mirko and Jeanist, both of them collapsed against the ground, their costumes stained red and scuffed with dirt. And just past Jeanist-

The world went quiet. Izuku's senses both dulled and became completely overwhelmed at the same time.

No, that wasn't right. That wasn't right at *all* .

Katsuki wouldn't be down and injured. Katsuki would be fighting. He was *always* fighting. He'd been injured so many times over the course of the last year and had always kept fighting. At Jaku, he'd been impaled and had *kept fighting* .

Why was he on the ground? Why was Katsuki just *laying there* ?

Maybe it wasn't him. Maybe it was somebody else.

For a sick, disgusting moment, one that Izuku would surely come to hate himself for, he hoped and prayed and *begged* for it to be anyone else. Not Katsuki. Not *Kacchan* .

Was he seeing things? There was no way Katsuki would be bested, not when Shigaraki was still breathing. Those couldn't be Katsuki's boots, with their obnoxiously orange soles. The small shards of army green plating littering the field weren't pieces of Katsuki's gauntlets. There was *no way* .

But Izuku couldn't convince himself of that, not when he could see Katsuki's spiky tufts of blonde hair, matted with dirt and blood and sweat. Izuku couldn't deny that the costume was Katsuki's costume, with his stupidly oversized pants and his chunky green utility belt. He couldn't make out Katsuki's face past the high collar of Katsuki's winter costume, and for that small mercy, Izuku was *grateful* . He couldn't bear to see Katsuki's face without his typical smirk, or the determined fire in his eyes. The sight just below his collar was enough for Izuku.

Training in the hero course had exposed Izuku to a lot of things. He, and his classmates, had become accustomed to violence and injuries alike. There were many different paths heroes chose between after signing with agencies; there were heroes who were more combat based, heroes that worked behind the scenes and operated in underground settings, heroes that specialized in rescue and revival attempts, and a number of other divisions.

The majority of UA students typically graduated and joined agencies that were more focused on direct encounters with villains. All Might and Endeavor had both graduated from the

prestigious school, and they had both been ranked number one at one point. Their quirks were certainly suited for fighting.

Aizawa, though, had also gone to UA and had chosen to work out of sight of the public for much of his career. He was involved in missions that weren't widely reported on, and his name was kept out of most of the public records regarding his work. It was a strategy the Hero Commission had used with a number of their heroes, as an upper hand against villains that were unsuspecting. Aizawa had lectured them on the importance of underground heroes and had divulged from the typical UA curriculum. Over the course of their first year, he had exposed Class A to more scenarios than any of them could count. He'd told them that if they weren't capable of working in every section of the field, they couldn't call themselves heroes at all.

In particular, Aizawa had stressed the importance of rescue missions and being able to treat and recognize injuries.

Izuku didn't need a week's worth of lectures on base level first aid or categorizing injuries to recognize that there was way too much blood pooling from Katsuki's chest to be normal. Izuku wasn't close enough to Katsuki, but the phantom scent of blood clogged his senses and he gagged involuntarily. His hands were clean and shielded by his gloves, and yet his skin felt sticky and wet, as if Katsuki's blood had soaked through the fabric and *contaminated him* and Izuku couldn't do it, he couldn't do *this* -

His brain had come slamming to a halt and he had stopped breathing at some point. He tried to remind himself to *breathe* , but small gasps of air slipped past his lips and simply weren't enough. His lungs burned in his chest, but Izuku could take it. Izuku could handle that pain, because that pain meant he was still alive.

He was still alive and Katsuki was not.

His breathing began to speed up, moisture pricking at the corners of his eyes. He hadn't been able to tear his gaze away from Katsuki's body, his form limp and unmoving, soaked in a puddle of his own blood.

No .

Izuku had been miles and miles away, listening to Toga talk to him about *love* and *crushes* and *boyfriends* and Katsuki had been here, oh god, Katsuki had been here *dying* .

How long had it taken? How long had he suffered, fighting to keep breathing? How hard had Katsuki *pushed himself* ? Had he kept fighting, even with life-threatening wounds? There was no way Katsuki had just laid down and *died* .

Oh god. Oh god.

Bile rose in Izuku's throat, thick and sour. He clenched his mouth shut, pushing it *down* , pushing his tears *down.*

This is my fault. I wasn't here. This is my fault. I thought he could handle it. I thought he would be okay .

When Toga had yanked Izuku through the warp behind her, he'd kept himself focused on the goal at hand: getting to UA to fight against Shigaraki. He'd promised himself, after the night before, that he wouldn't let his feelings distract him today.

Nothing about loving Katsuki was easy. Not a single day went by where Izuku felt like things between them were routine. And that fact, impossibly, made Izuku want Katsuki even *more* . He'd been chasing action his entire life; his body had thrown itself into danger how many times without Izuku even thinking? Loving Katsuki made him feel like he was racing headfirst into oncoming traffic, and yet, he somehow wasn't afraid; he wanted to keep rushing in, even if there were so many warning signs blaring in his face.

There was one thing, though, that had been reassuring, about Izuku's feelings for Katsuki. Months and months ago, he and Katsuki had established their rivalry, and had determined (more with punches rather than words) that their playing field was somewhat even. They were in a constant loop of chasing after each other, catching up and falling behind and rinsing and repeating. Where Izuku fell short, Katsuki excelled and vice versa. Neither of them wanted to admit it, especially Katsuki, but Izuku kept track of their stupid competitions with each other. At first, it had been about becoming the better hero, but had eventually turned into something *more* . They competed in every little thing they did, pushing the other to be better, picking and prodding and taunting each other.

The one thing that had kept Izuku going about their rivalry, that had comforted him more times than it hadn't, was that Katsuki was his equal in battle. If it was to be anyone, it was Katsuki, who struck harder and dodged faster than anyone else. His blasts were so powerful that Pro Heroes had given him praise, their eyebrows lifted in surprise at Katsuki's glaringly obvious potential. His strategies and quick thinking abilities were next level, setting him apart from the rest of their peers. His one drawback had been his unwillingness to work with others or accept help, which was something he'd slowly been doing ever since their Work Study with Endeavor.

Izuku didn't fret or worry over Katsuki like he did with some of their other classmates; he knew Katsuki was more than capable of handling himself, knew that he refused to be beat or bested. He didn't *need* Izuku to protect him.

And the one time Izuku hadn't been there, the *one time* Izuku hadn't been stressed about Katsuki's safety, he had-

He was-

Oh. Oh no. No no no no no.

He couldn't be dead. There was no way he was dead. It wasn't his blood. He was just… taking a breath. He had passed out or knocked out or *something,* anything besides being dead.

But, even from a distance, Izuku couldn't spot any movement. Katsuki's chest, dark and stained and *burst open,* was not moving. He was *not moving* .

Get up. Come on, get up. You've always been stronger than me. You've always been better than me. Get up.

Izuku's fingers twitched. Tears formed in his eyes as they began to sting. How long had it been since he had last blinked?

"Are you going to tell him why you're late?" a voice drawled, delighted. Shigaraki was taking *pleasure* in this. Had this been his plan? To separate them from each other and use Katsuki against Izuku?

You need to stay calm and focus on the battle at hand .

The voice belonged to one of the Vestiges, and Izuku didn't *care* . He didn't care about the battle. He didn't care about saving the world.

The rest of the world didn't fucking *matter* anymore.

Katsuki was dead, Katsuki was *dead* , his body wasn't moving, he would never breathe ever again, he would never be alive ever *again* -

Izuku's vision clouded, his body tingling, his skin so alive and electric. All of his senses narrowed onto Katsuki, Katsuki, *Katsuki* . There was no longer a world, not for Izuku. He would kill Shigaraki, he would save everyone, but his heart wouldn't be in it for the right reasons anymore. He would kill Shigaraki for taking Katsuki away from the world, from Izuku.

Heroes don't kill for the sake of revenge. Heroes don't kill people, they save them . You wanted to save Shigaraki, didn't you?

A different voice. Almost chiding him.

I don't care. I don't care about being a hero, I care about him .

Katsuki had been growing over the past year. He'd been changing and learning and becoming someone better. He'd made true friends, had started to relax around their classmates and let them in. He had opened up to Izuku, had allowed Izuku to mutter on and on about his stupid theories and ideas. Katsuki had listened, his face calm and almost gentle, unguarded in a way that was so *new* to Izuku. He hadn't flinched away when Izuku had interlocked their pinkies the night before; Izuku had ignored the searing heat of Katsuki's hands, because Izuku knew all too well what it was like to hurt people because of being too scared to ask for help.

Katsuki had promised to talk to him, hadn't he? After the war. He'd *promised* .

Get up. Stand up. Keep fighting. You've always been the strongest so why aren't you fighting?

Izuku couldn't do anything; he couldn't force his body to move, couldn't reign in Blackwhip as it shot out of his body and snapped through the air, couldn't control his breathing. He didn't *want* to control any of those things. How could he continue to fight when Katsuki was *dead* ? What was there for him to fight for?

The rest of the world.

Izuku didn't care about the rest of the world.

He wanted to let the world burn.

There wasn't a world Izuku wanted to live in without Katsuki. Call it obsessive or unhealthy, Izuku didn't care. Even if Katsuki somehow stood up and survived, Izuku would be happy to love him from a distance if it meant that Katsuki was still living and breathing.

Izuku's eyes were still locked on Katsuki's limp form, his limbs so uncharacteristically relaxed. For a moment, a memory flashed through Izuku's mind, of Katsuki marching ahead of him across a log, high above a river. They'd walked that same path so many times as children, all while playing hero with the other kids at the park. Katsuki had always been their leader, though. He had never been afraid of anything. Not bugs or snakes or heights. Katsuki had taken on everything with a confident grin on his face and his chubby fingers planted on his hips.

He'd been a *kid* . Izuku's stomach turned over again, his knees shaking. Oh *god* , he'd been a kid, a kid who had wanted nothing more than to become a hero. Katsuki had wanted it so bad, just as much as Izuku. Their entire lives, that's all he had ever wanted.

Katsuki wasn't a five year old anymore. He wasn't braving the playground and challenging fourth graders. He was- he *had* fought in a war. He was too young, he was *so young* , he was still just a *kid* .

He would never get to be a hero. He would never have an official license. He would never open his own agency. He would never end up on the Pro Charts.

He was gone, he was *gone* , he wasn't going to get back up, he was never again going to exist. Katsuki was never going to keep living and yet the world was going to keep turning without him.

If they won this war, Izuku would have to sit in a classroom with an empty seat in front of him. He would have to wake up every single day, knowing that Katsuki would never get to wake up again. He would have to stop getting excited about being paired with Katsuki for group exercises during class. He would have to try to find someone else to possibly fill the void of the time he spent with Katsuki and come up empty handed. He would have to eat breakfast and brush his teeth and fold his laundry knowing that Katsuki had done those things not knowing it would be his last time.

Izuku would have to find something new to catch up to.

The person he had been chasing after his entire life had been extinguished like a candle; Izuku didn't have anything else to chase after.

His dream had been to become a hero. All his life, he'd watched and admired All Might. But as he'd told Katsuki that Katsuki had been the hero in his life. His definition of victory.

When they got to UA, and Katsuki and Izuku had cemented themselves as rivals, challenging each other for the top spot in everything they did, Izuku had found himself chasing the life of a hero for different reasons. He wanted to save and that would always be the foundation for his motivation. But he'd found another reason to want to be a hero, a selfish reason that he kept hidden away.

His second reason was Bakugou Katsuki, who had, unknowingly, taught Izuku how to have fun. How to relax.

It was a little backwards and ironic, really, that Katsuki had taught him that. But Izuku had learned, over the course of their many evenings training, how to lose himself in the moment. When he and Katsuki sparred, matching each other's moves flawlessly, Izuku found himself relaxing, enjoying himself. When he and Katsuki puzzled through homework problems, bickering the entire time, Izuku savored the easy moments between them, the stupid fights that meant nothing at all. Katsuki's tone had long since lost its aggression with Izuku; there was something there now, something that Izuku was too afraid to question or look too hard at. He was afraid of reading into something that may not even exist in the first place.

He found himself excited at the prospect of studying or training with Katsuki. His heart stuttered along in his chest as he thought about the moments when Katsuki let his guard down. Every once in a while, Katsuki would lean over Izuku's shoulder to help him with a problem, occasionally letting his chin rest against Izuku's shoulder. Other times, when they were lifting together, Katsuki would offer to spot Izuku (even if Izuku didn't need it). He'd let his hands brush Izuku's arms, or he'd stand just behind Izuku, his eyes taking in Izuku's every move.

Those tiny moments had become so addictive. Izuku had found himself craving more.

When he'd spent time with Katsuki, Izuku had found himself living in the moment for once. Not worrying about Shigaraki or All for One or the war. Not being the best hero, not school, not *anything* . Katsuki simultaneously pushed him to work harder and reigned him in; in a sense, Katsuki had been Izuku's grounding force, whether he meant to be or not.

Stupidly, Izuku thought of all the other things Katsuki would never get to experience. Hadn't he just said the other day he was too focused on becoming a hero to think about anything else? But still, Izuku mourned the loss for him.

He would never graduate high school. He would never get married. God, had he even had his first kiss? He would never go out to a bar with his friends. He would never have his own apartment. He would never buy a car. He would never grow old. He would never make it past seventeen, and Izuku had been gone for a month of Katsuki's life, an entire *month* . He'd been gone for Katsuki's birthday, hadn't even bought him a present or brought it up. He'd only been back for a week and that was *it* . It was over.

The rekindled friendship between them had met its end. It had reached the end of the road and there was nowhere else for it to go.

It was over.

He could hear Shigaraki, could tell he was hissing out how this had been Izuku's fault, how he had caused this.

And, god, Izuku couldn't disagree. He couldn't fight back. He'd left UA to avoid this. He'd come back to UA because of Katsuki and it had gotten Katsuki killed. *He* had gotten Katsuki killed.

I did this. I did this to him. I killed him .

Blackwhip lashed around him and his vision began to darken and flicker.

It was Izuku's fault. It was all Izuku's fault.

If he'd stayed away, if he'd fought on his own, if he would have been faster coming to UA, if he'd never taken the quirk to begin with, Katsuki would be *okay.* He would be alive; he could hate Izuku for refusing to come back and it wouldn't matter. None of it mattered. Izuku could handle his hatred if it meant that Katsuki got to keep living.

"I hope you like your present," Shigaraki drawled. "Sorry it's not wrapped."

The words had his stomach clenching all over again. Shigaraki had done *this* to get to Izuku. He'd read Izuku so *easily* . He knew exactly how to distract him. He must have caught on to the fact that Izuku frequently lost control during battles due to his own emotions. He also must have caught on that Izuku's feelings towards Katsuki were deeper than his feelings towards anyone else.

How had he *known* ? Had it been Izuku's reaction in Jaku? Had he traced it back to Kamino and the summer camp, when Izuku had been desperate to save Katsuki from the League? How had he known that Katsuki was the person Izuku couldn't stand to lose? Had he been that obvious?

He'd called Katsuki a *present* . As if killing Katsuki had been easy. As if Katsuki was just another body. He'd reduced Katsuki to *nothing* , had stripped away all of the things that made Izuku's heart tumble over itself in his chest. He was just a tool to Shigaraki. A meaningless, expendable body.

White hot rage ripped through his body. *I'll kill him.*

"Deku, listen to me!"

Dimly, he registered the sound of Mirio's voice, a little too close. Hands were gripping his shoulders.

They want me to fight. They want me to keep fighting for them .

He fought back the urge to snap at Mirio, to let the last remnants of his control go. He was suddenly overwhelmed by resentment, deep and heavy.

They don't care that he's dead. They don't care about him, they'll just keep fighting like everything is okay.

Izuku knew it wasn't true. He knew they cared. He knew that they had no choice but to keep fighting because there were still people that needed to be saved. They were Heroes. Heroes couldn't give up on the rest of the world because one person died.

"Deku, it's okay! Everyone's still alive."

Izuku could no longer control his body. He was detached from his own body, his mind broken and crumbling and scrambling for an escape. He so badly wanted to close his eyes, to tear his gaze away from Katsuki. The image had already imprinted itself on the back of his eyelids; he would be lucky to ever stop seeing it. The blood, the broken costume pieces, the unnaturally bent arm, the *stillness* .

"Edgeshot is doing his best to save Bakugou as we speak," Mirio said. "You have to trust him."

Izuku could feel firm hands shaking his shoulders, pulling him back into his body.

He's dead, he's dead, how can he save him, he's gone, he's not breathing, there's so much blood-

"I know he's going to succeed," Mirio continued, shaking him slightly. "Shigaraki *wanted* this. You can't lose focus. You have to keep fighting."

Through the cloud of thoughts in Izuku's mind, one memory stood out. A voice, in a hazy world that only he and eight others walked in, saying, *You have to keep tabs on your heart* .

That's what this was, right? His heart?

Izuku had never felt this way for anybody other than Katsuki. There would never be anyone else.

Edgeshot is doing his best to save Bakugou as we speak .

… Save him?

Relief and certainty slammed into him all at once. He retracted Blackwhip and braced himself.

Katsuki would wake up. Katsuki *had to wake up* .

They still had a lot to talk about. Izuku hadn't been brave enough to ask the questions he wanted to ask the night before. He'd pushed those questions away, convinced that if he could fight a war, he would have the courage to lay himself bare for Katsuki.

And if Katsuki didn't wake up, if Edgeshot couldn't save him, Izuku refused to fail Katsuki. If he let Shigaraki win, if he let his rage consume him and he lost the war, Katsuki's death would have meant nothing. He would have died as a pawn, a tool used to cultivate Izuku's anger.

They would both be dead at that point. He could hear Katsuki chewing him out in the afterlife.

(“ *Seriously, you damn nerd? How many times did I fucking tell you not to let your feelings get the best of you during a fight? I knew it was going to get you killed at some point.* ”)

The thought of Katsuki’s voice made him smile. The thought of getting to *hear* that voice again made Izuku want to keep fighting. Whether he got to talk to Katsuki after Edgeshot revived him or in the afterlife, it didn’t matter. The thought of him was enough.

He’d been pushing Izuku their entire lives.

Please get up. Get up and swear at me and yell at me and smile at me and laugh with me and know me better than anybody else. Get up and fight beside me. It’s always been you, it’ll always be you. I want you by my side .

Izuku slammed his fist into his chest. Once, twice. He took a deep breath.

He wouldn’t give Katsuki a reason to chastise him after Edgeshot saved him; he knew he wouldn’t hear the end of it if he couldn’t handle Shigaraki.

It seemed, even in death, Katsuki continued to push Izuku.

Chapter End Notes

wooooow I finally wrote an izuku chapter (he's so hard to write, I love writing katsuki so much more) so I hope you guys enjoy. little timeskip coming after this chapter because I really want to turn the focus of the fic to some post-war healing and more of the romance :)
hope you've been enjoying so far!! comments and kudos appreciated <3
I feel like in every chapter I add more and more about hero society and politics. I love MHA for the characters and plot but I seriously think the universe is so captivating and could be explored so much. I'm especially obsessed with Hawks/Nagant and the Hero Commission but I also just like to think about the more technical things taught to hero students. i hope you guys enjoy reading those little tidbits that I throw in as much as I like thinking and writing about them!!
find me on TikTok! @lvndrsunny

my tears ricochet

Chapter Summary

I didn't have it in myself to go with grace
and you're the hero flying around, saving face
and if I'm dead to you, why are you at the wake?
cursing my name
wishing I stayed

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Hospitals. Fucking hospitals.

The average high school student probably went to a hospital maybe once or twice throughout their three years. And if Katsuki were to guess, those high schoolers probably weren't being admitted for impalement wounds or post-revival operations.

Over the course of the last few days, Katsuki had been exposed to enough medical jargon to last him the rest of his goddamn life. He'd seen a number of specialists, had been prescribed countless medications, and had been forced to schedule a number of follow-up appointments, ranging from physical therapy to stitch removals and check ups. His heart and arm had suffered the worst of the damage done, but the rest of his body wasn't exactly in great condition after, well, dying.

As soon as he'd woken up, brain fuzzy and mouth unbearably *dry* , he'd been met with the faces of his sobbing parents. From Masaru, that was expected. His father had always been the more emotional of the two. Seeing his mother crying, though, had immediately put Katsuki on edge. His mother didn't *cry* . Her and Katsuki were so similar in that regard, their emotions so repressed under the guise of being strong.

Instead of being put off by her reaction though, his body seemed to relax completely after a few seconds.

Dying changed a person.

Katsuki hadn't remembered if there was an *afterlife* during his brief period being dead, and his skin crawled a bit at the thought. When he'd woken up on the battlefield, feeling as if his body had just been drug over hot coals and beaten repetitively with a baseball bat, he hadn't been able to dwell on the fact that he had been *dead* . He'd gotten up, only one thing, one person, on his mind.

But after waking up in the hospital and having some time to himself, he'd done a bit of soul-searching.

He'd died with regrets. He didn't want that to be the case when death came for him again.

On that battlefield, with rain and blood soaking his skin, Katsuki had regretted pushing his emotions down so deeply his entire life. He'd had the chance to look back, to reflect, and the moments in which he'd seen himself as *strong* were the times when he'd allowed himself to finally open up. He'd been strong at Ground Beta and he'd been strong at Jaku and he'd been strong in the rain, when Izuku had been swaying on his feet, energy completely spent.

So he'd let his mother cry into his shoulder, patting her back awkwardly with his good arm.

His first day after waking up had been a living nightmare. And Katsuki stuck by that, even after both surviving a near death experience and actually dying within the span of the last two months.

The first doctor he spoke to was a cardiologist. She was young and assertive, cutting right to the chase regarding Katsuki's condition. He respected her for it, though he inwardly winced as she read off her clipboard, each sentence bringing about a fresh set of tears from his parents.

He had obviously suffered severe damage to his heart on the battlefield. The combination of his quirk emanating from his entire body and Shigaraki's blow to his chest had caused his heart to practically explode. Edgeshot had been able to stitch his heart back together on the battlefield, and Katsuki had been operated on twice at the hospital. His cardiologist seemed optimistic about his condition, though. She'd told him that, after both of his successful surgeries, his heart had been, in way less words than she'd used, fixed. Of course, he would need to be monitored for a good while to be sure that there had been no mistakes during his operations.

That thought made him cringe inwardly. The thought of being cut open already had him a little uneasy, let alone thinking about a bunch of people poking around in his heart and possibly making *mistakes* . She had assured him, though, that his surgeries had been performed by some of the best cardiovascular surgeons in the world. She wanted to monitor him to make sure new conditions or defects didn't arise due to his… uncommon situation.

After talking to her, a new group of medical professionals had entered his room. A few of them were doctors, but Katsuki had still been loopy from waking up, and their names and specialties went over his head. He did remember, though, that one of them was an orthopedic surgeon. He'd smirked a bit when the man had introduced himself, a memory playing in his mind.

"Maybe if this whole hero thing doesn't work out, I can go treat broken bones… or something like that."

"Right. You've been dreaming about being a hero since you could fucking breathe. No way you're gonna go work in orthopedics."

“Back up plans, Kacchan. They’re very important.”

“This is it for me. Fuck a back up plan.”

“What if it doesn’t work out? What if the media doesn’t like you because you have a bad attitude and you don’t make enough money to pay rent?”

“Good thing I’ll know a bone doctor that can afford a two bedroom apartment.”

Katsuki had woken up demanding to see Izuku. The nurse that had responded when he’d woken up had pushed him back down onto his mattress, her eyes apologetic. It had been the same shit as Jaku; the staff withheld information on Izuku’s state and refused to let him leave. They must have been aware of how he’d reacted the last time something like this had happened, and the nurse hadn’t left his side until she was positive he wouldn’t get up and try to find Izuku. He’d only followed instructions because of the whole *I-just-woke-up-from-being-dead thing* , and Katsuki would have been lying if he said he wasn’t a little bit concerned about the state of his own body.

The orthopedic surgeon had made Katsuki smile; his presence was a small reminder of the fact that he and Izuku had both been happy at some point. There had been a point in their lives in which they’d been able to smile and joke. Even if they’d been preparing for a war at that point, they’d still been able to joke about stupid shit.

Katsuki wondered if he would ever find his way back to that.

He wasn’t an idiot; he knew that his parents had consented to him being given some type of relaxant. He’d been given a cocktail of medications after waking up, and his track record with hospitals and injured Izuku’s wasn’t too good. At some point, a little while after taking the medication, his whole body had felt so solid and heavy, his brain a little fuzzy. Thoughts evaded him; whenever something important came into his mind, he couldn’t seem to latch onto it.

Katsuki didn’t *need* their damn fix-it pills, he needed to see Izuku. Katsuki hadn’t exactly been able to play catch up with Izuku on the battlefield, and he only knew bits and pieces of Izuku’s parts of the war. Until he could see that damn green haired self-sacrificing asshole, he didn’t trust a single thing his parents or nurses said about Izuku.

Because “he’s okay” could mean a lot of different things. The last time they’d been in a hospital, Katsuki’s nurses and friends and parents had told him that Izuku was “okay” and then he’d up and fucking *left* . When Katsuki had found him, *finally* , a month later, he’d looked like a walking corpse.

Katsuki did his best to pay attention to the group of doctors that had entered his room. Due to the extensive damage done to his arm, he had a number of specialists working together to help him recover.

Recover.

As they laid out all the damage and all the attempts they had made to fix Katsuki's arm, he found that recovery didn't mean walking it off and getting back to 100%.

His arm would never go back to normal. The damage to his bones and nerves and muscles had been practically irreversible. His doctors expected him to lose more than half of his range of motion in his fingers and wrist. They'd mentioned amputation, to which he had gone embarrassingly pale. Panic had set in, sharp and biting, his eyes glued to the hospital blanket pooling in his lap. His father rested a hand on Katsuki's shoulder.

"Prosthetics have come a long way. Pro Hero Mirko, as I'm sure you noticed, has used them to her advantage with hero work. Of course, in the best case scenario, we would be able to fix your arm. This might be another option for-"

"No. No, I'm not fucking doing that."

"Katsuki," his mother chided, though her voice was unstable.

He could feel tears in his own eyes, hot and embarrassing. God, he was fucking *crying* .

"I'll make it work," he muttered, using his good arm to wipe away his tears before they could fall. "I need my palms for my quirk. Can't replace that with a prosthetic."

Selfishly, he couldn't bring himself to give it up. Sure, struggling with a barely-functioning arm for the rest of his life would probably bring him unending amounts of frustration, but the thought of one of his two palms being *gone forever* shook him to his core. He didn't know what life was like without his quirk, and if keeping his arm took learning and adapting and healing, he would fucking do it. Shigaraki wouldn't get the best of him; he'd go to physical therapy and rehab and do every shitty ass exercise his doctors told him to do.

Was it wrong of him to keep his arm because he needed his palms to use his quirk?

Izuku had never even had a quirk to begin with. Katsuki was fucking lucky that he still had one arm that was completely functional.

His doctor hadn't pushed him towards amputation; the man simply nodded and marked it down on Katsuki's chart. He went on to explain the technicalities of the damage done to Katsuki's arm. Through it all, Katsuki kept his eyes down, wiggling the fingers of his right arm around just enough for him to know that it was still there.

The sling holding his arm was a very tangible reminder of what he had gone through. What they had *all* gone through. Everything had consequences. Some consequences lasted longer than others.

This would stay with Katsuki for the rest of his life.

When the doctors finally left his room and his parents headed out into the hallway to talk, Katsuki finally let out the breath he had been holding in for seemingly all day. His head hurt from the information that had been drilled into him. His body hurt from fighting in a war. His eyes hurt from unshed tears.

I'm going to be weak, I'm going to have to start from nothing with this fucking arm, it's going to hold me back, everyone is going to know-

He took a breath.

Another.

Izuku won't think you're weak. He'll probably look at you with that one look and tell you how amazing you are and offer to help. Izuku would never think you're weak.

Right?

Katsuki still didn't know how Izuku had reacted to his death. The moments in which they'd interacted after Katsuki had been revived had been short and chaotic; there hadn't exactly been time for tearful reunions and apologies and hugs and whatever other sappy shit Katsuki had guiltily wanted.

But he remembered, in sickening detail, the thoughts and fears he had had as he'd died. He remembered everything. The rain, the cold ground, the warmth leaving him, the stickiness of his own blood, the *pain* . He remembered blaming himself, feeling like he had failed Izuku, being afraid that he had never been able to catch up, that he hadn't been able to patch up their relationship. He'd been forced to relive every single mistake he had made throughout his entire life, all the things he had said to hurt Izuku. As his life had slipped away from him, Katsuki had mourned the loss of never being able to have Izuku as his own, because he'd been too self-loathing and convinced that he didn't deserve it to admit his feelings.

Had Izuku seen Katsuki dead and thought of him as weak? Had he been angry that Katsuki hadn't done more?

No, Izuku's not like that.

Actually, the more likely alternative made Katsuki sick to his stomach. He knew Izuku; he knew what kind of person Izuku was at his core, knew that his hero instincts ran too deep. He'd probably seen Katsuki's corpse and blamed himself for it.

He was probably down the hall, wallowing in misery and self-hatred. He probably thought Katsuki hated him because he'd been pulled through the wrong warp.

His parents re-entered his room, both of them looking pensive and teary-eyed.

"Katsuki," his father said gently. "How are you feeling?"

"Like I just died and came back to life," he said dryly.

"Not funny," his mother said, crossing her arms. "Tell us how you're actually feeling."

"Could use a glass of fucking water," he muttered. "And I want to go see Izuku."

"Katsuki-"

“ *No* . I sat through those stupid ass appointments and didn’t complain once. I didn’t yell at any nurses or try to go to his room without permission.”

“That’s how normal patients behave,” his mother said, handing him a plastic cup of water and watching him chug it down. “You don’t get an award for behaving like a normal person.”

“Nothing about this is *normal* .” He slammed the empty cup down on his bedside table. “None of this is *normal* . Fighting in a war at seventeen isn’t normal. Dying and coming back to life isn’t normal. Having heart surgery twice isn’t *goddamn normal* .”

“You’re right, it’s not.” Mitsuki pinched the bridge of her nose, her eyes flitting closed briefly.

“Yeah, so don’t tell me I need to act normal. The last time something like this happened, I *lost him* .”

Both of his parents paused, sharing a glance that annoyed Katsuki to no end. His mother’s eyebrows flicked up, and he clenched his good hand into a fist. Did they need to fucking stare at him like he had grown two heads?

“I’ll talk to Inko and Izuku’s doctors,” Masaru said, placing a hand on his wife’s shoulder. “You wouldn’t want to disrupt his recovery, right?”

Fuck off , he wanted to spit. *I know damn well he wants to see me* .

At least, that’s what Katsuki told himself. He didn’t know what he would do with himself if Izuku turned him away.

Katsuki was far past the point of accepting his feelings for Izuku. He’d known going into the war that he was probably in love with the person he had bullied in middle school. He’d died knowing for a fact that he was in love with Izuku.

There was no turning back. Hadn’t Izuku promised to talk to him after the war? About stupid mushy shit?

While his father left to go talk to Izuku’s doctors, his mother sat in the chair beside his bed. She let out a long sigh, tapping one of her perfectly manicured fingernails on his nightstand. Katsuki let her get away with it for a minute or so, until the repetitive tapping began to piss him off. His eye twitched.

“Spit it out, hag.”

Mitsuki avoided his gaze and didn’t speak for another few moments.

“I’m proud of you, kid. From what everyone said, you were pretty badass out there.”

“Whatever.”

She took his good hand in both of hers. The contact was unexpected and so out of character for Mitsuki that he almost yanked his hand away. “You shouldn’t have had to fight out there.”

“What, you think I wasn’t going to after they kidnapped me?”

She sighed again.

“Katsuki, I wanted to tell you that I’m sorry.”

“Huh? The hell do you have to be sorry for?”

“Well, for one, not putting my foot down and refusing to let my son fight in a war at only seventeen.” She scoffed, shaking her head. “You *died* . And your teachers feel all guilty, sure, but none of them experienced what your father and I did. When they started live streaming…”

Her voice broke and she wiped away a tear. Katsuki fought down the urge to shift away from her touch.

“You’re not a parent, so you don’t understand. But seeing you… seeing you *dead* , Katsuki, it was the worst thing I’ve ever experienced.”

He held back a comment that his death had probably been the worst thing he had ever experienced, too.

“And… I just felt like I had failed you.”

Surprised, he lifted his head to look at her. “Huh?”

“I just… I was so hard on you. I pushed you so much. I was always making sure you were stronger than all the other kids. I just… I was insecure. I never wanted to be weak when I was growing up. I wanted to be better than everybody else. And I pushed that onto you. Maybe… if I would’ve done things differently, I don’t know-”

“No point apologizing now,” he muttered. “You did what you did. I am who I am.”

“I just think… things would’ve been a little easier for you. If I wouldn’t have made you feel like you have to be strong all the time.”

“I’m figuring it out,” he said. Admitting it out loud made his heart feel a little bit lighter. He was heading in the right direction. “Don’t gotta apologize for it.”

She wiped her tears and smiled; Katsuki could tell it was fake. “If you have kids, don’t fuck them up like I did.”

He snorted. “First of all, I don’t think I’m all that fucked up, thank you very much. Second of all, you can kiss the idea of me having kids goodbye.”

“Oh, come on, I’m sure you’ll find some sweet girl eventually. I mean, I was always like you when I was younger. But then I met Masaru, and, well, I don’t know. He puts up with my attitude but keeps me in check. You’ll find someone like that.”

Katsuki had already found someone like that. He was laying in a hospital bed somewhere down the hall.

“I’m sure once you get tired of hero work you’ll settle down. Kids are fun. Probably harder to deal with than fighting villains. But it’s pretty rewarding.”

“I already told you, you can kiss grandkids goodbye. Not happening.”

“You’re still young, Katsuki. Things change! I didn’t want kids either when I was-”

“I never said I didn’t want them,” he said, a surprise to himself. Truthfully, he hadn’t really ever thought about it; he’d figured himself out in middle school. That had kind of ruled kids out by default.

“Then why are you telling me to kiss grandkids goodbye? You think you won’t be able to find some cute girl to put up with you?”

“Mom.”

“Well?”

“Can we talk about something else? Actually, literally anything else?”

“Aren’t there any nice girls in your class? I mean, knowing you, you’d want someone strong enough to handle herself. How about that one girl, you know, that you fought at the Sports Festival? She was pretty tough. Pretty too.”

He pinched the bridge of his nose and sighed. Uraraka? Fucking *really* ?

He didn’t mind Pink Cheeks. Was he annoyed as fuck that Izuku got all blushy around her? And that she fawned over Izuku? Yes. Did he respect her for holding her own and being one of the most badass girls, no, *people* , he’d ever met? Yes.

He couldn’t really fault her for crushing on Izuku, not when he was probably worse off.

If Katsuki had inherited anything from Mitsuki, it was her persistence. She’d always been that way; hadn’t she pushed and pushed and pushed for Masaru to go out with her for months?

He wasn’t getting out of this conversation.

He thought back to his anger the evening before the war. At his parents, for their questionable methods with him. Neither of them had ever really been able to handle him. His mother had just apologized for *failing* Katsuki, had told him not to fuck up if he ever had kids. Looking back, he almost felt bad for them.

There wasn’t a perfect book out there explaining how to be the best parent in the world. There wasn’t a book out there explaining how to deal with your child having a quirk stronger than the rest of his classmates’ quirks.

Katsuki was still angry. His anger at his parents probably wouldn't go away, at least until he worked through all the complicated emotions he had towards his childhood. But not everything had been bad. They'd done their best; they'd never meant to turn Katsuki into *this*.

"When I was in middle school, you knew… how I treated Izuku. Right?"

She blinked at him a few times. "Why are you asking?"

"Just answer me, Mom."

She looked away from him, tapping her fingernails again. "Yeah. Inko… she would mention it."

Katsuki looked out the window next to his bed. The city was still a nightmare; most of its residents had evacuated. Police officers were out in full force on just about every corner, ensuring returning civilians of their safety and monitoring crowds as they returned. The hospital hadn't been terribly damaged, thanks to Shoji and the rest of the heteromorphs. It was still functioning enough to treat the injured Heroes and hero students that had fought in the war. The entire city wasn't so lucky; some buildings had been trashed or burnt down. Most of the city streets were littered with debris and discarded weapons.

The war was over. They could clean up the streets. They could rebuild and repair the damaged buildings. They could wash away any spilled blood. They could stitch up wounds and prescribe pills.

The war would never truly end.

"Her and I were very close. Before… that. She would mention it, back when you two were just brats. She always said you were too rough towards Izuku on the playground. And I should've listened to her. But… I don't know."

His mother looked embarrassed. The expression was so unlike her that Katsuki couldn't look away. All his life, he'd never seen her admit that she was wrong or take accountability.

God, he'd really kicked the bucket and turned her into a sap.

"I thought it would do Izuku some good. It was none of my business, and I should have told you to be nicer. I should have taught you that you don't have to always worry about being stronger than everyone else. His father wasn't around to teach him how to be strong, and Inko… she's always been on the passive side. So I thought it was helping him. Making him stronger."

He gripped the blanket, his fist clenched so tight it hurt.

She hadn't *known* that he would end up taking it too far. She hadn't known that he would end up as terrible as he did.

Still, she hadn't stopped him. Or punished him. Or taught him how to just be fucking nice.

“I never knew what to say to you. When you got older… well, I guess I just thought…” She threw her head back. “You really ask the hard questions, huh?”

“You gonna answer?”

“Everyone bullied him,” she murmured. “It wasn’t right. I should have paid closer attention back then. I should have put a stop to it. I should have done a lot more than I did. I can’t defend myself. I can’t make the situation better. I can barely even look Inko in the eye. Izuku was the only kid at that school without a quirk. And he held onto that dream of being a hero, even though there was no way he could ever achieve it. I… I thought it was stupid. I thought it was stupid for him to dream of becoming a hero, and I thought it was stupid that Inko didn’t put a stop to it.”

Katsuki scoffed.

He’d been a child. A child, torturing another child.

His mother had known. She’d watched from afar and done nothing.

You can’t blame her for what you did. It’s not her fault.

“Izuku’s always been a hero,” he said finally. “He taught me a lot.”

She leaned forward, her eyes sharp and intrigued. “Really? Like what?”

“I think all this hero shit is stupid. That having a powerful quirk and knowing how to use it makes someone a hero. Look at fucking Endeavor. That guy fucked up how many kids? And still ended up number one?” He let go off his blanket, smoothing the wrinkles out against his leg. “It shouldn’t be about who has the most powerful quirk. Or who sells more merch or saves more people, or which Pro wears the sluttiest costume. I don’t think it even has anything to do with quirks, actually.”

Mitsuki continued watching him, her gaze never leaving him.

He hadn’t expected to open up to his mother. Out of his parents, he’d always been more inclined to admit things to his father, who tended to be way more lenient and accepting. He’d resented his father as a child; he’d seen Masaru as weak compared to his mother, who made the decisions and ran the household and so clearly had the stronger willpower of the two.

As he’d gotten older, he’d begun to appreciate his father more. Instead of admonishing Katsuki for being weak or for making mistakes, he’d always just been quietly supportive. He didn’t coddle Katsuki, but he didn’t tear him down either.

Katsuki wanted his mother to get it, though. He wanted her to know that he was growing up. That he was figuring his shit out.

“Getting that quirk didn’t make Izuku a hero,” he mumbled. “He’s always been saving people.”

Mitsuki squeezed his hand again. She was quiet for a few minutes, the silence punctuated by the beeping of Katsuki's heart monitor. Finally, she asked, "Why did you ask? About if I knew that you bullied Izuku."

Katsuki let his head fall back against his pillows, looking up at the square ceiling tiles. He sighed.

"I'm going to say some shit. And I don't want to hear anything about it. Got that?"

"Floor is yours, brat."

"I like him."

Her mouth dropped open. He glared.

"I realized a few months ago. I don't need your nosy ass asking me all kinds of questions about it because I'm not answering shit."

She pressed her lips together, her expression still shocked. "Okay. I… okay."

"I just want to know… if I can come back from what I did to him." He turned to look at her. He was *angry* , but not at her. He was angry at himself for the things he had done to Izuku. He was angry at himself for bullying someone so *good* . He was angry at himself for refusing to think that he could ever deserve Izuku.

"I don't know," she admitted. "I didn't even realize… I didn't know that you were…"

He did *not* feel like having that conversation. He'd never planned on making a big deal out of *coming out* to his parents, or whatever. It didn't need to be a big deal. He was who he was.

She coughed awkwardly. "I think that's something that only he can answer. But I think it's worth trying. If you really care about him."

"Yeah. Fucking thought you'd say something like that," he muttered.

Katsuki hadn't known what to expect from his mother. She could have scoffed at him. She could have called him weak for having feelings for someone in the first place. She could have called him a fucking idiot for falling for the one person that he didn't deserve.

Maybe this was Katsuki's karma. He'd gotten everything he'd ever wanted, right? A powerful quirk, acceptance into UA, the chance to become the number one hero. All the things he had wanted ever since he'd been a child, he *had* .

The one thing that he'd been pushing away for so many years, he'd come to appreciate and accept and *want* . He'd found a new goal to chase, something way more exciting and meaningful than becoming number one. Everything else dulled in comparison to the thought of being Izuku's.

He'd done so much damage to their relationship.

And yet, there would never be anyone else for Katsuki.

It was probably a very childish thought. He hadn't even graduated high school; it was a bit immature to decide that Izuku was the only person in the world for him.

But there was nobody else out there like Izuku. There was nobody else who could ever replicate the drive that Izuku ignited within Katsuki. Nobody else would ever leave Katsuki wanting *more* . Sure, there were probably other people out there that were like Izuku, with a hero's instinct and heart. But those people couldn't compare to the years between them. Nobody else would ever know Katsuki in the way that Izuku did. Izuku had been watching him ever since they were brats.

Izuku had been there for every moment in Katsuki's life. His breakdowns, his successes, his sacrifices, his death. Izuku had been there.

How could Katsuki ever find someone else? How could he ever explain to someone that he would be competing with Izuku forever, that Izuku would always be his priority?

No matter what path their relationship followed, it would always be the most important one in Katsuki's life. He should have appreciated Izuku years ago. Now that he'd finally figured his shit out, he wasn't going to let it slip away again.

"You gonna tell him now?" she asked.

Katsuki looked past her, to where his father was opening the door to his room, a small smile on his face. He gave Katsuki a thumbs-up. *Corny motherfucker* .

"Probably not very good timing. Ya know, considering we just fought in a goddamn war."

He tossed his legs out of bed, ignoring both of his parents as they shouted at him to wait and be careful. That thumbs-up was all he had needed.

Katsuki had been waiting the whole damn day to see Izuku. Now that he was finally able to, he was… nervous.

Don't be stupid. It's just Izuku.

The thought didn't calm him.

He stood on shaky legs, his stomach twisting and clenching as he did. The floor was cold against the soles of his feet, and he focused on that feeling, rather than his swimming vision and suddenly airy head. Every single muscle in his body ached as he took his first few steps. He could barely bend his legs, which were tight from spending the last few days in a coma. He could feel the stitches in his chest pulling as he moved.

Katsuki ignored the pain. He reached his doorway, grabbing the frame and pushing out into the hallway.

He had known pain on the battlefield.

This was nothing.

His father motioned to the right. “He’s three doors down. Are you sure you don’t want a wheelchair?”

“Fuck off,” he gritted out.

He would walk himself to Izuku. He would crawl on his hands and knees to Izuku if he had to.

Katsuki was done taking the easy way out. He was done letting other people pick up the slack for him. When it came to Izuku, he was giving his all or nothing.

Nurses glanced at him warily as he passed, but their faces were blurry. He pressed his good hand to the wall as he stumbled along, fighting against the shakiness in his legs and the exhaustion of his entire body. Behind him, his father pushed along his IV pole, which Katsuki had been tempted to rip out of his hand and abandon. The only thing preventing him had been the fact that the IV was placed in the back of his good hand, and his right hand could barely move, let alone rip out an IV.

Whatever. He would pull along a thousand of the damn poles if that’s what it took to get to Izuku.

Three doors had never felt further. His knees were shaking an embarrassing amount, and as he finally, *finally* reached Izuku’s door, Katsuki was out of breath. God, he’d fought in a fucking war only a few days earlier. He was in better shape than anyone else he knew. And he could barely make it down a hallway?

Katsuki stopped just outside the door. It was open, and he could hear voices from inside. He knew that All Might and Izuku were sharing the same hospital room, and, if he were anyone else, he would be embarrassed at how disheveled and ragged he looked.

But he wasn’t anyone else. He was Bakugou fucking Katsuki. He had beaten death twice. He could face his childhood best friend in his hospital bed.

Katsuki stepped into the room, still a bit wobbly. Izuku was in the bed closest to the door, more than half of his head wrapped in bandages. One of his eyes was covered by the thick, white bandages, and his arms were also wrapped.

“Hey, nerd,” he rasped, letting go of the door frame and stumbling into the room.

Izuku’s head snapped towards him, sitting up a bit straighter in his bed. His uncovered eye went wide, so bright and shiny and immediately full of tears.

“Kacchan!”

God, Katsuki had missed that voice. He’d missed hearing Izuku call him that stupid nickname.

“You look like shit,” he said. It was a complete and utter lie.

Even half mummified, the sight of Izuku immediately had Katsuki's entire body relaxing. Like a magnet, he was drawn into the room, stumbling towards the edge of the bed.

He'd never wanted anything so bad in his entire life.

"Should you be out of bed?" Izuku asked, his tone worried. "Are you allowed to be walking around?"

Katsuki poked Izuku's forehead. "You think I was gonna let those fuckers keep me off my feet for long?"

Izuku smiled softly. Katsuki mentally patted himself on the back. "Your injuries were serious. You… I just didn't want you to irritate them."

"Injuries? You mean when I died and got revived?"

Katsuki was fully aware of his own shortcomings in the way of social skills. And he could admit when he fucked up.

Saying that had definitely been a fuck up.

All Might was staring at him so intensely that Katsuki felt uncomfortable. Inko let out a choked cry from the other side of the room, a hand snapping up over her mouth. Katsuki's mother shouted his name from where she was eavesdropping in the hallway.

And Izuku just stared at him, that one eye so wide and so… empty.

He blinked, looked down at his lap. Katsuki watched as tears slid silently down Izuku's cheek.

Inko hurried over to Izuku's bedside, her gaze flicking between Katsuki and Izuku. "Katsuki… maybe now isn't the time. You both have a lot of healing to do. I'm sure the war has you both shaken up."

"It's okay, Mom," Izuku said, sniffling. "Could you… give us some space? To talk?"

"Are you sure?" She sent Katsuki a wary glance. If she was anyone else, he probably would have snapped at her. But this was Izuku's mother, and he'd wronged her just as much as he'd wronged Izuku. He clenched and unclenched his fist.

"Yes. I'm sure." He smiled at her. "Talking to Kacchan can't be worse than fighting in a war."

It was obviously an attempt at humor, but not a single person in the room laughed except Katsuki. Inko still had that incredulous, horrified look on her face, fluffing Izuku's pillows and brushing hair out of his face. All Might looked down at his lap awkwardly. Katsuki's mother and father had stepped into the doorway, ready to intervene if it seemed like Katsuki and Izuku were about to be at each other's throats.

But Katsuki let out a snort and collapsed gratefully into the empty chair next to Izuku's bed. Walking down the hall had taken all of his energy and left him spent. He shifted around,

yanking and repositioning his IV tube. Inko looked between him and Izuku again, then pulled the curtain between him and All Might shut. Her, Mitsuki, and Masaru paused in the doorway for a moment, the three of them exchanging glances.

“I’m not going to attack him,” he snapped, yanking his good hand through his hair. Someone must have washed it when he’d been admitted a few days back, but it had dried terribly. A few tufts were plastered to his face and he shoved them up in frustration.

The three exchanged *yet another* glance, before Inko nodded and they left the room, pulling the door halfway closed behind them.

Katsuki sighed.

All at once, the entire situation was awkward. He felt like an idiot for barging into Izuku’s room and demanding to talk to him. What if Izuku didn’t even want to see him? What if Izuku was mad at him? What if-

“Sorry for being all weird. I just… it was hard enough seeing you… uh…”

“I’m alive,” Katsuki said simply, glaring bullets at the tiled floor. “Everything’s fine.”

Izuku hummed in response, and only then did Katsuki lift his gaze. His uncovered eye was gazing at Katsuki with so much emotion he almost had to look away again.

Then the dam broke once more, and tears began to dot the pale blue hospital blanket bunched in Izuku’s lap. “I’m so sorry- if I hadn’t been pulled through- if I would have been faster- I shouldn’t have gotten distracted- you wouldn’t have- it shouldn’t have happened- I’m sorry, Kacchan, I’m so s-”

“Cut that out,” he muttered, reaching out and shoving Izuku’s head back against his pillows with as little force as he could manage. “No need to apologize.”

His face was warm and he felt the sudden urge to run away. Of course Izuku would feel like it was his fault. Of course Izuku wouldn’t be mad at Katsuki.

It still didn’t comfort him. Izuku was already dealing with enough; he didn’t need to work through the guilt of Katsuki’s choices on top of all his other shit.

“But I- Toga- I tried to get back as fast as I could- I-”

“ *Izuku* .”

Izuku’s face bunched up as he paused his rambling, his breathing fast and uneven.

“Nobody blames you for it.” Then, because Izuku had always been the type of person to not listen the first damn time, “I don’t blame you.”

“But-”

“But fucking what? It’s not your fault we got separated.”

“I just… I was fighting Toga. Danger Sense never went off with her, because she never meant me any harm. She pulled me through the warp to… to ask me to be her boyfriend.”

Katsuki and Izuku stared at each other for a couple seconds before Katsuki *laughed* .

He’d been worried, before coming in here, that they would never be the same after the war. And they wouldn’t. He would probably carry the trauma of that day with him for the rest of his life. He almost expected to have nightmares about being separated from Izuku and his own death. He knew his first few battles after being cleared would be straining, both mentally and physically. Not to mention the scars that surely covered his entire body.

But being able to laugh felt like healing. Being able to talk to Izuku and know that they could both keep living was healing.

“She asked you to be her boyfriend? What’d you tell her?”

Izuku’s face went red. “That I thought she was moving a bit too fast.”

“Aren’t you a gentleman,” Katsuki scoffed. He rested his good elbow on the rails of Izuku’s bed and leaned his chin on his hand. “Bet she didn’t like that.”

“I didn’t stick around to find out.”

Silence fell over them again. Katsuki picked a few pieces of lint from his sling. Izuku watched him intently.

“I know you won’t fucking ask,” he grumbled, leaning back in his seat. “Shigaraki messed up my arm pretty bad before…”

Izuku winced.

“Doctor said there’s a chance I’ll never be able to use it again. They had to set all the bone fragments and shit, which I’m sure gets you all excited. Damage was pretty fucking bad. I’ll have it in a sling for a while, then physical therapy for god knows how long.”

“Kacchan.” Izuku was pouting again.

“Don’t give me that look, nerd. I already told you, I don’t blame you.”

“Who do you blame?”

Me. If I’d been stronger, if I’d been better, if I hadn’t been so weak-

“Because it’s not your fault, either,” Izuku said softly.

Katsuki scoffed and ignored the comment. “I could’ve gotten it amputated.”

Izuku pondered that for a moment, then shook his head. “Nah. I bet you told them you’d ‘kick rehab’s ass’ or something. You wouldn’t give up that easily.”

There goes Izuku, always knowing everything there was to know about Katsuki. He wasn't looking down on Katsuki for his decision, wasn't judging him for refusing help. He understood.

"Whatever. Enough about me, nerd. What damage did you do this time?"

"Well, Eri rewinded my arms after I lost them to Shigaraki. My doctors still wanted to keep a close eye on them. And, well, my face took a couple bad hits. But it's really not that bad! I swear!"

"What about… your quirk?"

Katsuki hadn't wanted to ask.

Izuku having the quirk or not changed nothing. Not after what they had been through.

Without a doubt, Katsuki knew he wouldn't stop feeling the way he felt towards Izuku if he no longer had One for All. He could never go back to hating Izuku because of it; if anything, Izuku had proven that he didn't need his quirk to be strong. Katsuki hadn't fallen for him because of his power. His love for Izuku went a lot deeper than that. It had taken Katsuki years, it had taken so many failures, for him to realize that quirks meant nothing.

"Eri was able to rewind my body to the point before I lost it. It took a lot out of her, so I feel really guilty about it. Honestly, I didn't even care if she did it or not."

"You didn't care about losing your quirk?"

"It wasn't mine to begin with," Izuku pointed out. "And, besides, I think… I think I really want to take a different path."

"God, not this bone doctor shit again, Izuku."

"No," he said, laughing. "I still want to be a hero. But I want to do something… I don't know. After everything I've been through and after the war… I really want to save people in a different way."

"The hell does that mean?"

"When I was fighting Shigaraki… he said that he was my villain. That we were made to fight each other."

Katsuki snorted. "What a freak."

"I mean, I get what he meant… I really wanted to save Tenko."

"Tenko?"

"That was Shigaraki's name. He was the grandson of Shimura Nana."

"And you wanted to save him?"

“It’s complicated.”

“He killed how many fucking people? Me included.”

“I know. I just… nobody tried to help him. When he was younger. He had nobody to save him. And I wanted to.”

“What, dick sucking complex made another appearance?”

“ *Kacchan* .”

“Well?”

“I just feel like… like he was failed. He was just a little boy and nobody helped him. Can you imagine how scary that must have been, Kacchan? What if, when you manifested your quirk, you blew someone up by accident? And everyone treated you like you were some freak?”

“Everyone treated you like a freak and you didn’t grow up trying to kill everyone,” Katsuki pointed out, turning away from Izuku. He was irritated and exhausted and so overwhelmingly *fond* . Shigaraki had killed so many people, Katsuki included, and Izuku had still seen someone who needed saving. It should have made Katsuki a lot more angry, that Izuku could see past the whole villain thing, but it didn’t. Actually, it made Katsuki feel so disgustingly *soft* .

Hadn’t he just told his mother that Izuku had always been a hero?

Heroes saved people. Real heroes, like Izuku, saw past stupid labels of ‘good’ vs. ‘bad’. Heroes like Izuku wanted to save *everyone* .

“But that’s the thing. That’s my point. I had my mom. To her, it didn’t matter that I was quirkless. She still loved me more than anything. But Tenko… Tenko had nobody. Everyone turned away from him and refused to help. I know you think it’s stupid and that I’m self-sacrificial and everything else, but I wanted to save the little boy that he once was. I guess it’s easy for me to understand him. If I hadn’t had my mom… maybe I would have ended up like him.”

The thought of Izuku running around with a group of villains was a bit amusing. “Nah, you don’t have the villain face.”

“What’s that supposed to mean?”

“Exactly what it sounds like.”

What Katsuki wanted to say was that Izuku was too cute to be a villain. Or he could have used those wide, adoring eyes as a deceptive weapon. Which he probably would have.

“So you don’t think I could be a villain?”

“Oh, I think we’re all lucky as fuck that you didn’t seek revenge on the world for… you know. You’re like a freaky genius. If you wanted to get revenge on me, you have about five

notebooks worth of shit on me."

"Oh, you're scared of me?" Izuku's eyebrow quirked up, a small smile on his face.

"Don't get ahead of yourself, fuckhead."

Izuku turned in his bed, tossing his legs over the side and facing Katsuki. Katsuki almost chided him for moving around so soon after a fucking war, before he realized that would be hypocritical as fuck, and that Izuku definitely didn't need Katsuki to coddle him on top of his mother and the entire hospital staff.

"I'm really glad you're okay," Izuku said finally. "When I saw you… when I saw your body, I kind of… lost control. I couldn't think about anything. I couldn't *do* anything."

"That's what he wanted," Katsuki said, scoffing. "Told me he was going to leave my corpse as a gift to you."

"Yeah," Izuku breathed, "he said that to me, too."

The words had been so *sickening* . Izuku could talk about wanting to save Tenko all he wanted, but it didn't change the fact that Shigaraki had wanted to kill someone just to hurt Izuku. The fact that Izuku could look past that was something Katsuki could never understand.

Izuku reached out tentatively, and Katsuki stopped breathing. Izuku's scarred, bandaged hand hovered just above Katsuki's heart; Katsuki didn't miss how much Izuku's arm was quivering.

"Can I?" Izuku asked quietly, his eye not meeting Katsuki's.

"Whatever, nerd," Katsuki said tightly. He was afraid to move, he was afraid to *breathe* .

Izuku's palm rested over his heart, his fingers stretching out.

The last time they had been during the war. They'd been so focused on the battle, their skills and quirks so honed for combat. Nobody had ever trained Katsuki on how to do things like *this* .

Katsuki watched Izuku's face, watched as his body relaxed as Katsuki's heart beat steadily beneath his palm.

"See? Still beating."

At that, Izuku let out a soft sob, his body shifting forward.

Katsuki had caught him once before. Doing it again was instinct.

Izuku's arms wrapped around Katsuki, his fingers tightening in Katsuki's hospital gown. His head landed on Katsuki's shoulder, his unbandaged half closest to Katsuki's face. Matted

green curls pressed against his cheek. Katsuki's good arm found its way around Izuku's shoulders, pulling him close, holding him to Katsuki as if he were a lifeline.

Am I allowed to have this? Am I allowed to be hugged by him, after everything? Do I deserve this?

Izuku was here, Izuku was hugging him, Izuku was holding him and crying into his shoulder. Everything was okay and nothing was okay. They had been weaponized. They had been injured and tormented. Izuku had been forced to bear the weight of the entire world by himself; how many times had the Pros said that their strategy was to rely on Izuku? They had both been yanked out of the confines of being teenagers; it would probably take a long, long time for Katsuki and Izuku to learn how to relax, how to feel safe.

Izuku had already been struggling for a while. And Katsuki had been trying to figure himself out for months.

Shockingly enough, in that moment, holding each other close, Katsuki felt closer to being okay than he ever had in his entire life.

They would be okay. They would heal together. They would pick up the pieces. When Izuku needed to laugh, Katsuki would do anything to make him smile. When he needed a reminder that they had both made it, Katsuki would be there. When the stress of it all became too much, when the memories overwhelmed Izuku, Katsuki would drag him back to the present.

Katsuki was starting to pick himself up. He was starting to feel like he was allowed to have moments like this. That didn't mean he would stop trying, ever. That didn't mean he would stop wanting to prove himself to Izuku, or to stop trying to climb up to Izuku's level.

It just meant that, sometimes, Katsuki was okay with letting Izuku reach out to him and pull Katsuki up to his side.

Let me heal with you. Let me help you. I'll let you help me. I'm done fighting on my own. I want to fight by your side, always.

"We won," Izuku managed between gasps, "but it doesn't feel like it."

His arm that would never be the same. His heart that had been stitched together on a battlefield. His face, which he was almost positive would be scarred for the rest of his life.

Izuku, who had lost his own arms in the middle of the battle. Izuku, who had seen Katsuki's corpse, paired with taunts and jabs from Katsuki's murderer. Izuku, who had way too many scars for someone who was just about to turn seventeen.

"You got that right, nerd."

Chapter End Notes

okay I want to start by saying I only beta read like half of this and its def not my fav chapter but I felt it was very necessary before moving forward
about OFA: I chose to have Izuku keep his quirk because it actually destroys me to think of him losing it after everything he went through. that's not to say im not a fan of him losing it in the manga because I am. I love how he uses it as a positive experience to then go on and show others that being a hero isn't about the quirk, it's about who you are.
I hope you guys enjoyed this chapter though!! please let me know what you thought and consider leaving a kudos :) it means a bunch

find me on TikTok @lvndrsunny

would you fall in love with me again

Chapter Summary

> I will fall in love with you over and over again
> I don't care how, where, or when
> no matter how long it's been, you're mine

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki had spent the rest of the day in Izuku's room, sitting in the chair beside his bed, talking about everything and nothing. When they talked about the war, they tended to fall into awkward, uneasy silence whenever the topics got too dark. Katsuki did his best to steer the conversation away from anything war related, but there was only so much he could do.

At one point, Katsuki's nurse came by to change his bandages. The process was long and arduous, moreso for her than him. His face, chest, and arm were wrapped more than anything else, and he had a few stray bandages here and there, mostly covering small gashes caused by flying debris from both his explosions and Shigaraki's destruction of the UA battleground. She unwrapped his bandages slowly and carefully, doing her best to not jostle his injured arm. Through it all, Katsuki's annoyance grew more and more. He wasn't going to *break* and fall apart.

Throughout the entire process, Izuku watched silently. For the first time that day, he was completely still, not fidgeting in his seat or tapping his fingers. A single observative green eye raked over the still-sore cuts on Katsuki's cheek, the unnatural stiffness of his arm and the deep bruises arcing up it, the stitches down the center of his chest.

Katsuki didn't balk under Izuku's gaze, and if their circumstances were different, he might have been sickly satisfied to have Izuku's attention on him and only him.

After she rewrapped him, tight enough that his bandages put a bit of pressure on his wounds, she left him and Izuku to themselves again. A few minutes of silence passed as Katsuki did his best to readjust his hospital gown with one arm. Izuku was still looking at him, but his expression was full of too many emotions for Katsuki to decode.

"Your chest… and your face…"

Katsuki sighed. He'd known this was coming; they'd been going in circles all day. Izuku blamed himself for what happened, Katsuki blamed himself for not being stronger, they both wanted the other to feel better. "Don't start, Izuku. Look at your arms."

"Your arm will have scars too, though, won't it?"

“Fucking probably. Does it look like I care?”

“But-”

Katsuki glared at him, kicking his feet up onto the edge of Izuku’s bed. “But what? We’re Heroes. Heroes get injured and scarred and whatever the fuck else. Would’ve happened eventually.”

“I just… feel bad. The wound on your face… it’ll leave a pretty bad scar.”

“Makes me look more badass.”

Izuku frowned at him in a very typical Izuku way. It was a frown, but there was a hint of Katsuki-induced amusement present on his face, even beneath all the layers of his own self-hatred.

“What? You don’t think so?”

“Like you care what I think,” Izuku retorted.

More than you think. More than I should.

Katsuki didn’t care about scars. Like he’d said, it would’ve happened one way or another. Injuries were kind of a given as a Hero, especially Heroes that leaned towards combat. Katsuki had never been one to care about his appearance much, either. He put some effort into his outfits on days where he didn’t have to wear his school uniform, and he took good care of his skin and hair. Other than that, he didn’t care how he came across. He knew that people in their class thought he was attractive, but that had never concerned him. He hadn’t been interested in anything with anybody; if they thought he was attractive, so fucking be it. He wouldn’t use it to his advantage, like some pros did. Katsuki didn’t get the whole “sex appeal” thing. Being conventionally attractive had always seemed like an odd requirement to becoming a hero.

Even when his feelings for Izuku changed from loathing caused by his own insecurities into respect and, eventually, where he was at now, he’d never cared. He didn’t want Izuku to care about the things that were surface level.

“Well, let’s hear it, nerd. You don’t think I look badass?”

Izuku shifted in his bed, pulling his knees up to his chest. He, unlike Katsuki, obeyed the very strict directions of his doctors. He’d been told not to make any rough or fast movements, and to stay in bed. “I feel guilty, that’s all.”

“How many times do I have to tell-”

“I know, I know. You don’t blame me and it wasn’t my fault and you decided to keep fighting. I *know* . But you saying it won’t make me feel less guilty. At least, not right now.”

It had only been a few days since the war. That much was glaringly obvious, considering they were sitting in a hospital room, wrapped in an absurd amount of gauze and hooked up to a

number of machines. Their wounds, both the physical ones scarring their bodies, and the mental ones that couldn't be stitched up so easily, were still fresh. Katsuki had his own shit to work through. Even if it annoyed him to hell and back that Izuku felt guilty over being separated from him on the battlefield, he got it. Maybe he understood more than anybody else ever would; he'd been battling his own feelings of regret and self hatred for the better part of the last year.

"Yeah, whatever. It could be worse."

"Saying that does *not* make me feel better."

"If you want someone to make you feel better, it's not gonna be me. I'm not good at that sappy shit."

"Kacchan, did you just say you're not good at something? Should I call the nurse?" Izuku's tone was light and mocking.

"You can call her in after I explode the rest of your hair."

Izuku lifted a self-conscious hand to the half of his head that was uncovered by bandages. Earlier that day, he'd admitted to Katsuki that half of his head had been shaved off so the doctors could stitch up the gashes on his face and forehead. It was hypocritical that Katsuki mourned the temporary loss of Izuku's hair and not the scars on his own face, but nobody needed to know.

Like he'd said. It could've been worse.

"I should make you leave when they change my bandages. It looks pretty ugly."

"Maybe you'll start a new trend."

"Right," Izuku scoffed. "You'll probably tell me how hideous I look every day until it grows back."

Katsuki looked away, his face and palms hot. He rubbed his hand on his hospital gown, trying to wipe off as much sweat as he could.

Without even meaning to, Izuku had put him back in his place. That's who Katsuki was: the asshole bully that never failed to treat Izuku like garbage.

Katsuki had never hated anyone more than he hated himself.

"I'm not that much of an asshole," he said (lied). "Besides, I'm sure all your potential girlfriends aren't vain enough to care about a haircut. It's fucking hair. Who gives a shit about it?"

"Potential girlfriends?" Izuku's face went red.

"Oh, come on, you kicked ass and beat Shigaraki. I'm sure plenty of girls back at UA will be all over you."

“ *You* defeated All For One. They’ll be after you.”

“Fuck that.”

“What, you don’t want a girlfriend to tell you how amazing you are all the time?”

Without thinking, Katsuki shot back, “Why the hell would I need a girlfriend when you already do that every damn day?”

Izuku stared at him. Katsuki stared back.

Internally, his heart slammed against his chest so hard he was afraid he would relive his death all over again. At least there wasn’t a heart monitor around to tell Izuku exactly how fast his heart was beating.

“Besides, I don’t want a fucking girlfriend.” *I want you* .

“Would she take away from your training time? And make you stay up later than nine?”

“You know what, Izuku, everyone and their mother thinks you’re *so* perfect and sweet, when really, your attitude is just as bad as mine.”

“It is *not* .”

“Uh, yeah it fucking *is* . The difference is, you don’t look like a delinquent, so when you mouth off, it’s *cute* .”

“First of all, you wouldn’t look like a delinquent if you wore a belt. And your tie. Second of all, you think it’s cute when I ‘mouth off’?” Izuku put the last part in air quotes.

“Did I say I thought it was cute?”

“Basically.”

“Think whatever the hell you want. Doesn’t change the fact that you’re just as much of an asshole as I am.”

“Didn’t you tell Kaminari that a rock has more lines in it than his brain does after he failed our Marketing and Media midterm?”

“Yeah, I fucking did. What about it?”

Izuku shook his head, but there was a small smile on his face, his shoulders shaking just a bit with laughter.

Katsuki wasn’t good at making people feel better. He didn’t know how to offer hugs or hand-holding or anything like that. He didn’t know how to talk to people about their feelings, because he’d spent so long running and hiding from his own, pushing away anything that could possibly make him weak. Just because he wasn’t conventional, though, didn’t mean he completely failed at comforting, though. Maybe it wasn’t the right approach, maybe it

wouldn't work on anyone, but snarky comments and remarks had turned Izuku's wobbly frown into a smile. He was no longer fighting off tears, but instead, laughter.

Not everybody could handle Katsuki in the way that Izuku had. And Katsuki knew, because he knew Izuku so well, that Izuku had forgiven him a long, long time ago. He knew Izuku held nothing against him, knew that Izuku was always looking for the good in everybody, even if they were an asshole. He'd started to think that, maybe, there was something in Izuku's eyes that wasn't just admiration like it had once been. Izuku didn't need a Hero to idolize anymore, not when he was one of the greatest the world had ever seen.

Katsuki had started to think it was possible that Izuku's feelings towards him had changed. Into what, he didn't really know. And after everything, Katsuki wouldn't push it. He would wait, even if it took months or years or decades, for Izuku to come to him. Maybe it wasn't right, since Izuku had already spent years waiting for Katsuki to change as a person, but Katsuki wouldn't push him. He *knew* Izuku, knew there was a high likelihood that he was too nice to reject anybody.

I want to earn it , he thought. *I don't want it by default* .

That evening, after Katsuki's parents and Inko had returned to the room, Katsuki and Izuku's nurses swung by with twin hospital trays of food that looked entirely unappetizing. Katsuki had taken a few bites of his food, wincing at the lack of flavor and texture, but he'd forced himself to swallow. He'd been serious about recovering as best as he could, and if that took eating shitty hospital food, so be it. He'd eat enough to keep him going, and eventually, he'd convince his parents to sneak him in something a little more edible.

Izuku, on the other hand, ate his entire meal, even the shitty pudding cup the nurse had given him. When Katsuki had woken up, his father had insisted that he should eat something. He'd attempted to spoon-feed pudding to Katsuki, who hadn't taken lightly to that whatsoever. It had ended up on the other side of the room, splattered on the linoleum floor.

Katsuki shoved his leftovers onto Izuku's lap. He didn't have a pudding cup of his own, and he'd probably been put on the No Pudding Cup List after the nurse had seen his reaction to it that morning, but he did have half of his meal left. Izuku needed it more than him anyways. After coming back from his month away from UA, he'd been… different. Not exactly weaker, but *worn* . Izuku had been just as muscular as before he'd left, considering how he'd still been kicking ass out there, but his body had seemed so exhausted. Katsuki knew he hadn't been eating nearly as much as he needed to.

Izuku opened his mouth to argue, but Katsuki didn't give him the chance. "Stuff tastes like shit. Ruined my appetite."

"It wasn't *that* bad."

"That meal was an insult to food."

"Kacchan, be nice."

"The food doesn't have fucking feelings, Izuku."

Izuku just shook his head, picking at Katsuki's leftovers, before scarfing them down just as quickly as he had his own meal.

After finishing his food, Izuku almost immediately fell asleep. Katsuki had been in the middle of complaining about how his nurse had asked if he needed help using the restroom that afternoon, when he looked over and noticed that Izuku's eye had slipped shut. His chest was rising and falling in a slow, steady rhythm, his neck bent at an awkward angle.

He glanced out into the hallway. His parents and Inko had stepped out a few minutes earlier with Katsuki and Izuku's doctors respectively. On the other side of the curtain separating them from All Might, the former Pro was talking on the phone, his words unclear.

Katsuki reached out slowly, letting his fingers brush against the skin of Izuku's cheek, before allowing his palm to cup Izuku's face. Every tiny point of contact set his nerves on fire, more intense than any explosion.

Awkwardly, Katsuki did his best to shift Izuku's head into a more comfortable position, swearing under his breath at his bum arm. Being around Izuku for the day had distracted him from reality; it had been easy to forget that they would both be discharged from the hospital with permanent reminders of the war. It had been only a few days out of the rest of their lives. This had only been one day of healing shared between the two of them. Katsuki was almost positive the rest of them wouldn't be so easy and full of conversations and banter.

He tugged Izuku's blanket up to his chin, pushing a few of his green curls up and off his forehead. In that moment, everything in the entire world was okay. They had both survived. They would overcome what had happened to them. They would get better.

Katsuki refused to coddle Izuku in the way the rest of the hospital staff and Inko did. Izuku did his best to smile gratefully at each and every person who helped him, and while he did seem as if every ounce of energy had been leached from his body, Katsuki could tell it bothered him to lose his independence. Izuku wasn't like Katsuki, though; Katsuki didn't hesitate to bite back at his nurses when they were overbearing and fussy. He didn't need a group of people worrying over him every single second of the day. If he could fight in the war, he could handle the goddamn recovery.

Izuku also wouldn't ask for the small things. He wouldn't be an inconvenience to anybody, and he would rather suffer in silence than cause problems. Even after all of his classmates had fought to bring him back, even after Katsuki's apology and Uraraka's speech, Izuku still didn't know how to let other people help him.

So Katsuki helped in small ways, with gestures that he masked with indifference or irritation. The nurses could coddle and Inko could hover over Izuku's every movement, and yet, Katsuki knew how to handle him better than any of them. He knew how to help Izuku without setting off his sixth sense of being a burden or making him feel useless. Because Izuku had proven that he was far from it.

Mitsuki and Masaru wrangled Katsuki back to his own room later that evening. He'd wanted to argue, had felt panic set into his bones at the thought of being separated from Izuku again. Nothing good happened when they were apart, as history suggested. His heart slammed against his chest, his palms grew sweaty, he felt the sudden urge to *fight them* -

"He'll be here in the morning," Inko said, her tone surprisingly gentle. She clearly had her own feelings about Katsuki, whether or not Izuku held their past against him. But in that moment, she seemed so *motherly* ; her tone comforted him just enough for his mother to tug him out of the chair and towards the door.

"I need to-"

"There's nothing to worry about," she assured him. "There's no more villains to fight. There's nobody after him anymore. The hospital is being guarded at all times."

"What if-"

"Katsuki," she said softly, "I know exactly what you're thinking. And I know you feel like you need to be by his side when his guard is down so you can protect him. It's how I felt when those villains attacked UA, and then when you got kidnapped. I told him he wasn't allowed to go back to UA because I couldn't stand seeing him get hurt."

"That went well," he scoffed.

She ignored him. "There's more to healing than what's on the outside," she said. And then, shockingly, she stretched up and wrapped her arms around Katsuki, pulling him into a hug. She was warm against him, and she smelled just like he remembered the Midoriya home smelling when he was younger. A wave of nostalgia almost knocked him off his feet. On top of that, he went stiff at the sudden, unexpected contact. She'd been regarding him warily throughout the entire day, and he couldn't even blame her for it. "I don't just mean for him. But you two can't rely on each other. Okay?"

"Yeah, I get it," he muttered, disentangling himself from her hug. He'd never been a touchy person, and Inko was the last person he had expected a hug from.

"I'm really happy you're okay, Katsuki," she said, and he believed her. The Midoriyas didn't lie, certainly not about their emotions.

"Yeah," Katsuki said awkwardly. "Thanks."

The longer Katsuki was in the hospital, the more agitated he became. Every day followed the same routine: wake up, swallow a handful of pills, sneak to Izuku's room, eat breakfast, get his bandages changed, get checked by his doctor, lunch, an afternoon of talking or shitty movies, dinner, then back to his own room for bed. Sometimes, he got visitors. Usually, it was only his parents, and they'd come for a few hours in the afternoon, during which he'd reluctantly trudge back to his own room. Every once in a while, it was one or a few of his friends. Kirishima and Mina stopped by more than the rest of them. Jirou was still in the

hospital after having one of her earphone jacks cut off by All For One, and Kaminari was spending a lot of time with him. Sero stopped by here and there, too, but none of Katsuki's friends ever stayed too long. They were all quiet and unsure of how to handle him, and it pissed him off to no end.

Time crawled by at the slowest rate Katsuki had ever been subjected to. Everything in the entire hospital pissed him off. The food, the bland white tiles, the scratchy blankets, the uncomfortable mattress. The only bright spot in the damn place was Izuku.

As the days passed slowly, Katsuki's doctors began weaning him off some of his medications. He started to reacquaint himself with the tightness in his muscles and the sting of his wounds. His chest felt tight and his stitches pulled painfully every once in a while. His arm was numb half the time and ache-y the other half. He could barely move his fingers in his sling, and, though he'd never admit it, he broke down around the one week mark.

He'd known, from that very first day of being treated, that the damage to his arm would be permanent. Somehow, it just hadn't seemed *real* .

But the days had passed. His pain didn't fade. He couldn't clench his fingers into a fist. Sometimes, he could barely even feel his arm at all.

Then there were the memories.

Throughout the first few days, he'd suspected that he'd been put on at least one anxiety medication. In all his life, he'd never felt so *relaxed* . He hadn't even taken proper stock of the gravity of his situation.

Now that the medication was wearing off, everything was hitting Katsuki all at once. The thoughts he'd had in his final moments. The pain that had been so all-consuming up until the very end. The feeling of dying, of the heat and blood seeping out of his body, the cold ground beneath his body, the rain drenching his skin.

Sometimes, it caught Katsuki off guard.

He'd been standing in the shower one day when the water went cold, and in that moment, his entire body was overwhelmed by panic. He wasn't standing under the shower head in the most secure hospital in Japan. He was laying on the ground, his heart was failing, his eyes were searching desperately for a flash of green. The water dripping down over him was rain, freezing cold rain, soaking his skin and his hair and his hero costume. He was choking, he was choking on words he wanted to say, he was choking on regrets, he was choking on the air that he was trying to bring into his lungs-

Some nights, he woke up, his heart pounding so hard against his chest, his breathing ragged, a hand clutched over his heart. He could hear a grating voice, could feel Shigaraki's hand around his throat or his foot pressing Katsuki's face into the dirt. He could remember his panic at being separated from Izuku, his pain and weariness, his fear, his all-consuming regret as he died.

He felt so unbearably *weak* . He was Bakugou Katsuki, he shouldn't be waking up terrified of dying again. He shouldn't be letting some dumbass villain plague his nightmares. He should be back at UA already, not sitting around in a hospital bed.

Being in the hospital had him in a state of borderline panic. He'd spent the last two months living on the edge, in one sense or another. First, it had been preparations for Jaku. Then, he'd spent a month planning and searching for Izuku. After he'd gotten Izuku back, he'd been so laser-focused on preparing for the war. He'd spent his days sparring or working on upgrades to his gear. When he wasn't doing that, he had been strategizing, learning as much as he possibly could about the villains they were facing.

He'd been so battle-honed, so conditioned to think in terms of war and fighting, that he'd forgotten what it was like to live normally. He was stressed about the fact that there was nothing for him to stress over.

Both he and Izuku had been banned from watching any footage from the war. Somehow, both of their phones couldn't load any videos from the war, and just about every single news site had been blocked from both of their phones. Katsuki figured that it had been a mixture of Aizawa and their parents, who were insistent that it was way too early for them to watch anything.

Katsuki had wanted to watch, though, for a number of reasons. First and foremost, he wanted to evaluate himself, to see how he'd fought and what mistakes he had made. He'd wanted to see Izuku fight, too, and selfishly, he'd wanted to see how Izuku had reacted to him dying. When they'd talked, that very first day, about Katsuki dying, it had resulted in a torrent of tears from Izuku. They hadn't really talked about it since.

The only time Katsuki's mind wasn't reliving his last moments was when he was with Izuku. Thankfully, since their rooms were on the same floor and their nurses had long since given up on keeping them apart, that was more often than not.

They spent their days watching Hero movies, with Katsuki sitting in the chair by Izuku's bed. After the first few days of that routine, Izuku shifted over as far as he could and demanded that Katsuki sit beside him.

"That chair has to be killing your back. And I bet your angle on the TV is terrible from over there."

Katsuki had scoffed, but he'd sunk down onto the bed beside Izuku, his back and shoulders thanking him as he leaned back against the pillows.

There went his heartbeat again, so fast and pronounced.

Being around Izuku like this had made him acutely aware of just how deep his own feelings went. He found every little thing Izuku did endearing. Every time Izuku smiled, Katsuki wanted to take a picture. Every time Izuku laughed, he wanted to get drunk on the sound of it. Every time Katsuki forgot about their history and the things he had done, he thought there might be a chance for them to be happy together.

Because they knew each other better than anyone else. Izuku had known that Katsuki's back was hurting, and that he was too stubborn to mention it. Katsuki knew when Izuku was overthinking the tiniest things, and he knew how to bring him out of it. He knew Izuku's habits and his routines and *everything* .

Sometimes, Katsuki caught Izuku watching him instead of the movie. Sometimes, Katsuki watched Izuku, and the TV served as background noise.

Maybe that was how things were to be between them. One always watching the other. Whether it was in moments of rivalry, or of sacrifice, or of respect, or of something *more* , they were always watching each other.

Katsuki knew he didn't deserve it. And they still hadn't had that emotion-talk that Izuku had asked about before the war. But sometimes, when he was alone, he let his mind wander. He let himself think about the what-ifs.

In any other circumstance, he would have been up front about his feelings. He'd never been one to beat around the bush, or to wait around and find out. He'd never been taught how to sit back and let things come to him; he'd always been pushing his way to the front of everything.

This was different. Izuku made him different.

If it had been anyone else, Katsuki probably would have been up front about it. But not with Izuku.

Katsuki would wait and wait and wait. He would grovel and earn. He would work on himself, he would fix the parts of himself that needed it. All for Izuku.

He knew he didn't deserve forgiveness. He knew he was beyond redemption. But those weren't the things that he wanted. He knew Izuku forgave him, knew that Izuku didn't even see him as needing to be redeemed in the first place. But that's how Izuku saw everybody, and Katsuki wanted Izuku to see him as *more* .

After a week and a half since they had both woken up, they were sitting side by side in Izuku's bed. All Might had been discharged a few days earlier, and the room belonged entirely to them. They'd both been able to take their bandages off, and they had similar scars marring their cheeks. Even with the scar, Katsuki still thought Izuku was beautiful. He was the epitome of what Katsuki wanted. His scars only marked him as *strong* , not as someone who hadn't been strong enough. Izuku was soft and emotional and thoughtful and compassionate, and all of those things added to his strength.

"I talked to Todoroki today," Izuku said, turning a bit to face Katsuki. "He said the dorms will be reopening this week."

"Fuck him," Katsuki grumbed. "That asshole gets to sleep in a real bed. With blankets that don't feel like sandpaper."

"You should be discharged soon though, right? Your heart is stable, and they can't really start therapy on your arm until after the bones heal."

“Fucking hopefully. This place is making me lose my mind.”

Izuku smiled. “Yeah, I guess. I never thought I’d miss studying so much.”

“Damn right. The only shit I get to see are those stupid ass movies you pick.”

“They aren’t *stupid* , Kacchan. They’re good.”

“Whatever you say, nerd.”

Izuku laughed quietly, falling back into easy silence. He put another movie on the TV, but this was another day in which Katsuki couldn’t seem to look away from Izuku’s face.

“When we go back to the dorms,” Izuku murmured suddenly, “what do *we* do?”

“Uh, get a good night’s sleep? Eat real fucking food?”

“I meant… us.”

Katsuki watched him, waiting for him to explain.

“I just… I don’t want to sound stupid and you can tell me to shut up if you want but everything has been changing between us and then Jaku happened and then I… I went away for that month and I felt like, after you apologized, like I finally understood you more than I did before. And I never expected or wanted you to change in the first place, but you *did* because you wanted to, and you were so… you were so *amazing* . And that week, before the war, when we trained together, I felt so happy. Because I couldn’t believe that I got so lucky to have you in my life. Like, *really* in my life.”

Katsuki’s face was probably redder than Izuku’s damn tennis shoes. He looked away, gripping the arm of the bed with his good hand, his knuckles white.

“And now, we’ve been spending all this time together, and you’ve really been helping me feel better ever since everything that happened, and I… I don’t want things to go back to the way they were before. I want us to keep being like this.”

Do you want us to stay like this or do you want more, too?

“I get it, nerd.”

“I didn’t mean to be weird, or to scare you off, or-”

“Izuku. Chill the hell out. I told you I get it.”

“So what do we do? When we go back?”

Katsuki finally looked back at Izuku, his breath catching slightly as he met his gaze. He’d missed the full force of Izuku’s eyes when one had been covered, twin green and so unbelievably captivating. He was drawn towards Izuku, moving forward imperceptibly, pulled into Izuku’s orbit. He wondered how close was too close, how close he could get

without Izuku reading him for how he felt. Katsuki's eyes roamed over Izuku's features, memorizing the outline of the scar now residing on his cheek. His gaze flicked down, so briefly, to Izuku's lips, pink and chapped.

When Katsuki glanced back up, Izuku was watching him. He couldn't read Izuku's expression. He swallowed.

"Kacchan?"

"How the fuck am I supposed to know? We're not back there yet so why the fuck does it matter?"

Izuku blinked at him in surprise, scooting back until he hit the rail of the bed. As he moved, his leg pulled away from where it had been pressed against Katsuki's.

Katsuki's tone had been sharp and biting in a way it hadn't been with Izuku for so long. But he couldn't let Izuku see through him, he couldn't let Izuku know how he actually felt, he couldn't let Izuku use it against him.

Not him. Not Izuku. He wouldn't do that .

But, in the back of his mind, there was the same sense of insecurity that had been plaguing him for the last year. Now, though, instead of his fear of his weaknesses in the way of being a hero being exploited by Izuku's strengths, he was afraid of being made weak due to his feelings. The minute Izuku found out he could use Katsuki's feelings against him, he could weaponize them just as Shigaraki had.

And as much as he hated to admit, Katsuki was *scared* . He'd escaped death before, and he wasn't intent on throwing himself right back into its path. He'd let himself get closer to Izuku. So close that other people had realized it, that *villains* had realized it.

And worse than villains using Katsuki's feelings for Izuku against Katsuki, was the possibility of those very feelings being used to hurt Izuku.

Katsuki had faced and survived death. He'd spent what had felt like hours in agony on that battlefield, the life seeping out of him, wanting only for Izuku to make it out of the war, to *survive* , to be *okay* . Because everything he had been through was okay if it meant that Izuku made it out, that he was *safe* .

The League is gone. Nobody is coming to get us. We're safe. Izuku's safe.

Then Katsuki scoffed. He wasn't afraid of shit. Not some fuck ass villains or even dying. Because, at the end of the day, they had both survived and they were both *strong* . If anyone wanted to come for them, if anyone ever wanted to use Katsuki as a weapon to hurt Izuku ever again, he would be ready. He wouldn't fail this time. And he wouldn't wait around, insecure and afraid.

He turned to Izuku, who was still looking at him in shock, his mouth slightly parted and his eyebrows furrowed.

Katsuki reached out with his good hand, tracing the back of Izuku's hand slowly. He followed the lines of Izuku's scars, running his finger over each and every pale swatch of skin. Beneath him, he swore he felt Izuku shudder, letting out a small, gaspy breath.

He turned Izuku's hand over, letting his fingers ghost over the lines of Izuku's palm as lightly as he could. A wave of nostalgia rocked his body, reminding him of when Izuku had done this to him. His world had been focused entirely on every single point where their skin touched. There had been nothing in Katsuki's brain, other than the fact that Izuku was touching him so gently, as if Katsuki was worthy of it.

He followed Izuku's scars up his forearm and over his bicep, where they disappeared beneath the sleeve of his hospital gown. And finally, finally, he reached Izuku's cheek, where freckles were interrupted by a jagged line of scar tissue.

Izuku was so still beneath his fingers, barely even breathing. His eyes were locked onto Katsuki's face, though Katsuki never once met his gaze.

"Kacchan?" Izuku said again, but it came out as barely a whisper.

It wasn't enough, this wasn't enough, it would never be enough for Katsuki.

Still, he let his hand drop back to the bed, back to a scratchy blanket that could never compare to the feeling of Izuku's warm skin.

"I should go back to my room," he said, his voice tight. "See you tomorrow."

Chapter End Notes

im so sorry this chapter took longer than usual buuuut college kicked my ass this week. next chapter may also take a while but should definitely be worth it ;) I've also been working on top of school which has been killing me but its okay its okay no big deal
hope everyone enjoyed the Super Bowl (I didn't even watch it besides halftime and the first quarter)
love u guys sm!!!
find me on TikTok @lvndrsunny

casual

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki's time in the hospital stretched on and on and on. More check-ups by doctors, more shitty meals, more awkward visits from his parents and his friends.

For two days, Katsuki stayed away from Izuku's room. The days had been awful and long, bleak in the face of the days he had spent with Izuku. But he didn't go back. He knew it made him a coward, to hide from a situation that his own feelings had created. Every possible scenario ran through his mind; Izuku hating him, or figuring out how he felt, or even him not caring at all that Katsuki had stayed away.

On the second day, Kirishima, Kaminari, Mina, Sero, and Jirou showed up to visit.

"Hey, man," Kirishima said, pulling a chair up beside Katsuki's bed. Mina sat at Katsuki's feet with Jirou, and Kaminari and Sero argued over who got the last chair. "We stopped in Midoriya's room on the way here. He said he hasn't seen you in a while."

There was a knowing look in Kirishima's eyes, a suspicion that irked Katsuki to no end. Fuck his friends for actually giving a damn about his feelings.

"It's been two fucking days. Tell him he's a clingy piece of shit."

" *You* tell him," Mina said. "Or is there a reason why you aren't visiting anymore?"

"Who the hell said I'm not visiting anymore? Who's to say I wasn't planning on going there today? And why the fuck do *I* have to visit *him* ? His legs work just fine."

"Touchy," Kaminari muttered. Katsuki glared at him until he raised his hands in surrender.

"But you weren't going to visit him today, were you?" Mina asked, her eyebrows pulled together. "Did something happen?"

"What the hell could have happened in a hospital?" Katsuki was almost tempted to call his nurse and tell him that his visitors were disrupting his recovery.

"Did you two fight?" Kirishima asked. "Because that's not cool. You both need to focus on healing, not picking at each other."

"Holy shit, no, we didn't fight."

"Then what happened?" Mina asked. "Did you two kiss?"

"The *fuck* ?"

"Did you?"

“No, we did fucking *not* .”

“But you want to kiss him, right?”

“Get the fuck out of my room.”

“Dude, your face is red as hell,” Sero said.

“Guys,” Kirishima scolded, “don’t pick on him.”

“Kirishima to the rescue,” Jirou said. “How many times has he picked on us? Or been a complete dick to literally everyone? He deserves it.”

“Oh, fuck you, Ears.”

“Yeah, right back at you.”

“I really want to know what happened,” Mina whined. “There’s serious money on the line here, Blasty.”

“Why don’t you walk down the hall and ask Izuku what happened if you want to know so bad?”

“Oh, we did,” Kaminari said, a grin spreading across his face. “We just wanted to hear your side.”

At that, Katsuki’s heart sped up in his chest.

Izuku hadn’t come to Katsuki’s room. Katsuki had no idea what he was thinking.

He’d touched Izuku’s scars and face like a fucking weirdo, had been so close to leaning into him and taking what he’d been wanting for so long. But he’d been scared. He’d been a coward, just like he always had been. He’d been afraid of the consequences that would follow a decision like that, and he was scared of losing Izuku, of pushing him away.

“Well?” he snapped. “What the hell did he say?”

“He got all flustered and said that nothing happened and that he figured you needed space,” Kirishima said, shrugging. “But we kind of figured something had to have happened for you to stay away.”

“He’s damn right I needed space.”

“Right,” Jirou scoffed.

Before he could snap at her, Mina said, “He was *very* flustered, though. Which leads me to believe that *something* happened.”

“Maybe you should talk to him,” Kirishima said, sending Mina a warning look. She pouted back at him. “You’ve been there every day and now you’re suddenly avoiding him?”

I'm scared of going after what I want because I'm scared of losing him but when I'm with him I can't even think.

"You aren't my fucking therapist, Shitty Hair."

"No, but I'm your friend. And I'm his friend."

Katsuki looked away, his skin crawling with irritation. He couldn't even escape from Izuku when he tried to hide from him.

"If you all leave me the fuck alone about it, I'll go talk to him right now."

"Only if we get details," Mina squealed.

"Fuck off."

Days in the hospital bled into each other. Katsuki had spent months fighting and training and dying. Recovery, compared to the rest of it, was so oddly peaceful. It seemed like a fragment of his life that didn't fit in with the past year.

The hospital staff did their best to give him things to do that both benefited his recovery and kept him from blowing things up out of sheer boredom. He'd been given a few exercises to do as his arm healed, though it still hung uselessly in a sling. He was allowed to run on one of the treadmills two floors up from him, which at least kept him in good shape. He'd managed to convince his mother to bring him a video game console, and before he'd fucked everything up, him and Izuku had spent hours every day playing various games. Sometimes, they'd played against each other, arguing and shouting until a nurse came in to yell at them. Other times, since Katsuki only had one working arm, they shared the controller; Katsuki would hold one half and Izuku the other.

Slowly, Katsuki stopped feeling so on-edge. He didn't check behind every door or obsessively stare out his window in anticipation of an attack. When the nurses cracked his door open, he stopped jumping reflexively into a fighting stance.

Sleep wasn't easy, though. It was the one and only time in which Katsuki wasn't completely in control. When he slipped into his dreams, he couldn't repress the moments from the past few months that haunted him.

Screaming, blood, dying, fighting, pain, yearning, aching, dying, blood, rain, guilt, regret, regret, regret.

Some nights, he was spared and his dreams were bleak and empty. Other nights, he woke up drenched in his own sweat.

His nightmares were variations of the events that had happened on the day of his death. Sometimes, he relived the entire battle. Shigaraki's hand wrapped around his throat, snapping his arm, his cold foot pressing Katsuki's face into the dirt. Some nights, he was on the

battlefield, dying over and over and over again, feeling every ounce of pain that his adrenaline had repressed.

On the worst nights, he dreamed of Izuku being the one who had suffered and died. Katsuki was forced to watch as Izuku's arm was destroyed, as he was humiliated and thrown aside like garbage. Katsuki was forced to watch as both his blood and life seeped out of him, and he was left empty and dead in the rain.

His anger grew every single day. In school, he'd been able to spar or train to expel some of his frustrations. In the hospital, it was pretty frowned upon to blow things up as a coping mechanism.

He was angry with himself, for his numerous shortcomings and his own cowardice in the face of something as stupid as *feelings* . He was angry at his arm, for being dead weight at his side. He was angry at UA, for teaching him and Izuku how to be weapons, but not how to heal.

At the end of the day, he *was* traumatized. He knew he was. He knew he couldn't pretend like the war had never happened, or that he had never died. He couldn't push those thoughts away from himself and ignore how he felt. On the other side of it, he knew Izuku felt the same way. Ever since the first day in the hospital, Izuku had been a more reserved version of himself. Less mumbling, less smiles, less… Izuku-like.

Katsuki knew that Izuku was still holding onto the guilt of Katsuki's death. He knew that Izuku, three doors down, was probably also reliving Katsuki's death every time he closed his eyes and tried to sleep.

With his mind no longer occupied by training and strategizing to fight against the world's most dangerous group of villains, every single one of his thoughts strayed toward things he would rather forget. Katsuki had lost his ability to exist as something other than a weapon. Classes hadn't started back up yet, so he couldn't throw himself head first into studying, and his body was still crawling its way back towards full health, so most physical activity was out of the question. Outside of his academics and training, Katsuki hadn't done much before the war.

He wanted out of the hospital, he wanted his thoughts to quiet, he wanted to be able to stay by Izuku's side without being afraid of his own feelings.

The day after Kirishima and the rest of Katsuki's friends had visited, he found his way down the hall to Izuku's room. Katsuki didn't knock, but he felt unusually awkward as he pushed the door open and walked into Izuku's room.

During their first and even second week, Izuku's room had been flooded constantly by visitors. His mother practically lived by his bedside, and All Might, who had been transferred into a different room after a week, had been a frequent visitor. After most of their classmates had healed, a lot of them had visited Izuku on many occasions.

Uraraka, Todoroki, and Iida had been there the most out of any of their class. Uraraka had suffered multiple major stab wounds during her battle with Toga, which had ultimately ended

in Toga performing an impromptu blood transplant to save Uraraka's life. It was a little too similar to Edgeshot's heart surgery for Katsuki's comfort.

Todoroki had also suffered serious injuries during his fight with his estranged brother, but his body had been built for tolerating intense temperatures on both ends of the spectrum, so his healing had been smooth. Iida, who'd gotten Todoroki to his brother, had damaged his engines and had been monitored closely by his doctors to make sure he didn't suffer long-term effects from overusing his quirk.

But, with UA students being enlisted to help with war reparations, visitors became few and far between. Izuku's mother had gone back to work, and still visited every day but for only a few hours in the evening. Katsuki's own parents visited only a few times a week, depending on their schedules; it's not like he cared, though. He couldn't stand their fussing when they did show up.

"Kacchan?"

"Hey, nerd," he said, sitting in the empty chair beside Izuku's bed.

Izuku gazed at him like he had two heads for a few seconds, until Katsuki shot him a glare and his expression morphed into a smile. "I thought you got discharged and didn't tell me."

"Right," he muttered, reaching out and shoving Izuku's head. He'd missed the feeling of soft green locks beneath his fingers. "Like you didn't walk past my room like a stalker ten times a day."

"You *saw* me?"

Katsuki smirked. "Caught your ass."

Izuku glared at him, but it held no real anger. "You would've said goodbye."

"If you think so then why'd you have to check?" he challenged.

Izuku looked away from him, his face going red. His hair was starting to grow back in uneven patches where it had been shaved away. Katsuki was tempted to run his fingers over the clumps that had yet to develop into the curls that spotted the rest of his head. "I wasn't- I mean, I was, but- but I didn't think you actually got discharged without saying bye. You're not… I mean-"

"I'm not that much of an asshole?"

"I wasn't going to-"

A year ago, Katsuki was definitely that much of an asshole. He wouldn't have even considered saying goodbye to Izuku.

He'd apologized to Izuku a little over a month ago, though it still felt like he needed to say it again and again and again, until Izuku knew exactly how Katsuki felt and how much he regretted the person he'd been.

“I *was* an asshole. In middle school. Probably before that too. And at the beginning of the year, at UA.” He met Izuku’s gaze and refused to look away. Green eyes stared back at him, wide and welcoming, and so full of acceptance for the things that Katsuki was yet to say. “And I already said that I’m sorry. I am sorry. And I know your stupid ass will get all emotional and say ‘it’s okay’ and whatever other bullshit you’ll say. But I mean it, Izuku. That’s not who I am anymore.”

Izuku smiled at him, his eyes watery. “I know-”

“Fuck, Izuku, I’m trying really hard.” He rubbed a hand over his face, trying to hide the heat that was spreading over his cheeks. “And if I fuck up and make mistakes, or if I act like a dick, then *tell me* . I want to do better.” What he didn’t say was that he wanted to do better *for Izuku* .

A few silent tears escaped from Izuku’s wet eyes. “I don’t… you don’t have to… I don’t want you to change.”

“I’m not doing it for you, fuckhead,” he lied. “You’re just the only asshole that’ll tell me straight.”

“That’s not true,” Izuku argued. “Kirishima and all your other friends, they’re always telling you when you’re being an asshole.”

“Yeah, fuck them,” he said, propping his legs up on Izuku’s bed. His feet rested against Izuku’s thigh. “It’s different when you do it.”

“What, it pisses you off more?”

Katsuki smirked. “Yeah. Pisses me off that you’re right.”

Izuku was quiet for a few moments, looking down at his lap with an expression that Katsuki couldn’t read. He wanted to reach out and turn Izuku’s face towards him, so he could figure out what was going on behind his eyes.

“I was so jealous when we came to UA,” Izuku admitted, laughing quietly. “Of them.”

“Of who?”

“Kirishima and Kaminari. And Sero and Mina, too. Sometimes I still am.”

“The fuck are you jealous of those assholes for?”

Izuku ran a hand through his hair, exhaling a long, loud breath. Finally, he said, “You’re so *stupid* , Kacchan.”

Katsuki hadn’t been expecting that, and he laughed. For the first time in three long days, he laughed genuinely. For the first time in two months, he started to relax. “Fuck you. You’re stupid.”

“I wanted to be your friend for so long. When we were kids, after you started hating me. And in middle school. I wanted to go back to when we would watch All Might movies together and dream of being heroes. And I never understood why you hated me so much just for being quirkless.”

Katsuki bit his lip and looked away.

“We came to UA, and I had a quirk, and I thought *maybe* , you’d talk to me again. You’d start to respect me now that I had a quirk. But you still hated me, even though I was powerful. And I understood why, because you thought I’d been hiding a quirk from you our whole lives. But I couldn’t understand how things with you and them were so *easy* . You laughed with them and hung out with them and you were so close with Kirishima and-”

“I told you I was a dick. I can’t go back and change it.”

He couldn’t fault Izuku for talking about the things that Katsuki had done over the years, but his skin crawled when he thought of all the times he had fucked up and what he could have done instead. Where would they be if Katsuki had respected Izuku’s dreams from the start, way back when they were children? What if, instead of seeing Izuku’s strengths as something that made Katsuki weak, he’d seen them as motivation? They could have been working together, towards the same goal, for their entire lives. If Katsuki had gotten over himself, everything could have been different.

“I wanted you to care about me like you cared about him,” Izuku murmured.

Like a friend.

Kirishima and Kaminari and Sero and Mina were Katsuki’s *friends* . He didn’t feel the same way when he was with his friends as he did with Izuku. He didn’t feel like fleeing from them, or like he wanted to spend the rest of his life caught in their orbit. He didn’t throw himself into danger without stopping to think when they were involved. He wouldn’t give up his life for them like he had for Izuku.

Izuku wanted friendship from Katsuki, and Katsuki couldn’t give it to him. He didn’t know how to be Izuku’s friend, after so many years of animosity between them, and he didn’t know how to be Izuku’s friend after falling in love with him. He couldn’t go back to their easy competitiveness after everything that had happened. He couldn’t spar with Izuku and pretend like every moment between them didn’t leave him wanting more, wanting things that he couldn’t have.

Sitting here, in this room, with Izuku, was a mistake. Coming here had been a mistake. Having this conversation had been a *mistake* . These days in the hospital hadn’t been enough, and Katsuki was greedy, and it was getting harder and harder to be selfless.

He was only just standing from his chair when a hand locked his wrist. He could feel Izuku’s scars, rough against Katsuki’s skin.

“Are you going to leave and not come back for another three days?” Izuku asked.

“Let go,” he snapped, yanking his wrist away, but Izuku held tight,

“Why do you do this? You ran away before, after touching my scars, and I don’t *get it* , Kacchan.”

“Just fucking let go of me, Izuku.”

If anything, Izuku’s grip tightened. “Are you mad at me? For saying that you’re stupid? Or for saying you were a dick back then?”

“No, Izuku, I-”

“I’m tired of acting like everything is okay. We haven’t even talked about the war, Kacchan. We haven’t even talked about what *happened* .”

“I don’t want to fucking talk to you about that.” Katsuki finally yanked his wrist away, but he couldn’t bring himself to leave the room. Izuku’s glare had glued Katsuki’s feet to the ground. “I don’t want to hear whatever bullshit you’ll pull about how it was *your fault-* ”

“I saw you,” Izuku breathed. “I saw you *die* . I saw you bleed out. I saw Edgeshot bring you back. I watched him make your heart start beating again.”

“Izuku-”

“You can say whatever you want about me blaming myself, but I *wasn’t there* . I wasn’t there and you died, Kacchan. Sometimes, I can’t even believe you’re still alive. I’m scared I’m just imagining you.”

“Not your fucking fault, Izuku. Blame that crusty ass bastard.”

“I don’t care who’s fault it is.” More tears slipped down Izuku’s face, dotting his blue hospital gown. “None of that matters. What matters is that you were right in front of me and you were *dead* . I thought… I thought- I can’t, I-”

Izuku’s breathing sped up, tiny gasps as he tried to control it. Against his better judgement, Katsuki sat back down.

This was fucking hard. He’d fought in a war, he’d fought against All For One, and yet, he’d put this above Izuku. Whatever had been going on between them over the last few weeks was harder to navigate than the front lines of battle.

“I just… I… I can’t stop seeing it. I can’t stop seeing *you* .”

“I’m alive. I’m right here,” he said.

“Yeah, and you seem fine. Like none of it ever happened. You’re nicer, sure, but you seem perfectly fine and I just don’t get it, Kacchan. How does none of this affect you? How is it so *easy* for you?”

Katsuki took a deep breath.

He wanted to be better. He wanted to do better, for Izuku. All of it had been for Izuku. He wouldn't keep letting Izuku down; he would spend the rest of his life making things right.

"I'm not perfectly fine, Izuku. Don't be an idiot."

"You act like it."

"If I sat here and cried over it every damn day, would that make you feel better?" he snapped.

"Kacchan-"

"I can't stop thinking about it, Izuku. When I'm not with you, it's all I fucking think about."

"You-"

"You might have seen me die, but I *lived* it. And it's not your fucking fault, so don't be stupid about it. But do you know how it feels, to die knowing how much time you spent fucking things up and being an asshole? All I could think about was-"

He stopped himself, his breathing heavy. Izuku was watching him, his eyes still full of tears.

"I was dying and all I could think about was how much I fucked up everything."

"You didn't," Izuku said, shaking his head. "You were going to UA, just like you always wanted. You were on track to become a Pro."

"That's not what I mean, Izuku. You know that's not what I mean."

Izuku didn't say anything. They sat in silence and Katsuki counted the seconds, trying and failing to calm his heart down.

It would have been so easy to wake up in the hospital and blame Izuku for everything. It would have been easy to pretend like Katsuki's left arm didn't work because of Izuku. It would have been easy to push the blame onto anyone that wasn't himself.

But doing things the easy way hadn't gotten Katsuki as far as he had wanted. He was tired of taking the easy way out when it came to his feelings. It always came back to bite him in the ass later on.

I'm not him anymore. I'm not like that anymore. I don't want to be like that anymore.

"You've *changed* , Kacchan. It doesn't matter what happened before."

"None of it matters to you, Izuku? Are you that fucking forgiving?"

"Do you want me to hate you?"

"You should."

"I could never hate you."

“Because you’re stupid.”

“Maybe I hate you a little bit.”

“Right, Izuku. That’s why you missed me so much when I didn’t come visit.”

“Did *not* .”

“Did *too* .”

Katsuki and Izuku were released the same day. Inko had shown up at the hospital in record time, and Izuku had been whisked away before Katsuki could say goodbye. Katsuki’s parents hadn’t been far behind, and he’d changed into the clothes they’d brought him as they filled out paperwork and went over the details of his follow-up appointments with one of the medical assistants.

He’d been allowed to return to the dorms, though his parents hadn’t been too fond of the idea. But Katsuki refused to go back to his house to be babied and fussed over. They dropped him off at the school gates, and argued with him that they should at least help him get settled back in, to which he waved them off with his good hand and headed back to the dorms.

It was weird, entering the bedroom that he’d spent so much of the last year in. Everything was the same; his few posters still clung to the walls, his clothes were still folded in his drawers, and a textbook still lay open on his desk.

The room was untouched by the war that raged in Katsuki’s mind constantly. There was no evidence of the horrors that he had seen. His bloody uniform had been stripped away and discarded at the hospital, and the vast majority of his gear had been destroyed. None of it had been dropped off at his dorm.

He stood in the center of the room, feeling misplaced in a space that was entirely his own. Like the rest of the world had kept moving while he’d been dying. His room and possessions hadn’t died with him. Everything was still intact.

The thought should have comforted him, that he could die and return to his bedroom like nothing had ever happened. But it only made him think of what would have happened if he hadn’t been revived. An image flashed in his head, of his mother and father tearfully sorting through his dorm. He could imagine his mother getting angry and refusing to take part in it, and his father, as he always did, would pick up the pieces.

How many boxes would they fill? How much of his stuff would have been thrown out or donated? How much of it would collect dust, because it reminded them of him? *What* would even remind them of him?

Katsuki’s life, in the grand scheme of things, felt flimsy and expendable. Class 1-A would have noticed his loss, as would his parents and the rest of his family, but the majority of the world would have kept spinning as if nothing had ever happened.

There was a knock at his door, even though he'd left it slightly ajar when he'd first walked in. He almost didn't turn around to look, because there was only one person it would be.

"It's weird, isn't it?" Izuku asked, taking a few tentative steps into the room. Katsuki realized that Izuku had never been in his dorm. "That everything was… normal at one point?"

"If normal's what you want to call it," he snorted. Katsuki closed the textbook on his desk and stacked it with the rest of his books. He turned towards his bed, which he'd made right before leaving for Troy. It seemed like a lifetime had passed since he'd last been in this room.

Izuku stood awkwardly in the middle of the room, and Katsuki watched as Izuku glanced around. His room wasn't anything special, but he suddenly felt uncomfortable as Izuku scrutinized every detail.

Over the past few months, Katsuki had developed an appreciation for Izuku's attentiveness. Izuku knew Katsuki better than he probably knew himself, and being known so well by somebody comforted him. It didn't scare him, as it once had, that Izuku knew all of his strengths and weaknesses. It had taken him a long time to come to the conclusion that Izuku would never use any of those things against him.

Katsuki sat down on his bed and looked pointedly at the spot next to him. Izuku sat beside him, his back straight, his fists set uncomfortably on his knees.

"Why the hell do you look so scared?"

"I'm not," Izuku said, his voice high-pitched. "It's just… I don't know, I never expected to be in your room."

"It's nothing special."

"Of *course* it's special," Izuku said, looking over at Katsuki. "It's yours."

If Katsuki had experienced heart failure before, this was ten times more intense. He couldn't say anything in response; all he did was stare at Izuku, whose face was relaxed, as if he'd said nothing out of the ordinary.

"How did your last few appointments go? Did you hear anything about your arm?"

Katsuki's arm still hung in its sling, useless and heavy. The rest of his injuries had been cleared. "In a few weeks, it'll be out of the sling. Might be able to, I don't fucking know, bend my fingers halfway."

"It's better than nothing," Izuku said cheerfully. "My doctor was pretty lenient, actually. Since most of my injuries healed, he said I can go back to Hero training as soon as I want."

"Getting a head start on me, asshole?"

"No! If you really want me to, I'll wait until you're healed, too."

“Don’t be stupid.” Katsuki shoved Izuku’s shoulders. At some point, his posture had started to relax. “Who knows when I’ll be cleared to train? Probably be sitting here re-learning how to use chopsticks in a few months.”

Izuku frowned. “You could always work on your left arm, right? I mean, you’ll have to relearn your entire fighting style. Might as well practice.”

“I didn’t get cleared for shit.”

“So?”

“ *So* I care about my recovery. Since when do you break rules?”

“Since when do you follow rules?”

Katsuki glared at him. “What are you suggesting, then? I practice all my moves with my left hand?”

“It doesn’t hurt, Kacchan. We could train together! Like when I was still getting the hang of Blackwhip.”

When he mentioned the quirk that had been added to his arsenal, Izuku’s face creased. Something was bothering him.

“The hell is that face for? You look upset.”

“What? Me? No, I’m not upset. What would I have to be upset about?”

“When you said about Blackwhip. You made a face.”

“It’s nothing, Kacchan, seriously! We were talking about helping you and your quirk-”

“Is it gone?” Katsuki asked, panic overtaking him so suddenly. Izuku had told him in the hospital that he hadn’t lost One For All during his battle against Shigaraki, but was there a chance he’d been wrong? “Izuku-”

Katsuki’s feelings for Izuku wouldn’t change. Katsuki was almost 99% certain Izuku would continue being a better hero than the rest of their class even without a quirk.

But he’d spent his entire life hoping for a quirk and being isolated from the rest of the world due to not having one. Things were different now, and maybe, just maybe, society would be a little bit nicer to a kid who had just gotten unlucky at birth. But Katsuki couldn’t handle the thought of Izuku losing everything he’d dreamed of, after possessing a quirk for only a short time.

Izuku sighed, his eyes downcast and refusing to meet Katsuki’s. “The Vestiges removed their own quirks from One For All during the battle. I wasn’t too sure how Eri’s rewinding would work, because it couldn’t bring them back. And… it didn’t. One For All was the base quirk, and it stockpiled strength and quirks as it was passed on. When she rewinded my body, the strength stockpiled in the original quirk is what I kept. The Vestiges… are gone.”

Izuku didn't have to say that their quirks were gone, too. It was all over his face.

"I probably sound like a spoiled brat," he laughed humorously. "Being sad that I only have one quirk now instead of seven."

"Guess you'll have to rejoin us single-quirk lowlifes."

"Stop that."

"Well, I guess all of us except Todoroki. Fucking overpowered asshole."

" *Kacchan* ."

"What? He's not the only one with parent issues. Why the hell did he get a bonus quirk out of it?"

Izuku nudged Katsuki's shoulder with his own. "His dad sucks. At least your dad is cool."

"Whatever." Katsuki leaned back on his good elbow, looking up at Izuku. Izuku, who was still *sitting in Katsuki's bed* . "How's it feel to not have a bunch of old people talking in your head?"

"You make it sound weird."

"It was weird. What if they said weird shit to you?"

"They didn't say anything weird to me, Kacchan. They only really talked to me when it was about All For One and Shigaraki. What else would they have even said?"

"Could they see you all the time? Like they knew what you were doing all the time?"

"I think so…? I didn't really ask."

"So they probably saw you taking a shit."

"Oh my god, *Kacchan* . You're so immature."

"I'm immature because I wouldn't want a bunch of fuckheads in my head while I'm trying to take a shit?"

"They didn't talk to me while I was… using the bathroom."

"What about, fuck, if you were making out with someone?"

"I didn't- oh my god, I'm leaving." Izuku's face went beat red and he glared down at Katsuki. "I never made out with someone while they were in my head."

"So you have made out with someone?"

" *What* ? No. Why do you care?"

Because I can't stand the thought of someone kissing you that isn't me.

"Don't," he said, lifting his shoulder in a shrug. "Just wondered if they gave you any tips."

"I wasn't using a quirk that allowed me to talk to past users to ask for tips on how to make out with someone," Izuku said dryly, his face still completely pink. "Is that what *you* would've done?"

"I don't need tips from a bunch of dead fuckers," he snorted.

"Really?"

Izuku's tone sounded almost disappointed.

"No. Fuck that."

"So you've kissed someone before?"

"Why? You worried I'm getting ahead of you?"

Izuku blinked a few times, then shook his head, letting out a soft snort. "Yeah. You got me."

For some reason, Katsuki really didn't think that was the case. He didn't push Izuku though, partially because he was afraid of what Izuku would pick up from that conversation.

"You didn't answer me. On if you wanted to train together."

Katsuki almost said no. He almost shrugged Izuku off and told him to leave. But he was also caught craving more moments like this. When they'd trained together, before Jaku and the war, he'd found himself slipping everyday. He started realizing that Izuku being strong didn't automatically make Katsuki weak. And he'd realized, after getting out of that mindset, that most of the things he'd detested about Izuku, actually made him think the nerd was a bit endearing. His little habits stopped annoying Katsuki, and instead made him smile. His constant questioning was no longer a hindrance, but rather, a chance for Katsuki to talk to someone on his level, someone who understood him and his passions. Izuku didn't look at Katsuki like he was a villain every time he spoke, and his chidings were lighthearted.

In the moments they'd shared together, Katsuki had begun to feel loved.

"Fuck it," he said. "Maybe I'll blow your hair up and it'll all be the same length."

"That's nice, Kacchan."

Classes resumed, and Class 1-A became Class 2-A. Shinso joined their class, which had just about everyone in an uproar. It might've been the first hint of good news they had had since the war. Every day up until classes had resumed had been fairly bleak and uninteresting. The

class was aiding in post-war relief efforts, like cleaning up debris and ensuring that there were no All For One supporters still running around.

Katsuki, with his bum arm, hadn't been approved to help. He'd spent his first two weeks out of the hospital helping out at shelters or cleaning up the dorms.

He didn't exactly mind being at the shelters. Sure, some of the refugees were annoying as fuck, thanking him for his service and falling at his feet like he was some celebrity. But he was at least doing *something* .

Still, Katsuki quietly seethed every day, as Izuku returned to the dorms in the evenings and told Katsuki about what he'd done that day. His super-strength was an obvious asset to clearing out the city, so he spent just about every day helping out.

"I'll stay back today," Izuku said one morning, as they walked together towards the in-the-process-of-being-rebuilt Hero Course Tower. Each morning, the Hero Course students met at the main lecture hall on the first floor of the building to receive instructions for where they'd be placed that day. The students that had fought in the war received a lot more leniency on their assignments, and could typically weasel their way into different ones if they wanted. "I can help out at the shelter. I'm sure you're probably not doing a good job at comforting any of the refugees."

"I'm doing a perfectly fine job, asshole. And I don't want you to fucking pity me."

"I don't," Izuku said, waving his hands around in a hurry. "I really don't. I just…"

"You just what? Feel bad that I get the easy job while you're out there doing the real Hero work?"

"I- no-"

"It's *all* Hero work, Izuku. Or do you think you're better than me?"

Izuku rolled his eyes and they kept walking. This had become part of their daily routine; they met in the mornings and walked to the main campus building together.

Being back at UA had been an adjustment for all of them. He hadn't been particularly attentive to his classmates before, but he could sure as hell tell the difference now. And if he didn't notice it on his own, Izuku always mentioned it to him.

Almost half of the class had started going to therapy, which had been provided by the school as some effort to help them heal from the war. Katsuki didn't intend on talking to anyone about his problems any time soon, and he'd stuck his nose in the air at how half-assed it was on the school's part.

"Therapy helps, Kacchan," Izuku had said in response to his complaints. He was laying on Katsuki's bed, while Katsuki sat at his desk, gripping his pencil in frustration as he tried (and failed) to write legibly with his left hand. "Sometimes just telling someone what's going on makes you feel better."

“I already have you to pick around in my head and make me talk about my feelings,” he muttered. “Why the hell would I need someone who doesn’t even know me to do that?”

“Maybe it would help you, after everything that’s happened. Even before the war. Like the slime villain. And everything that happened at Kamino.”

“That shit looks like rainbows and sunshine compared to dying.”

“See, Kacchan. Therapy would help with that.”

“Never said I was against it. Just don’t fucking want to. And I think it’s bullshit from the school and the Commission. That’s why it pisses me off.”

“What more do you want from them?” Izuku’s tone was genuine.

“I don’t fucking know. I don’t give a shit about reform or any other bullshit. But I *died* because they wanted high school students to fight in their war, and they thought that offering me fucking *therapy* would do shit to fix it?”

“Is there something you’d want them to do to fix it?”

Katsuki didn’t have an answer for that. For some of his classmates, maybe offering a shrink *was* the best way to repay them for what they’d done during the war. They’d all fought on the front lines, and they’d all seen shit that was way too serious for teenagers to be dealing with. But some of them had definitely had it worse than others.

Kirishima and Mina had been significantly quieter since Jaku, when they’d found Midnight’s body. Kaminari, who’d seen Katsuki die, sometimes looked at Katsuki like he was seeing a ghost. Jirou was in and out of the hospital as doctors tried to create a prosthetic that could emulate her quirk. Uraraka had spent a considerable amount of time in the hospital, and had then spent a similar amount of time grieving. Todoroki spent most of his days visiting the hospital where Dabi was contained, visiting him and checking on his condition, waiting to see if there was a chance for survival.

Katsuki couldn’t imagine how offering up a few therapy sessions did anything to fix the things he and the rest of his class had experienced. He didn’t need some big parade, or an award, or any attention at all. He didn’t give a shit about having fans or merch or interviews.

Really, he wanted to focus on something much more important than Hero rankings and popularity.

Ever since their discharge, he and Izuku had been spending a good amount of time together. They still hung out with their own friend groups, and visited their families, but they somehow always gravitated towards each other. After the rest of the class fell asleep, they’d head to the training grounds and break just about every rule their doctors had laid out for them.

Some nights, Katsuki grew so frustrated that he’d blow up the closest inanimate object. They’d started slow, sparring without their quirks to get used to the feeling of fighting again. Izuku was almost back to full strength, and Katsuki was missing one arm. His chest also

seemed to tighten when he strained himself, and he was forced to relearn his own physical limits.

After they'd gotten used to fighting, they'd slowly progressed into quirk training. The strength of Katsuki's quirk didn't vary from hand to hand; the quirk came from his sweat. The only addition his physical strength made to the quirk, was how well his body could withstand the kickback from it. There was a difference, though, in his reliance on his primary arm.

Izuku, who knew everything there was to know about Katsuki, had pointed out how often Katsuki relied on his right arm during fights. He hadn't realized it himself until his right arm had been rendered completely useless.

With only one arm, it was harder for Katsuki to use aerial combat to his advantage. It was more difficult to change his trajectory *and* attack with only one hand.

During his battle with Shigaraki, his quirk had undergone what had been deemed an "awakening," allowing him to ignite sweat from anywhere on his body, not just his palms. But he'd spent his entire life learning how to use his hands, and training explosions from other parts of his body was harder than he'd thought.

When he tried to change his trajectory by igniting explosions from his feet, he either severely overshot the explosions, or didn't put enough power behind them to do much of anything.

"This is so fucking *stupid* ." He kicked over a trash can that took up residence on the Ground Beta street in which they were training. "This is a waste of fucking time."

Izuku, who'd dodged every single one of Katsuki's attacks without even breaking a sweat, was staring at him with that expression that screamed *I want to help you, I want to* save *you* . It only pissed Katsuki off more.

"You could try something like my Shoot Style," Izuku suggested. "You could attack with your legs and use your arm for flight."

"I don't want to copy your shitty ass Shoot Style," Katsuki snapped, a few explosions lighting off in his palm. "This is such fucking *bullshit* . I can't even beat you anymore."

"We've only been doing this for, like, a week."

Katsuki whirled on him. "So fucking *what* ? I can't even beat you and my arm sure as shit isn't getting any stronger. I should be able to kick your ass all the way back to the dorms without even trying."

Izuku let out a long sigh. "Do you want to try again?"

"No. Fuck this."

"You're not going to get better if you don't-"

Katsuki aimed an explosion at him, catching Izuku off guard as he jumped at him. Izuku was moving a second later, jumping out of the way and raising his fists. The next time Katsuki attacked, he feinted right, as if he forgot that his right arm no longer worked. Izuku was momentarily confused, and Katsuki was able to light off a few explosions, sending him over Izuku's head. He kicked Izuku sharply in the back, knocking him to his knees.

Izuku whirled around, green lightning dancing across his body, as he gripped Katsuki's still-extended leg and slammed him to the ground. The impact wracked Katsuki's body, but he didn't have time to think about that. He leapt to his feet, raising his left hand just as Izuku lunged for him.

This time, Katsuki really *did* forget that his right hand was out-of-service as he went to jump into the air and dodge the attack. Instead, Izuku slammed into them, knocking them both to the ground. Izuku was latched onto them, and they tumbled over each other. Instinctively, Katsuki's good hand found its way to the back of Izuku's head, keeping it from slamming against the pavement.

When they rolled to a stop, Izuku was above him, panting hard as he looked down at Katsuki.

Katsuki's hand was still tangled in Izuku's green curls, and he swallowed tightly as he noticed just how close they were. His own breathing was coming in harsh repetition, and his body ached from both the sparring and their tumble to the ground.

If Katsuki weren't Katsuki, maybe he would have used the hand so conveniently tangled in Izuku's hair to pull his face down to meet Katsuki's own.

Izuku was above him, eyes alight from the fight, his freckles stark against his pale skin. As he sucked in breath after breath, Katsuki couldn't help but stare at the gap between his lips.

When he finally pried his eyes up, Izuku was watching him, his eyes so focused and attentive. He blinked a few times, still staring at Katsuki, as if something had dawned on him.

Fuck. Fuck fuck fuck fuck fuck .

There's no way Izuku had missed the way Katsuki had been staring at his lips. He was looking at Katsuki like he *knew* .

Katsuki ripped his hand out of Izuku's hair and shoved at his shoulder. "Get the fuck off of me."

Izuku didn't even look remotely put off. He didn't budge, and Katsuki's appreciation for Izuku's muscles was immediately gone.

"Why?"

"The fuck? Because we're done training. I'm going to my dorm."

Izuku still didn't move. "Are you going to run away again and avoid me for days?"

" *What* ?"

“I don’t want you to hide from me again.”

“I wasn’t *hiding* from shit.”

“Then why did you stay away?”

Katsuki glared at him, shoving his shoulder again. Damn him for only having one working arm.

Maybe part of him didn’t want to push Izuku off. Maybe part of him didn’t want to hide.

He could use his entire body to flip them over and stalk back to the dorms and hide in his room. He could ignore Izuku for the next few days and pretend he’d never been caught staring.

Or he could figure his shit out. One piece at a time. He could stay here and have this conversation and finally, *finally* do something fucking right. He could finally stop being a coward when it came to the things that mattered most.

It’s just Izuku. Izuku, who would never hold anything against you or look at you different or-

“You’re thinking too much,” Izuku breathed.

“Fuck you,” Katsuki whispered back, only just starting to catch his breath. His heart was beating furiously in his chest, but not because of their training. “You’re the one that thinks too much.”

“Probably,” Izuku agreed. One of his hands found its way to Katsuki’s cheek. Calloused fingers traced the starburst scar that interrupted Katsuki’s pale skin. Just as Katsuki had once done, Izuku traced the scar, running his finger over the ridges of it so slowly. His touch was tender, as if he was afraid that Katsuki would crumble beneath him. Maybe Katsuki *was* crumbling beneath him.

“It suits you,” Izuku breathed. “Probably attracts all the girls.”

“Don’t want them,” he said, hoarse.

“No?”

“Fuck no.”

Izuku kissed him.

Chapter End Notes

guys I am SO sorry for the two week hiatus, I was absolutely slammed with exams BUT I should be able to update more often now until the end of this fic :)
this is like such a sorry excuse of a chapter BUT I hope the end was at least exciting
anyways I am literally exhausted so im abt to sleep for like 12 hours
tysm for reading and sticking around I really really appreciate it more than you know <3

my kinda lover

Chapter Summary

I can't do without you for too long
you're my situation
you're my kinda lover
my kinda lover

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki had never kissed anyone, but he was pretty convinced it was supposed to be more romantic than… this.

Izuku pulled away from him as quickly as he'd leaned in, his eyes wide and his face completely red. Katsuki was probably in a similar state of flushed, doing his best to get over the complete shock that had taken over his entire body.

Izuku had kissed him. *Izuku* had kissed *him* .

Katsuki had been yearning for this moment for months. Alone in his room, he'd thought of what it would be like to kiss Izuku. He'd thought it over an embarrassing amount of times, of how he would kiss Izuku if he ever worked up the nerve.

Not a single scenario had involved Izuku being the one to kiss *him* . Katsuki hadn't even dared to hope that Izuku would return his feelings in any form.

Katsuki was caught too off guard to even enjoy the moment, and Izuku was standing up faster than Katsuki could even process what happened.

"Shit," Izuku said. "Kacchan, I'm sorry, I-"

"Why the fuck did you do that?"

Shit . That was probably the last thing Katsuki should have said, but he was still trying to recover from his initial shock. His mouth was too preoccupied with memorizing how Izuku's lips had felt against his to form coherent thoughts and sentences.

"I'm so sorry," Izuku said, taking a few steps back. Katsuki shoved himself up with his good arm, trying to get to his feet.

Shit .

“Izuku-”

“Kacchan, look, I’m so sorry, I shouldn’t have done that, I-”

For one fleeting second, Katsuki felt undeniably *weak* . Had Izuku read him? Had Izuku caught onto his feelings, and did he plan to exploit Katsuki’s weakness? Was he going to use Katsuki’s feelings for him to his own benefit? Was this some elaborate scheme to get back at Katsuki for how he had treated Izuku in middle school?

Katsuki had never felt this way for anyone, and he’d never, in his entire life, let himself be so completely… himself around somebody. Izuku could, at any point, turn on him and so easily destroy everything Katsuki had worked for. Izuku surely knew all of Katsuki’s physical weaknesses, and now, god, *now* he clearly knew what Katsuki felt for him-

He took a deep breath.

This was *Izuku* . If Izuku had been plotting against him, he would have had multiple chances to get back at Katsuki over the years.

And if this was some elaborate scheme, Katsuki *wanted* to be tricked and deceived.

After all, it had *always* been Izuku. And for some reason, even before Katsuki had caught onto his own feelings, he’d let himself be weak around Izuku, for Izuku. He’d broken down in front of Izuku, all those months ago, about his fears and insecurities, about how he felt constantly suffocated after watching All Might fall because of *him* . For the past few months, in small ways, he’d been letting Izuku in.

Katsuki was terrified of people recognizing his weaknesses. The thought made his skin crawl, with anger bursting in his veins as his only method of defense. But Katsuki had learned to love living on the edge. Knowing that Izuku could backstab him at any moment scared him shitless, like he was standing at the very edge of a steep cliff, his toes dangling off the ledge.

This moment felt like falling.

“Why did you do that?” he asked again.

Izuku backed away from him, his face still red and his eyes full of tears. “I’m so-”

Katsuki caught his arm before Izuku could turn away and presumably avoid him for eternity. “Just tell me why you did it.”

Because if Izuku hadn’t kissed Katsuki as part of some sick and twisted plot, then why *had* he done it?

“I shouldn’t have- I just- I thought- I don’t know,” Izuku said finally. His eyes were so wide, and terrified, as if he was afraid of Katsuki.

Katsuki took a deep breath before he could lose his cool and shout in Izuku’s face. He loosened his grip on Izuku’s wrist, not all the way, but enough to ensure that he wouldn’t run.

Funny, how moments earlier, they'd been beating the shit out of each other without holding back, but talking about something like *this* had them both unable to function.

"I don't want to hear a fucking apology," he said. "Just tell me why."

Katsuki's heart was beating so fast in his chest, and, ever since his death, he was all too aware of his heart. Sometimes, its frantic pumping reminded him of how hard it had been beating right before he had died, due to how much he had overexerted himself during the battle. Standing in a dark street, talking to the boy he loved, wasn't necessarily as strenuous as fighting against the most dangerous villains the world had ever seen, but Katsuki lacked any of the confidence he had felt that day.

"Kacchan-"

"Izuku-"

A cough sounded behind them, and Katsuki swung around. He lifted his left arm, and though the feeling was unnatural, after throwing himself at Izuku so many times over again, the motion was becoming a bit more comfortable. He had more than enough sweat to create quite a few powerful blasts, depending on who their attacker was. Izuku could surely cover Katsuki's weakened right side, even with only his base quirk. They're best bet was to-

"I shouldn't even be surprised."

Katsuki's arm dropped to his side as Aizawa stepped out of the shadows. With one of his eyes covered, he looked even more intimidating than usual, and, though Katsuki would never admit it, pretty badass.

"I'm so sorry, sir," Izuku said immediately, his voice shaky. Katsuki wondered if it was from their unfinished conversation, or if it was out of fear of being punished for being out past curfew.

Aizawa sent Katsuki a pointed look.

"Sorry," he muttered.

"Do either of you want to explain what you're doing out here?"

Katsuki glanced at Izuku, who was already staring at him, as if waiting for Katsuki to answer. Katsuki glared back, hoping Izuku got the damn message. You *kissed me, asshole. You can explain* .

Izuku's lips turned up at the corners, as if he was fighting back laughter.

"I'm sorry, sir," Izuku said again.

"Save it, kid. You two would be the ones to break curfew to beat each other senseless right after getting out of the hospital. Did either of you stop to think about reinjuring yourselves?"

“We weren’t beating each other senseless,” Izuku argued, his face red. Katsuki hoped his face wasn’t a similar shade. It was bad enough that Aizawa’s sixth sense for them had gone off; Katsuki could only imagine his own mortification if Aizawa had shown up a minute earlier, when Izuku had been hovering over Katsuki, breathless, his hair sticking to his sweaty forehead, his head dipping down, his lips-

“What were you doing, then?”

Izuku didn’t say anything and Katsuki sure as shit wasn’t going to be the one to speak up. He glanced over at Izuku, trying to read his expression, but his face was hidden by the darkness. They hadn’t necessarily been beating each other senseless. Well, they *had* , but only for the sake of training. It’s not like they’d been throwing their most intense moves at each other, so soon after being discharged from the hospital. Katsuki wasn’t *that* reckless.

It just so happened, though, that Aizawa had shown up at precisely the wrong time, when Izuku was clearly too flustered to speak, and Katsuki’s brain had short-circuited. He didn’t have enough brain-power to snap back and defend himself, not so soon after Izuku had *kissed him* .

Aizawa seemed to take their silence as an admission, and he scoffed. “I shouldn’t have expected anything less from you two. You’ve both been out of the hospital for, what, three weeks? And you’re right back to fighting each other?”

Yeah, fighting . At that, Izuku did glance at Katsuki, and his expression appeared borderline amused. They’d been scolded by Aizawa enough times over the last year to take it with a grain of salt. Their teacher was intimidating when he needed to be, but Katsuki had never been particularly afraid. His punishments were nuisances more than anything, geared more towards teaching Katsuki some stupid lesson about being a better Hero. They were never permanent.

“I would’ve thought after everything you two have been through, you might have realized that there are more important things to worry about than a childish rivalry. I was optimistic, actually.”

Katsuki scoffed.

Aizawa’s surviving eye flashed red, and, all at once, Katsuki was hit with the sensation of being empty. As always, under the influence of Aizawa’s quirk, the loss of his quirk was uncomfortable enough to set Katsuki’s skin crawling. His strongest layer of defense was stripped away with a glance.

After having his quirk be a part of him for almost all of his life, losing it felt like losing a limb. Katsuki didn’t have to think about using his quirk, or about its presence in his body, but as soon as it was gone, he became intimately aware of the lack of power flowing through his veins and pulsing under his skin. His sweat was still nitroglycerin, but it would no longer ignite in his palms.

Funny enough, the fact that his sweat was still nitroglycerin reminded him of a conversation he and Izuku had had months ago, when Izuku had been debating over the effects

nitroglycerin might have on Katsuki's body.

"You two are on house arrest for the next two days," Aizawa said, spinning back around and heading in the direction of the dorms. Katsuki tried to pretend like he wasn't relieved to have his quirk back.

"Shouldn't we be helping out with the reparation efforts, sir?"

"You *should* , but you two also have a responsibility, as future Heroes, to take care of yourselves. Reinjuring yourselves will do nothing to help."

Katsuki clenched his left fist, his fingernails digging into his palm as he fought down the urge to snap back.

Sitting around waiting for his arm to heal wouldn't help anything. His doctor wasn't even certain it *would* heal, and Katsuki sure as hell wasn't going to wait on a possibility. They'd taken down a majority of the Paranormal Liberation Front, and any followers of Shigaraki, but they were still hearing reports of outbreaks and fights from smaller towns across the country. Even villains who hadn't supported All For One and the League were jumping at the chance to cause problems; Hero society was in a state of disarray, facing backlash from the public. The Commission was in shambles. Major cities had been turned into warzones. What better time to revolt than when Heroes and society were focused on anything *but* villains?

Katsuki wouldn't argue that point to Aizawa, though. He knew Aizawa hadn't exactly approved of the UA students fighting in the war, and that he'd been actively fighting against the Commission ever since the end of the war. He, among others, were fighting for a change to the whole system and its exploitation of Hero Course students across the country. He'd also been keeping the press away from the UA Campus, refusing to let interviewers and reporters talk to Katsuki or his classmates.

Katsuki wouldn't have taken well to being told he couldn't fight. He knew that he would have been an insufferable brat about it, shouting that he was better than half the Pros, and that he was more than capable of fighting. He wouldn't have taken no for an answer.

He understood now why there was so much outrage towards the Commission and UA's staff after the war. Katsuki probably understood better than most of his classmates. He'd *died* on that battlefield.

But he didn't blame the Commission for letting him fight, and he didn't blame them for his death either. He didn't blame Aizawa and the rest of his teachers for blindly letting him and his classmates fight. Katsuki's blame fell entirely on his own shoulders; not for choosing to fight, but for being too weak to win.

Sometimes, Katsuki *did* blame the Commission. Never for his own sake, though.

In the hospital, seeing Izuku with sunken, sad eyes had been more normal than not. Every day, he seemed more and more tired, with dark purple circles beneath his eyes and pale skin. Katsuki knew he was having nightmares, because Katsuki had been having them, too.

He blamed the Commission for putting so much pressure on Izuku's shoulders, for letting them push Izuku to the forefront of a war that didn't have to be fought by only him. He blamed the Commission for the scars that now took up residence on Izuku's face, and for the loss of his smile and his excitement.

"I'm sorry, sir. It won't happen again," Izuku mumbled.

"You and I both know that it will, Midoriya," Aizawa said, resigned. They were almost back to the dorms at this point; Heights Alliance was ahead of them, with most of its lights turned off this late into the night. When they reached the front door, Aizawa faced them again. "Do your best to not destroy the building tomorrow, you two."

"We won't," Izuku swore.

"Whatever," Katsuki muttered.

With that, their teacher marched off back in the direction of the teachers' dormitories. Katsuki and Izuku watched him go for a few moments. After he was out of sight, Katsuki turned and reached for the front door, but stopped when he heard muffled giggling coming from Izuku.

"The fuck's so funny, nerd?" he asked. The question fell from his lips, so *normal* . Like nothing had happened between them. Like they hadn't fought in a war. Like they were normal teenagers, who had just gotten scolded by their teacher on a normal day.

Izuku had a hand pressed over his mouth as he fought back laughter. Katsuki grabbed his wrist and pulled it away from Izuku's mouth.

"Share with the class," he snapped, letting go of Izuku's arm.

"Sorry, sorry," Izuku said through his fit of laughter. "It's just… doesn't this remind you of that first fight we had? After the Provisional License Exam?"

"What, when I kicked the shit out of you?"

"You did *not* kick the shit out of me! If anything, *I* kicked the shit out of you. Because, you know, Shoot Style?"

"That was the worst fucking joke you've ever made."

Izuku laughed again, bright and warm. It was achingly familiar and yet so far removed from what Katsuki was used to. When was the last time he'd made Izuku laugh like that? He couldn't remember.

"It just reminded me of how things used to be. Us, always getting in trouble for fighting."

It *was* nostalgic, to be placed on house arrest for fighting, as they had so many months ago. It was also ridiculously out of place in the grand scheme of things.

"I'm glad that something is going back to normal," Izuku said quietly. "You know?"

Katsuki opened the door to Heights Alliance, holding it open for Izuku and walking in after him. “You’re happy to be getting your ass beat again?”

“We tied today, Kacchan! That’s not even fair.”

“Yeah, we tied, and I only have one arm. I’d say that’s a win for me.”

“Whatever you say, Kacchan.”

They walked through the empty common room. The lights were off, and the entire dorm was dead silent. As they reached the bottom of the stairs, Katsuki couldn’t help but think back to Izuku kissing him. It wasn’t something he would easily forget, and he’d probably spend the rest of his night losing his mind over it. It hadn’t caused a rift between them, though. Izuku seemed a little bit on-edge, but when was he not anymore? He hadn’t fled from Katsuki, though. He was still laughing with him, like nothing had even happened.

God, how the fuck had they ended up here? They’d fought at Ground Beta, when Katsuki had needed to share his feelings with someone, and the only way he’d known how to vent his frustrations was through fighting. He’d *known* that Izuku would get it, that he wouldn’t judge Katsuki for anything he was feeling, and that he’d give Katsuki exactly what he had wanted: a chance to fight out his emotions without the chance of them being used against him.

Even back then, he’d been pathetic for Izuku without even knowing it. He’d known, subconsciously, that he could trust and rely on Izuku over anyone else.

They reached the bottom of the stairs and Izuku coughed awkwardly. “So, I guess I’ll see you tomorrow?”

“It’s not like I can go anywhere else.”

“Right.” Izuku’s face twisted at that, and Katsuki cursed himself for the disappointment that had taken over Izuku’s features.

Fuck . “I meant- shit- we’re stuck together. I don’t really have a choice in it.”

Izuku’s eyebrows raised.

Katsuki had never claimed to be good at comforting people. Saying the “right thing” wasn’t a skill that he’d mastered at any point in his life. Typically, if people didn’t like what he said or how he said it, he didn’t give a fuck. He didn’t need people to like him, and he didn’t need to make people feel better with his words.

Things were different with Izuku, though. More often than not, Izuku shrugged off the things Katsuki said. After knowing each other for nearly 17 years, Izuku had clearly picked up on Katsuki’s very shitty communication skills. He took most of what Katsuki said with a grain of salt, and didn’t fall crying at every word. He had a backbone, and he was stronger than anybody else Katsuki had ever met, and yet, he was so, *so* soft.

Katsuki had been so intimidated by Izuku’s quiet, empathetic strength all their lives. Izuku had always been strong, even before his absurd muscles and overpowered quirk. Izuku’s true

strength resided in his connection to his own emotions, his ability to understand the people around him. Katsuki would probably never reach that point, even if he dedicated himself to being gentle and nurturing for the rest of his life.

“You’re probably the least annoying person to be stuck with for two days,” he tried.

“Wow,” Izuku deadpanned. “You really know how to charm people.”

“Oh, fuck you. That’s the best you’re getting.”

Izuku went up the first few steps, and Katsuki followed behind him. “It’s okay, Kacchan. I know you don’t mean it.”

“Uh, yes the fuck I do. Just because you’re less annoying than the rest of these assholes doesn’t mean you’re not annoying.”

“Whatever you say.”

Izuku stopped on the second floor, glancing down the hall towards his bedroom. He swayed back and forth awkwardly, avoiding eye contact with Katsuki like it was the plague. Katsuki took the first two steps up to the next floor, when Izuku’s voice stopped him.

“Hey, Kacchan?”

“Hm?”

“You’re probably my top choice to get stuck with, too.”

“I did *not* say you were my top choice.”

“You didn’t have to,” Izuku said. His eyes were shining in that typical Izuku-way. Katsuki could have stood on the stairs and watched him for hours.

You’re pathetic , he told himself.

“Who knows, maybe we’ll have a good time.”

“ *Right* . Cleaning up this shithole is gonna be a real fun one. Might as well call it a date.”

Izuku blinked at him a few times, but Katsuki refused to back down from what he’d said. If they were going to do this, he could only take so much dancing around it. Izuku wouldn’t have kissed him for no reason, *right* ?

Katsuki couldn’t wrap his mind around it. He couldn’t understand how Izuku could see past who he’d been in middle school, or how he’d even forgiven Katsuki in the first place. He didn’t get why Izuku was still *here* , still following Katsuki after so long, when there were so many other people who had never hurt him in the way Katsuki had?

If Izuku wanted this, wanted *him* , Katsuki wouldn’t be strong enough to turn away from that. He wasn’t selfless and giving like Izuku; he wouldn’t refuse and say that Izuku deserved

better, he would simply *be* better.

If he spent the rest of his life groveling and working and earning Izuku's love, so be it.

Izuku smiled at him one last time, his face red, even in the dim hallway. His constellation of freckles was still visible, and Katsuki ached to reach out and trace his fingers over them.

"Good night, Kacchan."

"Night, Izuku."

Katsuki took the steps two at a time until he reached the fourth floor, walking right past his own bedroom door and pounding on Kirishima's. He didn't give two shits that it was well past midnight; he didn't stop knocking, even when he heard a muffled, "Jeez, I'm *coming* !" from inside. Kirishima opened the door, looking disheveled and confused. When he saw Katsuki, he did a double take. "I thought you were Kaminari."

"Do I fucking look like Kaminari?" Katsuki shoved past him, stomping into the room and collapsing onto his back onto Kirishima's bed. Kirishima left his light off, which mercifully kept his man-cave-turned-gym-turned-dorm hidden from sight, unless Katsuki squinted.

"Do you want me to answer that?"

"Fuck you."

The mattress sank as Kirishima sat down beside Katsuki. "You gonna tell me why you were banging on my door in the middle of the night?"

Katsuki took a deep breath, then let it out. It didn't help calm his nerves.

"I'm gonna tell you something. And I don't want to hear shit about it."

"Okay? Is something wrong?"

"Izuku kissed me."

Kirishima was silent for a few seconds. Katsuki counted in his head to 10, then he shot to his feet and started pacing.

"I don't know what to do."

"What do you mean, you don't know what to do? Did you kiss him back?"

"I don't know. *I don't know* ."

"You don't *know* ? What does that-"

"I don't fucking know, okay? He fucking kissed me then I asked him why the fuck he did that, then he almost started crying, then Aizawa showed up, and now we have house arrest

together for the next two fucking days."

It was a wonder that Izuku could mumble so much and not lose his breath. Katsuki stopped pacing in front of Kirishima, panting, two seconds away from ripping his own hair out.

"Um, okay," Kirishima said, reaching for his phone. "I'm calling Mina."

"Fuck you."

"Look, man, she will *kill* me if she finds out I know about this and didn't tell her. And she'll have better advice for you than I do."

"I don't need your shitty advice."

"Then why did you come to my room?"

Five minutes later, Mina arrived. She had a sleep mask pushed up into her hair, and her pajamas were silky and hot pink; she was a literal walking eyesore.

"You have an emergency?" she asked, sounding way too awake.

"You didn't tell her?" Katsuki shot Kirishima a glare.

"That's on you, dude."

"Tell me what?" She plopped down onto the bed beside Kirishima, crossing her legs under her.

"Izuku kissed me."

"Oh my god, *finally* ," she said. "How long have you two been in love with each other again? It's honestly been sickening to watch."

"Fuck you, Pinky."

She shrugged. "It's *true* . I mean, he's probably been in love with you for, like, ever. And we all knew you were into him. I mean, come on, dying for him twice? That whole proclamation of love in the rain?"

He glared at her.

She glanced between him and Kirishima, wrinkling her eyebrows. "Am I missing something? Why do you look so pissed off and frustrated?"

Kirishima coughed (which suspiciously sounded like a laugh). "Well, you see, Bakugou isn't very… romantic? And he, uh…"

"Izuku kissed me and I asked him why the fuck he did it."

"Smooth," she said. "Did you… kiss him goodnight afterwards, atleast?"

“Aizawa caught us out past curfew and gave us house arrest. We didn’t talk about it.”

“You didn’t talk about the fact that you two *kissed* ?”

“No, we fucking didn’t. That’s what I just said, isn’t it?”

“So go talk to him.” Mina waved her hands at him, incredulous. “That poor boy is probably having a panic attack.”

“Over what?”

“What do you *mean* , over what? Are you dumb?”

“Watch it, fuck face.”

“Bakugou, don’t be like that, man.”

Katsuki swung towards him. “I came here for help and you two *assholes* haven’t done shit.”

“I’m still trying to understand why your response to being kissed was ‘Why the fuck did you do that?’” Mina crossed her arms. “That was the best you could come up with?”

“I wasn’t expecting him to kiss me.”

“Details, Blasty. When did he kiss you?”

“We were training.”

She groaned. “Ew. You two are such *boys* . That’s not romantic at all.”

“What should I have done? Asked him to hold off until I light a few candles and change into a suit and tie?”

“Anything is better than what you actually said.”

Katsuki sunk into Kirishima’s desk chair, putting his head in his hands. “I don’t know what the fuck to do.”

“You said you have house arrest together right?” Mina asked.

“Yeah, you two could talk about it then,” Kirishima said, his voice annoyingly optimistic.

“I’m sure you could also do a lot of other things. Locked in the dorms together. All day. Alone.”

“What the fuck?”

“I’m just saying.” She shrugged.

“You two are no fucking help.”

“You could go ask Kaminari,” Kirishima suggested.

Katsuki lifted his head to glare. “Are you being fucking serious?”

“God, no,” Kirishima laughed. “Just… just be yourself, dude.”

“Again: you’re awful at advice.”

“Sorry, babe, but I have to agree,” Mina said, placing a hand on Kirishima’s arm. “I can’t believe you’ve been through a war and *died* , and you can’t even talk to a guy.”

“I’m fucking leaving.”

“I bet Izuku is having the same conversation with one of his friends right this very moment,” Mina said. “I don’t know why you two can’t figure your shit out.”

“Fuck you, that’s why.” He stood up, shoving Kirishima’s chair in and heading to the door. “This is why I handle my own problems.”

“Your problems aren’t handled,” Mina said. “They’re repressed.”

He slammed the door behind him.

Even while being on house arrest, Katsuki still woke up to his first alarm. Sunlight was just beginning to shine through his balcony curtains, and he rolled, stretching his left arm above his head until his back cracked.

Over the course of the last week, he and Izuku had been training. Their progress had been slow, and honestly, kind of embarrassing, but it was progress nonetheless. That morning, the left side of his upper body was sore from the recoil of his explosions. His right arm, finally out if its sling, still hung uselessly at his side. As he pushed his blankets aside and got out of bed, he practiced bending his fingers, one by one.

They hardly moved, and they shook with the effort. He swore.

During his initial checkup after being discharged from the hospital, Katsuki’s occupational therapist had walked him through a handful of exercises geared towards strengthening more precise movements.

Katsuki had failed miserably at every single exercise she’d directed him to do. His fingers barely bent at the first knuckle, he couldn’t rotate his wrist, and he couldn’t fully bend or straighten his elbow. After a half an hour of failure, he’d thrown the grip-trainer she’d been having him use at the wall.

Or he’d tried. He couldn’t raise his arm all the way, and the throw ended up being awkward and weak. The grip-trainer had clattered to the floor, and his OT had pursed her lips at him, letting out a very long sigh, before picking it up and having him try again.

Katsuki listened to everything his doctors said. His parents and friends seemed surprised at that fact, but he wasn't fucking around when it came to his future. He knew damn well he could still be a hero with only one arm, but why wouldn't he work towards fixing his right arm? He wasn't going to sit around and let it get worse.

Then it hit him.

Izuku had kissed him.

Fuck fuck fuck fuck-

His heartbeat sped up in his chest, and he stopped in front of his door.

What the fuck was he supposed to say to Izuku? How was he supposed to face him?

Katsuki had quite literally given the worst response to being kissed ever. Izuku had probably paced his room the entire night, mumbling and worrying over the entire night.

Shit shit shit shit shit shit -

Katsuki pulled on a pair of gray sweats and threw a black hoodie over his head. It read *UA High Sports Festival* across the front in yellow letters, and on the back, it said, *First Year: Bakugou Katsuki* . He stumbled out of his room, pushing past Kirishima, who was talking to Sero in the hallway.

"Bakugou, dude, why are you in such a hurry?" Sero called after him.

Katsuki whipped around, glaring at Kirishima. His red-haired best friend just smirked.

"My lips are sealed, Bakugou." Kirishima winked, and Katsuki scoffed.

"You are one corny motherfucker."

"Are you hiding something from me?" Sero asked. "Guys, don't be dicks."

"I'm sure you'll know soon enough," Kirishima said. "It's about-"

Katsuki kicked Kirishima in the shin, catching him just before Kirishima could activate his quirk. "Watch it, Shitty Hair. I'll fucking kill you."

"My manager told me that death threats aren't good PR for Heroes," Todoroki said, coming down the stairs and joining them on the landing.

Sero shouted, "You have a *manager* ?" as Katsuki said, "Get the fuck out of my business, Icy-Hot."

"By your 'business,' do you mean the conversation you're having in the middle of the hallway at eight in the morning?"

"I will fucking explode your stupid ass manager *and* you."

“I think that would hurt your chances of going Pro. You might end up in jail.”

“Fuck off.”

Todoroki started down the next flight of stairs. He glanced back over his shoulder at Katsuki. “Congrats, by the way. And not on house arrest.”

Kirishima hid his laughter behind his hand. Sero glanced between Todoroki, Kirishima, and Katsuki with a confused expression plastered on his face. Katsuki’s eye twitched.

“You got house arrest?” Sero asked, laughing. “The fuck did you do now? Get in a fight with Midoriya?”

The last question had been a joke, but he wasn’t exactly far off.

Katsuki ignored him and stomped down the stairs. He glanced down the hallway of the second floor, but heard only silence. Izuku’s door was closed, not that he was expecting it to be open. He took the rest of the stairs to the first floor, rounding the corner to the kitchen, and slamming directly into someone.

“Oh- sorry! I didn’t- oh, Kacchan! Hi! Good morning! I, uh- I didn’t see you there. I, um, did you sleep well? Not that there’s anything that would’ve kept you up. I just, I know that sleeping after the war has been, well, not great for everyone. And I thought, well, maybe you weren’t sleeping good because of that. Not because of anything else! I-”

“Holy shit,” Katsuki said, because he was absolutely god awful at words. “Take a fucking breath before you die.”

Izuku’s face was red, and Katsuki wasn’t sure if it was from their chance meeting or his rambling. He took a breath, his shoulders rising and falling. Katsuki watched the movement, watching Izuku’s eyes dart over Katsuki’s face.

Out of the corner of his eye, Katsuki noticed Uraraka, Todoroki, and a handful of their other classmates milling around the kitchen. Uraraka was watching them, not even bothering to pretend she wasn’t. Katsuki squeezed the bridge of his nose between two fingers and sighed. Damn their friends for being so fucking nosy.

“Better start fucking cleaning before Aizawa bitches at us even more,” Katsuki grumbled, pushing past Izuku and heading for the fridge. He would work up the confidence to talk to Izuku at some point, just not with an audience.

“So, Bakugou, how did you end up getting house arrest?” Uraraka asked, leaning against the kitchen island and crossing her arms. Her tone was sickly sweet and innocent. He glared at her.

“None of your fucking business, that’s how.”

“Midoriya told us last night, Uraraka, don’t you-”

Uraraka whacked Todoroki's arm, giggling. "Oh, Todoroki, you're right! It was so late, though, and Deku's story was so… eventful. It must've slipped my mind."

"Aren't you going to be late?" Izuku asked, his voice tight. "I think you both are going to be late."

Todoroki peered at the microwave clock. "We still have 15 minutes before-"

"Yeah, but… but the weather! The weather is really bad out! Wouldn't want to get stuck in it!"

"It's… sunny?"

"I heard there's a higher chance of idiots having their heads exploded today," Katsuki said, yanking a water bottle out of the fridge. Izuku met his gaze, smiling just slightly, before ducking his head.

"Really? I heard there's a high chance of-"

Izuku put his hand over Uraraka's mouth, muffling the rest of her sentence. He ushered her towards the doorway back to the common areas, shooing Todoroki after her. The rest of their classmates had filtered out at some point during the commotion, and it was just Katsuki and Izuku.

Izuku laughed awkwardly, scratching the back of his head. Katsuki could hear their classmates talking, a few stragglers hurrying down the stairs as the class headed out the door. It shut behind them, and their voices cut off. The dorm was all at once silent.

There was Izuku, and there was Katsuki, and there was a tension hanging between them, so unlike the tension that had been there their whole lives. This was new and uncharted, and Katsuki didn't even know where to start.

Katsuki took a deep breath, opening his mouth to say *something* , when Izuku beat him to it.

"I want to know how you feel about me."

Katsuki about dropped his water bottle on the floor. He blinked a few times, stunned. On the other side of the island, Izuku was watching him with bold, yet anxious eyes.

Sometimes, Izuku said things like *that* , things that caught Katsuki so off-guard that he was afraid his heart would stop. This time, though, he didn't know if he'd fight it.

Katsuki thought back to his first few days in the hospital. He'd been so desperate to find Izuku; even after dying, Izuku had been the first thing on Katsuki's mind. Damn his arm and his future. He could find ways to work around his injuries, but he couldn't find a way to work around Izuku. All of it would have been for nothing if Izuku wasn't okay, if he hadn't survived. Waking up would have been pointless.

Katsuki revolved around Izuku, and he was blind to have not seen that Izuku revolved around Katsuki.

When Izuku faltered, Katsuki was there. When Katsuki needed help, Izuku gave it before Katsuki had to ask. When Katsuki flew too close to the sun, Izuku pulled him back down to Earth. When Izuku couldn't see past his emotions, Katsuki bore half the weight.

He'd never expected this.

He'd never expected to fall for Izuku, or to have been kissed by him. Really, he'd never expected anything. Not his death, not the many attacks throughout his first year, not losing his right arm.

"You want to know fucking *what* ?"

Izuku didn't back down. His gaze stayed level. "It's changed, right? From how you used to feel?"

Katsuki's left fist clenched, his fingernails digging into his palms. He didn't know how to have this conversation with Izuku. He didn't know how to talk his feelings out, or how to not royally fuck up everything they'd fixed over the last year. The minute he opened his mouth, the conversation was more likely to end with punches.

"You've done… so much, Kacchan. You trained with me, you took stab wounds for me, you found me after I left, you… you *died* ." Izuku's voice cracked on the last word. "Tell me all of that meant nothing."

"You think I wouldn't save other people? You egotistical fuck."

"I think what you did for me was different."

"Trying to convince yourself of something?"

"No," Izuku said, his voice soft. "Just… thinking. About everything."

"You can shove your *thinking* so far up your ass-"

"Kacchan," Izuku murmured, coming around the island.

"Fuck you."

"Nothing you could say would make me look at you differently," Izuku said. His eyes were so *knowing* , and that very fact rooted Katsuki's feet to the ground. He couldn't run anymore, not when Izuku had figured him out. "You know that, right?"

"I don't give a fuck how you look at me," he lied.

"Do you want to ignore it, Kacchan? What happened last night?"

"I don't know, Izuku, what happened last night? Why don't you fucking-"

Katsuki was cut off as Izuku kissed him *again* . It was just as quick as the last one, and he wanted *more* . A split second wasn't enough for him. His body moved against his own will,

grabbing Izuku's arm before he could back away. They were close enough now that Katsuki could count every single freckle if he wanted to. He could see the tiny ridges surrounding the scars on his face, and the darker green that surrounded his pupils.

"Are you scared?" Izuku breathed. "Is that it?"

"I'm not scared of shit," he snapped.

Izuku could see right through that, though.

"Do I need to tell you again that I forgive you? For everything? I do, Kacchan. I never held it against you to begin with."

"Because you're stupid."

Izuku smiled. "I mean it. You changed. It's like… you still stayed you. You're the same old Kacchan, just…"

"Less of an asshole?"

He laughed, and the sound could have played in Katsuki's ears for the rest of his life. "I don't know if I'd say less. You're just… I don't know how to describe it. You kept all the good parts."

"You think there's good parts?"

"Of course. Your quirk, your strategizing, your battle sense-"

"That's a lame ass answer."

Izuku pinched Katsuki's side. "Your determination. Your ambition. Your dedication to your goals. The fact that you never give up."

"I like hearing all the things you like about me, nerd. What else?"

Izuku went delightfully red. Even after Izuku had kissed him twice, Katsuki liked that his words could turn Izuku's cheeks scarlet. "You care about people in your own way."

"Whatever."

"You *do* ," he insisted. "You open up more. You don't treat your emotions like weaknesses anymore."

Izuku glanced at Katsuki's hand, which was still gripping Izuku's arm like he'd disappear if Katsuki let go.

"You're still Kacchan, though. You know, 'Die, villains!' and 'I'll blow up your stupid face, asshole!'"

"You're not doing it right," Katsuki scoffed. "You weren't intimidating at all."

“You’re not intimidating either!”

“Yeah? Then what the fuck am I, dickhead?”

“I think it’s endearing,” Izuku giggled.

“ *Endearing* ? I’m not fucking endearing.”

“I’m endeared,” Izuku said, still smiling. Katsuki wanted to keep making him smile for the rest of their lives.

They were silent for a few moments, and Katsuki slowly let his grip fall from Izuku’s arm. He didn’t know how to hold on to the things that mattered most to him, and this was no different. He wanted to figure it out.

“You didn’t answer my question. From earlier.”

I want to know how you feel about me .

“If it really hasn’t changed, I get it,” Izuku said. He took a step back. “If you hate me for… for *that* , I understand. And if you never stopped hating me to begin with, that’s okay too.”

Katsuki looked down at his bum arm, scars marring the back of his hand and his entire forearm. Beneath his shirt, on his shoulder and abdomen, he bore scars on both his front and back. In his chest, beneath layers of muscle and tissue, his heart was stitched back together.

All of those things had happened to Katsuki because of how much he cared about Izuku.

It should have scared him shitless, and for so long it had. He should have pushed his feelings down and ignored them. He should have never given a name to them, and he should have never fed into them to begin with. His feelings for Izuku had led to him dying.

And yet, Katsuki felt nothing but calm. For once in his life, he didn’t want to run away from this. He didn’t want to let his fear of being weak rule his life. He didn’t want his idiotic habits to take away the one thing he really, really wanted.

“Everything,” he whispered.

“What?”

“I feel everything for you.” He took one of Izuku’s hand in his good one. He traced his thumb over Izuku’s knuckles. “Competition. Rivalry. Whatever the hell you want to call it. Every time you’re better than me, I want to beat the piss out of you and work even harder to catch up. Regret, for how I treated you. Worry, because your nerd ass jumps head first into danger without thinking of the consequences.”

Izuku looked away, his expression guilty.

“Hatred, yeah.” Izuku’s eyes snapped back to Katsuki’s face, and for the first time in the conversation, he looked truly scared. “I hate you a whole fucking lot sometimes, you know

that right?"

"Why?"

"Because you fucking-" Katsuki broke off, running a hand through his hair. "I don't fucking get it. I don't know why it started. But you… you do what nobody else has ever done to me."

Katsuki's entire world was narrowed in on the person right in front of him, the person who had somehow always been by his side, even when their paths should have separated. He didn't believe in fate, or destiny, or whatever the hell else. He didn't think there was some higher power out there, pulling strings to ensure that he and Izuku were always together.

In the same way the Earth orbited the sun, in the same way his heart pumped blood throughout his body, Katsuki was meant to be by Izuku's side. It wasn't fate or destiny, it was simply a fact.

"What's that?" Izuku murmured.

"You make me give a shit about stupid things. You make me want to work harder and be a better person. You make me lose my mind in battle when I think you're in danger. And I know you can fucking protect yourself, because you have a stupid OP quirk and you're a nerdy idiot and you're *jacked* as shit. It's not about that, Izuku. I don't need to fucking protect you, but I can't fucking handle it when I think there's a chance that you might not be okay. I don't know why I feel that way, or why it makes me so fucking crazy, but… but - I-"

"You don't have to explain yourself, Kacchan. I-"

"You look at me and I'm *weak* ," he breathed, because he'd been holding back his feelings for months, and he couldn't keep them in any longer. "And I don't even hate you for it. I don't want you to *stop* looking at me."

"I won't," Izuku said, his voice ragged. "Promise."

"You fucking better not."

"How could I? You're tall and blonde and handsome. You've got great eyes. And-"

"Alright, 'Zuku, cool it," Katsuki said. His face was flushed. "You're gonna run out of compliments."

Izuku was smiling up at him and *oh* , this was so real. This wasn't a dream.

It should have been a dream, but it wasn't, and Katsuki wasn't nearly as afraid as he'd thought he would be.

He hadn't planned on ever telling Izuku how he felt. When he was alone, his fear of being weak always seemed to outweigh the potential outcomes of admitting how he felt. But with Izuku, Katsuki wasn't afraid.

"Gonna kiss me, nerd? Or are you waiting for me to die again?"

Izuku complied, and this time they got one step closer to getting it right. Katsuki tilted his head to the side, and his fingers found purchase in the short curls at the back of Izuku's neck. "Bad joke," Izuku breathed against his lips, before kissing Katsuki even harder, fists clenching in the fabric of Katsuki's shirt on his shoulders. His heart was beating so *fast* , and his skin was burning, and Katsuki wanted *more* .

He hadn't let himself think too hard about this, because he'd been so convinced that he would never fix all the things he had done, but now that Katsuki had it within his reach, he couldn't find it in him to let go. Even as his lungs swelled and told him to take a break, he couldn't, not when Izuku was kissing him like he fucking meant it, tugging on his shoulders, fingers fisting in Katsuki's hair and *pulling* , pressing his body to Katsuki's and letting out tiny noises that were bordering on maddening.

Calloused palms were splayed on his cheeks, palms that were used to working fervently and selfishly. The strong body against his had been built on dedication and perseverance. Everything about Izuku was brave and heroic and *wondrous* .

Izuku broke away from him after what felt like only a few seconds, but also a lifetime, and this time, Katsuki didn't try to run away.

He was still scared. He was scared shitless.

Katsuki didn't know how to navigate things like this in the way Izuku did. Talking about his feelings was an alien concept to him, and pursuing them was even further away from his typical approach to things.

But Katsuki *wanted* .

All his life, he'd been chasing after a dream that had been implanted in him. He'd wanted to become number one, because so many people had been so sure he was capable of it. He'd wanted to prove to everyone that he was the strongest, the bravest, the *best* . Nothing else had mattered. He'd pushed friendships and extracurriculars to the side, and he'd dedicated a majority of his time to training.

But wanting Izuku felt so much *better* than wanting number one. He wanted to become the number one Hero to prove that he was the best. He wanted Izuku on his own accord. It was exhilarating and private and overwhelming, and it was *everything, everything, everything* .

It was terrifying and vulnerable and frustrating. It was exciting and breathless and warm. It was so much, all at once, that Katsuki didn't know how to handle it.

"What now?" he asked stupidly.

Izuku laughed, his forehead still pressed to Katsuki's. "I don't know. I've never made out with anyone before."

"Really? Fucking loser."

Izuku pulled back, his eyebrows pinching together. “You *have* ? Kacchan, why didn’t you tell me? Who was it?”

“Cool it, nerd. I haven’t kissed anyone either.”

“That would make you a loser, too.”

“No, you’re a loser because nobody wants to kiss you. Nobody has been up to my standards.”

Izuku grinned. “Until me.”

“Oh, don’t start getting a fucking ego.” Katsuki threw an arm around Izuku’s shoulders, pulling him close. He realized, with a huff at annoyance towards himself, that this was probably the first hug they had shared in over a decade. Izuku’s wayward curls tickled Katsuki’s face, but his body was muscular and warm against Katsuki. The simple notion of being hugged by Izuku was so *comforting* .

He’d started to let himself rely on others. Especially Izuku.

Izuku didn’t know what to do either. That meant Katsuki wasn’t alone or behind on this aspect, but he still didn’t know how to keep moving.

Was it that simple? Was it okay that they hadn’t figured everything out yet?

“So… I guess we should… get to cleaning? You said it’s a date, remember?”

“Raise your damn standards, ‘Zuku. What the hell kind of first date is cleaning up this shithole?”

“You said it! What standards should I even have? I’ve never been on a date.”

“Yeah, me fucking neither but I’ll be damned if my first date is cleaning up the dorms.”

“So it’s not a date, then?” Izuku looked up at him, his eyes all wide and playful. Katsuki’s breath caught.

“If you want it to be a date, it’s a fucking date, you sappy piece of shit.”

“Romantic, Kacchan. I’m surprised you don’t have more fangirls falling in love with you.”

“I have more than enough fangirls, asshole. Class Prez has to fight them off in the hallways.”

Izuku laughed into Katsuki’s neck, his breath warm. Katsuki shuddered. “You can’t even handle a couple fangirls? I thought you were big and tough and scary.”

“I fucking am, thank you very much.” Katsuki flicked Izuku’s nose.

“Of course you are,” Izuku said. “The Romantic *and* Scary Hero: Great Explosion Murder God Dynamight.”

Katsuki kicked him. “I am *not* romantic.”

“No, you’re… what did I say? *Endearing* ?”

Katsuki groaned. “And you’re sickening.”

Izuku mockingly put a hand over his heart. “I think that made me want to kiss you even more.”

“Shut up.”

“Charming, Kacchan. My pants are practically falling off.”

“Why do I even fucking like you again?”

Chapter End Notes

erm... hey guys... like two weeks later... ha ha

I'm soooo sorry for the late update I've actually been having the hardest and most stressful semester of my entire life (fuck it we ball) and I'm finally on spring break but I've been working soooo I haven't had a ton of time to write. I really wanted to put effort into this one and I hope it's good but I know it's not my best. I'm genuinely just so burnt out, and I wish I'd started this at a point in my life when I would have had more time to dedicate to it

I've seriously been having so much fun writing this tho. it's coming to an end here soon but maybe in the future I'll be back w more works? we shall see!

hope you guys enjoyed :) find me on TikTok @lvndrsunny

sailor song

Chapter Summary

I don't believe in god
but I believe that you're my savior

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki had no clue how to progress from the point he had reached.

It was honestly funny that he'd died and ended up here.

Maybe it was all a wonderful dream, a sick delusion playing out as his body decomposed and returned to the ground.

He couldn't pinpoint the exact moment during which he'd decided he no longer wanted to punch Izuku, but instead wanted to kiss him, but *somehow* he'd ended up getting all that he'd wanted and more.

Katsuki had never been one to stress, and he sure as shit wasn't going to start. Izuku did enough of that for both of them.

After their conversation in the kitchen, Izuku jumped just about every time Katsuki brushed past him. He'd spent so long trying to hide his feelings from Izuku, pretending like they didn't exist, that he wasn't sure what to do now that everything was in the open. He wasn't going to become a doting, lovesick sap, and that clearly wasn't what Izuku had seen in him. But he didn't know who to be when he wasn't *hiding* ; it was all he'd ever done. Every feeling he'd ever had had been buried beneath the rubble of his own insecurities, and Katsuki had *finally* started to figure it out.

Clearly, Izuku didn't know how to navigate whatever the fuck was going on either. Katsuki caught him staring often, like when they were scrubbing the windows, or vacuuming, or tidying up the common room.

After a few hours, Katsuki couldn't take it anymore.

"The fuck are you so jumpy for?"

"Huh? I don't know what you're talking about, Kacchan, I-"

"Oh, cut the shit. What's the matter?"

“Nothing’s *wrong* ,” Izuku said. He paused in his cleaning, setting down his rag and scratching the back of his head, his face pensive. Katsuki didn’t like seeing Izuku worked up, but *god* was it cute. “I’m just… I don’t know. I don’t know what we’re doing.”

“Wiping off the coffee table?”

“ *Kacchan* . Not that.”

“Then what?”

“Seriously?”

“Yeah, seriously.” Katsuki set his own rag down, crossing his arms poorly. “If you regret it just fucking say it.”

Because there was always a needle of doubt and self-loathing worming its way through Katsuki’s brain. It would likely never go away.

“ *What* ? That’s not it at all.”

“So you don’t regret it?”

“No, Kacchan, stop that.”

“Good.” He moved around the table, stopping in front of Izuku and watching as he inhaled sharply. Before he could think or question or doubt himself, he leaned down and kissed Izuku. It was nothing like the kiss they’d shared that morning in the kitchen; it was quick and soft and all their own. When Katsuki had kissed Izuku earlier, it had been driven by months of pent up longing. This kiss was simple and easy and casual. It was something he could get used to.

“You can’t just *do* that,” Izuku murmured, his face red. He snatched his rag off the coffee table and resumed wiping, scrubbing at a spot that had already been wiped five times over.

“Why not?”

“I don’t know, Kacchan. What if someone walked in?”
“I don’t give a shit.”

“Okay, what if it was, I don’t know, Aizawa? Or All Might? Or your *mom* ?”

“They’re gonna find out eventually.”

“Find out *what* , exactly?” Izuku said, his exasperation finally coming out in full force. “ *That’s* why I’m so jumpy. Because we kissed in the kitchen and you told me how you felt and you just kissed me like it’s normal and I don’t know what any of it means and-”

“What do you want it to mean?”

“ *What* ?”

“I don’t know, ‘Zuku, you tell me. You’re the one that’s probably already thought up five billion scenarios and explanations.”

“You haven’t been thinking about it?”

“I’ve spent the last fucking six months thinking about kissing you. All I’m thinking about is doing it more.”

Izuku’s entire face went bright red.

“I just… I don’t know what this means for us. What does it mean for our futures? How does something like this affect our potential as Heroes? Does this make us vulnerable? How do we hide this from our friends and family? Is this something we should just let go and ignore because there are so many things that can go *wrong* ?”

Katsuki couldn’t answer Izuku’s questions because Katsuki didn’t *know* . Neither of them had ever been in this position; they hadn’t sat through a lecture on this one, or written a paper about it, or taken an exam. There wasn’t a play-by-play of what to do when you fell in love with your rival-turned-best-friend after one of you died.

But Katsuki had been pushing ahead for most of his life, and everything about Izuku was so fucking worth it that he would take every chance.

“I don’t give a shit what anyone thinks of me.”

“You want to be number one. That’s all you’ve ever wanted.”

“Things change.”

“ *Kacchan* .”

“I still want to be number one. I still want to kick your ass in everything. Doesn’t mean I don’t want this just as much.”

Izuku looked away, his face still wonderfully red. “Yeah.”

“ *Yeah* .”

“I just- I-” Izuku broke off, shaking his head and sighing. “What is *this* ? What are the rules, Kacchan?”

“I don’t fucking know. Are there rules?”

“What even is this? Us?”

“What do you want it to be?”

“What do *you* want it to be?”

“Hey, asshole, I asked first.”

“But how am I supposed to know if we want the same thing out of this?”

Katsuki sighed, pinching the bridge of his nose. Of course Izuku was too wrapped up in a torrent of worries to just *breathe* .

“Izuku.”

“Kacchan.”

“Whatever you want, I want it. You want to pretend like this never happened? You want to bring all our fuckass friends in and tell them all? You want to, I don’t fucking know, hold my hand in the hallway? Fucking sure.”

Izuku’s eyebrows raised. “Really?”

“No, I wouldn’t hold your hand in the hallway, that’s gay as shit.”

Izuku glared at him. “I don’t want to hold your hand. Your hands are sweaty.”

“How many notebooks do you have about my sweat, asshole?”

“Don’t make it sound weird.”

“Don’t know how I could make it sound normal.”

Izuku rolled his eyes, finishing with his scrubbing of the coffee table. He started gathering their cleaning materials while Katsuki watched (mostly because the view was good, partly because his arm was aching after pushing his limits throughout the day). It was early afternoon at this point, and most of their classmates wouldn’t be back for a few hours.

“We don’t have to figure everything out right this second, Izuku,” Katsuki said after a while. He didn’t know what to say to Izuku to alleviate his stress.

Izuku headed towards the stairs, going up them backwards as he narrowed his eyes at Katsuki. “So what do we do now? Or tomorrow?”

They stopped on the second floor landing. Izuku took a few steps down the hall, but Katsuki caught his hand.

“I don’t fucking know. Let me take you out on an actual date.”

“This wasn’t an actual date?”

“Fuck no. I’m better than that.”

“Yeah?”

“Yeah. I’ll be fucking, I don’t know, number one at going out on dates.” Katsuki started up the stairs, pulling Izuku up after him.

“Really? What if I wanted to take you out on a date?”

“As long as it’s nothing fucking All Might themed, I’m all yours.”

Izuku smiled at him. Katsuki rolled his eyes in response.

Katsuki had spent enough time worrying to continue. He’d gotten the smallest taste of what he’d been wanting for so long, and he no longer had to hide behind walls and walls of anger and defensiveness. Katsuki didn’t want to spend his time thinking over all the things that could somehow come between him and Izuku; he’d fucking *died* for Izuku, and if that hadn’t kept them apart, he didn’t know what could.

If they didn’t have a name for whatever was going on between them, he didn’t *care* . He’d spent so much time waiting, and it had been worth it; waiting a bit longer until their lives were in a better place was logically the best option. It didn’t mean Katsuki wanted to wait, but over the course of loving Izuku, he’d learned the valuable lesson of patience.

And it didn’t matter if there were a million roadblocks that they would need to work through and talk about; as long as Izuku kept holding Katsuki’s hand and smiling at him like he deserved it, Katsuki could wait and wait and wait.

They spent the rest of the afternoon in Katsuki’s room, and his heart beat uncontrollably in his chest the entire time. Izuku was *in his room* , and Katsuki was laying in bed with him, trying to act like this wasn’t the most exhilarating moment of his entire life. Some TV show was playing in the background, but Katsuki didn’t pay attention. If anything, he was more interested in the rise and fall of Izuku’s chest underneath his cheek.

They ate dinner with the class, like usual, and though Kirishima and Mina kept giving him very pointed looks, he sat with them and pretended like everything was normal. He acted like house arrest was another one of Aizawa’s pointless punishments, even as Izuku smiled that pretty smile at him from the other end of the table.

Katsuki didn’t give a shit if people knew who he kissed in his spare time.

Izuku had brought up the point, and while it was very relevant to both of their futures, Katsuki simply didn’t care.

The Commission had a plethora of rules regarding personal relationships for Heroes. Privacy was a large part of it; villains were notorious for targeting people that were close with Heroes. If Katsuki was a villain, he would probably do the same thing. For the most part, Heroes shared minimal information with the public regarding their personal lives. He’d only learned that Rock Lock had a wife and child because Kirishima had worked with him during his internship.

Hero salaries typically paid enough for comfortable lives for the top 300 Pros, and the salaries were very generous for the top 100 Heroes. Some Heroes were paid a general salary to do the more menial tasks. These were Heroes typically ranked 200 and up. They didn’t assist in big missions unless their quirk was well-suited to the scenario, and they worked in shifts. Other Heroes - typically ranked under 100 - were on call for larger threats. They still

did scheduled shifts, but were more often than not pulled away to assist with other attacks and missions.

For Heroes that worked shifts, they were guaranteed as much stability as possible while being a Hero. They typically weren't sent far from their homes for missions and shifts, and they had relatively consistent schedules. For the higher ranked Pros, stability was thrown out the window. There was no telling where the Commission would send high-level Pros, or what missions they would be sent on. It was a main factor of why many Pros weren't married, or why they didn't have kids.

Still, Heroes weren't meant to publicly reveal the identities of their significant others and/or children, and they were encouraged to avoid confirming personal details in general, as a precaution. UA required all students to have a good understanding of the Commission's lengthy regulations before they were able to graduate, and Katsuki had already read over them a few times.

There weren't so many cases of Pros being married to other Pros, which was surprising, considering, from Katsuki's experiences, most of the adults he knew had met their partners through work. The Commission was a little more lenient towards those couples regarding privacy rules. In the case of a villain targeting one Hero out of a couple, that Hero was licensed to use their quirk in self-defense, while the average person wouldn't be. The rules were long and boring, and Katsuki just *didn't care* .

Before he and Izuku had even admitted their feelings to each other, they'd been weaponized to hurt each other. Shigaraki had killed Katsuki just to elicit a reaction from Izuku. If they continued on the path they were on, what would it change if they were together?

Sure, Katsuki was willing to lay his life down for Izuku, and Izuku became irrationally angry and possessive whenever anyone hurt Katsuki, but they were two of the strongest potential Heroes out there. They were stronger than a number of Pros after only finishing one year of high school; if someone wanted to target them, they'd see the same fate that Shigaraki had.

Katsuki *wanted* to be seen with Izuku. He wanted to flaunt the fact that Izuku chose him, and he wanted Izuku to feel the same way about him. He refused to feel ashamed about who he was, and he wouldn't hide from it. That wasn't how he operated. Throughout his entire life, when people had turned up their nose at him for whatever reason, he hadn't given two shits. This was no different.

After dinner, Katsuki dodged an interrogation from Kirishima and Mina and went straight to his room, leaving it unlocked behind him.

He was still on edge. He put on a brave face for Izuku, but he wasn't completely confident. There were so many fears and insecurities terrorizing his brain, and he couldn't switch them off. He'd once used anger as a shield, but he'd lost his anger towards his own emotions. He didn't know how to hide them, and he didn't know how to be open about them, and he didn't know *anything* .

The door creaked open later in the evening, when Katsuki was laying in bed, scrolling mindlessly on his phone. He didn't have to look up to know without a doubt that Izuku was

the one that had entered.

The mattress dipped as Izuku crawled onto the bed beside Katsuki. Katsuki set his phone down, but left it on so that the light illuminated Izuku's face.

"Hi," Izuku said.

"Hi."

"So, uhm. It's been a pretty crazy day."

"Izuku. Stop that."

"I don't know what to say," Izuku said, hiding his face in the pillow. "24 hours ago, I kissed you and we both ran away and didn't talk about it. And then we made out in the kitchen. And in the living room. And in your room."

"Your point?"

"I just… I didn't expect it all. And I don't know what I'm doing."

"You think I do?"

Izuku propped his head up on a fist. "You seem like it."

"I don't know shit. Every five seconds I'm convinced that none of this is real."

Izuku reached out and brushed his thumb over the scar on Katsuki's cheek. His calloused thumb sent shivers racing across Katsuki's skin. "It's real."

Katsuki just rolled his eyes.

"Can I stay here?"

He did a double take, peering at Izuku. "Huh?"

"Can I sleep here? I'll stay on the floor if you-"

"The fuck? You're not sleeping on the floor."

"I don't want to… rush you."
Katsuki kissed him once, because he could. Because Izuku was so pure and selfless and kind, and it made Katsuki so irrationally giddy.

"Don't try and seduce me in the night."

Izuku giggled, moving closer. Katsuki pulled Izuku to his chest, mesmerized by the solid body pressed against his own. "No promises."

Their next day of house arrest was less eventful than the first. There was no grand reveal in the kitchen, and most of their cleaning had been done the day before. Katsuki wasn't complaining whatsoever. There were other things that interested him much more than cleaning up after his classmates. Like kissing Izuku senseless on the common room couch. Or replaying that morning in his head over and over and over again. He'd woken up to Izuku's soft hair tickling his face, his voice rough from sleep. Izuku had clung to Katsuki that morning, had kissed him over and over again until Katsuki was sure his heart was going to explode.

Katsuki's first year of high school at UA had been anything but normal. Or, it deviated from whatever 'normal' was for 'hero-in-training' high school. Villain attacks, invasions, a war, *dying* , falling in love with his childhood best friend, you name it.

Izuku had left UA in April, right around the time during which Class 1A should have become Class 2A. Their finals had been cancelled for the most part, which would have typically excited the class. At first, it had. They were getting field experience against genuine villains, not spending hours poring over textbooks and taking exams.

The trade-off had been worse than any of them had expected, though, and exams almost sounded unbelievably exciting when compared to watching your friends die and fighting for your life.

The war, and what came after it, had stretched on into the very first weeks of June. The rainy season had just begun, but the air was starting to grow warmer. The surviving trees on campus sprouted flowers, and birds sang in the mornings. On Katsuki's walks from Heights Alliance to the main campus each morning, he could almost pretend like the surrounding area hadn't suffered extreme damage. Much of Musutafu had been decimated, and half the city lay in ruins. Civilians were slowly returning to their homes, if said homes had survived the war, but a majority of citizens remained in shelters, anguished over the things they had lost.

Instead of being thrown back into a semester, Nedzu had decided to employ UA students to help aid in war reparations. They cleaned up ruins and assisted with fixing up homes. They cooked and served food at refugee camps. Some students were enlisted to help with patrols, ensuring that the citizens that had returned home were safe, and that villains weren't terrorizing them.

They spent a few weeks like that, distracting themselves with heroic helpfulness. Most of Katsuki's classmates put all of their time and focus into the post-war efforts. By the time the sun set on UA, his classmates trudged back to the dorms, thoroughly exhausted, their energy too spent for them to dwell on memories of the war.

Most of them avoided talking about what they had experienced. Katsuki tried his best to not be reminded of the war, but that was exceedingly hard to accomplish when he could barely bend the fingers of his right hand. It seemed to be all he could think about, most days, even when he tried to keep it off his mind.

His frustrations grew more and more each and every day. He couldn't use his right hand, and learning how to use his left for everything was harder than he'd anticipated. He had appointments upon appointments, from physical therapists to occupational therapists to

cardiologists. Each appointment left him feeling worse than the last; he'd attend therapy for his arm and hand, and he'd leave without making any progress. He couldn't close his fingers around a pen or pencil, he couldn't hold chopsticks, he couldn't make a fist.

Katsuki's best method of coping was to pretend like nothing had ever happened. If he sat around moping, the League would have won, and he wouldn't give them that fucking satisfaction. He wasn't happy after the war, he wasn't whole, and he certainly had some underlying issues, but he wouldn't allow himself to wait around for those issues to fix themselves.

He did simple things, *easy* things. He went on a run every morning, rebuilding his endurance, which had been wrecked after his death and near-month-long hospital stay. Some mornings, he'd nudge Izuku awake, even after Izuku would complain about Katsuki's ridiculously early alarms. Izuku would still pull himself out of Katsuki's bed, yawning and wiping sleep from his eyes as they stepped out into the early morning chill.

Katsuki would cook dinner for the class, which was something he'd done often before the war. As much as he pretended like it was a hassle, he enjoyed their praise over his cooking. It wasn't a perfect escape, though, and his frustrations were fueled when he couldn't grip a knife, or hold a pot handle, or wash a dish. Sometimes, he'd smash a plate off the ground to alleviate his anger. Sometimes, even as the plate shattered into a million porcelain pieces, he didn't feel better. He'd kick over the kitchen stools, or throw ingredients at the walls, or shout at whoever was dumb enough to come into the kitchen to see what had happened.

A lot of the time, Izuku would take the brunt of it. He'd come into the kitchen, and he'd know in an instant that Katsuki hadn't accidentally dropped a plate. He could read through Katsuki's bunched shoulders and scowl.

Whatever was between them hadn't changed much. They still argued and picked at each other, they were still each other's greatest asset and most detrimental weakness. Nobody could frustrate Katsuki as fast as Izuku did, and nobody could calm Katsuki's nerves as easily and as simply as Izuku.

Sometimes, Katsuki would scream at Izuku in the kitchen. He'd tell Izuku he hated him, that he couldn't stand his coddling, that he didn't need Izuku's stupid help to clean up a broken plate. Even as Izuku swept up the pieces into a dustpan, letting Katsuki shout his frustrations, Izuku wouldn't respond. He would pick up the pieces, because Katsuki couldn't.

Sometimes, Katsuki would scream until his voice broke and his throat ached, and on very few occasions, he'd collapsed to the floor, his back to the island, his head hidden in his knees. Tears had welled in his eyes, embarrassing and blinding, and he was reminded that his fury, that he'd taken out on everyone else, was at himself.

On those days, Izuku would finish cleaning up whatever mess Katsuki had made, turn off the stove, and join Katsuki on the ground. Izuku would let Katsuki cry into his shoulder for as long as it took, and he wouldn't say a word.

Katsuki felt guilty everytime he shouted at Izuku, but he could never bring himself to broach the topic afterwards. Izuku cleaned up the mess and let Katsuki get his feelings out in the

only way he knew how, and even if it wasn't right, he was so incredibly grateful.

When he got angry with his parents and argued with them, his mother would shout right back, which did absolutely nothing to calm Katsuki's nerves. She'd call him weak, she'd tell him that he was doing nothing to help himself, she'd pick away at his every insecurity. His father would butt in on occasion, but would never take sides. When his friends witnessed him losing his temper over things that had once been second nature to him, they'd treat him like he was a fragile child. They'd fuss over him, trying to help him with the smallest tasks, even when he shouted at them that he *didn't need their fucking help* .

Izuku didn't coddle him, though, as much as Katsuki accused him of it. He didn't try to take tasks into his own hands and out of Katsuki's; most of the time, his brain was running a million miles per hour, trying to figure out the best way for Katsuki to work around his inhibitions. For every task that Katsuki struggled with, Izuku was right there to supply him with an alternate method of execution. Even when it pissed Katsuki off that Izuku was, most of the time, right, it was better than being treated like a child.

He let Izuku help him, because Izuku's help came without the added insult of being pitied. He was learning how to lean on others, but that didn't mean he needed the entire world to feel fucking *sorry* for him everytime something was hard. He wasn't helpless, as much as he felt like it some days. He was crippled, and there was so much he needed to relearn, but having his hand held through every second of his recovery wouldn't help him.

There were days in which he almost couldn't bring himself to leave Izuku's side. He'd thought that, the more time placed between him and the war, the more at peace with it he would become. But healing didn't happen linearly, and some days felt worse than being on the actual battlefield. They had come so incredibly close to losing each other forever. Being separated from Izuku sometimes sent Katsuki into a panic; when they weren't with each other, he couldn't stop panicking until he knew where Izuku was and who he was with.

When rain doused the campus, pouring down in sheets that lashed at the campus, Katsuki felt immediately uneasy. Mere months ago, he'd been laying on campus grounds, drenched to the bone, his heart failing. He couldn't bring himself to step outside when it was raining; he could remember how the rain had felt that day, so cold on his skin, slicing through the blood and grime plastered to his face. Rain had always left him feeling a bit helpless; it washed away his sweat and reduced the strength of his explosions. Now, it left him feeling vulnerable for an entirely different reason.

Izuku understood silently. When Katsuki had no choice but to make the trip to campus in the rain, Izuku was always finding him in the morning, rain jacket and umbrella held out in offering.

At first, Katsuki had been so frustrated with himself. He was training to be a hero and he couldn't handle the fucking *rain* ?

"Do you think that using support items makes me weak?" Izuku had asked him, after Katsuki had refused to use his obnoxious All Might umbrella.

"No?"

“Exactly,” Izuku said. “Stop thinking of it as something you need because you’re weak and think of it as something that helps make you stronger.”

Katsuki had reluctantly taken the umbrella, popping it open and heading off the porch of the dorms, Izuku at his side. “So fucking wise.”

Izuku’s cheeks had gone red.

“Your umbrella isn’t exactly inconspicuous, though. Couldn’t have gone with one that doesn’t scream, ‘I love All Might and I’m scared of the rain’?”

“My mom got me it,” Izuku whined, sticking close to Katsuki’s side to avoid getting lashed by the rain. “It’s sentimental.”

“I could throw a rock at your face and you’d call it sentimental.”

“Depends on if you throw the rock with love or not.”

“How the fuck am I supposed to throw a rock at you out of love?”

There were other days, in which Katsuki had to be the strong one.

Sometimes, Izuku would break down crying, and Katsuki wouldn’t always be able to figure out why. There were so many things that could have caused it, so many horrific memories and nightmares to choose from. Sometimes, Izuku would rest his ear over Katsuki’s heart, his fingers pressed to one of Katsuki’s pulse points, and that would be enough to stop his tears. Other times, he’d cry for what felt like hours, and Katsuki would hold him, feeling so utterly useless.

In the beginning, most of Izuku’s bad days started with nightmares and sleepless nights. Other times, somebody would say something about the war, or a poorly worded joke, and Izuku would grow so abnormally quiet. Then, as they’d started training again after Aizawa’s unfortunate interruption, he’d started to mourn the loss of the quirks that had been taken away from him.

Their good days didn’t always match up. There were times when Katsuki wanted nothing more than to scream and fight and avoid his feelings and Izuku was *happy* and excited to be back at school, looking like he had survived the war and come out the exact same afterwards. Then there were days that were the opposite, when Katsuki felt *good* , when he didn’t feel like his hand was holding him back, and Izuku looked miserable, his shoulders hunched and his eyes teary. It was hard to navigate; he didn’t want to bring Izuku down with him, and he wouldn’t be offended if Izuku didn’t want to expend his energy making Katsuki feel better. He was sure Izuku probably felt a similar tug towards hiding his feelings out of fear of being a burden, but Katsuki never let him get away with it.

At first, they’d do the whole mushy feelings talk. They were still figuring things out since they’d kissed, since Katsuki had admitted his feelings to Izuku in the kitchen. They hadn’t exactly clarified what it *was* they were doing, or the logistics (if that was something you were supposed to do). It was a bit… awkward at first. When was an appropriate time to kiss

someone that you'd been in love with for god knows how long? Was he even supposed to be thinking about kissing Izuku after one of them had just gotten done crying?

After way too many times crying to each other and then wallowing in misery, Katsuki decided to take a different approach. When Izuku couldn't bring himself to crawl out of bed in the morning, Katsuki would recruit Uraraka, Todoroki, Iida, and whatever other fuckheads he could find to cheer Izuku up. When Izuku was quiet on their walk back to the dorm after hours of working with refugees or cleaning up the city, Katsuki would change their route, stopping at the local take-out restaurant, or going to the ice cream shop, or swinging by the small store across the street to grab unhealthy snacks and soft drinks. It never completely brought Izuku back to his usual smiley self, but it alleviated some of the tension in his shoulders.

In a perfect world, they would have walked away from the war and returned to normal, whatever normal *was* anymore. But their world was far from perfect, and every single day reminded Katsuki of that. Small victories were still victories.

Midway through June, after the entire class was more than tired of assisting with war reparations, Nedzu announced that UA would commence with classes. It was a welcome relief; their post-war routine had become mind-numbing after the last month and a half. Katsuki could only take so much of it. When he was assigned to clearing out debris, he wasn't completely helpful; he couldn't do much heavy lifting, and his quirk was notorious for causing destruction, not relieving it. On days where he was placed on refugee duty, he considered poking his eye out with a fork. A majority of the refugees were blubbering and whiny, and another portion of them had become demanding the longer they were kept from returning to their homes. He didn't have the patience to answer their questions, which often ended in him getting reprimanded for having a bad attitude.

Throughout their first year, divided into three semesters, they'd taken a majority of introductory classes. At UA, students still had to take typical high school classes. Half of their day was occupied by those classes; while UA tried to keep homeroom classes together, their Gen Ed credits were mixes of students from different classes and courses. Of course, Katsuki and Izuku had always been neck and neck, even surrounded by other classmates.

The other half of the day was dedicated to whatever classes aligned with their pledged course. In the first year of the Hero Course, they'd taken classes like Hero History, Quirk Analysis and Theory, Introductory Heroics, Introductory Marketing and Media, Combat Training, Basic First Aid, Hero Ethics, and Mission Strategy. Their first year of classes hadn't been particularly grueling; Hero History, Quirk A&T, and Introductory Heroics had been lecture-based courses that had made Katsuki want to drill his eyeballs out. He didn't give a shit about what Heroes had come before him and what they'd done, and he didn't give two shits about learning about quirks. He knew Izuku ate those classes up, the nerd. Introductory Heroics wasn't as miserable as the other two, since they actually covered content that was useful, like the structure of Hero society and the various areas of Hero work, but he still spent most of those lectures holding back his aggravation.

Katsuki had enjoyed Combat Training, Hero Ethics, and Mission Strategy. Not only did those classes get him out of the actual classroom, it was the closest he could get to actual Hero

work. Combat Training was self-explanatory; a lot of their classes were spent on one of the various training grounds around the campus. They would do team exercises or one-on-one sparring, practicing using their quirks to enhance their fighting styles. In Hero Ethics, they'd run through mock exercises, typically geared towards rescuing civilians. Katsuki's worst grades had been in that class, much to his irritation, but he couldn't deny the fact that he was terrible at comforting people. He'd also enjoyed Mission Strategy, which was more focused on preparing and planning for missions rather than executing them. On some of their assignments, Aizawa would force them to create strategies for missions with quirks that didn't pair well together.

The second year curriculum was typically more geared towards combat training and mission preparation. At that point, they were expected to have either learned and adapted to a specific set of heroic morals, or have been expelled. It was also assumed that they had learned enough about their own quirks to use them properly, and to have found the best possible ways of strengthening their individual quirks. Their course load tended to be lighter, as they were encouraged to take internships with the local agencies.

This semester, though, Aizawa had decided to take a different approach. Their semester was shortened, due to the war and the aftermath. None of Katsuki's classmates were particularly looking forward to classes that would be reminiscent of the war. Even Katsuki, during his duels with Izuku, had to struggle past memories of unexplainable *fear* , an all-consuming dread, and helplessness and weakness so prominent. Fighting, which had once been the very structure of Katsuki, was now something he didn't quite know how to approach. First off, because of his obvious physical liabilities. But also because of what he'd experienced.

The class as a whole had experienced villain attacks throughout their first year. Katsuki himself had been kidnapped by the League of Villains. Nothing compared to the horror of the war, and nothing had truly prepared them for it. They could sit in a classroom for hours and hours, they could train and duel every single day, and none of it would ever be comparable to the war. In the same sense, Katsuki didn't know how to handle the *after* . He'd experienced the worst villains that the world had to offer; why sit in a classroom after that?

"I'm excited to have class again," Mina was saying. She was sitting at her vanity, a face mask plastered to her skin. She was painting her nails an obnoxious shade of pink as she talked, and it was almost impressive how quickly she managed to paint each fingernail. "We've been doing the same stuff for *months* ."

"Agreed," Kaminari said. "I get sad seeing all those refugees every day."

"Of course you do," Katsuki scoffed. His back was resting against Mina's bed, his legs stretched out in front of him. He was curling and uncurling his right hand into her rug, doing his best to conceal his winces when his fingers refused to budge every so often.

"Sorry I have a heart, *Kacchan* . Not all of us want to become Heroes just so we can beat people up."

"Didn't you say you want to become a Hero so you look cool?" Jirou asked, raising her eyebrows at him. "You're not exactly the pillar of heroism yourself."

“Since when do you defend him? That’s so not cool.”

Jirou jabbed Kaminari with her lone earphone jack. He pouted at her.

“I think it’ll be good for everyone,” Kirishima said. “Starting classes again, I mean.”

“I miss the *drama* ,” Mina sighed, finishing with her nails. She screwed the lid back onto the polish bottle and spun around in her chair to face the rest of them. “And the stupid stuff. Like the Sports Festival. And having study parties. And regular parties.”

Kirishima smiled at her, so soft and adoring. Katsuki wondered if he ever looked that way when he looked at Izuku. “Maybe it’ll bring up the morale. Everyone seems so… quiet.”

“War tends to do that to people,” Jirou said. She was laying against Kaminari’s shoulder as she fiddled with her phone.

“Well, *yeah* ,” Kirishima said. “But maybe people will start feeling better once we get back into our normal routine.”

“You’re so optimistic,” Mina said. She slid to the floor where the rest of them sat, laying her head across Kirishima’s lap.

“Can you guys stop?” Sero whined. “I’m getting lonely.”

“You can cuddle with Bakugou,” Kaminari suggested. “He’s on the market.”

Katsuki lifted his hand, fully intending to light off an explosion right in his face, but Mina shrieked, grabbing onto his arm before he could.

“You wouldn’t *dare* ! Do you know how long it took me to decorate in here?”

“Oh, I fucking would dare.”

“It’s not like he said anything wrong,” Sero teased. “Unless you and Midor-”

“Shut the fuck up.”

“Oh, come *on* ,” Kaminari said, smirking. “We all know there’s something going on there.”

“You should learn how to mind your own goddamn business.”

“I thought you were trying to be a better friend,” Sero said. “Or was that only for Midoriya and not the rest of us?”

“Him and Midoriya are *great* friends,” Kaminari said, his eyebrows wiggling. “The type of friends that want to fuck.”

Jirou jabbed him again, and this time Kaminari yelped, rubbing at his arm.

“You’re all insufferable,” Katsuki grumbled, trying (and failing) to cross his arms over his chest. His right arm still refused to bend all the way, so he let it rest awkwardly at his side.

And then, because he *did* want to be a better friend, he said, “We kissed.”

Mina and Kirishima let out twin exhales and Katsuki shot them a look.

“I couldn’t keep it a secret anymore,” Mina said. “Do you know how hard it was to not tell Kaminari?”

“Wait a minute, you and Midoriya *kissed* ?” Kaminari shouted. Then, “Wait, Mina, you *knew* ?”

“Oh, yeah, Blasty told me as soon as it happened.”

“Okay, first of all, that hurts, man. Second of all, details?”

“Fuck off,” Katsuki groaned. “We kissed. What other details do you fucking want?”

“Was he a good kisser?” Kaminari asked.

“I bet Bakugou’s not,” Sero said, laughing.

“Fuck you.”

“I think it’s cute,” Mina cooed. “Bakugou Katsuki, the cold-hearted, closed-off asshole Hero with a soft spot for Midoriya Izuku, the favorite of All Might and the nicest person you’ll ever meet.” She sighed. “I, for one, have always seen the potential.”

“Yeah, I mean, sometimes your rivalry was a little… much,” Kaminari agreed. “We could all see the sexual tension.”

“I always knew,” Jirou said, shrugging. “You were always checking him out. Especially when he got all those upgrades on his Hero costume.”

Katsuki’s first instinct was to deny, deny, deny. But he took a deep breath. He wasn’t being exploited for being weak, he was talking to his friends. He was talking to friends who didn’t see him as less than just for loving someone.

“So?”

“Who kissed who?” Sero asked, cutting off the conversation. “I don’t want all the details. I just have a lot of money riding on this.”

Katsuki glared away at the wall. “Izuku kissed me.”

The room broke out into pandemonium. Money was passed between the group. Katsuki heard shouts of, “I fucking *knew it* !”

At one point, it would have made him uncomfortable and angry to be the center of a joke, to be picked on and teased.

But this was something he wanted to get used to. His friends, laughing and poking fun at him, not caring about who was the strongest, or who was the best, or who's quirk was the most powerful. For once, those things didn't matter. For once, Katsuki didn't have to push and push and push himself just to feel like he was good enough for himself.

It was like a breath of fresh air, to be around people that held him to no standard, that didn't have expectations laid out for him.

"Are you at least going to tell us how?" Kaminari whined. "Was it romantic? Were there candles and rose petals?"

"It was right after we got done beating the shit out of each other."

"Close enough."

Chapter End Notes

... hiiiiii

okay guys I've been having such a rough semester after spring break so pls forgive me for this long overdue update. I had so many exams the past two weeks that I've been studying for and I haven't been motivated BUT I liked how this chapter got into their healing (mentally) and just being able to explore how healing isn't linear and perfect for everyone :)

this fic is probably going to wrap up here soon?? I think??? I want to explore their healing a bit more and I want to do an epilogue with glimpses into their future. but you may be seeing more bkdk from me in the future?? we shall see??

I love all your comments and appreciate ur kudos so so very much!

lav <3

supercut

Chapter Summary

I'm someone you maybe might love
I'll be your quiet afternoon crush
be your violent overnight rush
make you crazy over my touch

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Things are kind of boring around here when we’re not preparing for war,” Mina said, tossing her pencil onto the table and pouting. “This time last year, we were going into battle with the most dangerous villains to ever live.”

“And this is the most dangerous English homework to ever live,” Iida said, pushing his glasses up his nose and giving her a pointed look.

“Iida, was that a *joke* ?” Kaminari said, fake gasping. “Are you okay?”

“Kaminari, you should take this seriously-”

“Oh, save it, Class Prez,” Katsuki grumbled. “I don’t think you’ll ever succeed in making him give a shit about anything other than impressing Ears.”

“Yeah, aren’t you ranked, like, worst in the class?” Kirishima asked.

“That depends,” Kaminari said, propping his elbows on the table. “What’s the category?”

“Intelligence,” Mina said.

“I’m definitely not the *dumbest* ,” he argued.

“Definitely are,” Sero said, flicking a piece of paper at Kaminari.

“Okay, well, if we’re talking looks, then I’m at least top 3.”

“What’s your ranking?” Todoroki asked from down the table.

“Come on, Todoroki, you know damn well you’re number one.”

Todoroki, with his annoyingly stoic face, just blinked. “Oh. Thank you.”

Katsuki snorted. “Yeah fucking right. IcyHot isn’t number one at shit.”

“Then what’s your ranking, Kacchan?” Izuku asked from Katsuki’s left. His eyes flashed playfully as he looked up from his homework.

“Yeah, *Kacchan* ,” Kaminari said, “what’s your ranking?”

“You’re all ugly and I’m number one. Obviously.”

Izuku kicked him under the table. Katsuki kicked back.

“Izuku, it may be time to reevaluate,” Mina said, reaching across the table to pat his cheek in faux sympathy. “Blink twice if you want us to rescue you.”

Izuku just laughed, but to Katsuki it wasn’t *just laughing* . His laugh sounded whole and real and genuine, and he couldn’t pinpoint the moment it had switched to that from the awful forced laughter Izuku had done after the war. Here was Izuku, smiling and laughing and happy, with his hair grown back in, with his bright eyes and anxious muttering. And here was Katsuki, writing (sloppily and slowly) with his right arm, completely cleared from his cardiologist with annual check-ups only.

At the pace of a snail, their lives had returned to normal. Somehow, after fighting a war and killing villains, everything had returned to what it had once been. Nearly a year after the war, Katsuki sat at a table in the common room, surrounded by his friends, bitching about assignments and procrastinating studying.

The last year hadn’t been easy in any sense, though.

Katsuki had never been so busy in his life. From school and assignments to a work study to his numerous doctor’s appointments, Katsuki barely had a second to *breathe* . On top of that, his parents were up his ass every second of every day.

Obviously, with him *dying on live television* , that was to be expected. But his mom had always had an… odd parenting style, and Katsuki had secretly hoped she would stay off his back like she had before. But after he had died, she’d had a breakdown that she should have been more involved, more protective, more *loving* , and she’d told him how guilty she felt, and Katsuki, for once, hadn’t known what to say.

He’d been envious of Izuku at various points in their life, for the pure and unconditional love Inko had for him. Inko didn’t place value in Izuku because of how strong or how smart or how powerful he was. She loved Izuku simply because he was Izuku.

Katsuki didn’t doubt that his mom loved him. But she loved him in a way that was different from a typical mother’s love.

He didn’t know how to accept her newfound worry for him, after going so long without it. He’d made it this far without being coddled, but he couldn’t find it in him to tell her to *fuck off and mind her own business* .

She pestered him about his grades and asked him about his classes. She offered to take him to every single appointment he had, even if she had to call off work. She called him almost daily

to ask mundane, repetitive questions that had Katsuki five seconds away from bashing his head against his wall.

“It’s sweet,” Izuku said one night after Katsuki hung up the phone.

“It’s fucking annoying, is what it is,” he had muttered, flopping onto the bed beside Izuku. His room was basically *their* room at this point, minus Izuku’s ever-growing All Might collection.

“Did she ask how I was doing?” Izuku asked, rolling onto his side.

“No,” he lied. “She asked when I’m getting a new boyfriend.”

Izuku pouted. “Probably never with your attitude.”

“Attitude? What attitude?” Katsuki glared at him. “I’ll kill you.”

To anyone else, Katsuki probably sounded like an insufferable brat. He was probably a terrible significant other, with a shit sense of humor. He was working through his stubbornness and his anger issues (slowly, because he kept refusing to go to the therapist his mother continuously recommended). He shouted often, he swore even more frequently, and he was shit at showing affection.

But Izuku knew him and Izuku knew all of those things and still, for some reason, wanted him. No matter what he said, Izuku looked at him like he had hung the moon and the stars in the sky, like he was the number one hero, like he was *everything* .

Katsuki had learned the important lesson of gratitude. If it made him a sappy, emotional, sentimental bastard, then so be it. He appreciated the small things now, like quiet mornings spent with Izuku and only Izuku, like Friday nights with Kirishima, Kaminari, Mina, Sero, and Jirou, like annoying training exercises and even more annoying essays and assignments. Those were the things he had thought back on when he had died, when he’d been stuck in a weird limbo, waiting for his heart to stutter to a stop and for his memories to stop assaulting him. Those few seconds had felt like *years* , as he’d looked back on all the mistakes he’d made, on the things he had taken for granted, on the moments he wished he could experience one last time.

So forgive Katsuki if he’d grown *soft* after the war.

Izuku had made the first move, had stepped right over the shaky boundaries they’d never spoken into existence, and Katsuki had been floored from that moment on. Everything was real, Katsuki himself was *real* , he was alive and his heart was beating, and he and Izuku had kissed, and his heart would beat a little too hard in his chest whenever he thought about it.

It had been cause for an awkward conversation at one of his check-ups, when his doctor had been measuring his heartbeat, and Izuku, who’d offered to go with Katsuki, had smiled at him from the other side of the room, and the aggravating beeps of the machine had grown more frequent, and fuck everything, Izuku was never going with him again.

After three months of whatever-the-hell they were doing, Katsuki broke.

He could only handle it for so long. The sleepovers, waking up to Izuku's soft smile and feather-light kisses, his hands tracing patterns up and down Katsuki's arms. The *casual* -ness, when he would rest his hand on Izuku's thigh under the dinner table, or steadying him with hands around the waist whenever Izuku almost tripped over himself. When Katsuki was feeling more confident, more sure of himself, not like he was going to be exploited and thought of as weak, he'd let his arm rest around Izuku's shoulders while they hung out with one of their friend groups.

Nobody mentioned it. His friends teased him relentlessly, sure, but they never thought of him as less-than, or as weak, or that he and Izuku were doing something *wrong* .

What Katsuki couldn't figure out, though, was *what* they were doing.

And one morning, when he started to get out of bed to go on a run and Izuku reached out, grabbing Katsuki's wrist, asking, in a melodic, half-asleep voice, for Katsuki to *stay with him* , he broke.

"Izuku," he said, resigning himself to the fact that he probably wasn't going to be going for a run that morning.

"Hm?"

"What the fuck are we doing?" he asked, eloquently if he does say so himself.

Izuku pushed up onto his elbows, rubbing sleep out of his eyes. Katsuki bit back an annoyed remark, only due to it being six in the morning on a Saturday. "What do you mean?"

"I mean *this* . You're sleeping. In my bed."

Izuku blinked at him. "I have been every night? Do you… not want me to?"

"Oh my fucking- yes I want you to."

"Then what do you mean?"

"I mean, you fucking sleep here, you kiss me good morning, you do all this sappy shit. Like what the fuck does it mean?"

Izuku sat up, clearly abandoning his hopes of going back to sleep. "Is it supposed to mean something?"

Everything went still for a few seconds, during which all of Katsuki's fears and doubts seemed to come true. Did it mean nothing to Izuku? Was he just a game, entertainment, a distraction? Had Izuku been plotting this whole time to get closer to him, to find out how to hurt him?

"Fuck you."

“ *Huh* ? Kacchan, what are you talking about-hey!”

Katsuki whacked him with a pillow, which, in hindsight, was a very pitiful attack. “You heard me, fuck you and get the fuck out of my room.”

“I have no idea what’s going on right now.” Izuku leaned over, reaching blindly for his clothes that were strewn across the floor. “Did I… do something?”

“Did you *do something* ? You just fucking said this means nothing!”

“ *What* ? I meant, like, what is this *supposed* to mean? I don’t even know what you’re trying to ask me!”

Katsuki reached down, finding Izuku’s discarded shorts and tossing them into his face. “Why are you here?”

“You just told me you wanted me to be here!”

“Yeah, do *you* want to be here?”

“Yeah? I wouldn’t put up with your snoring if I didn’t.”

“I *snore* ?”

Izuku tugged on his shorts and grabbed a shirt off the floor - *Katsuki’s shirt* . He pulled it over his head, backing towards the door with his arms extended, like Katsuki was a dangerous animal. He laughed awkwardly. “Uh, no? Maybe a little bit. It’s not that bad, I swear!”

Katsuki marched across the room and shoved him against the door. “That’s not the fucking point.”

“I don’t know what the point is,” Izuku said, defeated. “I’m *tired* , Kacchan, and you’re yelling at me and I don’t even know *why* .”

“Are you just here for your own personal gain?” Izuku’s eyebrows shot up. “Are you trying to get shit on me so you can use it against me? Some sick and twisted way of getting ahead?”

Izuku let out a long exhale. “Kacchan. No.”

“Then, I’ll fucking repeat myself, what the fuck are we doing?”

“I love you?” Izuku said, so simply, like it was the most obvious thing in the world.

Katsuki held Izuku by the shoulders, squeezing a bit more than he should have. He searched Izuku’s gaze, as if there were secrets hidden deep in those viridian eyes. He was coming up blank, though, and Katsuki had to wonder if his self-doubt would ever fade. Would there be a time in his life where he wouldn’t doubt Izuku’s feelings for him, or his own deservingness of love? Would there be a time in his life where he’d stop being so pitifully *afraid* ?

“I love you,” Izuku said again. “And if you’re not ready for that, if you still don’t want to put a label on us, if you’re *never* ready, it won’t change anything.”

Katsuki’s head fell, his forehead resting against Izuku’s shoulder. “Better not change your mind then,” he muttered, blinking away tears that had formed there unwillingly. “I’ll fucking kill whatever nobody comes after me.”

“ *Kacchan* .”

“I’m serious.” He sniffled. “Probably won’t be half as cool as me anyways.”

“Does that mean you’ll be my boyfriend?”

“Good fucking lord, you’re cheesy.”

“Is that a yes?”

“What do you think, nerd?”

Being seventeen was awkward and horrible and depressing.

After he’d been physically cleared from the war, he’d tried to go about his life normally. He kept up his routines of waking up early and working out. He continued to cook and eat healthy. He turned in his assignments on time, and studied hard for exams, and he was one of the top students in his class when it came to rankings for their quirks, capabilities, training, and everything else.

But Katsuki also had to navigate the parts of being a teenager that nobody had prepared him for.

He’d told his mother when he’d been in the hospital that he liked Izuku. Which had been a detrimental mistake.

She pestered him every single day about Izuku. For the first while after they’d kissed, he’d done his best to keep it a secret. But he could only handle so much before he snapped, and, well, he had.

“Katsuki, you know that we’ll accept you no matter what,” his father had been saying. Katsuki’s eye twitched.

“And if it’s not Izuku and there’s someone else, we would love to hear about it,” his mom said. He nearly blew up his phone.

Izuku, who was sitting at his desk, turned and raised his eyebrows. Katsuki glared back. He should’ve known better than to put a call from his parents on speaker phone.

“Did you try talking to Izuku about your feelings?” his mother asked. “Or have you asked him out on a date?”

Izuku held a hand over his mouth, trying and failing to smother his giggles.

“Holy fuck, Mom. Stop being so goddamn nosy.”

“Your mother just wants to be involved,” his father chided.

Katsuki rolled his eyes and pinched the bridge of his nose, willing his irritation to subside. “Yeah, I’m sure she does.”

“Do you need advice?”

Izuku made a strangled sound and Katsuki’s free hand started smoking.

“I don’t need your shit ass advice, Dad.”

“Well, I’m just saying, you told your mother about this back when you were in the hospital and it’s been months-”

“Holy fucking shit, we kissed, we held hands, we did whatever the hell else you want to hear. Will you get off my goddamn back about it?”

There was silence on the other end of the phone. Izuku’s face was bright red, but his eyes were wonderfully amused. Katsuki sighed.

“It’s bad enough that you two are always up my ass about therapy and my arm and school and everything the fuck else,” he muttered.

“We want to be involved,” his dad said, and *fuck it* , Katsuki was so much more sensitive than he let on. For his entire life, he’d wanted to be strong to impress his mother, but he’d always known, without questioning, without having to prove himself, that his dad loved him unconditionally. For a while, he’d thought that made his dad weak, but he wasn’t a repressed 13 year old anymore, and suddenly, it didn’t matter if his dad was the toughest, strongest, most badass person alive. All that mattered was that he loved Katsuki, that he always had, that he always would.

“There’s your involvement.”

“Why don’t you bring him over to dinner?” his mom asked.

Izuku shook his head wildly. He mouthed, *They’re scary* .

Katsuki grinned in a slightly evil, manic way. “Sure thing, hag. He loves spicy food.”

And so Katsuki had to navigate *those* situations. Sometimes, fighting and training for a war seemed mundane and boring in comparison to the simple things that normal teenagers did every day. How could he find Hero training interesting when he got to spend every second of his free time with *Izuku* ? But Katsuki had never anticipated being in this situation, having a *boyfriend* , taking his boyfriend to have dinner with his parents, having awkward conversations with both of their families about their relationship. Like when Izuku accidentally told Inko that he sneaks into Katsuki’s dorm every night.

“And what does Mitsuki have to say about that?” she’d demanded, her tone stern.

“Uh, well, she doesn’t… she doesn’t know?” Izuku responded, laughing awkwardly.

“Izuku, I’m just not sure how I feel about all of this,” she said. Katsuki rolled his eyes. “I mean, he used to bully you.”

Katsuki had worked damn hard for the last two years of his life to make up for the countless mistakes he’d made in regards to Izuku. And while Izuku had forgiven him, others clearly hadn’t.

“Mom,” Izuku said gently, “I promise he’s not the same person that he was in middle school.”

“I just worry that he’s not treating you right.”

“Mom. He’s great. I swear.”

Katsuki had been putting up with his own parents his entire life. He knew what he could get away with, and he knew they’d just about given up on chastising him at this point. Having Izuku over for dinner was definitely… weird, at the start, but it’s not like he had anything to worry about. His parents laughed and joked and talked about school, and his mother fawned over Izuku’s… Izuku-ness. She loved his nerdiness, loved his shy, polite demeanor, and his constant smile. And his father seemed to enjoy talking to Izuku about anything under the sun; they were scarily alike, and that fact made Katsuki a bit uncomfortable.

But he wasn’t prepared for it to be his turn.

“Your mom will hate me either way,” he muttered as Izuku vetoed his third outfit. “Why does it matter if my pants are slouchy or not?”

Izuku’s lips tilted down at the corners, and if Katsuki weren’t about to blow up the entire closet, it would have been sickeningly cute. “She won’t *hate* you. But it would probably improve your chances of winning her over if your pants weren’t sagging down to your knees.”

“Won you over,” he scoffed, snatching the pair of pants Izuku was holding up.

Luckily for Katsuki, the fourth pair of pants was a winner, and Izuku gave him a toothy grin in approval. Like always, Katsuki’s heart stutterd in his chest, and like always, he had to remind himself that this was real, that they both survived, that things were starting to be okay.

Even months after everything had happened, after a number of appointments, nobody was completely over it. Some nights, Izuku would shoot awake in a panic, waking Katsuki right along with him. It would take Katsuki a couple tries to remind him that *it’s not real, it’s a nightmare, you’re in the dorms, the war is over* . He was god awful at comforting, especially when Izuku was frantic; it set him on edge.

Izuku was the type of person to hold in his emotions so as not to be a burden to anyone else, and Katsuki was completely inept at emotional conversations, which made them an imperfectly perfect match. But they could only handle so much, and Katsuki, for once in his

life, was ahead of Izuku when it came to realizing that talking about their issues made them easier to handle.

For the first couple months of their kind-of-sort-of-relationship, Katsuki questioned if they'd made the right decisions. They fought often, and they were so used to being pitted against each other in class exercises, that the easiest way to solve their problems was to spar. And that worked sometimes. But not all the time.

When Izuku woke up from a nightmare, shaking and mortified, Katsuki couldn't trade an emotional conversation for 30 minutes of sparring. So he was getting better, slowly.

Because, months earlier, his heart had stopped while he lay in the rain, drenched to the bone, and he'd told himself that after the war, he would do better. He would be a better son and a better friend and a better student and a better *person* . He would stop working only for his own gain, he would stop pushing people away because of his own insecurities, he would stop refusing help, he would stop acting like he was better than everyone else. And he'd known, god he had *known* , that he wouldn't survive. That had been the worst part of it; Katsuki had known what was coming, and he couldn't turn around and run away. He couldn't hide behind his ego and his sharp tongue. He could do nothing to stop it, to change the fate that had been decided for him, that he *deserved* .

And after he was gone, the world would continue spinning on its axis, orbiting the sun in the same way that he had orbited Izuku. Everything would continue on as normal, and Katsuki would have been a small and insignificant blip in the grand scheme of things, uselessly tossed aside and easily defeated.

He'd been given a second chance, though, miraculously. He'd been brought back to life, and all of those promises that he'd made to himself, he intended to keep.

It wasn't easy to unlearn the person he had been for the last 17 years. It wasn't easy to change, and a lot of the time, it made his skin crawl, and it made him so unbelievably pissed off that he blew something up. But slow progress was still progress, and every time he did something *right* , he earned a beautifully pure smile from Izuku, and that made it all worth it.

Katsuki still doubted himself, though. He couldn't 100% trust Izuku's love for him, not after everything. How could he blindly trust it after everything he'd done to Izuku? How could he possibly deserve to be loved so purely by Izuku after the words he had said?

Katsuki spent way too much of his time remembering the past. It should be behind him, beneath him, unworthy of his consideration. He should scoff at it, and shrug off any responsibility of the things he had said and done throughout his miserable life.

But he didn't. He thought back on everything he'd fucked up and he thought about what he should've done better, what he wished he would have done. And he'd taken to telling Izuku those things, whenever he thought of them. It was a small notion, but one that seemed to make Izuku glow nonetheless.

Mostly, Katsuki told Izuku of his ponderings late in the evening, when his dorm was doused in shadows and he could say whatever he wanted without repercussions, because it was just

him and Izuku. He started off with the bigger things, the ones that were more obvious: he wished he'd never told Izuku to kill himself, he wished he'd never given Izuku the nickname 'Deku', he wished he would have held Izuku's hand in the river that one day, he wished he would have talked about heroes with Izuku for all hours of the day.

Then he started listing the smaller things.

He wished Izuku would have been the one to reach out his hand to Katsuki after everything that had happened at Kamino. He wished he would have invited Izuku to his birthday parties because he wanted to, and not just because Mitsuki said he had to. He wished he would have gone after Izuku immediately after waking up in the hospital after Jaku. He wished he could change it all.

And because Izuku was so *good* , he always said something like, "If you wouldn't have done that, we might not be here right now."

"You're a fucking psycho," Katsuki told him. "Still don't really know what you see in me."

Izuku pretended to think for a few seconds, his eyes bright and mischievous. "Tall, blonde, handsome. That's what, like, every girl wants."

"Right."

"Oh, come on Kacchan, you basically have a fan club."

"Do not."

Izuku rolled his eyes. He yanked at the blanket (which Katsuki was definitely not hogging) until Katsuki relented some of it to him (because he was a loving boyfriend, not because Izuku was buff as shit and one of Katsuki's arms didn't work). "You're telling me you don't hear the way the first years talk about you?"

"You do enough listening for the both of us."

"I heard a girl from the Business Course talking about how you'd probably rank in the Top 10 if you modeled underwear."

"If it pays the bills." He smirked.

Izuku pinched his side. "I was helping Ectoplasm with demonstrations for one of his Quirk Combat classes and a group of girls wouldn't stop talking about how-" he paused, scrunching his nose, "-fuckable you are."

"You agreed with them, right?"

"What- *Kacchan* ! No, I didn't tell the first years that I think you're fuckable."

"Okay, wow, fuck you."

“I’m sure Ectoplasm would have loved that. You know, maybe instead of helping with lessons, I should just talk everyone’s ears off about how *hot Kacchan is* .”

“That might be the only good idea you’ve ever had.”

Izuku glared at him, his cheeks pink, even in the darkness of Katsuki’s dorm. “I shouldn’t even tell you these things, it goes straight to your head.”

He shrugged. “Can’t help it that I’m tall, blonde, and handsome, and you’re short and nerdy.”
“I’m not that short,” Izuku argued. “And girls *like* smart guys, actually.”

“Where’s your fan club?” (Katsuki was asking this sarcastically and *not* because he wanted to know the names of every single extra that was in said fan club. He definitely wasn’t planning on glaring them to death or making it a point to stand extra close to Izuku in front of them.)

“Laying in bed with me.”

“You fucking wish.”

Chapter End Notes

.... hellooooo (if anyones still there)
soooooo super super late update almost 2 months later but I lowkey got my ass kicked by life. my finals were so unbelievably stressful this semester AND I got laid off by my job bc my company literally went bankrupt YIKES. so. its been an absolutely wonderful last two months
I hope you guys enjoy this and I hope you don't burn me at the stake. there's probably only going to be one more chapter after this (kind of like an epilogue)
this chapter (and the next) are just supposed to outline some of the quiet moments of their relationship growing after everything that happened
anyways TikTok is @lvndrsunny
thank you for reading :)
lav <3

tv static

Chapter Summary

> I know why you're
> flying high above me
> your atmosphere is
> pushing pulling all
> the things around me
> and I'm still here

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There were two years separating Izuku from what had quite possibly been the worst time of his life. Two years of smiling and laughing and training. Two years that were surprisingly relaxing, without the added pressure of having to take down the worst villain in the world. The pressures that had mounted on his shoulders were slowly lifted away and distributed evenly, and even when he wanted to fight against it, to say *I'm fine, I can handle it, I'll be okay* , he didn't. He'd fought plenty of battles alone, convinced that it had been his mess and his mess only, inherited in the form of a golden hair when he'd been barely 14 years old.

But it had never just been his problem, and it had taken a lot for him to realize that.

He was starting to get better in that regard, to rely on others, to accept that he couldn't possibly save and protect everyone. But some things would never go away.

When spring came and UA was pelted by a healthy dousing of rain, Izuku couldn't find his usual optimism. In the first year after the war, he'd sit by the window, watching as the earth became saturated, and he had to remind himself it was just rain.

At one point, though, rain had drenched the campus grounds, had washed blood and grime away from his face, had plastered his hair to his forehead and his uniform to his skin. The air had been a conglomeration of scents - smoke, and the faintest hint of nitroglycerin, the clean scent of ozone that Izuku was accustomed to, and the rain.

Izuku would never forget the sight of Katsuki, completely still, his costume saturated with blood, his support items smashed and discarded.

"I'm supposed to be the one that mopes over the rain, not you," Katsuki said to him one day. Izuku was sitting at one of the tables on the first floor of the dorms, his head resting on the table in a pillow of his arms. Katsuki pulled out the chair next to him, flopping into it and propping his legs up on the table.

“Not moping.”

“Uh huh.”

He sighed.

“Gonna tell me what the problem is?”

Izuku let out another long breath.

Anger was new to him, but as his therapist was constantly reminding him, anger was just another part of grief.

There were so many moments in his life where he should’ve been angry, where he should have stood up for himself and fought back. Ironically, the anger only came to him after the smoke had cleared, after everything was, as the Heroes said, okay.

He tried not to take his anger out on Katsuki.

Over the last year, and throughout their relationship - that Izuku *still* couldn’t comprehend - Katsuki had been so *good* . Izuku liked to think that he wouldn’t have kissed Katsuki without knowing for a fact that he’d changed, that he wasn’t the same person he’d been in middle school. He’d been so infatuated with Katsuki for their entire lives, and he’d been no better than anyone else, putting Katsuki on a pedestal. But things had *changed* , they’d both changed. Katsuki had proved it time and time again, that he no longer saw Izuku as useless, that he saw them now as equals, regardless of Izuku’s quirk.

At one point, and Izuku always thought that that point had been their fight at Ground Beta, Katsuki’s words had lost their sharp edge. His actions took on a different tone, as if he was working towards a new goal, not just to be the best.

How many times had Katsuki shown Izuku that he no longer worked only to win?

And, when Katsuki started to change, so did Izuku’s feelings, from intense infatuation and admiration into something so wonderfully different. He didn’t see Katsuki as a playground friend with the potential to be a Hero anymore. He saw him as his quiet methods of showing that he cared, as his ever-present drive and unrelenting ambition, as his vulnerability that he was slowly becoming more comfortable with showing.

“Just thinking,” he said, voice muffled by his arms. “About y’know.”

“I don’t know,” Katsuki said dryly, flicking Izuku’s forehead. “You’re always thinking about something, nerd.”

Izuku didn’t say anything.

Rain was still lashing the campus, pitter-pattering against the window, the sidewalks, the grass. At one point, Katsuki had lain on that very grass, his heart stopped. Izuku had been forced to stand there, to see Katsuki, *his Kacchan* , so unnaturally still. He’d had to keep fighting, even after being told that Katsuki’s corpse was his *gift* .

Shigaraki had *known* , he had somehow known, that Izuku loved Katsuki. Whether he had targeted Katsuki because he knew that he and Izuku had been friends their entire lives, or because of Izuku's reaction to Katsuki being first kidnapped then stabbed by Shigaraki, or if he had been able to read Izuku for the things he had guiltily wanted, he still couldn't fathom it.

Katsuki had been a child at one point, though. When Izuku had seen him, he'd seen every version of Katsuki, every single moment of his life from start to finish. As toddlers on the playground, pretending to be Heroes. As kids at Izuku's kitchen table, scribbling drawings of their Hero costumes with crayons. As middle schoolers, shooting glares at Izuku, insulting him at every turn. As new students at UA, wearing crisp blazers, frustrated with the world as it beat Katsuki down left and right. As equals, after almost a year of being at UA, when Katsuki's words and actions lost their edge, when he looked at Izuku like he *mattered* , like he was something to look at.

"Moping out here by yourself isn't going to make you feel better," Katsuki said, his voice taking on a gentle tone. Or, as gentle as his voice *could* be. "All our loser friends are trying to pick out a movie."

There were words he wanted to say, there were things he wanted to tell Katsuki to make him understand, but Izuku didn't have to say them. Katsuki had been the one to die; if anyone should be moping, it was him.

"I want to stop feeling like this," he whispered.

Katsuki's hand found his own. Both of their hands were battle-worn and scarred, and Katsuki's fingers couldn't curl all the way around Izuku's.

The void that constantly grew and shifted inside of him would probably never go away. The confusing tangle of emotions that he couldn't navigate was just something he would have to get used to, a now permanent fixture of his life. His nightmares of Katsuki's death and the horrors that he'd seen during the war would continue to plague his sleep. His fear and anxiety of being separated from Katsuki during Hero work would become his 'normal'. Izuku would have to find a way to be *happy* , while simultaneously feeling so *empty* .

His dream of being a Hero felt tarnished and corrupted. He hadn't been able to save Tenko, and he hadn't been able to save Katsuki, and there were thousands of civilians that had been harmed or killed during the war that he hadn't been able to protect. The Commission was still trying to recover from the war, with Hawks now in charge and making changes to a system that was severely outdated. Civilians were starting to be more accepting of quirks that didn't fit the standard, and all of it should have made Izuku feel optimistic, but it was hard to feel anything after all he had given up to get to this point.

He'd become the greatest Hero, as everyone kept telling him, and he wondered how it was possible that the greatest Hero couldn't find it in himself to get out of bed some days. He'd beaten Shigaraki, but he couldn't beat the nightmares that plagued him. He didn't know where to go from here, how to keep working hard in blissful ignorance, like everything was completely okay. He couldn't continue living his life like nothing had happened, like his dreams hadn't been flipped upside down and used as weapons against him.

Selfishly, he missed his quirks, too. He still had base One for All, but none of the stockpiled quirks that he'd unlocked over the course of his first year. The voices of the past users were gone too, and he wished he could talk to them one more time, to ask them the questions that he was afraid to voice out loud.

He wanted to ask them if it gets better, if he'll escape from the constant visions of Katsuki's dead body or the sounds of his classmates screaming in pain on the battlefield. He wanted to ask them how to keep going forward, what there was left to work for.

On his good days, he knew that these were stupid questions to ponder. He still wanted to become a Hero, and he wanted to keep working towards saving people, even if the League of Villains no longer existed. He wanted to work towards being happy for himself, happiness that didn't come from a Hero ranking or a statistic.

"Hey," Katsuki said softly, "don't be falling apart on me, 'Zuku." And Izuku, who was well-versed in the language of Katsuki, knew he meant *I love you* .

Some days, Izuku couldn't hold it together so well. Some days, that beautiful dissociation was unreachable, and he felt everything tenfold.

"I feel worthless," he told Katsuki one day, sitting at the end of the bed that had become theirs, picking at the clasp of one of his gloves.

"Huh? The hell are you talking about?" Katsuki kicked off his boots. They were freshly made, courtesy of the Support Course and his costume designer, who insisted on making him an entirely new costume after the war.

Izuku flopped backwards, not bothering to take off his support gear. They'd just finished with another team exercise, a hostage-training simulation, and he was *tired* .

"Is this about losing all your quirks?"

He sighed.

"Because I get it, it probably fucking sucks, but you can't just lay here sad about it all damn day, Izuku. You're making it harder on yourself."

"And what the fuck do you suggest I do then?"

Katsuki blinked at him for a solid couple seconds, mouth parted in shock. Even Izuku could admit to himself that it wasn't *fair* to snap at Katsuki, not when Katsuki just wanted to help him feel better. But he'd been hearing the same thing from everyone, over and over and over again, that he just had to keep pushing, that he would feel better eventually, that it was okay to feel sad sometimes.

He couldn't stand it when his mother, his therapist, his teachers, *and* his boyfriend told him to keep moving, to find distractions, to focus on the positive things. *Sure you lost seven quirks, but you still have one, be positive! You're sad that Katsuki died, but he came back, so be happy! Find passion in the things you do!*

He wouldn't say anything, because he couldn't be mad that people were offering him advice and trying to help. He couldn't fault them for being blissfully ignorant to how he felt everyday. He could never explain it to them fully.

Half the time, he couldn't even identify his feelings for himself. He couldn't differentiate sadness from emptiness from anger from loneliness.

He heard Katsuki take a deep breath as the mattress sank beside him.

Sometimes, he wished Katsuki would just yell back.

At one point, they'd been able to fight out all their problems, matching each other blow for blow, too out of breath to shout at each other over who-knows-what. It was easier to throw punches or explosions at each other, because that's what they were good at. Neither of them were good at navigating this, at figuring out their own emotions and how to support each other.

As much as he wished for it, Katsuki *didn't* yell back. It frustrated Izuku to no end, and yet, it made his heart swell, because Katsuki had *changed* , and Katsuki cared about him in little ways, even when Izuku didn't want it.

"Izuku."

"Leave me alone."

"You're in my room."

"Our room."

"Watch yourself, nerd," Katsuki said. The clasps on his gloves popped free and Katsuki pulled them off of Izuku's hands, setting them aside. "I'll kick your ass out so fast. Have fun sleeping by yourself tonight."

He didn't answer.

"Izuku," he said again, his tone softer. "You're not worthless."

"Feels like it."

"Why? Because you lost all your bonus quirks and now you're just strong enough to lift up, I don't know, a whole goddamn building?"

"You don't get it."

"No, I don't get it, so you have to talk to me about it."

It was hard to decide, in that moment, if he wanted to scream at Katsuki that he *didn't know how to explain it* , or if he wanted to say *I love you I love you I love you* .

He sat up, facing Katsuki full on. Izuku had seen those carnelian eyes with so many different emotions in them, but for once, they were open and accepting and patient.

“I don’t *want* to talk about it. I don’t want everyone treating me like I’m about to fall apart.”

“You walk around like a ghost, Izuku,” Katsuki said, a hint of annoyance in his voice. “Did you think we’d all just sit back and fucking watch?”

“I don’t need you trying to baby me all the time,” he snapped. “I… I survived a war. I beat Shigaraki. I can handle the aftermath.”

“Clearly not.”

“I hate you,” he whispered. His eyes betrayed him, and tears slid silently down his cheeks.

“I hate you too,” Katsuki said. “So we’re even.”

Izuku scooted closer to him and Katsuki sighed, reaching out and wrapping strong arms around him. Izuku let his head fall to Katsuki’s shoulder, squeezing his eyes closed like he could block out the rest of the world. He felt so unbelievably *tiny* , with too many emotions for one person to have, with no way to let them out.

Gentle fingers worked their way through Izuku’s hair, tugging at the knots that had formed at some point during training. It was funny, really, that at one point, those hands had been rough and hateful when directed at him, explosive and violent and dangerous. He never would have guessed that those same hands could be so unbelievably tender, as they brushed through his hair or cupped his face or held his hand.

“I don’t know how I’m supposed to feel,” he admitted once his tears had stopped falling, and the only evidence of their existence were the wet marks on Katsuki’s t-shirt. “About anything.”

“However the fuck you want. There’s not exactly a guide on inheriting a quirk one random day, which ultimately led to you having to fight some fuck ass villain that’s been terrorizing for the last couple hundred years, watching your childhood best friend-turned-hot-as-fuck boyfriend die, then losing, what, seven quirks?”

Izuku laughed, sniffling. It felt nice, to be so far removed from the constant threat of danger, to be wrapped in a blanket of the scent of caramel, and quirk-warmed hands holding him like he was simultaneously the most fragile piece of glass in the world and the most stable rock in existence.

“Sometimes I wonder what would have happened if All Might had picked someone else.”

Izuku didn’t think about it often, because he didn’t quite know what to think.

He’d been given his dream, in a stroke of unbelievable luck, because he’d been *good* , because he couldn’t bear to watch Katsuki die, not when he had yet to become the Hero Izuku knew he would become. And yet.

Had the tradeoff been worth it? The trauma, the injuries, the creak of his bones every time he took a step, the nightmares that plagued him every night? He'd been a Hero, he'd saved people, he'd done what he had always dreamed of doing, and yet.

"He would have found some other self-sacrificial nuthead to rope into his war."

"It's not his fault, Kacchan."

"It *is* his fault."

"How could he have known what would happen?"

"You can't be serious, right? How could he have *not* known? This quirk has been passed down how many times? All for the sake of beating some guy's fuckass brother. It's not like All Might walked up to you on the street and said, 'Here, eat my hair, but be warned! You'll have to fight some guy with a nutsack for a face to the death one day! And he can steal quirks so he's super OP! Maybe he'll murder your boyfriend too. But at the end of it, you get to be a Hero so no big deal!'"

"If he said it like that, nobody would take it."

"And maybe nobody should have it," Katsuki snapped. "It's cursed."

"If he would have kept it, he would have died to All For One and nobody would have been able to defeat him."

"Are you forgetting that *I* beat him?"

Izuku leaned back. "Do you think you could have done it on your own? Without me using One For All?"

Katsuki glared at him, but surprisingly didn't take offense to the question. Izuku didn't doubt him, he was just thinking realistically. "With some backup, who the hell knows? I'm just saying, it was fucked up, Izuku. All Might saw a kid, a *kid* , that just wanted to save people, even at the cost of his own life. And he gave you a quirk, knowing that you were self-sacrificial as fuck, that you would do anything to beat All For One."

"You make him sound evil."

Katsuki reached down, undoing the clasps on Izuku's boots. "He's not evil, obviously, he's fucking All Might. I just think it was shitty to put a burden on a kid who had no idea what the fuck was coming for him."

Izuku opened his mouth to respond, but Katsuki cut him off, glaring. "Don't say it wasn't a burden, either, because it *was* ."

Izuku stayed silent, watching as Katsuki knelt, pulling off one of Izuku's boots, then the other, before setting them neatly next to his own.

Izuku had spent so long obsessing over and idolizing All Might, watching his each and every move, first on the fuzzy monitor in his mother's bedroom, then at his side, as his partner and successor. How could he ever look at All Might as anything less than his own personal Hero? How could All Might, the number one Hero, the savior of millions, the Symbol of Peace, have done something *wrong* , something that had affected someone so negatively?

"I don't think he was being some calculated manipulative villain," Katsuki said, returning to sit beside Izuku. "I doubt he thought about it at all, honestly. Probably just saw some nutty ass fanboy without a quirk, took pity on you, and sent you on your way."

"He was the only person who believed in me," Izuku murmured.

Katsuki looked away from him, like he always did when their conversations strayed too close to their past. There was always such a sense of shame surrounding him whenever the topic came up, and Izuku could talk about forgiveness and growth for hours, and Katsuki wouldn't accept it. "Looking back, it was really stupid to not believe in you."

"You don't have to say that, Kacchan."

"No, listen here, fuckface. I was an idiot, and everyone and their goddamn mom made me think that Heroes and strong quirks were the same thing, but they're not. Even without a quirk, you wanted to save people and that's all that really matters at the end of the day, right?"

"So winning doesn't matter?"

"Shut it, asshole. Winning matters to me, but you're not like that." He paused, then met Izuku's gaze again. Izuku was still getting used to the feeling of being swallowed whole by those red, red eyes, like he was something worth looking at and someone worth falling for. "You're better."

"Kacchan," he said adoringly, "it's not a competition."

"Yeah right, nerd, it's always a competition with us."

"Even if it all kind of… messed me up for life, I'm glad All Might gave me One For All."

"Yeah?"

"I might not have gotten to… have this. If he hadn't. Maybe I would have found another way to be a Hero. Or I would have done something else to save people. But if I never would've gotten One For All, I probably wouldn't be in Great Explosion Murder God Dynamight's bed."

Katsuki put one arm around Izuku's shoulders, pulling him close. The motion was so sickeningly domestic, so casual and comfortable, like this had been the right choice, and they had just taken 17 years to figure it out. "I would've come around."

"Oh really?"

“I mean, in this alternate reality of yours, you still get super jacked or?”

“ *Kacchan* .”

Graduation came and went in a storm of hugs and tears. Izuku was pulled this way and that, yanked into a million pictures with his classmates, and to his surprise, with first and second year students that saw him as some type of mini celebrity.

“Get used to it,” Katsuki muttered to him after the fifth first year girl of the day asked him for a picture. “This is half of the profession.”

“I don’t see you taking pictures with fans,” Izuku grumbled, keeping his smile firmly planted on his face.

Katsuki’s face twisted incredulously, his eyebrows shooting up. “Do I look approachable to you?”

“Aw, Kacchan, I love how self aware you are!”

“Can it, nerd.”

They hadn’t exactly been hiding their relationship throughout their final two years at UA. Izuku had told his friends pretty much everything from the start. When he’d started to feel more for Katsuki than just admiration and rivalry, he’d gone to Uraraka. When he wasn’t with Katsuki during their time in the hospital, he’d been texting her about his own personal hell that was confusing and thrilling all at the same time. When he’d kissed Katsuki, he’d gone straight to her dorm, already freaking out, pacing around her room and ripping at his hair.

Todoroki had also been subjected to a number of rants, but he wasn’t exactly the most… romantic person. He nodded along when Izuku talked, but half the time, he questioned what Izuku saw in Katsuki in the first place, which was decidedly *not* helpful. He had conceded, only once, that Katsuki “wasn’t awful to look at.”

Iida was a surprisingly good listener, and even more surprisingly, offered actual good advice. Even with the mild distaste he held towards Katsuki and his… rebelliousness, Iida had always been more than happy to listen to Izuku’s freakouts over the little things Katsuki did that had his entire world flipping. He’d visited Izuku in the hospital, right after Katsuki had run a finger along Izuku’s scars, following the path they made all the way up to his cheek, and he’d sat in silence as Izuku panicked over it for an hour because *what did it even mean* . Iida had been the one to encourage Izuku to make a move, talking to Izuku with so much wisdom it was hard to believe they were the same age.

Izuku knew that Katsuki had told his friends, and he’d put it together after everything between them was out in the open. Suddenly, the innuendos that Kaminari had been tossing

his way over the course of their first few weeks back at UA had made so much sense, as had Mina's suggestive looks when he and Katsuki did anything together.

They weren't outright about their relationship, though. He was sure the rest of their classmates had pieced it together at some point. Izuku slept in Katsuki's bedroom every night anyways, and after a few months, he had stopped caring about sneaking around.

Katsuki had let it slip to Mitsuki and Masaru before Izuku had told Inko, and that had gone over surprisingly well. Mitsuki had welcomed him into their home with a bright smile, and she had gone on and on about how happy she was that Katsuki had found someone that would "keep him in check." Masaru, who'd always been quiet and kind, had pulled Izuku aside during the dinner, shaking his hand and telling Izuku he was proud of him, he supported him, and he thought Izuku was good for Katsuki. The entire conversation had been exceedingly formal, and Izuku had been a very deep shade of red by the end of it. When they'd left, Mitsuki had shouted after them about being "safe and responsible teenagers" and it had been Katsuki's turn to go red.

As for Inko, she'd been quietly supportive. She'd invited Katsuki over to dinner, which was 10 times more awkward than dinner had been at the Bakugous. Katsuki hadn't stopped fussing over his shirt the entire time they'd been there, pulling at the collar and smoothing it down every five seconds. Inko hadn't said much throughout, asking only the necessary questions about school and Katsuki's recovery.

Almost a year and a half after that dinner, she was still having a hard time coming around. Izuku didn't blame her; he'd watched Katsuki change and grow first-hand, while most of her experiences with him had been harsh words, scraped knees, and hurt feelings.

As for their teachers, well, there had been a very unfortunate reveal. They'd kept up their training together, and Aizawa had eventually given up on trying to stop them. On occasions, All Might joined them, offering advice where it was needed (much to Katsuki's annoyance). He typically left before them, and, one night, Katsuki had clearly taken that as permission to kiss him senseless. They'd just finished fighting, and reminiscent of their first kiss, Katsuki was pinned to the ground by Izuku, breathing hard and glaring.

"I win," Izuku said, trying to catch his breath.

"You wish, nerd."

And then Katsuki was kissing him, pulling Izuku down with a strong hand at the back of his neck. Izuku ignored the giddy feeling that bubbled up in his stomach, that somehow still happened every time Katsuki did something like this. He tangled his own fingers in Katsuki's hair, pressing further against him, not caring how needy he came across. Katsuki's hand found its way to Izuku's waist, fitting so perfectly and-

"Oh! Young Midoriya, I almost forgot to- *oh* ."

Izuku rolled off of Katsuki faster than he could even think the words *holy fuck* . His face was immediately a thousand degrees and most definitely the darkest shade of red imaginable.

Beside him, Katsuki was sitting up, leaning back on his hands and looking way too relaxed for Izuku's comfort.

"My apologies," All Might said awkwardly, wincing and taking a couple steps back. "I, um, wasn't expecting, uh-"

"Weren't expecting what?" Katsuki said, glaring.

"Well, I mean, I… it's not a bad thing! I didn't mean it in, uh, a negative sense. I just-"

"Quit your fucking stuttering. It's like you've never seen two people kiss before."

"I'm, uh, very happy for the two of you," All Might said after a few seconds of awkward silence. Izuku was on the verge of digging his own grave. He'd never wished so desperately for the ground to open up and swallow him whole. He refused to look up from the pavement, which was suddenly extremely captivating.

"The fuck is that supposed to mean?"

"I think it's great!" All Might's face was growing more and more red by the second, still blinking in poorly disguised shock. "You two know that I respect you no matter what."

"If you think I'm scared you'd look down on me for who I kiss in my spare time, then-"

"I can assure you I don't have any problems with who you kiss, Young Bakugou." All Might's voice took on an amused tone. "It has no effect on the Hero you'll become, either."

At that, Katsuki didn't say anything, his hardened expression breaking just a little. Izuku knew first-hand how much Katsuki valued All Might's opinion, even when he acted like it didn't matter. He had carefully constructed a fortress around his feelings, and Izuku was only just tearing down the walls, brick by brick. Behind his anger and defensiveness, Izuku knew that Katsuki craved the approval he'd been searching for his entire life. Katsuki didn't talk about it, but Izuku had always wondered if a part of Katsuki was afraid that being with Izuku would make him *weak* , that villains would exploit him for it, that people would see him as less than.

"Damn right it doesn't," he scoffed.

"Anyways," All Might said, clearing his throat, "I'll, uh, leave you two to it then."

Izuku hid his face in his hands, not watching as his predecessor turned around and walked away.

"Well."

"Oh my god. All Might just caught us making out."

"And?"

"All Might just caught us *making out* ."

“Izuku. Chill the fuck out.”

“Kacchan, how are you *not* freaking out?”

“Because I don’t give a shit what that old fuck thinks about me.”

Izuku snorted. “You carry his signed playing card around with you everywhere.”

“Not the point.”

“He caught us making out, Kacchan. *Making out* !”

“Could’ve been worse.”

“No, not it could not have been.”

Katsuki raised his eyebrows.

Izuku went even more red, half-convinced his heart was about to beat out of his chest. “I can’t believe All Might just caught us making out. Kacchan, what do we *do* ?”

“Make out more?”

Izuku choked.

Even over a year later, Izuku still winced when he thought back to that night, finding it somewhat hard to look All Might in the eye.

After another handful of pictures with fans and classmates, Izuku’s mentor found him and Katsuki in the crowd of people on the UA lawn.

“Congratulations,” All Might said, his smile warm and proud. “And to you, too, Young Bakugou.”

“Yeah, whatever.”

“I’m excited to see where you two go from here,” All Might said, and while Izuku was hanging on every word, still transfixed by the fact that his childhood *idol* saw him as someone worthy of praise, he could tell that Katsuki was fighting the urge to tell him to “spare them the speech.”

“Don’t ask Izuku unless you want to hear his detailed run down of the next 10 years.”

“ *Kacchan* ,” he complained, “it’s good to have a plan.”

“Yeah, my plan is to get out there and fuck up some villains. You’ll be too busy checking your goddamn timeline.”

“I think ahead,” he argued, fully aware of the pout that was working its way onto his face.

“Yeah, I’ll fucking say so. Let me guess, you wrote down ‘smother Kacchan in his sleep so I can finally beat him and be #1’ on there.”

“Wow, you guessed it. You better watch out, that one’s only 4 years and 87 days away.”

“Think-a-fucking-gain, nerd. It’s not gonna take me 4 years to be number one.”

“Then I guess I need to change my timeline.”

“You two are still the same,” All Might said fondly. He pulled them both into a hug. It was so nostalgic to the first time Izuku had met All Might, when he’d had stars in his eyes and had been so naive and wanting. And here he was, three years later, a UA graduate, being hugged by the Hero that he’d admired throughout his entire childhood. Beside him, he heard Katsuki let out a strained noise, tensing up until All Might released them.

“You can say that again,” Mitsuki said, thwacking Katsuki with his own rolled up diploma. “Maybe you’ll start to be nicer now that you’ve been spending all this time with Izuku.”

“Doubtful,” Masaru and Izuku said simultaneously.

Katsuki shoved Izuku.

“What *are* your plans, Young Midoriya?”

“Well, I definitely want to join an agency and work under an experienced pro for a little while, just to get a good understanding of how an agency operates and to save up some money. Then I’ll probably start my own agency, but I want to do a lot of research first. Like what the best area would be, either where there’s a high crime rate or where there aren’t many other Hero agencies. And I’d like to be a part of the work study program through UA to help students develop their quirks. I even thought about teaching here at UA, which I haven’t really talked to anyone about yet, but I’ve always loved to analyze quirks, and I think it would give me a chance to see what kind of Heroes there’ll be in future generations.”

All Might nodded proudly, even though he’s already heard the same rundown a hundred times over, with a million scenarios and theories to back up each and every decision Izuku was considering. In Izuku’s dorm, which he rarely spent time in, he had notebooks filled to the brim with his ponderings. He had lists of the pros and cons for each and every agency he’d gotten a job offer from, complete with the statistics of the individual Heroes working there. He’d given All Might the notebooks to look over, and he was almost positive All Might got overwhelmed after a couple pages and gave up.

“I meant in general,” All Might said, correcting himself. “Anything special?”

Izuku avoided looking at any of the adults and laughed awkwardly, scratching at the back of his head. “Oh, you know…”

“What is it, sweetie?” his mother asked in a sickly sweet tone, which was unbelievably patronizing, considering he’d just graduated from the most prestigious school in the country *and* had one of the most powerful quirks in the world.

“Yeah, ‘Zuku, what is it?”

Izuku elbowed Katsuki hard in the ribs.

A couple months earlier, when it had suddenly become *real* that they would be moving on from UA, that this wasn’t their final stop, Izuku had asked Katsuki what was next.

Most Heroes didn’t go to college, unless they planned to work on the business side of things. Certain Heroes that specialized in rescue missions often got degrees in something health-related, or got various certifications for first aid. Some vigilantes that Izuku had spoken to over the years had gone to college for a number of different things, sometimes for the sake of missions. Aizawa had gone to college to get a degree in education.

Izuku wasn’t planning to go to college, even if he did follow through with teaching at UA. His goal had always been to become a Hero, and he was still chasing after that. It felt so much *closer* , as he stood in front of UA, which had once been so tall and intimidating, holding his diploma and preparing to join the ranks of the pros.

“The fuck do you mean, ‘what’s next?’” Katsuki had asked from where his head was resting on Izuku’s stomach. His voice was scratchier than normal, and Izuku winced, somehow having forgotten that Katsuki fell asleep when the sun was still up.

Izuku idly tangled his fingers in Katsuki’s hair. Katsuki relaxed against him, letting out a long exhale, somehow shifting closer.

Moments like these always had Izuku *reeling* . At one point, his drive to surpass Katsuki as a Hero had changed into a yearning for them to have something that was all theirs. For years, Izuku had wanted Katsuki to see Izuku as capable, as someone that he could rely on. And even after almost a year and a half of being together, the hints of vulnerability that Katsuki shared made Izuku feel *loved* , *secure* . When it was just them, when everything was out in the open, when the rest of the world was stupid and unimportant and worthless, because it was just them, always had been just them, whether it was with scarred hands joined together, or Katsuki looking up at Izuku with blown pupils, expression unguarded and wanting.

“Like, after UA.”

“We go Pro. Obviously.”

“Well, *yeah* . But… everything else.”

“Quit being cryptic.”

“Cryptic? I’m not being cryptic.”

“Yes you fucking are.”

“No I’m not, I’m just considering all the possibilities but I wanted to hear your thoughts before I said mine because whatifyouthinkI’mstupidandyoudon’tagreewithmeand-”

“Izuku.”

“What do *we* do next?”

“If you think I’m popping the fucking question on graduation then think again.”

“Pop what qu- *Kacchan* . That is *not* what I meant.”

“Then what did you mean?”

Izuku took a deep breath. “Where are you living?”

Katsuki sat up, bathed in the light cast from the nightstand lamp. Izuku was all at once jealous of the reporter he’d met in his first year, who’s quirk allowed him to take pictures at any second in time. “ *That’s* what you’re scared to ask me?”

Izuku picked at his nails to avoid meeting Katsuki’s glare.

“What, you wanna move in with me?”

His question wasn’t mocking or sarcastic. He took one of Izuku’s hands, forcing him to stop fiddling.

“I thought that was a given,” Katsuki continued. “If I let you live alone, you’ll blow up your kitchen within a week.”

“Not true,” he muttered.

“Fine, you just won’t bother to feed yourself.”

“I’m not that bad,” he argued.

Katsuki laid back down. “I kind of like having you around, anyway.”

“Just kind of?”

“You have your benefits.”

“Like?”

“Don’t fish for compliments.”

That’s how they found themselves touring apartments on their off-days. Katsuki insisted that they had to have a big kitchen (which Izuku couldn’t care less about). He was the one that made all the judgments, which to Izuku, was both endearing and amusing. Katsuki walked through each apartment, pointing out the things he didn’t like, his hands on his hips and a frown on his face. In the apartments that he did like, which were few and far between, he’d point things out quietly to Izuku.

“We could turn this into your All Might shrine room,” Katsuki murmured after the realtor left them alone in a spare bedroom. “We can add all our dumbass friends’ merch, too.”

Then, after forcing Izuku to hold one end of a tape measure as he scrutinized the dimensions of the master bedroom, he nodded approvingly.

“Does it meet your standards?”

“Yep. Big enough for us to beat the shit out of each other. And have some extra leg room.”

“Ah, yes, my favorite bedroom activity with you. That’s just what I was envisioning us doing in here.”

“Your mother know you talk like that?”

They hadn’t *tried* to hide it from their families. There just hadn’t been a good time to tell them.

Inko had found out that Izuku spent every night at Katsuki’s, which had led to a handful of petrifying conversations, especially when she’d asked him about them being *safe* .

He did his best to avoid talking about his relationship to his mother, outside of what was necessary. He told her about the fun things they did, partially as a way to prove to her that Katsuki wasn’t as awful as she seemed to think he was. He’d never tell Katsuki that, though, as he insisted on proving it to Inko on his own that he had changed.

Telling both of their parents that they were moving in together was *not* a conversation Izuku wanted to have. Mitsuki and Masaru would’ve been easier to handle, and definitely more accepting. They seemed to adore Izuku, which was something he was still getting used to. His mother, on the other hand, was more skeptical of him and Katsuki’s entire relationship, and he couldn’t even blame her for it.

“Izuku?” his mom asked again, tugging on his sleeve.

“Sorry! Zoned out!”

“Midoriya, Bakugou!”

At that moment, Kirishima and Kaminari decided to come to their temporary rescue. Kirishima wrapped his arm around Katsuki’s shoulder, pulling him into a half-hug that was surprisingly returned.

“Oh, it’s you brats,” Mitsuki said, but she was smiling. “Izuku and Katsuki were just telling us about their plans for after UA.”

“Oh, you mean their sick ass apartment?” Kaminari said.

Fuck.

Inko wrinkled her eyebrows at Izuku, Mitsuki started shouting at Katsuki for not telling her, Masaru tried to calm her down, and All Might patted Izuku on the shoulder.

“Surprise?”

Boxes took up just about every open space in the apartment. Some were halfway unpacked, scribbles dictating what was held in each and every one. Most of the stuff was Izuku's; after all, he had 18 years' worth of Hero merch and Hero analysis notebooks. Katsuki's boxes were a lot neater than his, and most of his belongings had been items he'd bought for the kitchen. During their various shopping trips, Izuku had just nodded along as Katsuki picked out plates and utensils and mini appliances. Izuku hadn't even realized there were so many different toasters, and he also didn't understand why Katsuki cared so much about finding the perfect one.

Izuku currently sat in the master bedroom closet, his legs crossed, digging through the boxes containing both of their clothes. He was surrounded by stacks of folded pants and shirts, and he would be lying if he said he didn't steal one of Katsuki's old UA hoodies to wear while he organized. In the spare bedroom, he could hear Katsuki swearing as he attempted to put together a shelf to house some of Izuku's All Might collection.

"You're so fucking lucky I like you more than the average person," Katsuki called.

"You never fail to charm me," Izuku called back, folding another pair of sweatpants. All of their items were together, side by side. Izuku would wake up next to Katsuki, get dressed next to Katsuki, brush his teeth next to Katsuki.

"If you ever cheat on me, I'm auctioning all of this shit off. I'd never have to work again."

"You think I'd cheat on you?"

Katsuki appeared in the doorway, holding a screwdriver, his forehead sweaty. He wiped it with his forearm, his shirt lifting just slightly. "If they offered you that limited edition Silver Age All Might figurine that you never got, maybe."

Izuku wadded up a sock and threw it at him.

Katsuki flopped down onto the floor beside Izuku, leaning on his good arm. Izuku watched as Katsuki looked around the room, his sharp, red eyes taking in every detail.

"Does it meet your standards?"

"Your folding needs work," Katsuki commented. He reached out, taking Izuku's hand in his, his thumb tracing the scars that were now years old, distant memories of sporting events and chasing after villains.

They were in an apartment that was all *theirs* , which still didn't feel particularly real. This wasn't just Katsuki's dorm, this was their apartment, Katsuki and Izuku, Kacchan and Deku, the Symbol of Hope and the Symbol of Victory.

It wasn't perfect, and it wasn't near complete, and there were probably a million fights waiting for them over the next couple days. Izuku could see it clearly, because it had always been him and Katsuki, and it always would be. Izuku would leave his dirty dishes in the sink,

Katsuki would snore too loud, their friends would show up unannounced with takeout and laughter.

They would wake up to each other, happy and loving and cheesy and *disgusting* . They would wake up to each other falling apart, reliving the moment when Katsuki *died* , and in some other reality, he didn't come back. Katsuki would wake up to Izuku's tears, the ones he suffered in silence and tried to hide, and Katsuki would say something so *him* that it would fix everything if only for the night. Izuku would wake up to Katsuki's swearing, his hands popping, his angry shouting. He would listen in silence, without judgement, while Katsuki let out the frustrations that he couldn't voice to anyone else. His arm, his chest, his scars, his *pain* .

"I love you," Izuku said, because he'd always felt it, he'd always meant it, and it had all been worth it.

"Yeah nerd," Katsuki said. "I love you."

Chapter End Notes

hellloooooo party people I can't believe this is the last chapter and that this fic is over but here we are :(I appreciate every single last one of you for reading this and (if anybody even did) for keeping up even when it took me forever and a half to update writing this has been such a joy. I love this story, I loved exploring these characters and their dynamic. Im thinking of writing a fantasy au as a little summer project (probably won't be nearly as long or as angsty)
as always, I hope you all enjoyed the chapter
love you all :) and see u next time!
-lav <3

End Notes

thank you soooo much for reading if you made it through that absolute word vomit. this was super exposition-y and I promise there's more interactions and actual plot stuff coming up soon if you decide to stick around
im super excited to be writing this and ive never done an MHA fic before so I hope I do the characters justice (I'm also not all the way caught up on the anime but we won't talk about that)
love reading ur comments and kudos is much appreciated!!
also more tags will be added in the future!!
<3

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!